No Strings Attached

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/23173117.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra) (Past Relationship)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), also the rest of them, you know the crew, Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra)

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Modern AU, adora is damaged, glimmer has been hit by a train called 'life', Friends With Benefits, There Was Only One Bed, Angst, Fluff, Smut, Angst and Fluff and Smut, Slow Burn, Character Death

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by Say_Anything

Summary

"If we're going to do this we need to lay down some ground rules."

"Okay..."

"One; no cuddling. Two; no talking about any of this outside the bedroom. Fight Club style. And three; no falling in love with me."

Glimmer teases her with a wink, but the last rule makes Adora's heart stop.

When Adora and Glimmer reconnect years after drifting apart, they find comfort from their emotional trauma in the physical. It can't get any more complicated... Unless one of them catches feelings.

Notes

....hiiii :D
Another modern AU, but this time it's smut with feelings. Big thanks to EtherianFrigateBird for helping me lay out basically the entire plot of this story! Please go read her fic ADORA: Vagabond of the Etherian Cosmos. It's awesome!

Anyway, first chapter of the friends with benefits glimmadora AU starts here, rated M for a reason, please take that into account if that's not your jam.
Otherwise, enjoy!

Chapter 1

“You know what? Fuck 'er,” Glimmer slurred as she took yet another straight shot of cranberry vodka directly from the bottle as Bow watched her with an expression that was only growing more and more concerned. “Fuck all women. Y’know? They’re all liars and cheaters.'ve never met *anyone* who proved me otherwise. Y'KNOW?"

“Mhm,” Bow agreed noncommittally as he eyed the now almost empty bottle. “Alright, Glimmer. I think it’s time we put the bottle away.”

Glimmer stretched to hold the bottle out of Bow’s reach as he gently tried to pry it from her hands. Considering their height difference, she was not very successful, and Bow managed to get a solid grip around the bottle before Glimmer hugged it to her chest.

“Bow!”

“Glimmer.”

“This is all I have,” she argued, tugging the bottle towards herself with muscles that felt like water thanks to the current amount of alcohol coursing through her body. “Don’t take it away from me too.”

Pity flashed across Bow’s face but he did not relinquish his hold on the liquor. “If you keep going like this you are *really* going to regret it in the morning.”

In a move that was entirely considered cheating, in Glimmer’s opinion. Bow poked her in the ribs, yanking the bottle away when she squeaked and flinched.

“Look, I know it sucks,” Bow admitted as he locked the basically empty bottle back in his fathers’ liquor cabinet.

"It more than sucks."

"It *really* sucks," Bow amended, coming back to sit on the couch next to Glimmer as she sunk into the cushions, her neck now bent at an awkward angle. The alcohol had done nothing to dull her emotional agony (surprise, surprise). Now she just felt sick, dizzy *and* sad. "But I'm telling you, anyone who decides that the best way to end their relationship is by cheating on their partner, they weren't worth your time in the first place."

"I really liked her," Glimmer shot back weakly, allowing Bow to scoop her into a slightly awkward side hug, her spinning head now resting on his shoulder. "I thought… Maybe, y'know, this one might stick. A year is like… My record."

Bow was quiet for a moment, rubbing her arm gently. "I'm sorry, Glimmer. You didn't deserve to be treated like that. Nobody does. But you least of all. You're a good friend, and a great girlfriend! The right person will see that someday, I promise."

"The right person doesn't exist," Glimmer grumbled, half of her wanting to shove Bow away and the other half thankful for his steady support.

Bow smiled sadly, shaking his head. "Do you want me to hang onto your phone for a few days, so you're not tempted to text her?"

"I need my phone to survive, Bow. Besides… You can't keep it forever. I'll have to face the temptation someday."

"Sure, but, you know. Just till the edge wears off."

Glimmer ran her hands over her face, groaning. She'd been too heartbroken the past few days to really think about the logistics of her current situation. But of course, Bow, being Bow, had to bring it up.

Her girlfriend of exactly one year, Mermista, had cheated on and dumped her for some scummy dude bro she'd met at a bar the

weekend prior. In Glimmer's mind, it had been nothing short of a slap in the face. The two of them rarely ever got into arguments. If anything, Mermista had seemed a little … bored(?) of her (?) lately… But Mermista always seemed bored! Glimmer had no reason to think that anything was wrong.

No reason to think that she wasn't good enough anymore.

Not only had she lost her girlfriend, but her roommate, and apartment, all in one fell swoop. Bow had offered to house her for a few days. But he still lived with his dad's while he was finishing his final year in school. There was no way Glimmer would be allowed to stay for more than a week tops.

She supposed, if worst came to worst, she could move back in with her (shudder) *mom* for a bit. But imagining the lecturing Angella would give her about this whole mess almost made Glimmer feel as sick as the alcohol. She could practically hear her mother's shrill voice now:

' *You moved in with her after knowing her for three months?'*

'You met her getting completely wasted at a dive bar?'

'It took you exactly how many minutes to decide you wanted to sleep with her?'

"I want to die…," Glimmer groaned, tears springing to sting her eyes as her mother's voice faded.

"Don't say that," Bow's voice was sympathetic, but genuinely pained too. "I promise it'll be okay, Glimmer. Just take this time to focus on yourself. Who knows, this could be really good for you."

"You sound like a fucking therapist."

"Well, considering that's what I'm trying to become, I'm going to take that as a compliment."

"Yeah, well, you should…," Glimmer fought back the burning tears with everything she had. She didn't want to break in front of Bow. In front of anyone. No one deserved to see her that vulnerable. Ever again.

Fuck them.

"Why don't you try to sleep, huh?" Bow suggested as he pulled a blanket off the end of the couch and helped Glimmer ease down onto the cushions. "I'll be here in the morning. When you might *actually* want to die." He cast a not-so-subtle glance at the alcohol cabinet.

Glimmer grunted and pulled the covers up to her chin, letting her eyes slip shut even though it made her head spin worse.

Maybe Bow was right though….

Or maybe he was very wrong and this was about to be the worst year of her life.

It never really got easier, watching Catra leave. Adora couldn't help but hope that every time she visited, it might be different. But they'd kept their relationship ambiguous for so long.

Adora often found herself wishing, when she lay awake as Catra snored loudly in bed beside her, that they could go back to the simple days. When they were young and in love and actually dating… Not just the casual weird weekend hookup thing they had going now.

Not that it has ever been simple, realy. Nothing was simple with Catra.

After (the first time) they'd broken up, it had felt almost comforting to know Catra still wanted her in some capacity. Even if she left before dawn broke, texted other girls, slept with other girls…. Lived with other girls.

She currently kinda had a live-in girlfriend. Scorpia. Adora only knew the name because thinking about her made her sick to her stomach. But either Scorpia didn’t care, or Catra didn’t tell her she was also sleeping with Adora.

And being kept a dirty little secret hurt even more than the way Catra seemed to love to play cat-and-mouse with her heart.

This particular morning shouldn't have been a surprise. It was nothing new. Catra shoved her into bed the night before, kissing her roughly, every sense electric and alive until she forgot to be upset that they were doing this.

She'd slept beside Adora afterwards, not close enough to cuddle, but so that she could still feel her warmth. And then, the second Adora had dared to close her eyes, Catra slipped out from under the sheets and left the apartment, not even bothering to lock the front door with the key Adora had so stupidly given her months ago.

In the hopes it might make her feel more...what?

Dedicated?

Adora knew she was fooling herself. She should be smarter than this. It was over. They didn't love each other anymore. Or at least Catra didn't love her anymore. She was absolutely abusing how much Adora still cared for her.

And yet...

Adora couldn't say no.

She was a loyal friend, a hard worker, a diligent manager, smart, kind, she worked hard on her appearance. She was capable and in control of her own life.

But, when it came to romance, Adora had always been subject to the follies of her heart. And considering she'd spent most of her

life tailing after Catra, it was safe to say she most often got the short end of the stick.

She watched through her bedroom window as Catra strolled down the street in the early morning light, hands stuffed into the pockets of her leather jacket. As casually as if she hadn't just thrown off the equilibrium of Adora's entire upcoming week.

As if she hadn't just broken her heart all over again.

Snapping the curtains shut, Adora slammed her fist down on her alarm clock as it began to buzz. She heard something crack, but didn't check the damage. She'd deal with it later. When she didn't feel like punching a hole through her apartment's thin walls.

Luckily, she had an opening shift at the gym this morning. She would gladly punch something there.

Bow had been right.

The next morning, Glimmer sincerely did want to die. She'd spent almost the entire morning in Bow's bathroom, ruining his toilet bowl before collapsing back on the couch and sleeping the day away.

Now, it was Monday, and Glimmer flipped mindlessly through Bow's Netflix account, as said best friend got ready for classes.

"Glimmer," Bow called from the bathroom she'd trashed yesterday. "I want you to try to do something today, okay?"

Glimmer gave a non-committal grunt, sinking further into her blanket fort on the couch.

"Glimmer," Bow said again, moving to stand in front of the TV. Glimmer defiantly pointed the remote through him and kept clicking. Bow snatched it away, setting it on the coffee table and slapping Glimmer's foot away when she tried to reach it with her

toes."I'm serious. Go take a walk through the park. Or go shopping. Take my gym card and go burn off some angst."

Glimmer glowered as Bow put the card down next to the remote.

"The gym? Really, Bow?"

"Yes, really," he said, crossing his arms. "Exercise has been proven to release endorphins, which'll help your mood and energy level. Maybe...Even inspire you to look for a job."

"Okay, Mom," Glimmer grumbled, unwilling to admit that his logic was sound. It always was. *He* always was. God...Why'd she have to make friends with the Golden Boy.

Bow rolled his eyes at her jab. "C'mon, my dad's will be back from their trip tomorrow and you need to figure out what you're going to do next. Just try to get out of the house a little, okay? It'll help, I promise."

Glimmer nodded sullenly, huffing a sigh through her nose when Bow affectionately ruffled her already messy (and probably dirty hair.)

"I'll be back around 3, okay?" Bow said as he grabbed his jacket and headed for the door. "And I want a list of all the productive things you did today when I get back!"

Glimmer flipped him off even as he grinned and waved goodbye before slipping out the door.

After he'd gone, Glimmer spent another hour on the couch, staring blankly at the TV screen as it scrolled through list upon list of nature documentaries. Why were there so many? Why did Bow *watch* so many?

Her eyes flickered over the abandoned gym card more than once, and finally, as the clock hit noon, she forced herself up from the couch (which basically had her ass imprinted on it at this point) and headed for Bow's room.

They'd stowed all the boxes she'd packed from Mermista's place in here when Bow helped her move out. Luckily...It wasn't much. Clothes, a few personal trinkets, toiletries.

Glimmer nudged a few boxes aside with her toes until she found the ones containing her athletic clothes. There weren't too many options. She made it a rule to generally avoid spandex and tank tops as they exposed her arms. She didn't need any deep seated insecurities to add to her pain today.

Deciding on a light purple t-shirt a pair of black athletic shorts she'd had since high school, Glimmer grabbed the gym card from the table and headed for the door. Her hair was still a disaster, and she *still* smelled faintly of alcohol, but showering *before* the gym seemed entirely counterproductive, so she let it be.

Whatever.

Who cared what anyone thought of her at this point?

Luckily, Glimmer knew the gym was not far from Bow's house. But with the afternoon sun beating down on her, she was already sweating by the time she stepped through the doors into sweet, sweet air conditioning.

Approaching the front desk, Glimmer scanned the card under the reader. The man behind the desk only looked briefly confused when it was Bow's picture that probably showed up on the screen and not the short, purple haired girl standing before him. But he grunted and waved her in anyway.

Glancing around the gym, Glimmer pondered what exactly she should do. There was a boxing class being led by the heavy bags in the far corner. A few weight machines and barbells scattered about.

Pass.

Glimmer wasn't about to play dude bro.

There was a row of treadmills on the other side of the gym...Granted, she'd already done her walking for the day in *getting* here. But she also just kind of wanted something mindless to do. And staring out the window while walking in place seemed absolutely perfect.

It wasn't until Glimmer had climbed onto the machine and set her speed that she realized she'd forgotten her headphones. What was the fucking point of exercising at all is she couldn't simultaneously listen to her freshly minted break up playlist?

Frustrated, she'd almost decided to leave the gym right then and there, when a familiar voice made her turn around.

"Glimmer?"

Looking around, trying to figure out who the fuck could possibly know her here, Glimmer felt her heart stop as she locked eyes with--

"Adora? Oh my god…"

The blonde stood at the foot of the treadmill, staring at her with those bright blue eyes Glimmer remembered so well. She looked older now, her cheeks less round than when Glimmer had first met her. She wore a red tank top with the gym logo, that unfairly showed off the definition in her arms. And a pair of black spandex leggings that clung to her thighs so nicely Glimmer had to remind herself that it was rude to stare.

"It is you!" Adora's eyes quickly roamed over her, taking her in. Glimmer knew she looked quite a bit different now than what Adora must remember from high school. And she considered it a glow up. But for some reason, the fleeting gaze made her self conscious.

"I didn't think you'd keep the purple after…,"Adora pointed to her own head, indicating the word 'hair', before awkwardly clearing her throat. "Anyway… How are you? It's been awhile."

"A couple years, yeah," Glimmer agreed, stopping the treadmill and only tripping *a little bit* as she stepped off it.

"Yeah…," the light in Adora's eyes dulled a bit. "Are you...uh, good? What are you up to these days?"

"Oh, you know," Glimmer tried to lean casually against the arm of the treadmill, only to miss and stumble slightly. "Uh...Lots of stuff. So much stuff."

Adora nodded, her expression so earnest and enraptured that it filled Glimmer's stomach with guilt to lie.

"Are you still in school?"

"Oh, uh, nah…,"Glimmer hated the way Adora's brow wrinkled in...concern?...confusion? It wasn't pity, certainly, and for that, at least, Glimmer was grateful. "School just kinda turned out not to be my vibe."

"Oh." Adora seemed even more confused by that explanation, and Glimmer knew why, but luckily she didn't linger on it.

"Are you working then?"

"I'm…," Glimmer suddenly felt like her face was on fire. Fuck, she shouldn't care. But she knew she must sound like a pathetic deadbeat. "I'm in between jobs right now actually."

Adora nodded again and Glimmer quickly changed the subject before she could ask another question that made Glimmer sound like a loser.

"What about you? How are you? You work here?" She pointed to the logo on Adora's chest. But the blonde still looked down as if she'd forgotten the answer herself. Glimmer almost smiled to herself, at least it seemed it was only Adora's appearance that had changed.

"Oh! Yeah. I'm one of the class instructors." She pointed over her shoulder at the dispersing boxing class.

"Oh that's," (*hot)* , "Neat."

"Pays the bills," Adora said with a shrug and lopsided grin.

"I thought… Y'know. Sports were in your future. You got that scholarship and everything, I remember." Glimmer felt herself flush as Adora's grin brightened. As if she was overjoyed Glimmer remembered that fact at all.

"Oh, I tore my ACL during a match freshman year. Broke my ankle too," Adora explained nonchalantly, gesturing to her foot as if the injury was still there. "They told me I'd never be able to play professionally so I switched gears."

Glimmer almost wanted to argue. To remind Adora that pro sports had been her dream since she'd made the varsity lacrosse team at Bright Moon High. But she held her tongue. She didn't know this woman well enough to question her life choices.

Not anymore anyway.

"That sucks…. I'm sorry…" It didn't feel like enough, but it was all Glimmer could think to say.

Adora's smile returned, the one that reached her eyes and made them as soft as the morning sky.

"It's alright, I figured it out. Majored in Business instead. I'm planning on taking over this gym once Lonnie makes the move to L.A."

"Lonnie works here?" Glimmer asked, temporarily stunned that already more people than she would have liked seemed to have stuck around the city after high school.

"Yeah! If you want I can grab her--,"

"Er, nah, that's. That's alright, don't bother her. I'll catch her another time."

Adora's puppy dog expression told her she was still ignorant to how much the jocks had teased Glimmer in high school. Adora had been the outlier. But then of course, she'd secretly been as much of a dork as she and Bow were.

The Best Friends Squad.

As if Adora was reading her mind, she brightened and asked. "Oh, hey! Do you still talk to Bow?"

"Yeah, I'm… He's… We're," deciding it wasn't appropriate to explain her living situation right now, Glimmer changed direction. "He's in school to become a therapist."

"That sounds perfect for Bow," Adora laughed.

"Haven't you seen him?" Glimmer pulled Bow's gym card out of her pocket. "He's a member here."

"Oh?" Adora peered at it as if it were a foreign object. "No, I guess he must be new."

Pursing her lips, relieved that Bow hadn't tricked her into this conversation with a ghost from her past, Glimmer pocketed the card just as Adora looked over her shoulder to see a few gym members streaming in.

"Hey, I'm so sorry, but I've got one more class to teach. But, um, if you're not busy… Maybe we could catch up after. Grab a drink?"

Glimmer's brain stalled trying to process that *and* not throw up at the idea of more alcohol. "Wait...Like, coffee?"

"Yes?" Adora's expression was a mix of "duh" and "what the fuck were you thinking"?

Lately, Glimmer had found herself conveniently forgetting that not everyone was a day drinker. Then again, not everyone's life was as shit as hers had become.

"Oh, yeah sure. Cool. I'll just… I'll just walk. Here. On this. Till you're done." Glimmer patted the treadmill as if it were a large mechanical dog.

Adora was grinning and Glimmer was desperately trying to ignore the way her heart was stuttering.

It was probably just a side effect of an entire bottle of vodka.

That she'd consumed two days ago…

"Awesome," Adora saved Glimmer from her own brain as she backed towards the heavy bags. "I'll meet you at the front after!"

Glimmer watched her walk away for a *bit* too long. Those spandex tights really were nice…

'Stop being gay for two seconds, Glimmer.'

Shaking her gay head, Glimmer climbed carefully back up onto the treadmill, setting the speed to a mere meander.

Luckily, she found herself not even needing music as she waited the thirty minute duration of Adora's class. Her mind was spinning too many circles to care about the silence.

Adora was here.

After….how many years? She'd greeted her so warmly. After everything…

And she wanted to get a drink? To catch up?

Glimmer was half convinced she was still passed out on Bow's couch, dreaming.

It wouldn't have been the first time Adora had ever appeared in her dreams after all. But that was a long time ago. For all Glimmer cared, it was practically another lifetime.

As soon as Adora's class began to disperse, Glimmer shut off the treadmill and inched toward the front door. Adora was busy waving each student goodbye, but her eyes caught Glimmer's through the crowd of people and she grinned again.

A shiver passed through Glimmer, the anxiety building in her as she drew closer. She knew she looked like shit and she must still smell like vomit and alcohol. But if Adora noticed, she didn't seem to mind.

Or maybe she was still the perfectly polite, A+ student she always had been.

"You ready?" Adora asked, looking over Glimmer briefly as if she'd expected her to bring more than herself and the gym card.

In lieu of a verbal response, Glimmer nodded and Adora led the way out into the parking lot.

"I'll drive," the blonde said as she led the way to the old red pickup truck Glimmer remembered.

"You'll have to. Unless you want to wait for me to catch up on foot," Glimmer said as she tugged on the passenger side door only to realize it was still locked.

Adora's smile was teasing as she pointedly hit the unlock button. "Oh? Are you in between cars right now too?"

"Oh, I didn't realize you were a comedian too." Glimmer rolled her eyes to fight the blush threatening to take over her face. "Did that happen after we graduated then?"

"I've always been funny," Adora insisted, waiting until Glimmer was situated in the passenger seat before starting the engine.

A reply was on the tip of Glimmer’s tongue before she realized that the banter was too easy. It was too comfortable talking to her again. It shouldn’t be. It couldn’t be.

So instead of replying, she gave Adora a smile that was too wide and leaned back in her seat to stare out the window. Unfortunately, that in itself brought back so many memories that she forced herself to stare at her pink sneakers instead.

If the brief and tense silence had bothered Adora at all, she didn’t show it, turning on the radio instead and humming along as they drove.

Luckily, the coffee shop she’d chosen was only about an eight minute drive, and once they’d parked Adora leapt out of her seat, scurrying around to the passengers side door to open it for Glimmer.

“The door is still kinda sticky,” she explained when Glimmer looked at her with owlish eyes. “It’s easier to open from the outside.”

“You have a serial killer’s car, you know that, right?” Glimmer said as she slid out of the giant car, hoping she didn’t look like an idiot when her feet didn’t immediately touch the ground.

Adora’s laugh rang out. It was pure and sweet and it made Glimmer’s heart flutter.

‘Stop that, traitor.’

Adora led the way inside, holding the door open for Glimmer as she passed. For a moment it looked like Adora wanted to say something, her lips parting slightly, then she swallowed and quickly looked away, letting the door swing shut behind them.

"Why don't you grab us a seat," Adora suggested. "I'll grab the drinks. What do you want?"

"Hang on, I don't want you to pay for me."

"Oh, were you gonna pay with your in between job money?" Adora smirked.

Glimmer huffed, planting her hands on her hips in an effort to look intimidating. "Will you let that go? I have a rich mom to mooch off of remember?"

Adora's smile turned fond. "Angella. How is she?"

"Fine." Glimmer grimaced, hating how this conversation kept jumping from highs to lows in a matter of seconds. It was already emotionally exhausting and they'd been in each other's presence maybe a total of twenty minutes.

"That's good…. Tell her I say hello, if you can."

"Sure."

Catching the reluctance to discuss her mother in Glimmer's tone, Adora grabbed her drink order and hurried off to the counter.

As Glimmer waited, she pulled out her phone, sending a quick text to Bow. He'd still be in class right now, but when she got back to his house, she knew he'd want to discuss this.

-'I met up with Adora at the gym. She says hi. We're getting a drink.'

-'Coffee.'

-'Not a drink drink.'

-'....'

-'You knew that probably.'

-'She's coming back. Bye.'

Adora smiled kindly at her as she set Glimmer's drink down at the table in front of her.

"Bow says hi," Glimmer lied, pocketing her phone quickly. It was just a small lie though, she was sure he'd say hi later, and Adora's smile brightened so….adorably, that Glimmer felt no guilt.

"Tell him I said hi back." Adora took a seat across from her, watching with an amused twinkle in her eye when Glimmer took a sip of her green tea and grimaced as it went down.

"I never figured you for the tea type."

' *You would be absolutely right.'*

"Yeah, well, I've heard it's good for detoxing… And… Uh, I'm doing a cleanse… That's… That's why I went to the gym today too." Glimmer snapped her mouth shut after taking another full swig to prove her point. "What about you? Black coffee?"

Glimmer remembered Adora being incredibly strict when it came to her calorie intake back in highschool. Back then, it had worried her. Even though Adora always insisted it was for the sake of her sports performance.

"I'm branching out, actually," Adora held her cup aloft, like a holy grail. "A vanilla latte."

"Milk *and* sugar? Who are you?"

Adora snort-giggled. Glimmer liked making her do that.

"Someone who realized she deserves to enjoy the finer things in life since there's no way she'll ever have a career in pro sports anyway."

"Uh huh," Glimmer drawled, propping her chin in her hand. "I'll bet you still had a kale smoothie for breakfast today though.

Adora shrugged. "Hey, some habits die hard."

For the first time, Glimmer felt her own giggle rising. But she beat it into submission before it could leave her body.

"So are you and Bow roommates now?" Adora asked, bringing the conversation around before Glimmer could dodge.

"Uh...No. I'm just kinda crashing on his couch right now."

That adorable wrinkle formed between Adora's dark eyebrows.

"I'm…," Glimmer sighed. "My living situation got a little complicated as of a few days ago. I don't, technically, have a permanent place to stay… Bow would love to help, but he lives with his dads at the moment."

"What about Angella?" The wrinkle in Adora's forehead deepened. "Surely, she'd--"

"Honestly, I'd rather live in a box under a bridge than go back to my mom's house." Glimmer heaved a sigh and slumped back in her chair.

So Adora didn't know all the details, but now at least she'd gathered that Glimmer was a fucking loser. It was out in the open. Maybe she could stop feeling so nervous now?

"Well," Adora began after a long moment of tense silence. "Maybe...If you wanted to...You could move in with me?"

Glimmer's head snapped around so fast she heard her neck crack. "What?"

"Just until you get back on your feet or something, you know? I could use the help with rent and, hey, it might be fun! The Best Friends Squad back together again...Right?"

Right. That's what they were. The Best Friends Squad.

No.

That's what they *used* to be.

"That's, um, wow… That's a nice offer, Adora."

Adora gave her a nervous grin. Either Glimmer's reaction was less than what she'd hoped for, or she was already regretting making the offer. Glimmer was going to assume the latter.

"I'm-I'm okay, though. I'll figure something out. I wouldn't want to, like, inconvenience you or anything…"

'What are you going to figure out, Glimmer? Where are you planning to go?'

"It's not an inconvenience," Adora assured her, although she was now playing nervously with the lid of her cup, avoiding Glimmer's gaze.

"I mean, you totally don't have to, Glimmer. But don't say no just because you feel like you're going to put me out for any reason. I wouldn't have offered if I didn't sincerely want to help."

Glimmer looked down at her tea, to hide the burn in her cheeks. "I'll… I'll think about it. Thank you."

Adora nodded, gesturing to Glimmer's arm before the silence could get awkward. "I like your sleeve."

Glimmer had to look down at said tattoo before remembering that it was permanently etched into her skin.

"Oh, thank you."

It was easy to forget that she must look like a completely different person to Adora now. The tattoos, the piercings. When Adora knew her, she'd been all anime t-shirts and mom jeans.

"I like your--," Glimmer stopped herself before she could say 'muscles'. "Hair…"

"My hair?" Adora chuckled slightly, running a hand through said blonde strands.

"Yeah. You let down the hair poof finally. Seems freeing."

Again, Adora laughed. Damn it, Glimmer really liked that sound.

"It's less work to keep up that's for sure."

The conversation only lasted until Adora had finished her latte and Glimmer bitterly threw away the rest of her now cold tea.

The two had driven back to Bow's house in silence, but it wasn't as icy, in fact they even both hummed along to one of their old favorite songs that had played over the radio.

The beaming smile Adora had given her when they both recognized it… Glimmer was now seriously considering her offer.

"Here's my number," Adora handed Glimmer a gym business card as they parked outside Bow's house. "If you change your mind or...Y'know, just wanna chat again sometime… Let me know."

"Yeah. I will. Thanks again, Adora. For the coffee and stuff. The offer was nice too." Adora smiled fondly and suddenly Glimmer didn't want to get out of the car. "I'll see you around then."

"Yeah."

Glimmer struggled with the passenger side door for an awkward few seconds before hopping out of the truck and hurrying up Bow's driveway. She glanced over her shoulder just in time to see the beat up truck driving away.

For some reason, the sight made her heart feel heavy.

Bow had been in a frenzy upon returning, asking dozens of questions about their former best friend. It wasn't until Glimmer realized she couldn't answer most of them, that she must have been terrible conversation.

As soon as Bow realized the questions were depressing his already depressed house guest, he'd plopped her down on the couch and turned on the TV instead.

But Glimmer's mind still whirled around Adora and her offer.

"So, Glimmer. My dads are back tomorrow." Bow said as he watched TV and Glimmer tapped mindlessly over the same three apps on her phone. He poked her cheek to grab her attention. "Have you decided what you're going to do?"

Glimmer pushed his hand away and pulled up her contacts list, staring hard at the new number.

"Glimmer?"

"Yup," she said, opening a new text conversation. "I'm moving in with Adora."

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> I cannot believe I introduce the crackiest of crack ships in chapter 1. Glimista, and y'all got nothing to say about it. Smh...
>
> Anyway: Glimmer moves in and remembers how the Best Friends Squad met. Also ft. Adora wearing questionable pajamas. Everything is fine.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hadn't really expected anything to come of her offer to Glimmer. It would have been strange to hang her hopes on it. And even stranger to expect Glimmer to accept it when they were in fact basically...strangers.

And that's why she nearly jumped out of her skin when she heard her phone buzzing at 2am as she lay beside a snoring Catra.

Scrambling to pick up the incoming call before it woke her sleeping partner, Adora was more than surprised to hear Glimmer's voice on the other end of the line.

"Hello?"

"Hey, so, I've decided it would be…cool, to accept your offer. If, uh, it still stands. Bow's lowkey kicking me out, like, tomorrow. So...it's kinda last minute. But...You know." A brief pause ensued. "This is Glimmer, by the way."

"Uh, yeah. Yeah! I-Hang on." Adora tried to keep her voice low as she left the bedroom, grabbing a robe and slipping out onto the balcony. "Yeah, sorry. Um. My offer still stands, absolutely. So, tomorrow, you said?"

"Yeah. If that's okay. Bow will help me move everything, so don't worry about that."

The timing couldn't have been better, honestly. Catra was leaving on tour with her band tomorrow for at least a month. Adora had at least that much time to worry about introducing the concept of a new roommate to her. Not that she should have to worry. But Catra used her and her apartment as her own so often these days, Adora wondered if she'd secretly been kicked out of the one she supposedly shared with Scorpia.

"Yeah, cool. Okay! Is the afternoon alright? I work tomorrow morning."

"Yeah, totally fine. We'll… See you then, I guess?"

"Great, I'll be ready."

"Cool… Oh, and… Thanks, Adora."

"You're--" The phone clicked and Adora was left staring in silence at the city lights laid out like twinkling stars before her. "...Welcome."

Sighing, wondering what on earth she'd just gotten herself into, Adora was about to turn her phone off for the night when it buzzed one last time.

It was an incoming text from the number she now recognized as Glimmer's.

-'I forgot to ask you for your address...👉👈'

Adora chuckled to herself, quickly typing out the name and address of her complex before telling Glimmer she'd see her tomorrow and hurrying back inside the apartment.

A strange feeling filled her chest as she slipped back underneath the sheets. It wasn't the usual tightness. The usual sensation of being strangled and choked by her conflicting emotions. In fact,

she felt kind of … light? As if the emotional weight of the night spent with Catra had been lifted from her shoulders.

Turning onto her side, Adora curled into a tight ball, eyes trained on a mysterious stain she'd never been able to identify imprinted on the far wall.

This was going to be a good thing.

Time away from Catra, with an old friend. A good friend.

What could possibly go wrong?

"Are you *sure* this is a good idea, Glimmer?" Bow asked, as they packed the last of her boxes in the back of his dads' Sedan.

"Of course it's a good idea," Glimmer assured him, reaching onto her tiptoes for the door of the trunk. "I've never had a bad idea in my entire life."

"Debatable," Bow reached over her and closed the trunk, earning an 'I had it' glare. "It's just… This is Adora. You know?"

"I do know of her, Bow, yes," Glimmer said as she hopped into the passenger seat. "She was our friend. We liked her. Remember?"

Bow sighed as he pulled out of the driveway. "Uh, yeah, that's the problem."

"What do you mean?'

"Glimmer, you planted drugs in her girlfriend's bag at Prom because you were so jealous that she didn't ask--"

"Weed isn't drugs, Bow."

"I don't think Doctor Hope saw it that way!" Bow squeaked. "And what if she finds out you did that? *While* you're living there?!"

"She won't!" Glimmer objected, crossing her arms and looking stubbornly out the window. "Why would we even talk about High School?"

"Why would you not?" Bow shot back. "I will bet you twenty bucks right now that it's one of the first things out of her mouth."

"That's not fair."

"Why? Because you know I'm right?"

"Bow."

"Glimmer."

"Look!" Glimmer threw her hands in the air. "If she gets going and *seems* to magically be on track and close to figuring it out then I'll flash the titties and she'll forget all about it. It'll be fine."

Bow had taken his eyes off the road to give Glimmer a doleful look.

"What?!"

"Why is that your solution to everything?"

"Because I've got nice ones, Bow. You've seen. You know. They're like a get out of jail free card."

Bow held up his hand, signaling he was done with the conversation (and probably also using it as a fake partition so he didn't have to look at her and know she was right, Glimmer guessed.)

Whatever. She'd basically won and they both knew it.

Turning on the stereo, Glimmer leaned back in her seat, propping her feet up on the dashboard despite a disapproving glare from Bow. They didn't talk much after that, letting the music fill the

silence. And it wasn't until they drew closer to Adora's apartment that Glimmer began to feel the butterflies filling her gut.

She was about to *live* with Adora. Her long time (former) best friend. And, if she was being honest with herself, even longer time crush.

They would be living in the same, presumably tiny, apartment space. One bedroom? *Did Adora even have a spare bed?* Glimmer had failed to consider the entire sleeping situation when she'd made the decision to accept Adora's offer at 2 a.m.

But she didn't have a choice!

They'd figure things out. And Glimmer would be fine in the whole *feelings* department. It had been a solid three years since she'd seen Adora. They'd both grown up since then… And Glimmer had just gotten out of a semi-sort-of-not really-serious relationship. She wasn't looking for a rebound. Especially not with her ex best friend.

As long as she didn't let it *feel* complicated, it wouldn't be! Easy as that.

God, she could really use a drink.

Before long, they pulled up at the apartment complex. It looked significantly more expensive than the one she'd lived in with Mermista, Glimmer noted. Either Adora made a lot more working at the gym than Glimmer had initially assumed, or she'd been saving a long time to live here.

Not that it was any of Glimmer's business….But still. Before she could open her mouth to mention it to Bow, the main gate swung open and they were buzzed through.

Adora was waiting for them outside building 5. Bow waved frantically through the windshield when he saw her and Adora waved back, practically jumping up and down when she recognized Bow.

Sliding into the parking spot she directed them to, Bow barely waited long enough to shut off the car before he was bounding towards Adora and throwing his arms around her.

"*Adora!"*

"Bow! Hi!"

Both of them were laughing and spinning and simultaneously trying to lift the other and despite everything, it brought a rueful smile to Glimmer's lips. If things hadn't ended between them so badly back then, maybe… their reunion wouldn't have been so fucking awkward.

Wiping away the smile, Glimmer kicked her way out of the car, standing awkwardly on the curb as the two squeezed each other. Bow caught her eye and gestured for her to join, but Glimmer shook her head minutely, earning a frown from her friend.

"How are you?" Adora interrupted the moment, pulling back and clapping Bow on the shoulders. "Glimmer told me you're in school to become a therapist."

Bow beamed. "That's right! On track to graduate next year."

"That's so awesome! Wow...We've come a long way since High School, huh?" Adora chuckled.

Bow nodded eagerly, casting a pointed 'you owe me twenty bucks' look at Glimmer over Adora's shoulder. She flipped him off, hiding her hand behind her back a split second before the blonde turned to look at her.

"You ready?" Adora asked, a charming smile spreading her lips.

' *No.* '

"Yup."

"Let's get started unloading then," Bow cut in, leading the girls around to the back of the Sedan. He stacked three boxes in Adora's arms before she moved for the stairs, Glimmer meanwhile trailing behind trying to ignore the way the blonde's arms strained through her black turtleneck.

What kind of person seriously wore turtlenecks anyway, Glimmer pouted to herself, tearing her eyes away as Adora glanced over her shoulder.

"Careful, the stairs are kinda steep here."

Glimmer smiled grimly in response, shuffling her single box around with another furtive glance at the definition in her shoulders.

Adora led them to the third floor, both Bow and Glimmer having broken into a sweat by the time they reached the top. Adora seemed entirely unaffected, despite her box load. Together, they made their way down the hallway to the door at the end.

Apartment 215.

Glimmer's new home for who knew how long.

"I'm gonna go get the next load started," Bow said, setting his box by the door and heading back for the stairs. As soon as he'd disappeared, Adora offered Glimmer a slightly nervous smile, and balanced her boxes against the door and her knee as she fished around in her pocket for her key.

Successfully, and somehow still with only one hand, Adora retrieved her key and unlocked the door, prodding it open with her shoe and gesturing for Glimmer to step inside first.

She did so, taking in a pristinely organized apartment. It was small, or at least not any bigger than what she and Mermista had shared. But maybe it was just the lack of beer bottles, old takeout and dirty clothes all over the floor that made it seem larger.

“Sorry, I tried to clean before work today,” Adora explained, setting her boxes down before stepping back outside to retrieve Bow’s. “But it’s still kind of a disaster.”

“Uh,” Glimmer glanced around at the blankets folded neatly on the couch and the sink in the small kitchen that was free of dirty dishes. “Adora, this is cleaner than Bow’s dads’ place, and that’s saying something,”

“Oh?” Adora looked genuinely surprised and then chuckled to herself. “Nevermind then. I take back my apology.”

Glimmer snorted before hoisting the box still in her arms. “Where should I put this?”

Adora stepped back, glancing around the apartment, fists planted on her hips as she considered the question.

“Let’s put them all in the living room for now. I figured we’d set you up on the couch and you’d probably want your stuff nearby?”

“The… Couch?” Glimmer asked, eyeing the tiny piece of furniture. It looked cozy enough, but Glimmer was definitely a restless sleeper. And imagining falling off the narrow space every night didn’t exactly appeal to her.

“Oh!” Adora seemed to have caught her dismay, because she ran excitedly over to the couch, reaching for a brown handle on the side. “Yeah, it folds out! Check it. I got it in case anyone ever needed a place to--,”

Adora cranked the handle and an *extremely* loud snapping noise filled the air. The bottom of the couch spasmed once and then fell back down flat.

“--crash.”

The two of them stared at the now broken couch in both awe, and maybe the slight hope that it would magically fix itself before the awkward tension smothered them both.

“Okay…,” Adora dropped the handle and cleared her throat, straightening the end of her (stupid) turtleneck. “Um. Forget the couch...We can maybe go buy a blow up mattress later today.”

God. Those things suck.

“Sure, totally,” Glimmer agreed, forcing a smile that she hoped would calm her now flustered host. “I don’t mind. I’ll sleep wherever. Give me a blanket and a bathtub.”

It worked. Adora laughed, opening her mouth to speak, but Bow reappeared with a few more boxes before she could.

“You guys coming back down?” He asked, setting his boxes unknowingly on the broken couch. “There’s at least two more trips worth of stuff. Because Glimmer’s a hoarder.”

“Bow!”

“What? I saw your old apartment.”

“ *Bow.* ”

Bow shrugged innocently as Adora tried to hide a laugh behind a forced cough. Glimmer pinned them both with a glare that she knew so closely emulated her mother’s, the two cringed.

“No one will look for you when you disappear,” she growled, sweeping past both of them with her head held high.

“ *Evil* , Glimmer!” Bow jogged after her. “Come on, we’re just teasing. Right, Adora?”

“Right!” Adora assured her, catching up on her other side just as Bow wrapped an arm around her shoulders.

“We’re the Best Friends Squad, it’s what we do!”

Glimmer stared at the clock that hung just above the library doors. Only 40 more minutes until her tutoring shift was up and then she could *finally* bail for the day. She didn't know why she continued to act as a tutor after school. Nowadays, she rarely saw any students come in for help. And those that did preferred the online classroom she'd set up to try and boost 'business'. In reality, this period was her study hall more than anything else. But today she didn't have any of her own homework to do and the forty minutes she had left were made even longer knowing that Bow was already out of classes and waiting for her so they could head down to the comic book shop.

The newest issue of Captain Fusion had dropped today and Glimmer *knew* that by the time they got down there, the stupid shop would be sold out. It would be her penance for not reserving a copy in advance, she supposed.

Pulling out her phone, Glimmer flipped mindlessly through a few apps before glancing back up at the clock to see that only two minutes had passed.

Gritting her teeth to stop from screaming, she sent a quick text to Bow.

-'I'm dying… Do you wanna head down there without me? To make sure we actually get our issues?'

Bow's reply was almost instantaneous. He must have been bored too.

-'I don't wanna go without you :(.... Can't you just leave if no one's showing up?'

-'Technically no. bc someone still has 38 minutes /to/ show up.'

Bow sent her a gif of a Kermit doll swirling slowly in a tub of water, drawing a quiet snicker from Glimmer. She was scrolling through her own collection of gifs, looking for a reply when the slam of heavy textbooks hitting the table nearly startled her out of her chair.

" *SSSSSSSSSSHHH* !" came the hiss from the librarian.

"Sorry…," the girl who had just encroached upon Glimmer's meme search whispered back, her face turning pink.

Glimmer didn't recognize her, but then again, she didn't really know any of the jocks and this girl was clearly one of them. She was still wearing her, whatever sport, uniform, the white and purple colors of Bright Moon High contrasting her tan skin...really nicely. Her long blonde hair was done up in a ponytail that poofed out on the top of her head. It was...A weird choice, in Glimmer's opinion, but she held her tongue as the girl plopped down into the seat next to her, dropping her gym bag on the floor.

"Hi, are you, um...This is the tutoring space, yeah?"

"Oh, yes." Glimmer's eyes flickered to her laptop as if hoping she'd forgotten that this girl had made an appointment.

"Okay. Awesome. I wasn't sure if I had to sign up or just… Walk in, or--So…. Here I am." She swallowed and then held out her hand for Glimmer to shake. "I'm Adora."

"Glimmer." She took the girls hand, noting the incredibly calloused palms. If she knew sports better, that might have been a better giveaway than the lacrosse stick poking out of the bag at her feet.

Adora smiled. It was bright and warm and made Glimmer's heart do a stupid kick flip in her chest.

"Nice to meet you. Oh! You don't have to-I made it on time, right?"

Glimmer glanced at the clock, thirty five minutes that she suddenly wished would move a lot slower.

"You're good," Glimmer insisted. "We've got time. What did you need help with?"

"Well," Adora reached into her bag and pulled out a haggard notebook and opened one of her textbooks. "I'm in Trig this year, but the tests are killing me. The homework is so dense too and our professor loads it on. It's like he thinks he teaches the only class in the entire school."

Glimmer took a quick glance at the girl's notes. They were haphazard, barely legible, and intermingled with random doodles and drawings.

"Uh, well… It usually helps me to build a cheat sheet. Especially for a subject like math, with all the formulas and stuff, right?" Glimmer said, flipping Adora's notebook to a new sheet and pulling out a pencil. "So why don't we start with that. I find it makes homework faster and then the practice makes tests seem easier, and it all kinda snowballs from there."

Adora nodded, enraptured as the two went through her textbook, Glimmer writing down the most important formulas in her much neater handwriting. As soon as they were done with that, they went on to practicing some of the most recent homework problems Adora had been assigned. The girl was quick to catch on, using the cheat sheet Glimmer had made her efficiently. If anything she seemed a little flustered and somewhat nervous, her leg constantly bouncing beneath the table. If Glimmer had to guess, it was a struggle with concentration that was causing her issues in the classroom.

Maybe there was a way she could help with that too…

"Is that right?" Adora asked, pushing the paper towards Glimmer, with the solution she'd come to. Glimmer looked it over, finger tapping her chin for dramatic effect.

"Hmm...I have no idea."

Adora snorted and then laughed out loud earning another harsh 'SSHH' from the librarian.

“You’re the tutor!” she yell/whispered to Glimmer who was biting her lip to keep from giggling.

“Yeah and? I don’t know *everything* ,” Glimmer whispered back as she flipped to the solutions section in the textbook. “But this does.”

Adora stared at the book like she’d never seen words before. “That’s in there?”

“Yeah! All textbooks have a solutions section. Most kids I know just cheat out of it.”

Adora gaped at her, as if the concept of cheating were foreign too.

“Don’t do that though,” Glimmer amended, and Adora nodded solemnly. “You don’t learn anything that way. So what do you think?” she continued as she pushed the book back towards the blonde. “Homework seem a bit more manageable for tonight, at least?”

“Yeah, it does. Thanks for your help. I--Um, do you have other days you tutor?”

“Every day,” Glimmer replied, glancing at her phone as it began to buzz.

“Perfect! I don’t have practice on Fridays, I could come in earlier and stay later. I play for the lacrosse team usually--,”

“I got that,” Glimmer pointed lazily with her pencil at the lacrosse stick falling out of Adora’s bag.

The blonde blushed, nudging the bag aside with her foot. Glimmer offered her a warm smile to let her know it was just a tease, when her phone buzzed yet again.

“Do you need to get that?” Adora asked, glancing at Glimmer’s sparkly phone case.

“It’s just my friend Bow,” she looked up at the library clock. “But I probably should wrap it up… He wanted to head down to the Hall of Heroes today.”

“The comic book shop?” Adora asked as she stuffed her books into her already stuffed gym bag.

Glimmer paused, gritting her teeth. She’d become so comfortable around Adora in the last thirty minutes, that she’d completely forgotten that this was a jock sitting across from her. There was no way she wasn’t about to be teased for wanting to go buy comic books. Unable to back out now, Glimmer nodded quietly.

“I love that place! The new Captain Fusion came out today, I think.”

Glimmer felt the world drop out from under her feet at Adora’s words.

“Yeah…,” she began slowly, rising from her chair when Adora did too. “We were gonna go try to snag some copies. Did you… Do you want to come…? Or…?” She pointed to Adora’s gym bag.

“Oh!” Adora looked down at the lacrosse gear. “No, I’m good today. Yeah, Id’--I mean if you guys wouldn’t mind me tagging along… That could be fun.”

“Let’s hurry then before he I waste all my data downloading the thousands of gifs he’s already sent me,” Glimmer told her, holding out the phone to show that she had 20 new text messages. Snickering, Adora grabbed her things and followed Glimmer out of the library, waving politely to the librarian as they passed.

“Do you guys go a lot?” Adora asked, more loudly now that they were out in the empty hall. Her eyes shone with an excitement that hadn’t been there as they slogged through homework. “I can never get any of my friends to go with me.

‘ *Can’t imagine why…’*

“When we have the money! Comics books are not a poor man or woman’s hobby.”

Adora chuckled again before pointing to Glimmer’s hoodie. “I like your pins.”

Glimmer looked down, momentarily forgetting she’d been wearing them all day.

“Oh, yeah. Thanks.”

“What are they for?”

“Anime and stuff mostly…,” Glimmer pulled the collar of her hoodie out to study the pins upside down. “This one says ‘yeet or be yeeted’.”

“That’s awesome.” Adora laughed and Glimmer couldn’t help but beam back at her. “Your hair is cool too,” she pointed to the pink/purple mess on Glimmer’s head. “Also anime inspired?”

“How’d you guess?”

Adora smirked and Glimmer’s heart did that jumpy thing again.

“What’s your favorite comic book?”

“I mean, Captain Fusion is up there, obviously,” Glimmer said, pulling a pack of gum out of her pocket to calm her nerves and offering a piece to Adora. “But Batman is my favorite.”

“Harley Quinn fan?” Adora teased, taking the gum.

Glimmer snorted. “Please, Poison Ivy gave me my gay awakening.”

“Ah, right,” Adora’s chuckle turned nervous as she choked slightly on the gum.

Luckily, it was at that moment that Bow came charging down the hall. “Glimmer!! We have five minutes to get down to the shop at

this point! I--," He paused, taking in the sight of Glimmer meandering towards him with Adora right beside her. "Hello?"

"Bow, this is Adora. She was the last student to come in for tutoring and said she'd like to come check out Captain Fusion with us."

"Hi," Adora held out her hand for Bow, who shook it instantly. "Nice to meet you, Bow."

"You play lacrosse?" he asked, falling into line on Glimmer's other side. "That's so cool."

Adora shouldered the bag in a nervous gesture. "Thanks. It's--I like it. Um, thanks for letting me join you guys."

"Of course! The more the merrier! Right, Glimmer?" Bow asked, slinging his arm around her shoulder.

"Right." She turned to grin at Adora, who smiled back a bit more shyly.

"Captain Fusion here we come!"

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer blinked, returning to the present as jarringly as if she'd just been pulled from an icy bath. She was standing alone with Adora in her apartment now, the boxes piled high around the room.

She wasn't sure where Bow was and she didn't remember saying goodbye to him either.

But Adora was shuffling nervously from foot-to-foot, scratching at her undercut in such a blatant display of anxiety that Glimmer assumed Bow was long gone.

"Did you want to go see if we could find that mattress now?"

“Oh, yeah. Right, we should probably do that.” A quick look at the microwave clock told her it was late in the evening now anyway. And unless she wanted to spend the night literally sleeping in the bathtub, then they needed to go now.

It only took another trip down the stairs to remind Glimmer to take a shower later. They piled into Adora’s truck, heading downtown for the 24-hour Bright-Mart. It wasn’t until they’d pulled into the parking lot that they saw the sign.

“‘Closed for Construction’,” Adora read aloud, slumping back in her seat and casting a baleful glance in Glimmer’s direction. “Sorry… I didn’t realize. But, we can just come back tomorrow. Or whenever… Um.”

“It’s cool, Adora, really,” Glimmer tried to sound more casual than she felt. “I’ll sleep on the floor, or in one of my boxes or something.”

“Or…,” Adora paused, drawing her bottom lip between her teeth. Glimmer tried not to watch it slide back out slowly, now slightly reddened. “We could just… Share my bed? For tonight. I guess? It’s big. Really big. We won’t be squished or anything. And hey-- It’ll be just like old times, right?”

Resisting the urge to space out again and relive the days with Adora back when they were simple, Glimmer just nodded. “Sure, that works. It’s no big deal, okay? Really.”

They drove back to the apartment complex in silence.

As soon as they’d gotten inside, Adora offered the bathroom to Glimmer first, who prepared herself for bed as slowly as she could, a pit of dread filling her stomach. This wouldn’t be weird, would it? This would be fine.

‘ *It’s fine. It’s fine. It’s fine.’*

This wouldn't *re-* awaken anything in her. Right?

Making sure she was bundled in more layers than she usually wore to bed, Glimmer slipped underneath the soft sheets of Adora's bed as the blonde took her place in the bathroom. The mattress was kind of hard, but the sheets were soft and there were a lot of pillows on Glimmer's side and Adora was right. It had to be a king size bed. Why Adora had one so large, Glimmer didn't know, but at least she wasn't at risk of actually kicking Adora in her sleep, probably.

Glimmer's eyes shot to the bedroom door as Adora slipped inside. She was wearing a tank top and some sleep shorts that exposed far too much toned leg for Glimmer's liking. She looked away quickly, eyes locking on the ceiling fan.

She felt the mattress dip as Adora slipped in beside her.

"Comfy?" Adora asked after a brief silence.

"Yeah."

"A little more roomy than old times, huh?"

Glimmer chuckled at that, despite herself. "Definitely."

Back then they'd stuffed themselves into Glimmer's twin bed during their sleepovers. She'd often woken up with Adora's elbow in her face, or a long leg between hers. And they'd always gone to sleep, whispering after Angella had told them to quiet down. Always nearly pressed forehead to forehead in the dark…

"Alright, well… Um, welcome home, I guess. And… G'night, Glim. Sleep tight."

Adora turned off the bedside lamp, plunging the room into darkness.

' *Glim.'*

Only Adora and Bow had ever been close enough for Glimmer to let them use the affectionate shortening of her name. And after

high school, Glimmer had never expected to hear it in Adora's voice again. It set off a funny feeling in her stomach.

She wondered if Adora could hear how loudly her heart was pounding right now, the room was certainly quiet enough.

Slowly, Glimmer closed her eyes, willing herself to sleep. But her mind kept replaying images of nights in her teenage bedroom. So long ago now...

` *Tell me a story, Glim.'*

'You're 17 years old. You want a bedtime story?'

'You tell them so well!'

'Kiss ass.'

'The kissiest.'

'Alright, fine… A bedtime story for the baby.'

'A good one.'

'Ok...I've got one. It's about a hero and a princess…'

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading!

All comments/thoughts are welcome!

Until next time...

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> Hello! A bit more filler here, I'm sorry. Got some bits to set up before we dig in...
>
> In summation: Glimmer and Adora find their stride. Glimmer remembers why and when she crushed in High School. Also they steal things.
>
> Enjoy!

Adora was not in bed when Glimmer woke the next morning.

Which was definitely a good thing. Glimmer wasn't sure how she would have handled staring at her ex-best friends muscled back, or perfect face, in the soft morning light. Probably not well.

Why had she agreed to this again? This was stupid. She was already reeling from her breakup. Piling on the uncomfortable, repressed memories Adora invoked in her was like adding gasoline to a bonfire. Unnecessary and dangerous.

Glimmer stared at the spinning ceiling fan, listening to the whir of a blender and the banging of pots and pans out in the kitchen. The alarm clock on the bedside table read 7a.m. Normally it was far too early for Glimmer to even consider being awake, but the night before hadn't exactly been a restful one. Her mind too busy swirling with high school memories that kept her somewhere between dreaming and barely conscious all night.

With a groan and an enormous stretch, Glimmer flipped onto her stomach, creeping halfway onto Adora's side of the bed. It was still warm and smelled like her. Glimmer closed her eyes, unwilling to face the day yet. She grabbed Adora's (slightly hard) pillow instead, burying her face in it to hide from the sounds outside and the sun creeping in through the window.

It wasn't until she smelled the faint scent of something burning that she decided to rise for the day, kicking off the blankets and shuffling out into the main room.

Adora was in the kitchen, running a steaming (more like smoking really) pan under the sink. She looked over her shoulder when she heard the scrape of a chair against tile as Glimmer plopped down at the table.

"Morning," she beamed, setting the smoking pan down and waving a towel next to the nearby fire alarm a few times. "Sorry. Did I wake you up? I was just making us some eggs."

"And your death smoothie," Glimmer pointed to the greenish-yellow concoction still lying in wait inside the blender.

Adora blinked at it innocently. "It's not a death smoothie. It's good for you."

"If you like *drinking* your vegetables, sure," Glimmer teased, trying to lighten her tone. She knew that the playful sarcasm was probably coming off as way more antagonistic as it should. Especially in her gravelly, 'I just woke up' voice. "But, um, thank you. Breakfast. That's very nice of you…"

The wrinkle between Adora's brow disappeared and she grinned. "Not a problem. It's been awhile since I've had someone over for breakfast. I kinda missed cooking."

Glimmer decided to let the ambiguity of that comment slide, gratefully accepting her plate of slightly burnt eggs and slimy green smoothie. Adora plopped down across from her, digging in immediately, inhaling the burnt bits without even seeming to notice.

Glimmer picked at her food more slowly, her eyes flickering to Adora occasionally. She still looked the same. Glimmer had been too on edge to really study her during their first and subsequent meetings. But now, really, she noticed that nothing significant had changed. Her face was slimmer, the line of her jaw more defined.

But she still sported the same light sprinkling of freckles across her nose. The same slate blue eyes. The undercut was new. And really cool… But Glimmer found her gaze drawn to what she'd never been able to ignore about Adora the night after it had happened. The scar that cut through her left brow. It had faded quite a bit in the last few years, but the hair never grew back.

A constant reminder of that night…

Glimmer wondered if she thought about it every time she looked in the mirror.

Adora chose that moment to meet Glimmer's gaze over the rim of her glass. A hot blush crept up her cheeks and Glimmer immediately hid herself behind her own glass, taking a gulp far too large for her own liking. She swallowed quickly, shuddering at the slimy texture that filled her mouth and then slid down her throat.

"Good?" Adora's tone was earnest, her eyes almost owlish as she waited for Glimmer's response.

Glimmer gave her a thumbs up, not entirely sure she wouldn't throw up if she opened her mouth.

Smiling, satisfied with that answer, Adora picked up their dishes and headed to the sink. Glimmer was almost surprised as she took the time to wash them and place them in the dishwasher instead of dumping them and leaving them for future Adora.

"Want any help?" Glimmer stood up from the table, suddenly unsure of how or where to stand as she looked around the kitchen for something to clean. The damn place was sparkling.

"I've got it," Adora insisted. "You're the guest anyway."

'Well, more like a semi-permanent roommate now,' Glimmer mused, but she did not argue, picking nervously at the table instead.

"So, hey," Adora closed the dishwasher with her foot, wiping her hands on a nearby dish towel as she turned to face Glimmer. "I've got work today but only till noon, so I was thinking we go out after I get back and do something."

"Do something…?"

"Yeah," Adora tossed the towel away, taking a few steps towards Glimmer. She stopped at an odd distance. Almost too far away for it to be a comfortable conversation, but also too close for Glimmer not to battle a blush that threatened to take over her entire body. She was suddenly very aware of the fact that Adora was already dressed for work, and she was still in her sleep shirt and oversized sweatpants.

"We could head downtown and hang out at the mall or something. The park is nice. Maybe Bow can come too?"

"Oh! Oh, yeah… Bow, sure I'll—I can ask him," Glimmer agreed.

"Great. Oh! And before I forget, um, I know you were kinda 'in between jobs'," Adora made air quotes with her fingers and Glimmer pursed her lips to fight the amused smile that threatened to show itself. "But my friend Kyle… You remember, Kyle? From High School?"

Deciding it would probably be best *not* to remind Adora that Glimmer had hated/did not know most of her High School friends, she simply shook her head in silence.

Adora's face fell, as if she hadn't realized that was a silly question… Maybe she hadn't. "Well, anyway, he runs a bar downtown now that's looking for servers. I figured, if you wanted, I'd give him a call for you? You know? It's just a temporary something… You don't *have* to take it either! I just thought—servers make good tip money and stuff and—,"

"No, that's great, Adora. I'd—Yeah, I'd love it if you gave him a call." Glimmer interrupted her rambling, knowing it could go on for quite awhile. In reality, Glimmer had been without a job for almost

a year. Ever since she'd been fired from the independent coffee shop she'd worked at after dropping out of school. God…She was such a loser. And it was especially clear when she stopped to think about it. So, yeah, a serving job. That would be good. Great, in fact.

"Cool," Adora's crooked grin returned. "I'll do that on my way to work then! Maybe he can see you today? I'll let you know."

Glimmer nodded and stepped aside as Adora headed for the bedroom. "In any case, I gotta grab my stuff and take off. But hey, make yourself at home until I get back, okay? What's mine is yours."

Glimmer looked around at the tidy apartment as Adora slipped into the bedroom. She imagined she'd do what she knew best and spend most of the day watching TV from the broken couch, until Adora returned. There didn't seem to be much else to do that might occupy her time, save for a pink yoga mat in the corner. And Glimmer was not about to mess with *any* of that shit.

Plopping down on the couch, Glimmer reached for the remote just as Adora returned, her gym bag slung over her shoulder.

"You gonna be okay?" Adora asked, pausing, one hand already on the doorknob.

"Oh yeah," Glimmer waved her off confidently. "I'm a master of couch potato-ing. Don't worry about me. Go have fun teaching people to release their aggression by punching big heavy things."

Adora chuckled, that stupid cute half smile lifting her lips. "Alright, I'll be back in a few hours."

The door clicked shut behind her and Glimmer stared down at the remote in her hands. Suddenly the idea of spacing out in front of the television didn't seem plausible *or* appealing. Tossing the remote aside, Glimmer rummaged through the piles of boxes they'd left in the corner of the living room. She knew she'd stacked her guitar case here somewhere…

Finding it tucked around the side of Adora's large bookshelf, Glimmer took the aged and battered guitar out of its case and returned to the couch, leaning back against the cushions and folding her legs beneath her as she began to play.

Glimmer plucked absently at the strings on her ukulele, trying to figure out the chord progression that was so much clearer in her head for the new song she was working on. It didn't help that the band hall was rife with activity at the moment. Students walking back and forth, carrying heavy instrument cases, the marching band practicing loudly in the room at the end of the hall and the choir singing in their full soprano glory in the room at the other end.

Glimmer probably should have picked a better spot, maybe underneath a quiet tree outside… But the band hall was practically home anyway, the clarinet case sitting beside her evidence enough of her own participation in the usual chaos.

"Glimmer!"

Glimmer looked up at the sound of her name, expecting to see Bow and surprised to see Adora instead. The jock had been tagging after her and Bow more and more often lately. They were…Kinda friends? Glimmer guessed, at this point. Adora didn't seem embarrassed of them or anything. She'd introduced them to her teammates and then sat with them the last few lunch periods. And she kept asking if they could all go back to the comic book shop together.

Now she was charging down the band hall, drawing a menagerie of confused and judgmental stares. Clique culture ran strong at Bright Moon High. No matter how kind Adora might be, (and how secretly nerdy), she absolutely wasn't welcome in this half of the school while wearing her lacrosse uniform.

"Hey," Adora plopped down beside Glimmer, ignorant of the stares, leaning back against the linoleum wall. "I couldn't find you

in the cafeteria, but Bow said you spend lunch period up here sometimes."

"He'd be right," Glimmer pushed her clarinet case aside so that Adora could scoot closer. "I wasn't hungry and wanted to play. Welcome to the realm of my people, by the way."

Adora looked around, waving at a baffled group of tuba players as they passed by. It was almost…charming, how ignorant—or maybe just indifferent—she was to the hard looks.

"It's nice. Definitely doesn't smell as bad as locker rooms."

Glimmer snorted, the strings on her ukulele twanging.

"I didn't know you played," Adora pointed to the ukulele and then the clarinet case.

"I am, unfortunately," Glimmer heaved a weary sigh. "A band geek."

"That's so cool." Adora's genuine response was not what she'd expected. She was beaming at Glimmer, blue eyes practically sparkling. "I don't know the first thing about instruments. My foster mother refuses to let them inside the house. Says they're too loud and obnoxious."

Glimmer frowned, but held her tongue, not sure she knew Adora well enough yet to go off on her foster mother. But who didn't like *music?*

Also… Adora had a foster mother?

"I guess I could understand that if you were, like, playing drums or something…But a ukulele is really small and quiet." She glanced down at the purple painted, sparkly instrument before handing it to Adora. "Want me to teach you?"

Adora blinked down at it in awe, as if Glimmer had just gifted her the entire world. "Really…?"

“It’s easy,” Glimmer shrugged and placed the ukulele in Adora’s lap. “Okay, hold the neck in your left hand, like that, yeah. But bow your wrist out a bit more. And then rest this part on your thigh. Comfy?”

Adora looked nervous now, like she was handling a baby. “Yes?”

“It’s important that your comfortable! If you tense up, you’ll be able to hear it when you play.”

Adora forced her shoulders to relax, slumping against the wall as Glimmer scooted to sit in front of her to better guide her fingers.

“Okay, I’ll teach you some chords. We’ll do the easy ones first.”

Glimmer felt a blush warming her cheeks as she gently moved Adora’s long, calloused fingers over the strings. She lingered longer than she knew she should, running her own fingers over the blonde’s knuckles, as if she could imagine what that rough skin might feel like elsewhere.

‘Bad, Glimmer. Stop that.’

Shaking her head, forcing herself to focus, Glimmer manage to teach Adora a few chord placements before encouraging her to strum. An uncertain and wobbly noise came out of the ukulele as Adora played the chords she’d been taught; but the girl was absolutely glowing with joy. She laughed, looking up at Glimmer with those sparkling eyes.

“I think I need some more practice,” Adora chuckled as she relinquished the ukulele back to Glimmer.

“Come back again sometime then,” Glimmer replied easily, strumming a few chords as she leaned back against the wall. “I’d be happy to teach you.”

“Will you play for me?”

Glimmer froze, chancing a glance over at Adora, who was leaning towards her now, expectantly.

"Oh, um, yeah…Sure," Glimmer cleared her throat and began to play the new song she'd been working on, humming the melody quietly. So quietly, she hoped that Adora might not hear it behind the chaos of the band hall. But the blonde listened intently, her smile growing somehow broader as Glimmer played.

When she finished, letting the song die on the last chord she'd written down, Adora sat back—Glimmer hadn't realized how close she'd gotten.

"That was amazing! You're really good… Did you write that?"

Glimmer nodded, suddenly uncharacteristically shy of her talent. Before Adora could speak again, the bell rang signaling the end of the lunch period. The blonde stood, grabbing Glimmer's clarinet case for her and offering a hand to help her to her feet.

"Can I really come back tomorrow?" she asked, easily tugging Glimmer up when she took the strong and calloused hand.

"Yeah, of course," Glimmer slung the ukulele around her shoulders, ignoring the odd looks the two of them received as they walked out together. "Anytime."

Adora smiled again—bright and kind, and Glimmer felt her whole world turning upside down.

By the time Adora got back from work, Glimmer had peeled herself off the couch long enough to shower, make a sandwich (which she was sure to clean up afterwards), and change into the first non-pajama type clothing she'd worn in days.

She paused to examine herself in the full-length mirror inside Adora's bedroom door. A deep red skirt over a pair of (fashionably) ripped tights, her hot pink doc martens, and a tank top with a cut off jean vest over top.

Break-up and depression aside, she could still rock it.

She heard the front door open and quickly hurried out of the bedroom to meet her host.

"Hey, sorry I'm late. I stopped to get you a copy of the key and I —," Adora stopped, glancing up at Glimmer from where she'd been rummaging around in her pocket. Her slate blue eyes raked unabashedly over her body, absorbing—and probably trying to understand—the new look. It was a big change from high school.

"Oh," Adora murmured faintly, her knuckles whitening on the key in her palm. "You look nice."

"Thanks," Glimmer couldn't find herself to tease, or maybe even flirt, the look on Adora's face was too genuine. The tension became a bit unbearable after a moment though, as they continued to stare at each other. Glimmer cleared her throat and pointed to Adora's fist. "Um, you got me a key?"

"Oh! Right, yeah," Adora crossed the room quickly, dropping the small golden key into Glimmer's hand. "Just so, y'know, you're not reliant on me to get in and out."

"Thanks," Glimmer gave her a genuine smile. "That was really thoughtful of you."

Adora just shrugged, turning away, but not before Glimmer caught the hint of a flustered blush. "We're roommates now. You *need* one."

Glimmer pursed her lips, slipping the key into her vest pocket before following Adora into the kitchen. The blonde was currently downing a glass of water. Glimmer's eyes followed the flex of her throat.

"So," pushing down the weird fluttering in her gut, Glimmer leaned as casually as she could against the kitchen table. "Were we gonna go to the mall? Or…whatever?"

“Sure!” Adora slammed the glass down a little too hard; they both jumped. “Ah, lemme go get changed and we can head out. Was Bow coming?”

“Uh,” Glimmer panicked, realizing she’d had all morning to ask and had completely forgotten. “Lemme double check.”

Pulling out her phone as Adora slipped into the bedroom, she sent a quick, frenzied text to Bow.

-‘BOW CAN YOU MEET ME AND ADORA AT THE MALL IN LIKE 10 MINUTES? IT’S IMPORTANT’

-‘I’ve got another class. Why? What’s going on?’

-‘I don’t want to go with her alone!! I need your support!’

-‘Glimmer. You’ll be fine. Reconnect. It won’t hurt you.’

-‘BOW’

-‘glimmer.’

Adora returned from the fastest wardrobe change ever and Glimmer quickly stuffed her phone away into her purse. “Um… He won’t be able to make it.”

Adora’s face fell, but Glimmer was too busy examining her outfit to really notice.

She wore a pair of faded (and cuffed) jeans, a plain white t-shirt, beat up red converse sneakers, and a jacket Glimmer remembered very well.

“You still have that old jacket?” she teased, hoping too late she didn’t actually offend her new roommate. But Adora just stuffed her hands in the pockets and chuckled.

“Still fits! Why not wear it?”

“Cuz it makes you look like a jock-meathead,” Glimmer pointed out helpfully as Adora grabbed her wallet and keys off the table and headed for the door.

“I am what I am,” she blonde shot back, jerking her chin for Glimmer to follow. “Let’s go, Flowers.”

“Are you comparing me to a comic book character?”

Concern tightened Adora’s features for a moment. “I thought you liked comic books? Or you know…You use to. I didn’t—With the hair, I just—,”

“Relax,” Glimmer nudged Adora’s shoulder as she locked the door behind them. “I’m fucking with you. But you would not be the first to make that reference.”

Adora’s face eased into a playful smirk. “Damn. Not as clever as I thought I was.”

“Did that need to be stated?” Glimmer called over her shoulder as she headed down the stairs. She wasn’t quite sure where the confidence was coming from. But easing back into bantering with Adora was something she remembered well. It was comfortable.

It was easy.

“Did I walk in with a target on my back or something?” Adora called, scurrying after her. Glimmer could see her grinning, despite the drawl in her voice. “Because I basically gifted you a whole apartment about five minutes ago. You’d think I’d get a little thanks.”

Glimmer simply stuck out her tongue out, all the replies spinning in her head would take them uncomfortably into X-rated territory. And she was certain Adora wouldn’t be able to field them. So she switched on the radio as they hopped into the car, taking off down the street towards downtown.

“Classic avoidance maneuver,” Adora laughed, even as she turned the radio louder.

The drive to the mall wasn’t long and before Glimmer knew it, Adora was pulling into the parking lot in front of:

“Split Happens?” Glimmer gaped up at the neon bowling alley sign in awe. “I haven’t been to this place since—,”

“High school?” Adora finished for her, with a knowing grin as she slid out of the car.

Glimmer waited patiently for Adora to open the sticky passenger side door for her, supposing it wasn’t too terrible to be treated like royalty for a bit.

Together they made their way into the alley. Immediately, Glimmer was hit with the familiar scent of cheap pizza, old shoes, and that weird plastic-y smell that seemed to seem into every surface of old arcades.

“Hope you wore socks.” Glimmer nearly jumped out of her skin, when Adora’s voice ghosted right beside her ear as she headed for the counter. An involuntary shiver passed through Glimmer at the soft heat of her breath against her neck.

‘*Stop… Not today,’*

“Who doesn’t wear socks with doc martens?” Glimmer asked, scurrying after the taller woman. “That would be disgusting.”

Adora tossed a teasing grin over her shoulder as she ordered them some bowling shoes. It shouldn’t have surprised Glimmer but watching Adora order size 9 shoes for herself was still a little shocking. Granted, Glimmer had always had exceptionally tiny feet. Adora was tall, so it made sense…Why was she thinking so much about feet anyway?

“Should we get some pizza?” Adora asked as she guided them to a free lane.

“Beers first,” Glimmer insisted, picking out a pink, sparkly ball.

Adora blinked at her. “You don’t think drinking might mess up your aim?”

“Oh, I’m sure it will. But I don’t play to win. I play to have a good time.” Adora watched dumbfounded as Glimmer threw her first strike. “Oh, but… Looks like I might win anyway.”

She clapped imaginary dust off her hands, smirking at Adora, who chuckled—a determined look crossing her face. “We’ll see about that, Glim. The gloves are off now.”

Maybe it was the comfortable atmosphere of the bowling alley, or the stupid old jacket Adora wore, or the familiar smells that reminded Glimmer of a simpler time. But the longer they played, the more the tension wore away. After a while, they weren’t two people who had drifted apart. They weren’t new roommates with nothing in common. They were Glimmer and Adora.

The Best Friends Squad.

“Strike!”

Adora had taken off her jacket a long time ago, revealing her honed arms beneath the plain white t-shirt she wore. And Glimmer was already on her second beer, struggling to ignore what those arms were doing to her right now.

Adora plopped down at the little table, trying to inhale a particularly cheesy piece of pizza while also maintaining aggressively smug eye contact with Glimmer. The result was a wad of cheese and sauce plopping directly onto Adora’s crotch.

“Aw!” Adora stared down sadly at the goop while Glimmer (courtesy of the two cheap beers) burst into hysterical laughter.

“That’s literally what you get for being so cocky,” Glimmer snorted, rocking back in her seat.

Even Adora chuckled at that, wiping the cheese off as best she could with a napkin.

"Your turn."

"Alright, watch and weep," Glimmer stood, wobbled slightly, and threw a supremely impressive gutter ball.

"Ooooh, how the mighty fall," Adora pouted out her bottom lip, laughing loudly when Glimmer flipped her off.

"I'm still ahead," she pointed at the screen, to show that she was in fact about 7 points ahead.

"Not for long," Adora disagreed, rolling up her sleeves, and oh god did that do something funny to Glimmer's stomach.

Probably just the beers though…

Adora made another impressive shot, pulling her ahead. She stooped low as Glimmer gave her a round of exaggerated applause. A few more turns of hijinks and gentle teasing and Glimmer had (sloppily) managed to win the game. The screen shot a bunch of fake confetti around her score in celebration.

Glimmer turned around just in time to see Adora approaching her, in the next second she'd placed a child's paper birthday tiara on her head.

"Good game, Princess."

Glimmer reached up, taking the crown off to examine it. "Where the fuck did you get this?"

Adora pointed over her shoulder as a children's birthday party taking place in the next lane.

"You stole this from a kid?!" Glimmer scream whispered, although a laugh was begging to escape.

“I thought it was a cute gesture!”

“Not if they catch us.”

“You’re right,” Adora snickered, taking Glimmer’s hand and grabbing her jacket off the seat. “Let’s bail.”

The two made a mad dash for the door, cackling like…well, children; the crowns still clutched tightly in Glimmer’s hand. It wasn’t until they were safely inside the car that Glimmer asked, “Since when did you become such a rebel?”

“I’ve always been—,”

“You have not!” Glimmer put the crown back on her head, eyeing the text in the rearview mirror. ‘Happy 11th Birthday!’. “You were the straightest gay girl in school.”

Adora’s cheeks flushed. “People change. I learned how to have a little fun in the last three years.”

“Uh, Adora….?” Glimmer looked down at their feet. “Did you maybe also learn how to become a felon? Because we totally stole these shoes.”

“Aw, fuck…”

-‘Bow.’

-‘Yes?’

-‘*Bow.’*

-‘Yes *Glimmer*?’

-‘she’s so cute Bow.’

-‘who…?’

-‘Adora’

-‘*O h…’*

Bow’s typing bubble disappeared and then the image of a Kermit doll bent over holding his…hole open with his hands appeared in their chat.

-‘is this you’

-‘*BOW!!* Shkgshlgkhsdgl that’s horrible’

-‘am I wrong?’

Ignoring that obvious question, Glimmer continued with:

-‘she’s been having me teach her ukulele at lunch… she’s so bad it’s so cute’

-‘plus her muscles, amirite?’

-‘I was trying not to be a perv about it… but… yeah… she’s hot too.’

-‘her butt’s nice’

-‘BOOOOWWWW’

-‘you were thinking it. I could tell. The braincell we share was quaking.’

-‘what do I do?’

-‘what do u men?’

-‘mean*’

-‘Do I…confess???? IDK I’ve known her for like a week and a hjalf…’ Glimmer didn’t bother to correct her own spelling error.

-‘maybe hold off on that a bit Casanova.’

-‘who’s that?’

Bow glossed over that: ‘What do you really know about this girl? Keep it cool. Be her friend. See where it goes!’

-‘Yeah…You’re right, yes, yeah….Yes, I can do that…’

-‘I’m always right.’

Glimmer left him on read and switched over to her text chain with Adora. It was very short… Consisting mainly of, ‘you tutoring?’ or ‘are you in the band hall?’ over and over again.

Fingers trembling, Glimmer propped herself up against her pillows, wording and rewording her message until she sent:

-‘Hey! Bow and I are gonna do a movie marathon on Friday night. Wanna join?’

She’d ask Bow if he was cool with that later. There was no response for awhile. Long enough to make Glimmer nervous, when finally, Adora’s typing bubble appeared.

-‘what movies?’

-‘good ones….come on…pls…we’ll have so many snacks…’

There was a brief pause… a few abandoned typing bubbles and then:

-‘what time?’

Success.

-‘whenever you’re done with practice!’

-‘I’ll have to ask…’

-‘ask?’ Glimmer sent her a laughing face. ‘dude you’re like 17!’

Adora’s typing bubble disappeared long enough for Glimmer to realize she’d probably said the wrong thing.

-‘sorry… please come? If you can. We’d love to have you.’

Adora sent her an upside-down smiley face and Glimmer tossed her phone aside, somehow she’d already managed to fuck up. After a few moments of emotional agony, her phone buzzed again and Glimmer lunged for it immediately.

-‘mission is a go.’

Glimmer sighed as she felt her world turning again.

They’d returned the shoes, but not the crown. It rested on Adora’s bedside table. A trophy from the day.

Of course, it wasn’t until they’d gotten home late that they realized they’d forgotten the mattress again. Adora had offered to sleep on the couch, but they’d ended up sharing the bed again without much argument. Adora was fluffing her pillows, squirming on her side, trying to find a comfortable spot and Glimmer was flipping through her phone while simultaneously texting Bow about the day’s events.

-‘have fun?’

-‘It was….a blast… I guess I missed her…a little bit. Not a lot. Don’t make it a big deal.’

Bow sent her a very familiar Kermit picture.

-‘actual photo of you.’

-‘fucK yo’

She couldn’t finish the text before Adora rolled over to face her and Glimmer nearly threw her phone across the room to hide the picture Bow had sent.

“Oh, hey, I completely forgot to tell you. Kyle said he’d love to see you around noon tomorrow for an interview. Can you swing that?”

“Lucky for him,” Glimmer plastered on a nervous smile. “My schedule is wide open.”

Adora’s smile was soft, affectionate. It made Glimmer’s heart do a flip in her chest.

‘Stop. That. You. Piece. Of—’

“Cool. I’m sure you’ll do great. Kyle’s nice too. You’ve basically already got the job.” Adora yawned wide and then shook her hair, freeing her hair of its usual ponytail. She turned onto her other side, back to Glimmer, golden locks spilling onto the white sheets. “Night, Glim.”

Glimmer watched her quietly for some time, waiting until her breathing slowed and the moon was highlighting strands of her hair.

“Night, Adora.”

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

:D

Enter the M-rated Spicy part of this slow burn

This just in: Adora really wants to kiss Glimmer. But hey, she remembers she wanted that in High School too. She gets way too high for her own good and Glimmer's alone time isn't as 'alone' as she thought it might be.

Oh, also, lemme just give ya'll whiplash and put in a trigger warning for themes of child abuse....

Adora woke bright and early the next morning, just minutes before her alarm. Which was probably a good thing, considering Glimmer had proven not to be much of a morning person. Very carefully, Adora crept out of bed, slipping into the kitchen to prepare a (quieter) breakfast than usual. She left some extra bacon and eggs for Glimmer, along with a note and a few bucks for an Uber, on the kitchen table. Glimmer had her interview with Kyle today, but Adora would be at work until at least noon. She'd offered to pick Glimmer up afterwards via the note afterwards.

After finishing breakfast, Adora made her way to the bathroom, dealing with her morning routine before slipping quietly back into the bedroom to change. Her uniform was easy to find, hung perfectly pristine in her closet, waiting for her. Her shoes, on the other hand, had suddenly vanished. Confused, wondering briefly if she'd left them in the car after the bowling shoe debacle, Adora made a quick search of the room.

Under the bed? No.

Behind the dresser? No.

Hiding inside the closet? Adora wasn't sure how they could have gotten there, but she checked anyway, crouching low to peer into the darkest corners of her closet. No shoes. But she did see a box she wasn't familiar with.

All of Glimmer's move in boxes still lay stacked in the living room, and they were all labeled. This one was smaller than the others and free of any text. Confused, wondering if it was something Adora herself had stored away and forgotten about, the blonde grabbed the box, pulling it open as her curiosity piqued.

What she saw made her eyes bulge. This was definitely not her box. No less than three dildos, all of varying size and colors, lay stacked inside, along with what looked to be a few small bullet looking objects. Adora almost reached out to touch one before she realized she'd be putting her hands on something that had very likely been inside—

Holy fuck.

It hit her like a brick. She was staring at a box full of sex toys, absolutely belonging to her new roommate. Adora stared down at the longest dildo. A hot pink model, curved at the tip. In the back of her mind she could see Glimmer, naked, one hand easing the toy inside herself. Slowly…. A low moan rumbling in her chest….

Slamming the box shut, Adora shoved it back into the corner and bolted out of the room. Fuck it, she'd wear dress shoes. She *could not* be in the apartment a moment longer.

She drove to work slowly, her mind still playing back the images of the many toys… Each one of them exhibiting a scene in which Glimmer used them on herself in a different way. Squeezing her eyes shut, Adora shook her head fiercely. This wasn't right. Or appropriate! Glimmer had hidden them for a reason. Adora wasn't supposed to know about them, much less fantasize about using them.

With her… Friend.

Her *friend.*

They'd always been friends… Just friends.

…Fuck.

It was going to be a long day and Adora's mind was already spinning with repressed memories…

Adora took a deep breath, pausing just outside the enormous double doors of the Sato family mansion. Well, okay, it wasn't really a mansion. But it was far larger than the house she lived in with Mrs. Weaver. And in a nicer part of town too. They had a big gate and everything.

Steadying herself, hoping she'd parked her bike in a spot that wouldn't be in the way of any cars, Adora knocked on the large doors. She stepped back immediately, as if they might swing open on their own, and tucked her hands behind her back, trying to look as presentable as possible and less like the sweaty, tired mess she was.

She heard a faint 'I got it!' shouted from inside and then the doors were swinging open and Glimmer stood in the entryway, beaming at her. She was dressed in a set of pink and purple pajamas, a pillow tucked underneath one arm. Bow was nowhere to be seen, but Adora heard him holler her name from somewhere inside the enormous house.

"You made it!" Glimmer exclaimed, sounding almost as breathless as Adora felt.

"Yeah, I… Um, I can't stay too long. My curfew is midnight."

Glimmer 'pfffffted' and waved her off before literally dragging her inside by the wrist. Adora knew better than to struggle, instead following her host inside, taking in the ornate and pristine interior of the house. She could see a large kitchen off to the right, two

adults she recognized as Glimmer's parents, wandering around preparing bowls of something.

To the left, the direction Glimmer dragged her, was a gigantic living room, with a large domed ceiling. Adora was so busy staring up at it that she almost tripped over Bow, who was sprawled on the floor, underneath a large blanket/pillow fort he and Glimmer must had built before Adora arrived.

"You made it!" He threw his arms out, parroting Glimmer and reaching out to drag Adora down into the fort. They'd left an opening large enough to see the *enormous* television screen mounted against the opposite wall of the living room.

"Get comfy!" Glimmer plopped down beside her, setting the large pillow she'd been carrying behind her and lying back. "Mom and Dad are almost done with the snacks and then they said we have the living room to ourselves all night!"

She high fived Bow behind Adora's back, who decided not to point out again that she'd have to leave before midnight. It was already almost nine o' clock now.

"What are we watching?" she asked instead, still sitting ramrod straight as Bow and Glimmer melted into a puddle around her.

"Alien!" Bow snarled, raising his hands into claws. "It's a fav. You ever seen it?"

"I don't really do horror movies," Adora admitted.

Glimmer tugged the back of her shirt, pulling Adora down until she was lying between them.

"It's more of a thriller. It's not really '*scary*, scary'," Glimmer explained and Adora found herself almost entranced by the enthusiastic sparkle in her eyes. It was impossible not to be excited when Glimmer was smiling at her like that.

"Okay," Adora's voice broke shyly under the absolute brilliance of Glimmer's beaming grin. She was so ridiculously excited to have Adora *here*. Hanging out with them outside of school. And Adora wasn't really sure why, but it made her feel all tingly and fuzzy.

It was at that moment that a large shadow loomed over Adora and she looked up to see a man with long black hair pulled up into a bun, dark eyes, and a smile that matched Glimmer's hovering above them. He was balancing at least four bowls of snacks in his arms.

"Grubs up," he exclaimed, crouching to set the bowls at the front of their fort.

"Thanks Dad!" Glimmer scrambled forward to pull the treats inside, but the man cleared his throat, raising one thick brow at his daughter and Glimmer paused.

"Oh! Sorry. Dad, this is Adora. She's our friend from school." Glimmer nudged Adora's shoulder. "Adora this is my dad."

"It's nice to meet you, Mr. Sato," Adora dipped her chin politely. "Thank you for having me over tonight."

"It's absolutely our pleasure, Adora," he replied, his grin somehow growing. "Bow practically lives here as it is. Any friend of Glimmer's is welcome. And please, call me Micah. Mr. Sato makes me sound old."

Well, Adora didn't think she was physically capable of doing that, but she smiled and nodded anyway.

"Do you play for the school?" Micah gestured to the jersey Adora still wore from practice.

Once again, Adora offered a nod. "Lacrosse."

"Excellent sport. I used to be a football guy back in my school days." Micah fully sat down on the floor with them now, leaning back on his palms.

“DaaAAD,” Glimmer interrupted, shoving her father’s shoulder. “Adora doesn’t care. She came here to watch a movie. She doesn’t want your sports career story!”

“I—I don’t mind,” Adora objected, not wanting to be rude. Glimmer gave her a glare that said ‘betrayal’. But Micah just chuckled.

“Maybe some other time then. I expect we’ll be seeing a lot more of you around here, Adora?” He glanced questioningly at her, but before Adora could respond, another person interrupted.

The smoothest, most soothing voice Adora had ever heard (with just the hint of an accent) asked, “Is everyone settled?”

“Mom!” Glimmer poked her head out of the fort. “Get Dad out of here, he’s trying to tell stories to my friends again.”

“Wouldn’t that be a tragedy,” Glimmer’s mother chuckled, shaking her head. Her long, light colored hair flowed elegantly around her shoulders with the movement. Adora couldn’t see much similarities between Glimmer and her mother. She was tall and thin with a sharp face and light hair. Her eyes matched Glimmer’s though, the same striking lavender. However, whereas Glimmer’s were warm and welcoming. This woman’s eyes were sharp, striking. And there was an air of elegance around her that both Glimmer and her father seemed to lack.

The woman’s intense gaze landed on Adora, a perfectly pleasant smile spreading her lips.

“Glimmer?” Adora noticed she left the ‘R’ off of Glimmer’s name. “Won’t you introduce me to your new friend?”

Glimmer heaved a sigh, rolling her eyes, clearly ready for her parents to excuse themselves from movie night. “Mom, Adora. Adora, Mom.”

“Pleasure, Adora.” Adora assumed the sourness in her tone was directed at her daughter’s impatience. “My name is Angella.”

“The pleasure’s all mine, An—Mrs. S—Sato.”

Angella’s smile warmed and she tapped Micah’s shoulder. He rose with a grunt, weaving an arm around his wife’s waist.

“Alright, we’ll leave you kids to it. Have fun, don’t stay up too late. School tomorrow, remember?”

“Yeah, yeah, we know,” Glimmer waved them away, batting at Micah’s hand when he ruffled her already messy hair.

Adora watched them go, earnestly wishing for more time. Angella was a little intimidating, but Micah seemed warm, and—she’d never had an adult take a genuine interest in something she cared about before….

“Adora!” Glimmer’s face appearing inches in front of her ripped her back to reality.

“Y—yeah?” Adora could *feel* the blush creeping up her neck.

“You ready?” Glimmer aimed the remote at the TV, that had suddenly queued up the movie when she wasn’t looking.

“Oh, yeah… Yes.”

“Relax,” Glimmer pushed gently on her shoulder, guiding her back down to lean against the pillow mountain. “Get cozy.”

Bow plopped a bowl of popcorn in each of their laps, then pulled up a large pink blanket, draping it over the three of them. Adora finally allowed herself to settle, taking her popcorn on kernel at a time. The movie started slowly; it gave her time to zone out… To consider how strange this all felt. To be so at home, so comfortable with people who were still practically strangers to her. They were all so welcoming, inviting, interested in *her* as a person. It was equal parts exciting and terrifying.

She settled into the blankets and pillows more fully, abandoning her popcorn and ignoring the time. She felt Bow yawn loudly to

her right as he pulled out his phone, beginning to scroll through his apps, bored, even as the movie ramped up.

Glimmer had sunken against her left side, her head propped on Adora's shoulder, as if the fifty other pillows weren't good enough. It was… Strangely intimate for how short a time she'd known Glimmer. Even still, Adora couldn't find it in herself to move. Glimmer was warm, and soft and her hair smelled like lavender. It made Adora's stomach flutter.

Her attention finally returned to the screen at the wrong moment. Just as the creature burst out of the man's chest. Adora cringed, turning her head away instinctually, her nose finding its way into Glimmer's cloud of hair at the same time her hand clamped down on her thigh.

She froze. Horrified Glimmer might pull away. But instead the girl giggled softly and laced her fingers through Adora's clenched ones.

"You really aren't great with these movies, are you?" She murmured, tipping her head up until she was looking at Adora with a smirk.

Adora's breath caught in her throat; she could practically count Glimmer's long dark eyelashes, see the shine of her lips glowing in the television light. Swallowing thickly, Adora unconsciously squeezed her hand and shook her head.

"Not great. No."

"It's okay. I've got you," Glimmer hummed, turning back to face the TV and leaning into Adora's shoulder once more. Slowly, so slowly, Adora eased into Glimmer as well. Her eyes beginning to droop, despite the horror happening on screen. Before she knew it, she'd turned slightly, curling against Glimmer's side as her head lolled and her eyes slipped shut.

The world went black and the last thing she remembered was Glimmer's warm hand squeezing her own.

Adora didn’t know where she was when she woke the next morning. After struggling with a brief and minor panic attack, she slowly gained awareness of her surroundings.

After a moment, Adora realized she was still inside the Sato house. Which meant she’d missed her curfew, which meant she was absolutely going to be busted when she got home. Squeezing her eyes shut again, Adora heaved a frustrated groan. With luck, she’d be let out the house again for anything besides school within a few months, but Mrs. Weaver would have her head for this slip up.

Deciding it would be best *not* to check her phone for the inevitable barrage of texts, Adora glanced around at her two sleeping companions. Bow was sprawled on his back, his phone lying on his stomach where he’d probably dropped it as he’d crashed.

Glimmer was draped halfway over Adora, pressed tightly against her chest, her fluffy hair tucked directly beneath the blonde’s chin. Like a clingy, purple starfish.

Adora found she couldn’t move, let alone breathe as she registered how close Glimmer was. Her hands were clenched lightly in the front of Adora’s jersey and the blonde could feel her soft breath tickling her neck.

For a long time, Adora found she didn’t *want* to move. Despite that fact that she knew she should get home before she had to leave for school. Glimmer was *really* warm and soft, and the closeness was making her heart flutter like a little bird in her chest.

The moment was shattered when Adora felt her phone buzz in her back pocket. She had to leave. Carefully, striving not to wake her friends, Adora extricated herself from Glimmer’s grip, attempting to replace her body with a pillow when Glimmer’s blinked awake.

“ ’Dora…?”

Adora’s heart swelled at the slurred, unintentional nickname. Glimmer blinked blearily, sitting up after her, pink hair sticking in a dozen different directions. She squinted at Adora, her body rocking somewhat precariously as she battled off sleep enough to figure out what was going on.

“What’re you doin’?”

“I have to go home,” Adora explained softly, daring to push gently on Glimmer’s shoulder, almost surprised when she let the blonde guide her back down. “I wasn’t supposed to spend the night.”

“N’is’okay,” Glimmer insisted sleepily. “Bow stays all th’time.”

“I know.” Adora knew Glimmer wasn’t cognizant enough for her to explain Mrs. Weaver’s strict rules, so she smiled softly instead and rubbed Glimmer’s shoulder comfortingly as she snuggled back into the pillows.

“I’ll see you at school today, okay?” She whispered and Glimmer murmured a garbled response before passing out again.

Carefully, Adora picked her way out of the blanket fort, sneaking for the front door on her tip toes.

“Headed out so soon?”

The voice from the kitchen nearly shocked Adora out of her skin. She whirled around to see Micah standing in the doorway. He wore an apron with purple moons decorating the front and wielded a greasy spatula in one hand.

“You’ve still got a while before school starts,” he insisted when Adora remained silent. “And you’re more than welcome to stay for breakfast.”

“Oh, I, um,” Adora crept another step back towards the front door. “I’d love to but… I—I can’t… I have to get back home. I’m sorry. I

mean, t—thank you. I had a great time."

An amused smile lit up Micah's face and he chuckled. "Alright, understood. But you're welcome back anytime, Adora. I'll let Glimmer know you had to take off early. She's not the most cognizant first thing in the morning."

Micah turned back into the kitchen, leaving Adora to glance back once longingly at the living room before slipping out the front door.

Suffice it to say, the confrontation with her foster mother was *not* how she wanted to spend the morning. And as she packed her bags for school, her empty rumbling stomach a reminder of her punishment for missing curfew, Adora found herself imagining what it might have been like to spend a lively morning eating breakfast at the Sato house.

Glimmer was more than a little disappointed when she woke the second time to find Adora had slipped out earlier that morning. The taller girl made for a very cozy pillow. And Glimmer would have been lying to herself if she'd said it hadn't made her heart do somersaults to hold her hand all night. Her skin was rough and calloused from sports, but her long fingers had curled around Glimmer's so perfectly.

"Eggs okay, Glim?" Micah asked, gesturing with his spatula and Glimmer realized she'd been staring blankly at her breakfast plate for who knew how long.

"Oh, yeah! They're good, Dad." Glimmer took a bite that was far too big to prove it.

She caught Bow's knowing smirk from the corner of her eye and shot him a dangerous look.

'Keep your mouth shut.'

He did not.

“Breakfast just isn’t what Glimmer would rather be eating right now,” Bow snickered, keeping his voice low enough that Micah *might* have missed it. Glimmer aimed a swift kick as his shins anyway.

“Shutup,” she hissed.

Bow wiggled his eyebrows and pointed to her phone. Somehow, probably when she was zoning out about Adora’s fingers, he’d sent her the Kermit Asshole Spread picture again, but this time he’d typed her name out over its face. Flushing hot, Glimmer just managed to turn off her phone screen as her father turned around to dump more bacon onto her plate.

“What’s so funny you two?” he asked, glancing at Bow who was turning red in an effort to contain his laughter.

“Nothing!” Glimmer spoke for him. “Bow’s just being stupid, but what’s new?”

Bow’s brow furrowed, his eyes narrowing. It was war now.

“Easy,” Micah chuckled. “What did Bow ever do to you?”

“She’s just grumpy her new favorite pillow left early this morning,” Bow hummed casually around a mouthful of egg.

Glimmer’s eyes widened at his betrayal as Micah turned to her, his brows rising curiously.

“Oh?”

“Dad! It’s not like that, Bow just likes to see me suffer. Adora’s my *friend.*” She stressed the word and raised her butter knife threateningly in Bow’s direction. He seemed entirely nonplussed.

“Your hands seemed to be a lot more than friends,” he muttered.

“Bow! What does that even *mean*??”

Micah snorted and returned to the stove, flipping even more bacon than either Bow or Glimmer could handle at this point. "I see."

"DAD!" Glimmer objected without a more detailed argument than the word itself. "Bow, stop!"

"Stop what?"

"Being a jerk!" Glimmer felt on the verge of angry tears and she wasn't even sure why. So what if she liked holding Adora's hand. And snuggling her. And falling asleep on top of her. And teaching her ukulele at lunch. And watching her play lacrosse in the afternoons as she 'studied'. So what?! It didn't mean anything!

"Honey," Micah had returned, placing a calming (and preemptive) hand over Glimmer's (the one holding the knife). "It's alright if you have a crush on, Adora. She seems like a very nice, polite young woman. And she's an athlete! That's impressive."

"I *don't* though," Glimmer objected weakly, pinning both men with the most venomous glare she could muster.

"Just remember," Micah ignored her objection. "If you two decide to start fooling around, dental dams are wonderful and essential measure. So are condoms, in fact. Even for women, yes—,"

Glimmer slammed her hands over her ears, utensils clattering to the floor as Bow burst into hysterical laughter. "*DAD!* Stop!"

"I'm being entirely sincere, Glimmer," Micah laughed.

"Shutup! And no one uses those stupid things anyway!"

"No one uses what things?"

All laughter in the kitchen abruptly stopped as Angella swept into the room. She glanced around at the scene, taking in Bow hunched over his plate, Micah scratching nervously at his beard, and Glimmer's face, red as a ripe tomato.

"Are you alright, Glimmer?" she prodded when no one answered her question.

"Fine," Glimmer ducked away from the hand incoming to brush her unruly hair back. "Everyone's just making fun of me this morning."

Angella sincerely didn't need to know about her crush on Adora. Yeah, there she said it. She definitely had one. But ever since coming out as a freshman two years ago, Angella had not been the most supportive of Glimmer's 'decision'. Micah had been the one to take her to Pride, and tease her about cute girls, and buy her campy rainbow knickknacks.

Angella liked to pretend that Bow was still the guy Glimmer was going to marry someday.

Angrily, Glimmer went back to her eggs as quiet activity resumed in the kitchen. The joke was over now that her mother was here. Discussing it any further would sincerely end in tears. Even Bow was quiet as the two finished breakfast, for which Glimmer was thankful.

It allowed Glimmer's thoughts to return to Adora and how nice it had felt to fall asleep against her chest, one hand resting lightly against her muscled abdomen.

Ugh, yeah okay, she had it bad.

Adora's shift had really sucked.

For as much as she'd tried to concentrate, Glimmer and the stupid box of toys had been on her mind all day. She couldn't stop picturing things…And it was starting to frustrate her. She wasn't *allowed* to think of Glimmer like that! It was… wrong. And it didn't help that the fantasies were bringing up memories she'd buried deep inside herself a long time ago.

She didn't want to remember how she used to watch Glimmer play her sparkly ukulele during lunch. Listening to her sing and imagining kissing her glossed lips. That was a long time ago. And Adora didn't feel that way about her anymore. She had… Whatever the fuck Catra was to her now. Glimmer was her roommate.

Her friend.

That was it.

She was just hot and flustered by the surprise of the box of toys. And it didn't help that mid-Summer had hit Bright Moon hard.

Even with the AC blasting in her truck, Adora was sweating as she pulled into the parking lot of Kyle's bar to pick Glimmer up from her interview. She'd just gotten off her shift at the gym, and luckily, the timing was perfect as Glimmer had just finished up with Kyle a few minutes ago.

Adora parked near the front, leaving the engine running so as not to risk suffocating in the stifling heat. Shooting a quick text to let Glimmer know she'd arrived, Adora sat back, scrolling so intently through her social media feed that she almost missed the moment Glimmer stepped out of the restaurant.

Adora had left early that morning, she hadn't been around to see what outfit Glimmer had donned for her interview. Perhaps, in her mind, Adora had assumed that all Glimmer owned were ripped jean shorts, tank tops and knee-high socks.

It seemed she'd assumed wrong, or Glimmer had at least a one formal outfit to whip out when she needed it.

Adora gaped, completely aware that she probably looked like a caveman as Glimmer saw her and sauntered towards the truck. She was wearing a sleek black pair of tights that shone in the burning sunlight, underneath a red pencil skirt that clung to her hips. A pair of black heels that made her at least three inches taller joined them. And her top was a sleeveless (and backless

Adora would soon discover) black v-neck that exposed her tattooed sleeve.

Adora snapped her jaw shut as Glimmer opened the passenger side door, a wave of heat invading the cool cabin of the truck.

"How'd it go?" she asked, desperate to fill the silence between them immediately, worried she might do something supremely stupid otherwise. The thoughts were more present now… Which was even more disconcerting with Glimmer now in the car beside her.

"I shouldn't have worn so much black," Glimmer muttered, kicking off her heels and pushing back her seat so that she could rest her feet against the dashboard. Adora swallowed at the sight of her legs sculpted so perfectly within the tights.

"But, good! I think," Glimmer continued, unaware of Adora's gawking. "He told me he'd go over my paperwork and that I could get ready for training shifts within the week."

"Mhm," Adora mumbled, laying one arm across the back of Glimmer's seat as she pulled back out of the parking lot and onto the road. "Oh, uh, great! I mean, that's awesome, Glim. I told you that you were a shoe-in."

Glimmer smiled, it was small but genuine and a bit shy. It made Adora's stomach flip.

"Thanks for… You know, setting it up for me and everything." She chanced a quick glance at Adora, who smiled back as (un)nervously as she could.

"You're welcome. I'm happy to help."

Glimmer hummed contentedly and pulled out her phone, scrolling, unaware of the tension vibrating through Adora's body as she drove.

“Hey, wanna grab something to eat somewhere?” Glimmer pointed to the dashboard clock. Adora’s eyes followed the curve of her calf instead. “It’s almost one now. And you just got done training. You hungry?”

“I—Hungry?” Adora tried to process the words, but her eyes were drawn away from Glimmer’s calf to her neck, where a single drop of sweat was crawling its way across her skin. Down, down, down to the divot of her chest and then into the slope of her breasts.

“Adora?”

For some reason, Glimmer’s voice sounded hazy and far away, Adora’s entire world shrinking to the notion of what Glimmer’s heated skin might taste like underneath her tongue.

“Food can wait.”

Adora pulled the truck off the street so quickly the tires squeaked. She drove them into an abandoned parking lot, despite Glimmer’s cry of surprise. Throwing the truck into park, Adora grabbed Glimmer’s hips, pulling her over the median and into her lap, pushing the tight skirt up her thighs to allow her more room to straddle the blonde’s thighs.

“Adora—?”

Adora silenced her, lips finding her neck, tongue and teeth laving over the skin as she followed the same pathway that drop of sweat had, down to Glimmer’s cleavage. Glimmer’s moan was hazy and distant, Adora’s ears occupied with the roar of her rushing blood. In fact, it could have been her own.

Using one hand, Adora reached underneath her skirt, tugging at the tights until she heard a satisfying tear. In the next instant she felt silky wetness against her fingertips. Unable to stifle a groan, Adora continued her furious track down to Glimmer’s breasts.

“So wet for me…”

“What are you doing?” Glimmer gasped.

Once again, Adora responded with actions not words, she pulled the hem of Glimmer’s top down, exposing one of her dark nipples. Licking her lips, Adora leaned in and—

“*ADORA*! What the fuck? What are you *doing?* You’re in the wrong lane!!”

Snapping back to reality, Adora wrenched the steering wheel to the right, just in time to avoid careening headfirst into an oncoming Sedan. Glimmer’s hand was on the wheel above hers, as if she’d been trying to correct it and when Adora looked over, she noticed her clothes were still perfectly pristine. Had she… Imagined the whole thing?

Panicked, heart pounding like a sledgehammer against her ribs, Adora glued her eyes to the road, her knuckles going white against the steering wheel.

“Holy shit, sorry. Sorry… I totally spaced out. The heat… It’s—,”

“Just… Do you want me to drive?” Glimmer’s voice shook with fear from the close call, Adora could only imagine her heart was pounding just as fast. Neither of them decided to point out Adora’s excuse was null in the air conditioning of the car.

“No, I’m good. I’m sorry… I’ve got it. Um, where did you want to eat?”

Glimmer responded, but Adora didn’t hear her. She was too busy trying to understand what the fuck had just happened inside her head. She’d just fantasized fully having her way with Glimmer…

But it didn’t mean anything. It couldn’t. Her clothes looked nice and it was hot and she missed Catra probably… She hadn’t gotten laid in a while… That was it. She was hot and horny. And Glimmer’s clothes looked nice…. She said that already.

“—They’ve got good burgers.”

“Huh?” Adora asked as her thoughts cleared briefly enough for Glimmer’s voice to come through.

Glimmer blinked at her, confusion turning into a solemn frown. “Maybe we should just head back to the apartment? You really don’t seem alright, Adora.”

“No, no, no, I’m sorry. I’m fine.” Adora’s grip tightened somehow further on the steering wheel. “Lunch sounds great. You lead us there. I’m all good…. Promise.”

Glimmer pursed her lips, dubious, but didn’t argue further.

As it turned out, the did *not* make it to the restaurant. Glimmer spotted an ice cream shop instead and considering the heat, Adora didn’t need much convincing to agree. She wasn’t that hungry anyway. Certainly not for food.

They ate their cones underneath the shade of the shop’s awning. Adora had gotten plain vanilla, a choice for which Glimmer had given her no small amount of shit. While Glimmer had gotten a peanut butter fudge swirl.

Adora kept her eyes trained on her cone after a while, because watching Glimmer’s little pink tongue make long strokes in the ice cream was not making the fantasies any less intense.

She had to stop this, or she might actually go fucking insane.

Glimmer chatted nonstop on the drive home, flitting from subject to subject to quickly for Adora’s sluggish and overheated brain to follow, but she tried. Nodding and inserting a “uh huh” whenever it felt necessary.

They both collapsed on the couch when they returned home, Adora turning on every fan she could, along with the AC.

“It’s so hot, I want to die,” Glimmer groaned. “I should change. Seriously, black was a fucking stupid choice.”

Adora still wore her gym clothes, which were light enough to combat the heat, so instead she offered to make them some cold smoothies while Glimmer used the bedroom to change.

They spent the afternoon flipping through dumb shows on Netflix and binging on snacks. The normalcy made Adora feel a bit better, and while the box was not forgotten, she was able to remember how easy it was to feel at home around Glimmer.

Her laugh was familiar, as were the toes poking underneath her thigh as they queued up another movie. They sat on opposite ends of the couch, but Adora hadn't felt this close to someone in a long time.

It was nice… Really, nice.

And by the time they stumbled into bed that night (the idea of the blow-up mattress basically fucked at this point), Adora was convinced that maybe… Maybe this could work. The fantasies would fade, and she had her friend back. It was good.

It was what she needed.

"Adora!"

Adora turned around in the lunch line to see Glimmer shoving her way through the crowd. The smile quickly faded from the blonde's lips, however, when she saw her friends furious scowl.

"Hey, Glim," she began weakling, holding her empty lunch tray up between them like a shield. "I'm sorry about this morning—,"

"You ditched us!" Glimmer exclaimed, waving an arm to include an imaginary Bow, who was still struggling through the crowd a ways behind her. "We were gonna cook breakfast for you and everything."

"I know… I'm sorry, I—," Adora bit her lip. Glimmer didn't need to know about all of Mrs. Weaver's devastatingly strict rules and

punishments. The idea of sharing that side of her life with Glimmer made Adora want to puke. It made her feel like maybe Glimmer might not want to hang out with her anymore. So she scrambled quickly for an excuse. "I forgot my books at home and I've got an assignment due today in English. I had to scramble. I —I'll do better next time."

Glimmer's nose wrinkled, confused or concerned by Adora's words. "Do better—? No, Adora. We just wanted to hang out with you this morning, that's all. You don't need to be sorry or anything, geez…"

Glimmer scuffed her toe against the linoleum floor. "Sorry I yelled at you. It was a weird morning."

Another smile crept onto Adora's lips as she pulled Glimmer into the moving line with her, ignoring the annoyed shouts from some of the other kids behind them. Bow seemed to have disappeared entirely, maybe abandoning the struggle to swim through the crowd for finding a table instead.

"Did you at least like the movie last night?" Glimmer asked, her lavender eyes trained on Adora's hand around her wrist.

"No, I did not," Adora chuckled, continuing before Glimmer could be offended. "But I liked spending time with you guys."

Glimmer beamed up at her. "Well you should totally come over more often then! We do movies and study sessions all the time. I've got a few Ghibli movies I think you might really like. And Disney stuff too. We've also got, Harry Potter? I dunno, my Dad's a big fan of the series—,"

She continued to babble as Adora grabbed two slices of pizza and made her way to the cashier, handing over her student ID for them to scan.

"Sorry," the woman's drawl interrupted Glimmer's speech. "You're out of lunch credit."

“What?” Adora blinked dumbly at her. That couldn’t be possible. She’d had plenty of credit literally the day before. Unless... Mrs. Weaver was usually the one who refilled it. In which case, it seemed her punishment was to extend throughout the entire day…

Stomach aching, mouth watering as she gazed down at the pizza, Adora almost forgot to be embarrassed until she remembered Glimmer standing right beside her witnessing the whole thing.

“So…,” the cashier said. “Move it or lose it, sweetheart.”

Adora was about to abandon the tray, her face burning, when Glimmer gave the cashier her own ID.

“Scan mine,” she insisted. “I’ve got plenty.”

“Only one scan per student,” the cashier droned. “So if I use it for her then—,”

“Did I fucking stutter?” Glimmer snapped. “Scan it.”

Shrugging apathetically, the cashier did as she was told and waved them on their way. Glimmer handed Adora her tray again and pushed her out of the line, since the blonde was essentially frozen in place.

“C’mon, Bow’s over there,” Glimmer guided her through the cafeteria, soft fingers around her elbow.

“You didn’t have to do that,” Adora murmured, the furious blush beginning to fade. She was grateful, but also glad Glimmer wasn’t patronizing her for what had just happened. “Did you want some of my pizza?”

Glimmer cast a tender glance her way but shook her head. “I never eat lunch anyway. Don’t worry about it, Adora. Seriously. You just owe me another movie *and* subsequent breakfast, okay?”

Adora beamed, her heart fluttering at the thought. “Deal.”

They found Bow at a table in the far corner. He'd placed his jacket and backpack in the seats for them, pushing them aside as the two girls plopped down.

"Long time no see, Adora," he teased, popping his home made PB&J into his mouth. "Did you like the movie last night?"

Adora caught Bow giving Glimmer a weird eyebrow wiggle but decided not to think anything of it.

"I think I'd prefer some of the other movies Glimmer has."

"Oh?" Bow perked up. "You're down for another movie night?"

"Yeah, absolutely."

Adora didn't want to consider that would mean sneaking out of her room to avoid Mrs. Weaver's wrath again. But for the moment, the *idea* for spending the nights with her friends, of falling asleep with Glimmer's soft body draped over hers… It was really nice. So she let her mind wander.

Adora's mind didn't stop wandering back to the box all week. And it didn't help that the heat seemed to keep climbing, determined to burn Bright Moon to the ground.

A few days into the torrential heat and…the AC broke. It so happened to be the hottest day of the week, with the temperate reaching almost 100 degrees Fahrenheit. Adora opened windows and turned on fans. But all it served to do was churn the stifling air around the tiny apartment.

Exhausted, way too hot, and frustrated, Adora paced the living room as she was put on hold with the repair company, while Glimmer melted into the couch, eyes glued to the television as if it could teleport her away from the heat.

Adora's eyes flickered to her as she waited… It was hot. Very hot. Naturally Glimmer was wearing as little as she could… a light tank

top, purple sports bra, and itty bitty elastic shorts. Adora wasn't wearing much more...but her mind kept drifting. She'd never *seen* this much of Glimmer. The smooth expanse of her thighs and slight show of her cleavage with the help of the sports bra.

She could see a lot more of the woman's tattoos than she was used to. The familiar trail of moons below her right ear, her sleeve of course. But she'd also been audience to the intricate pair of wings on her shoulder blades and the colorful Sakura blossoms curling up her right thigh until they disappeared deep into her shorts.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut, mentally slapping herself for staring as the hold ringtone continued. Now was not the time for the fantasies to come back. Not when she already felt like she was about to mentally snap.

Even still… as the hold tone rang on, Adora eyes drifted back, following a small bead of sweat as it slid down the slope of Glimmer's breasts. This stupid sweat thing would be the death of her.

Glimmer chose that moment to look up.

"You okay?"

Adora didn't respond. Instead, she dropped the phone and dove forward onto her knees, placing herself between Glimmer's thighs.

Glimmer blinked down at her, her mouth opening in shock as Adora's hands slid up her soft skin, gripped her hips fiercely and then leaned towards her breasts. One long stroke of her tongue against the salty tang of Glimmer's skin was all Adora needed.

A rough moan pulled free, a fire hotter than the apartment stoked between her thighs as she bit down, sucking on the tanned salty skin.

"Adora?"

Adora blinked.

She was still standing in the center of the room, the phone clutched in a vice grip in her hand. She was gaping at Glimmer, drool probably hanging out of her mouth at this point.

"You okay?"

"Yes," Adora straightened, wiping the sweat from her brow. "Just… hot."

Glimmer snorted. "No kidding. You still on hold?"

Adora was about to answer when her eyes followed another drop of sweat beneath Glimmer's tank top and she became aware of…. Something that made her brain fry faster than an egg on the sidewalk would right now.

Two parallel bumps stood out on either side of Glimmer's...nipples. For 1/5th of a second, Adora wondered if her new roommate had 6 nipples before reality struck her.

"Gl...Glimmer….um...did you know that you..?" She shouldn't be saying this out loud. *WHY WAS SHE SAYING THIS*? "Your um...your...y-your n…" she swallowed thickly. "Your nipples…"

Glimmer looked down as if she'd forgotten she had them.

"Oh! Yeah…" She reached up, toying with one of the bumps briefly in a way that made Adora want to come crawling to her on her knees. "I pierced ‘em like 3 years ago. Bow was there. My emotional support. He hated every second."

She laughed and returned her attention to the TV, as if she hadn't just turned Adora's entire world upside down.

Adora nodded silently, taking the phone out onto the balcony, considering hurling herself off it as the hold tone filled her entire brain like a dial up noise.

Glimmer started work at the bar at the end of the week, her first shift was an evening one that Saturday. She spent the morning in a mood brighter than Adora had ever seen her in. She unpacked and cleared out her boxes, she cleaned the bathroom and kitchen, humming all the while. When Adora tried to help, she was forced back down onto the couch and ordered to relax.

Adora wasn't going to lie. It was nice having a roommate who pulled her own weight. Content and happy, lulled by Glimmer's humming (which she hadn't heard in three years), Adora fell asleep on the couch. It was late by the time she woke up from her nap and Glimmer had already headed out for her first shift.

Adora noticed a delicious smell filling the air however. Wandering into the kitchen she found a tray of brownies, now cool to the touch. There was no note beside them, nothing to suggest that Glimmer had made them *for* her, or wanted her to avoid them.

So, shrugging off any potential consequences, Adora ate one. And then another. And a then third. They were sincerely delicious. Rich, chocolately and smooth. Addicting. Adora hadn't known Glimmer to be such a good baker, but she was certainly grateful for it now.

Plopping back down in front of the TV, Adora threw on a show she didn't really care if she fell asleep in front of and waited for Glimmer to return home. It wasn't long… Maybe 30 minutes? Or… maybe more like two hours? Adora wasn't sure… Time suddenly seemed to stretch and elongate and mutate in a way that didn't make sense. It existed and didn't exist all at once. Glimmer had been gone awhile. Right? Or maybe she hadn't…

Adora had another brownie to calm herself.

It wasn't long after that the voices from the television mutated into words Adora couldn't really understand. They sounded distant and were right beside her at the same time. And although Adora knew, she *knew*, they were speaking English. None of it made any fucking sense.

Her stomach rumbled uncomfortably then and she sank into the couch, watching the ceiling fan and lights warp and flicker above her head. She felt sort of like she was floating. Like she wasn't really a part of her body anymore. But it wasn't scary, it probably should have been… It just was. She kept her eyes open, giggling occasionally, and staring at the ceiling lights to keep herself grounded. She wasn't sure where she would go if she let her eyes slip shut.

Her body sagged, heavy, like a gym weight or a sandbag as she sunk deeper and deeper into the couch. It was swallowing her whole, she was disappearing entirely, until suddenly—

"Adora?"

She heard the door open from one hundred miles away and then Glimmer's weight was on the couch next to hers and they were sinking together.

"Glimmer!" she exclaimed excitedly; her tongue thick in her mouth. "You're back now! That's nice."

"What are you—?" Glimmer's face turned white and she hopped up from the couch making Adora all floaty again as she ran for the kitchen.

"Oh god, Adora!" Glimmer shouted from the kitchen, or maybe from a basement, Adora couldn't really tell. "You weren't supposed to touch these! I didn't think you would. You hate sweets."

"But they w're so good," Adora mumbled, tipping her head over the back of the couch to look at Glimmer upside down.

"Fuck," Glimmer mumbled, moving to sit down beside her again. "How many did you eat?"

Adora pursed her lips, thinking about it. "Many."

She burst into a fit of giggles, nearly toppling over into Glimmer's lap. Oh… Wait, yes. She was in Glimmer's lap now, the Sakura tattoo was right here, beneath her ear.

"Oh god, um, okay," Glimmer sounded panicked, her hands actually shaking as they rubbed Adora's shoulder.

Adora's heart suddenly picked up speed, a cold sweat coming over her as she registered Glimmer's distress. "Are you mad?"

"No!" Glimmer insisted, one hand now running through Adora's undercut. Oh, that felt really good. She might actually be purring right now, she wasn't sure. "No, I'm not mad. I just don't want you do die right now and there's not much I can do for you except take you to the hospital if it gets worse. Fuck…Um…Okay, let me get some water."

Adora sat up as Glimmer scurried to grab a glass of water. She'd just let her head loll back again when Glimmer returned, tipping it forward and holding the glass to her lips.

"Please, drink."

Adora downed the entire glass in 2 seconds. She was really fucking thirsty now.

"Can I have more?" she asked, blinking owlishly at Glimmer who dashed for another glass. Adora watched her, bleary eyes roaming over her nightscape/owl sleeve.

"You're so pretty, Glim," Adora practically whined as Glimmer returned to the couch yet again. "Your hair is so pretty too. You know what? You really are. You're like Starlight."

Glimmer paused for a second, a blush coloring her face before she shook it off and held the glass up again.

"You're so fucking high right now, Adora."

Adora giggled, blowing bubbles in the water. "Yeah."

She finished the glass, collapsing in Glimmer's lap again. She smelled nice beneath the cigarette smoke and booze smell of the bar. Beneath that was her 'Glimmer' smell. And Adora really liked it. She rolled onto her back, looking up at Glimmer through eyes that refuse to blink at the same time.

"G'immer… Your boobs have metal in them." She reminded her roommate of her piercings matter-of-factly. "You're like a sexy robot."

Glimmer's face was a combination of horror and embarrassment. "Adora, please don't die. I'm gonna call Bow real quick, okay?"

Adora nodded sagely, allowed Glimmer to move her head so she could pull her phone out of her pocket. The rest of the night sort of faded in and out of Adora's consciousness.

Somehow, she ended up in bed and when the sun rose the next morning, she only felt sick to her stomach and still a little drunk.

Glimmer was already up and making her breakfast when Adora shuffled out, a blanket draped around her shoulders. The brownies were nowhere to be found… As if Adora would ever touch them again.

"What happened last night?" Adora mumbled as Glimmer set down a plate of eggs and bacon in front of her.

"You got super stoned on the weed brownies I made," Glimmer explained, plopping down beside her. "Like… Really stoned. I had to convince you that jumping off the balcony wouldn't end in you flying to the moon."

Adora stared down at her eggs as she processed that.

"Oh."

"I'll warn you next time. I didn't think you'd touch them. I'm so sorry."

Looking up when she heard the quaver in Glimmer's voice, Adora was surprised to see tears gathering in her lavender eyes.

"Hey," Adora pulled her forward into a comforting hug, out of instinct. Glimmer's arms wrapped around her waist immediately, fingers digging into the back of her shirt. "It's okay. I'm fine now. It's… Kinda funny, right?"

Glimmer sniffed against her shoulder. "I straight up thought you might die."

"Well," Adora chuckled. "I didn't… And I'll ask next time before consuming any of your cooking."

Glimmer slapped her shoulder weakly, pulling away and rubbing the tears out of her eyes. "Good, because I am not taking care of high-as-a-kite Adora ever again. She has no idea which reality she's in and it's weird."

Adora decided not to question that statement. If she'd said anything to upset or confuse Glimmer, she had absolutely no recollection of it.

Glimmer stood up, turning back to the stove and Adora chewed her eggs slowly as she studied her roommate.

There was one thing playing in her mind after last night. A single word, caught in her head, spinning like a Ferris Wheel around and around.

Glimmer was like starlight.

About a week and a half into Glimmer's stay, work pulled them apart. Their schedules contrasted sharply now, with Adora working early mornings and Glimmer working late into the night. She had more days off than Adora did, but the blonde had yet to memorize which ones they were. In any case, the time apart hadn't helped her deal with her ever growing fantasies.

It seemed Glimmer did something new every day to stoke something within Adora. Be it as simple as drinking a glass of water, the flex of her throat doing weird things to Adora's stomach. Or wearing something that left little to the imagination when it came to those damn piercings.

In any case, the stifling hot car ride home from work did nothing to cool the fire burning in Adora's belly. She'd made some bullshit excuse to Lonnie in order to get off her shift early. It was too much. Glimmer. On her mind, constantly nowadays. And those stupid fucking toys she'd seen. She couldn't stop picturing them… Picturing *things* with Glimmer.

If Adora could just get some time alone… Take care of this burning itch. She'd be fine. She'd get over it. Things would go back to normal.

Feeling a bit more confident as she repeated this excuse to herself over and over again, Adora climbed the stairs to the apartment, sliding the key into the lock and pushing the door open quietly. The apartment was still, Glimmer nowhere to be found.

She was probably out with Bow, or at one of her shifts, it was late enough in the afternoon now for that to be the case anyway. Adora supposed it might be smart to send a text to check, but she was also desperate to get her fucking clothes off and—

Adora heard something as she approached the bedroom door. It was nearly closed, a crack only about two inches wide allowing Adora to peek inside without fully opening it. She heard the noise again as she peered inside the dark room.

The blinds were closed, the lights off, but Adora could make still make out the figure of her roommate lying sprawled on top of the sheets. She shifted slightly, her body sort of undulating in a way that made Adora realize she'd just walked in on something very intimate.

One of her hands was busy with her left breast, fingers toying with the tiny piercings Adora had fantasized about for days now. The other hand held one of the sleek toys Adora had found. And it was currently sliding in and out of Glimmer's body at an agonizingly slow pace. Adora nearly whimpered at the same time Glimmer sighed a long, low moan.

This could not be happening. Fuck, shit, what the *fuck?* She could *not* have just walked in on Glimmer pleasuring herself. This was another hallucination it had to be. Adora pinched her arm to be sure.

To both her horror and perverse sense of pleasure, she did not wake up.

Glimmer picked up speed, the toy plunging in and out of her faster now, a wet sound filling Adora's ears. Somehow louder than the roar of her own blood rushing.

"Fuck, *yes…,"* Glimmer hissed, twisting her nipple as her back arched off the bed. "More. God… Adora, *please*."

Adora's heart must have stopped beating long enough for her to feel faint, because she almost passed out on the floor right then and there. Not only had she walked in on Glimmer masturbating. But Glimmer was imaging *her* doing exactly the things Adora wanted to right now.

This wasn't REAL.

Adora stood paralyzed, even though she knew she should stop watching. She should leave. Run off this energy. Pretend she'd never seen it. But then Glimmer let out a whine that sent a shock of pleasure straight to Adora's core.

Holy shit, she needed to get out of here. If she was present for the moment Glimmer reached her cli—

Adora couldn't even think it. She turned on her heel, bolting out of the apartment with Glimmer's voice chasing her down the hall.

'Adora, please.' Echoed in her mind for the entire hour she ran circles around the boiling hot park. Please… Faster? Harder? What else had been going through Glimmer's mind? Was it Adora's lips teasing her nipple? Her hips driving the end of the toy?

Suffice it to say, the run did nothing but serve to make Adora sweaty, frustrated, and hotter than before. By the time she returned to the apartment, Glimmer was laying casually on the couch, holding her Switch above her head as she played some game Adora could never begin to understand the fun of.

"Hey," Glimmer glanced up at her when she heard the door open. "You look terrible. Did you fucking run home?"

Adora let out a nervous laugh. "I… Took a quick jog after work… Exercise."

Glimmer stared at her like she had lobsters crawling out of her ears. "Exercise?"

"Yes. Yeah. Yup. I'm gonna shower now."

Adora inched sideways across the apartment, slipping into the bathroom without quarrel despite Glimmer's very confused gaze following her all the way there.

She closed the door, locking it behind her and starting an icy cold shower. Stripping out of her sweaty, wet clothes, Adora pushed the shower head aside, so that the stream barely touched her back. Pressing one shaking forearm against the shower wall, Adora let trembling fingers trail down her stomach towards her now aching (and still very wet core).

'Adora. Please…'

Adora squeezed her eyes shut, the silhouette of Glimmer's arching body burned behind her eyelids. She was so beautiful.

'Adora…'

Adora’s fingers slid far too easily through her own wet folds as Glimmer’s moans filled her head.

‘Please.’

It barely took any effort… Two fingers inside, a quick rub of her clit and Adora was choking out an orgasm, trying to remain quiet beneath the spray of the water. She bit her lip, whimpering as the waves subsided. Glimmer’s moans still circled in her head, but the aching between her legs had subsided somewhat.

How the fuck they were supposed to sleep in the same bed tonight… The bed Glimmer had very possibly orgasmed on… Adora had no fucking clue.

This could *not* be real.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

I tried to write smut, I really did but then I 'oops all High School flashback' ... :--(

Ingredients include: Adora finds a home with the Sato family. Oops she falls harder for Glimmer. One bad night leaves a sour taste in everyone's mouth.

Enjoy!

For better of for worse, Mrs. Weaver's punishment for Adora's unintended sleepover at the Sato house ended with the lack of food. She was still allowed out, although her curfew was threatened more frequently now. And really, the only problem was that Mrs. Weaver sometimes 'forgot' to feed her. It wouldn't be an issue if she didn't keep all the cabinets locked. But Adora made do at school, where Glimmer basically handed over her lunch card, insisting she didn't need it. Even Bow started bringing extra goodies from home for her now. As it turned out, his dad George was an excellent baker.

Adora appreciated her friends' help. And even more so she appreciated how it didn't fill her with guilt to accept their help. They brushed it off as if it were something anyone would do. Adora knew that was not the case. But Bow's snacks and Glimmer's shared lunches got her through her lacrosse practices with the energy she needed and for that she was incredibly grateful.

She started spending most, if not all, of her afternoons at the Sato house. The three occasionally switched things up and stayed at Bow's house; Adora met his very kind fathers. But the norm, it seemed, was to gather their assignments and projects and camp out in Glimmer's room, or the living room, and study/eat/share memes/and talk until the late hours of the night. Movies were

reserved for weekends (mostly), and they always set up the pillow fort to make it extra cozy.

Adora didn't want to risk staying past midnight again so soon, but Glimmer didn't seem to have issue falling asleep on her every time they did watch a movie. And soon enough Adora was accustomed to the soft warmth of her body, almost craving it on the nights she stayed home.

She liked Glimmer's house for a lot of reasons. But Glimmer's parents were especially interesting. Mrs. Sato was rather reserved, always offering Adora tea or pleasant smiles when she came over. Stepping in to shush the trio if they got too rambunctious while studying or reminding them to turn off the lights before they slept during movie nights. She wasn't afraid to scold Glimmer in front of them, which Bow seemed accustomed to, and Adora almost respected. It wasn't like the cold sneers or screaming fits Mrs. Weaver used on her.

It always started with an airy, "Glimmer, could you come here a moment?"

Glimmer would huff, roll her eyes and slouch over to wherever her mother was, accepting the berating but not without biting back. Adora couldn't even imagine what it must be like to feel it was even *possible* to argue a punishment. But Glimmer certainly did. She was fiery and full of life. She burned bright like a star and more and more Adora found herself wanting to be like her. To carry the same spark and confidence. Or maybe it was brashness. Either way, Adora liked it.

Micah more quickly became someone Adora looked forward to seeing every day. He was often reading on the porch outside when she arrived at the house on her old bike.

"Those are some squeaky chains you've got there," he noted, lowering his reading glasses to peer at Adora as she bounded up the porch. Adora looked back at her broken-down bike; it was a little pathetic. The handlebars were worn, the brakes didn't really

work, the seat cut into her thighs… But it got her from point A to point B.

"Yeah, Swifty's old… I've had him since I was 13," Adora admitted, the nickname for her trusty bike slipping out without her noticing.

Micah's eyes twinkled and he smiled warmly. "Couldn't hurt to fix him up a bit then, huh?"

"Oh, sure," Adora scuffed her toe against the porch step in embarrassment. "I just… I don't have any tools or anything."

Micah's hummed thoughtfully, then closed his book and stood, gesturing for Adora to follow him. She did, glancing back at the front door as she went, nervous that her friends might be waiting for her. It wasn't like she was going far though.

So, she followed Micah as he led her into a shed that stood a ways off from the three-car garage. He pushed the door open to reveal a small workshop. Tires, tools, oils, old bolts, everything Adora could imagine might be in a mechanics shop existed within. Micah stood back, watching almost proudly as Adora poked around the room.

"I fancy myself a bit of a mechanic," he told her, rummaging through a cabinet until he pulled out a small red toolbox. "But I've got more than what I can ever use, so why don't you hold onto this for me?"

Adora took the box, blinking down at it. It looked relatively new, the case unscuffed and only covered in a little bit of grease.

"Oh, and use this on the chain," Micah handed her a bottle of Tri-Flow. "But not too much, just a little spritz will do."

Adora gaped after him as he moved behind a workbench, rubbing his beard in thought.

"The brakes we'd have to order but installing them should be simple. Tell you what, let me get a good look at the bike itself and

I'll try and find the closest model. I can order them tonight and —,"

"Y-you really don't have to do all that," Adora interrupted, her face flushing red hot as Micah blinked curiously at her. "I—I mean, the brakes are… Fine. They work. Sort of. But—All of this, is more than enough. I should pay you for it. I don't—I mean, thank you. Sir."

Another warm smile appeared on Micah's face and he led Adora out of the workshop, one large hand on her shoulder. It was a comforting weight, she noticed. Firm, but not as tight and hard as Mrs. Weaver held her.

"It's not a problem at all, Adora. I need a new project anyway. And listen," he turned her around. "If you really feel like you owe me for helping fix up your bike, just promise me you'll keep Glimmer out of trouble. Alright? She needs a friend like you."

Micah's eyes twinkled again, and he pushed her towards the house before she could protest. "Speaking of Glimmer, I'm sure she's waiting." He took the toolbox from her. "We'll set these back in the workshop and you can use them whenever you like, alright?"

Adora nodded rapidly, swallowing the burning lump in her throat. "Yes, sir. Thank you."

Turning towards the house, Adora saw Glimmer and Bow peeking out at her from the window of Glimmer's room. They ducked behind the curtains again when they noticed she'd spotted them and Adora hurried inside.

She kicked off her shoes (Mrs. Sato's strict rule) and took the winding stairs two at a time until she burst into Glimmer's room. They both jumped, screeching as if they hadn't seen her dash inside the house.

"Adora!" Glimmer ran up to her, patting her arms and face like she'd just gotten out of a fight and Glimmer was checking for

wounds. “What did my Dad want? Did he force you to listen to his dumb school stories? Show you his weird collection of mystery novels? The trophy case in the garage? What? Speak to me, Adora!”

Adora grinned, shoving her hands away and plopping on the (ridiculously) soft bed. “He showed me his workshop. He’s gonna help me fix Swift Wind.”

“Your bike?” Bow clarified, looking out the window again.

Adora nodded, bouncing slightly as Glimmer hurled herself onto the bed beside her. “Ugggggghhh, Adora don’t go ‘bonding’ with my Dad, okay? I’m warning you. Once he starts talking, he doesn’t stop.”

“Your Dad’s cool, Glim. I don’t mind.”

Glimmer’s face contorted into a horrified grimace. “My parents are not ‘cool’, Adora. Don’t you ever say that to my face again.”

Rolling her eyes, Adora snorted and poked Glimmer in the side. She yelped, curling in on herself like a sparkly purple shrimp, batting Adora’s hand away.

“Alright, children,” Bow clapped his hands. “We should actually get this report done while there’s still light out.”

“Aww, I thought we were doing a movie tonight?” Glimmer groaned, stretching out on the bed again until she slid off it and melted into a puddle on the floor.

“Work first,” Bow insisted. “We’ve got to earn the movie. Right, Adora?”

“Right.” Adora chuckled, pulling her books out of her backpack and sliding onto the floor next to Glimmer.

“Why am I friends with you nerds?” Glimmer moaned. Her nose wrinkled when Adora tapped it with the end of her pencil.

“Shut up and sit up,” Bow ordered, kicking the bottom of her foot until Glimmer slouched back up, hunching over her notebooks like a pouting child.

They did not end up earning the movie that night, their project taking longer than expected. And Glimmer was half asleep on the floor by the time Adora packed up to leave anyway. Bow had made camp on the bed, still pouring over his notes as Adora draped a blanket over Glimmer and tucked a pillow beneath her head. She stroked Glimmer’s wild hair back, smiling when the girl mumbled something in her sleep.

“See you at school tomorrow?” Bow asked as she headed for the door.

“Of course,” Adora grinned and then ducked into the hall.

She could see a flickering light coming from the TV in Mr. and Mrs. Sato’s room. Deciding not to bother them, Adora crept downstairs, avoiding the creaky step and slipped out the front door into the night.

Her squeaky bike chain accompanied her all the way home.

Micah did end up helping Adora with her bike.

They spent a few sunny afternoons just outside the workshop, exchanging sports stories as they replaced the broken pieces of Swift Wind. Glimmer joined them sometimes, sitting on the workbench and swinging her legs, bored out of her mind as Adora and her father basically compared battle scars.

Micah had been a football star, different than Adora, but their shared experiences of fierce coaches, injuries, and intense games was enough to keep the blonde interested in what he had to say. She’d never been able to talk with another adult like this. To share her successes and failures and have them engaged in what she was saying. Offering advice, or their own experiences in return.

It made Adora crave more.

She wanted this. Always. She wanted to be able to share with someone who could tell her they were proud of her and sincerely mean it.

It made her so happy to spend afternoons with Micah, she almost forgot Glimmer was there sometimes, until she'd drape herself over Adora's back as they worked, or hand them tools, or play her ukulele and sing to herself in the background. Those simple afternoons full of laughter and shared stories and music, were some of the happiest days of Adora's life.

"There we go," Micah said one afternoon, straightening and wiping the sweat off his brow. "Swifty's as good as new now."

Adora studied the bike proudly. A new paint job, brake pads, a more comfortable seat and handlebars. New all-terrain tires and a chain that didn't squeak. A grin she couldn't contain spread her lips and she laughed when Micah nudged her shoulder.

"You did some good work, Adora."

"I just handed you the tools," she objected, and Micah chuckled.

"Well you were a very helpful assistant then. What do you say we celebrate a job well done?" Micah shuffled into the workshop again and came back out holding an old football. "How's your throw?"

Adora had never really even considered football before. But she was a quick learner and picked up every sport she'd ever tried relatively quickly. So, she nodded and before long (after a few pointers), she and Micah were spread out in the enormous front yard, tossing the ball back and forth.

"Glimmer's grades have been improving since she's been studying more with you and Bow," Micah told Adora as he tossed a throw that almost went over her head. "I have to thank you. She seems a lot happier these days too. Just… More invested."

“Oh…,” Adora wasn’t really sure how to respond, unsure of where Micah might be going with this conversation. “Well, Glimmer’s really been helping me with math a lot lately, so I have to thank her for my own grades too.”

“She’s a smart kid,” Micah nodded. “Tends to get wrapped up in her own head a lot though. Lots of very strong emotions.”

Adora agreed quietly. That was what she liked about Glimmer. She felt things deeply and wasn’t afraid to express her feelings just as fiercely.

“She talks a lot about you, y’know?” Micah continued as he stretched to catch an off-kilter throw. “You’re a favorite breakfast conversation.”

Adora’s face burned. She wasn’t quite sure how to feel about that. What did they say about her? Good things…? Did Glimmer tell them about her lunch issues…?

Micah paused, lowering the football and holding it against his chest instead of throwing it back to Adora when he noticed her silence.

“I’m sorry, I don’t mean to make you uncomfortable.” He tossed the ball lightly this time. “I just mean to say that it’s very nice to see Glimmer so happy. And to know that it’s a wonderful young woman like you that makes her so happy.”

Adora wasn’t sure her face could burn any hotter. So she just swallowed nervously and murmured. “I like Glimmer a lot too.”

Micah chuckled, catching the ball and neglecting to throw it again when the front door opened. “Speak of the devil…”

“Adora!” Glimmer shouted from the porch. “It’s movie time! Stop being a jock for two seconds and come inside.”

Adora exchanged a private smile with Micah before jogging past him and meeting Glimmer on the porch.

“You smell like grass and grease,” Glimmer wrinkled her nose, tugging at the hem of Adora’s dirtied t-shirt.

Adora laughed, placing her hand over Glimmer’s. “Is that better than a sweaty jersey?”

“Barely,” Glimmer murmured; her lavender eyes locked on their interlaced fingers. Adora squeezed gently, her heart still racing from Micah’s words. Glimmer liked her a lot. She liked Glimmer a lot. She liked this house a lot. She liked these people a lot. She felt full, like she was bursting with the sunlight that was beating down on them.

“Come on,” Adora led her inside with a coy smile. “It’s movie time.”

Adora really didn’t care for all the Disney movies Glimmer gravitated towards when it was her turn to choose for movie night. They were all cheesy, and too colorful, and the singing really threw her off. Why did they just burst into song like that? Could the other characters hear them?

Glimmer adored them though. She sang along with every song, Bow did too sometimes. And the movie she picked tonight seemed to be a particular favorite, because near the end, as the main couple came together for a romantic dance scene; Glimmer leapt to her feet and grabbed Bow’s hand, dragging him into the center of the living room.

Adora blinked up at them from her place in the pillow fort, confused as Bow bowed deeply with a flourish of his hand and Glimmer curtsied in return.

“Princess Glimmer,” Bow lowered his voice a few octaves. “May I have this dance?”

“You may, Sir Bow,” Glimmer replied through her giggles and then the two of them were dancing around the large living room, almost perfectly mirroring the choreography on screen.

Adora wasn't sure whether to laugh or be wildly impressed because they moved with a frivolity and precision that she could never hope to mimic. A smile grew on her face as she watched them, the music of the movie swelling until it ended and Bow spun Glimmer out before bowing again. The two then burst into giggles and Glimmer bounded over to Adora, grabbing her hand and dragging her to her feet.

"Your turn!"

"What?"

Bow was already rewinding the scene back to the beginning.

"C'mon, it's fun!" Glimmer insisted, placing one of Adora's hands on her waist.

Adora froze up, her hand unconsciously clenching and unclenching in the fabric of Glimmer's shirt.

"I—I really don't dance, Glimmer. I've never even seen this movie before. I don't know—,"

"It's okay, Adora," Glimmer insisted, lacing the fingers of their other hands as she draped one arm around the blonde's shoulders. "Bow and I have been practicing this for years. We'll just go slow for you, okay?"

Adora swallowed, wondering if Glimmer could *feel* the heat radiating off her face. They were so close Adora could feel every inch of Glimmer pressed against her. Her stomach was doing vicious somersaults.

The music began again and Adora thought maybe the living room lights dimmed? And wait…where had Bow gone?

Then suddenly Glimmer was moving, they were swaying in a tiny square. It wasn't nearly as impressive as the many spins and twirls Bow and Glimmer had done together, but Adora could keep

up without stepping on Glimmer's socked feet and that was all that mattered.

"See?" Glimmer's voice was suddenly very soft, it wavered slightly, Adora noticed. And her lavender eyes were round, almost glowing in the light from the television. "You've got it."

Adora let her arm slide further around Glimmer's waist and suddenly she wasn't in Glimmer's living room anymore.

They stood in a massive ballroom instead, gold accents and flowers and ribbons and banners decorating every inch of the walls. They were surrounded by a faceless crowd, but soft spotlights trained on them made it seem as if they were the only ones in the universe. Glimmer was dressed in a long white robe, trimmed in gold, a brilliant lilac outfit beneath. A thin golden crown donned her brow.

She looked like royalty.

Adora didn't dare look down at herself for fear of losing sight of Glimmer, but somewhere in the back of her mind, she knew she matched. Their awkward shuffle evolved into something even more magnificent than what she'd observed with Bow. She spun Glimmer around the room, lifting her into the air and listening to the echoing ring of her laughter.

They danced until the music slowed, and then she pulled Glimmer close as the lights faded, and the crowd disappeared. Her forehead touched the cold metal of Glimmer's crown, she could feel the girl's breath ghosting her lips and then—

The song ended and Bow was clapping.

"Excellent shuffle, Adora!" he cheered.

Adora blinked, looking down at Glimmer, who was now pressed against her chest. Adora's arm had slipped fully around her middle and Glimmer's, likewise, was curled around her neck. The tension in the air was palpable, but with Bow nearby—and clearly ignorant

the to the moment—Adora knew she couldn't do what her body was screaming for.

Instead, she grinned and placed both hands on Glimmer's hips, easily hoisting her into the air or a quick spin. It wasn't as majestic as her fantasy had been, but Glimmer's laugh was the same and the butterflies in Adora's stomach rejoiced at the noise.

Setting Glimmer down, Adora copied the steep bow she'd seen Bow pull off earlier, glancing up at Glimmer from beneath her lashes. "Princess…"

A hot pink blush colored Glimmer's cheeks as she curtsied again and Adora could feel herself blushing just as hard.

There was a break in their movie nights after that for a couple weeks while Adora's practices ramped up. She was spending more and more time on the field and less with her friends and it truly sucked…

She managed to befriend some of the kids on her lacrosse team a bit better in the meantime. One girl named Lonnie was the friendliest of the bunch, but even that wasn't saying much.

By the time Saturday rolled around, Adora was *dying* to make her way back to the Sato house. She flew down the sidewalk on Swift Wind, eager to escape Mrs. Weaver. She'd been in a particularly sour mood today and Adora hadn't left the encounter unscathed. She was sporting a particularly ugly and painful bruise on her upper arm where Mrs. Weaver had gripped her so tightly Adora thought her arm might break. But she figured her t-shirt covered enough of it not to worry Bow or Glimmer.

The sun was setting by the time she arrived at the Sato household, but she could smell something rich and delicious wafting from within the mansion. Parking her bike outside the workshop, Adora bounded up the stairs, raising her hand to knock just as Glimmer opened the door.

The two blinked at each other for a moment, then Glimmer beamed and launched herself at Adora, throwing her arms around the blonde's neck. If Adora hadn't been significantly taller, they might've taken a bad fall down the steps. As it was, she spun Glimmer in a circle instead, before setting her down and pulling back to look at her.

"Hey, Glim. I'm sorry I've been AWOL. Practice is killer."

"It's been TWO WEEKS, Adora," Glimmer scolded her, with a pout Adora found herself wanting to kiss away.

"I know. It's been a long time. I'm—Hey, have you gotten taller?"

That earned her a light slap on the arm (Adora tried not to flinch when it landed against her bruise) and a high pitched, "Adora!"

The blonde laughed, taking Glimmer's hand and pulling her inside. She kicked off her shoes and followed her nose to the kitchen where both Micah and Angella stood by the stove. Bow was there too, sitting on a stool at the kitchen island. He turned around when the two girls entered, giving Adora a blinding smile.

"Adora!" Micah greeted her too with a warm bellow. "You're just in time for dinner."

"Glimmer." Angella took in the sight of Adora's face, still sweaty from the bike ride. "Why don't you take Adora and Bow and wash up before we eat."

Glimmer groaned and rolled her eyes but dragged them both out of the kitchen anyway.

"Have you been okay, Adora?" Bow asked as they took turns washing their hands thoroughly in the guest bathroom. "We haven't heard from you in a while."

"Yeah! No, I'm good. Practices have just been rough lately. We've got a few big games coming up here soon and Coach wants us to be ready." Adora sat on the lid of the toilet, waiting her turn.

Glimmer let out a furious snort as she scrubbed her skin. "That woman is a fucking monster. I hate her."

"Easy, Glimmer," Bow chuckled.

"No! She's an asshole. She's the worst teacher at the school."

"She's definitely not nice," Adora agreed, standing and handing Glimmer a small towel. "But she does know how to coach a team into shape."

Glimmer grumbled but didn't argue further. Adora couldn't help but smile fondly. She really had missed everyone, but Glimmer especially. For a moment, she was tempted to simply step forward and wrap Glimmer in her arms; only the fear of what Bow might say stopped her.

Glimmer, on the other hand, didn't seem to care. Because she caught Adora's eye and then barreled into her, wrapping her arms as tight as she could around the taller girl.

"I missed you," she practically growled, her face buried in Adora's shoulder. "Don't ditch us again. I don't care how busy you are. We'll come watch your games or something."

Adora's heart fluttered. '*I* missed you'. Not 'we', although she was sure Bow had too.

"Deal," she chuckled, attempting to pry Glimmer off her. The girl only squeezed harder, her steel grip now pressing down on the bruise on Adora's arm.

She flinched, hissing in pain and Glimmer drew back immediately. "You okay?"

Quickly, Adora waved her off, guiding both of her now concerned looking friends out of the bathroom. "Yup, just…uh, hungry… Let's eat."

Glimmer and Bow exchanged worried glances but didn't push the issue, for which Adora was thankful.

Dinner was jovial. It always was at the Sato's. They played 'High/Low', where everyone went around and told the group about a high and low point of their day. Adora told everyone how her practices had been going, noticing that Micah beamed proudly the entire time. Bow told them all about the trip his Dad's had just gotten back from in Switzerland of all places. Micah told a series of bad jokes. Glimmer was the only one who remained uncharacteristically quiet, her eyes on Adora for most of the evening.

By the time they'd settled in Glimmer's room to study a bit before Adora had to leave, Glimmer seemed ready to burst.

"Are you alright…?" Adora asked, setting her pencil down from where she sat at Glimmer's desk.

Glimmer was perched on the edge of her bed, glaring at Adora, her entire body taut like a string.

"Did you get hurt?"

"Glimmer," Bow hissed and Adora felt her face beginning to burn.

"What? N—No. Why would you think that?"

Glimmer's lavender eyes narrowed. "At practice or something. Did you get hurt?"

"I'm fine," Adora insisted, turning back to her work, although she could hear and *feel* Glimmer creeping up behind her.

"Adora." She tensed as Glimmer's soft hand landed just above the bruise, her thumb rubbing gently. "You can tell us. We're not going to judge you or anything… If you're hurt, we want to help."

Bow had joined them, standing on Adora's other side, his face now just as concerned as Glimmer's. Looking between them,

Adora realized she had no choice. They wouldn't drop it now. Or at least, Glimmer certainly wouldn't.

Sighing, she rolled up her t-shirt sleeve, revealing the dark (very clearly) hand shaped bruise around her upper arm.

Glimmer's eyes widened and even Bow looked on in horror. Adora cringed, shrinking in on herself. They were disgusted by her.

"Adora, what happened?" The question came from Glimmer, who's hand was hovering over the hot and swelling bruise. "It was the stupid fucking coach, wasn't it? I swear to god I'm talking to my mom tomorrow she'll call Doctor Hope directly and get her fucking ass—,"

"Glimmer, no," Adora put a hand over Glimmer's, accidentally laying it against the bruise but… It felt kind of nice. A soft, cool something to caress the burning skin. "It wasn't Coach. Okay. It's…"

Bow knelt beside her, the understanding in his eyes made Adora want to cry. "You don't have to talk about it, Adora."

Glimmer still seemed confused, because she almost objected, but Bow shot her a dangerous look.

"No, it's okay. I—You guys are my best friends. It's just… Hard."

Bow put a comforting hand on her other shoulder and Glimmer squeezed just gently enough to encourage her.

"I grew up in the foster care system," Adora heaved a huge sigh. "My parents. I never knew them. They left me at an orphanage as an infant. I've always been moved around from home to home. No one ever seemed to want to keep me for whatever reason. Until, Mrs. Weaver. She adopted me. She's the only one who's ever dealt with me for more than a few years. But she… She's not… She's had a lot of her own struggles and sometimes she gets mad. We *disagree* on things sometimes and—She doesn't mean for it to get out of hand. She always apologizes but—,"

“Your foster mother did this?” Glimmer’s voice was barely above a whisper.

“It’ll go away. And she’s not mad anymore. I left so she could cool off. I’ll be fine.” Adora looked up at Glimmer with pleading eyes. “Please, don’t… Don’t make it a big deal.”

Glimmer’s face contorted and paled, her body tense like she was seconds away from dashing to tell her own parents. But her lilac eyes flickered to Bow’s and then Adora’s and finally, she nodded solemnly.

“Okay…But Adora. You know if you’re ever in trouble, you can come here. Okay? You’re safe here, always.”

“I know,” Adora replied as both her friends hugged her at once.

She did know.

This was home.

Glimmer hadn't been expecting Adora tonight. Which was why she'd just changed into her pjs and busted out her laptop to watch some Netflix when her phone buzzed suddenly.

-'I'm out front can I come in? I didn't want to knock in case your parents are asleep.'

Confused, and more than a little panicked, Glimmer simply typed a quick 'be right there' before leaping out of bed and hurrying downstairs.

It wasn't like Adora to show up unannounced, especially not after she'd already declined Glimmer's offer to binge movies. It was almost midnight at this point too. Unless Adora snuck out, she shouldn’t be here…

Hurrying to the large front doors, Glimmer tugged on them with her entire body weight to reveal Adora standing on the front

porch. She had one trembling hand pressed to her forehead, but Glimmer could see an unnerving amount of red spilling between her fingers. For a startling few seconds, she just gaped at the...blood(?)....spilling down her best friends forehead. It didn't seem real. More like the horror movies Adora was so afraid of.

But then Adora was stepping forward, asking to come in again, and Glimmer quickly pulled her inside.

"Adora, what the fuck happened to you?" She had a vice grip on Adora's free hand that she knew couldn't be comfortable, but the blonde didn't shake her. She gripped back, just as tightly.

"I said some stupid things...To my foster mom. It was an accident. But I didn't know where to go and I just thought--," Adora's voice was rising with barely contained panic, so Glimmer quickly steered her towards the couch, sitting her down firmly.

"You did the right thing, okay? You're here and you're safe now." Glimmer made sure to keep her hands pressed hard to Adora's shoulders so that she'd feel grounded.

Adora stared up at her through red rimmed eyes, eventually nodded and taking her hand away from the injury on her brow.

"Keep that there," Glimmer pushed it back into place, ignoring the slick warm feeling of the blood staining her own skin. "I'll be right back with some stuff to stop the bleeding, okay?"

Adora nodded, watching her leave the living room like a lost puppy. It wasn't until Glimmer had made it to the guest bathroom that she felt the panic swelling up inside her, making it difficult to breathe.

Adora was bleeding. *Badly.* She should probably be taken to the fucking hospital. But she'd come here for help and Glimmer *needed* to be here for her, but she had no idea what to do.

She began rummaging through the bathroom cabinets, searching through everything for something to help Adora. But her hands

were shaky, and her vision was sorta blurry, and she couldn't think straight for some reason.

Mouthwash. Would that work? It was usually for mouths, but it killed germs, right? *WHERE WERE THE FUCKING BANDAIDS?*

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer whirled around to see her mother standing in the doorway, still somehow regal despite the face free of makeup and dressed in only her night robe.

"What are you doing? Did I hear the front door?"

"Y-yeah. It's… I'm just…," Glimmer blinked away the hot tears forming in her eyes. "Adora's hurt. She needs help, but I don't know what to do and I--"

Angella's slightly disapproving glare, turned to concern and she stepped forward, cupping her panicking daughter's cheek to calm her.

"Adora's here?"

"Yeah," Glimmer sniffed. "In the living room."

"And she's hurt?"

“She's bleeding."

Angella straightened, her cool demeanor calming Glimmer somewhat.

"Well then, if she's hurt, this," she gently extricated a strangled tube of tooth paste from her daughter's hand, "won't help. Come. Let me see her."

Glimmer hurried out of the bathroom, leading Angella to where she'd left Adora. The girl was standing now, staring down at the couch, her hand still pressed over her wound.

She looked around when she heard Glimmer and shrunk back when Angella appeared behind her.

"Mrs. Sato! Ma'am...I uh, I'm sorry...I dripped on your couch…"

Glimmer glanced down to see a few spots of red staining the brown leather.

Angella's face was still relaxed as she approached, but Glimmer could see a hint of concern in her eyes.

"Don't worry about the couch, Adora. Are you alright?"

"I think so," Adora mumbled, looking like she wanted to disappear entirely. "I'm kinda dizzy."

"Let's go to the kitchen," Angella offered, guiding Adora with a gentle hand on her back. "We'll get you some water."

Adora followed, glancing back at Glimmer who was practically stepping on her heels she was so close.

Angella pulled two stools up to the island, having Adora sit in the one across from her, while she instructed Glimmer to grab a glass of water.

Glimmer did so, one eye glued to her mother and Adora as Angella removed her hand to check the damage.

"It doesn't look too bad," she insisted with a small smile just as Glimmer returned, setting the water on the island beside Adora. She could see a long vertical cut through Adora's brow. It wasn't very deep, but it was still dripping blood down Adora's face and it had taken a large chunk of her eyebrow.

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer snapped to attention at her mother's voice.

"I need you to get some supplies from the master bathroom for me."

Glimmer hurried off as soon as she'd gotten the list, repeating it in her head as she took the stairs two at a time. She dashed so quickly to the master bathroom, that she didn't notice her father reading one of his fantasy novels in bed.

"Where's the fire?" He chuckled as Glimmer shot past him.

"Adora got hurt," Glimmer called from the bathroom as she rummaged for the required supplies. "Mom's helping her, she sent me to get stuff."

Micah frowned, closing his book. "She's hurt? It's late… She came here?"

"Yeah," Glimmer responded, gathering a roll of gauze last and charging back towards the stairs. She dropped the bottle of rubbing alcohol in the process, but Micah was right behind her, picking it up and nodding for her to continue.

By the time they made it to the kitchen, a pile of bloody paper towels had accrued on the counter. Glimmer dropped her supplies next to Angella, proceeding to hover over her mother's shoulder like a nervous bird as she reached for the cotton balls and rubbing alcohol.

Adora seemed to shrink somehow further into herself as Micah appeared in the doorway. She did her best to stare at the ground, even as Angella lifted her chin with gentle fingers to begin dabbing at the wound.

"Adora, are you alright?" Micah kept a fair distance, careful not to overwhelm their injured house guest, but concern was clear in his voice.

"Yeah, I'm okay… it's not bad… I just got into an argument with my foster mom… But it's okay, it was just an accident."

Glimmer watched her parents carefully. Neither said anything to argue, but Glimmer saw her father's fists clench at his sides and Adora winced as Angella probably pressed a little too hard in frustration.

"You were smart to come here," Micah reassured her and Adora gave the tiniest of nods.

"Hold still," Angella reminded her as she finished cleaning the wound. It looked a lot smaller, Glimmer realized, with all the blood gone.

"Glimmer." Glimmer jumped, realizing she was almost entirely leaning over her mother's shoulder to see. "Why don't you pull up a stool?"

Glimmer did so quickly, plopping down beside Adora and taking her hand. Adora's eyes flickered to her, a soft smile gracing her lips as she squeezed Glimmer's fingers.

Glimmer squeezed back firmly. *'I'm here. I'm not going anywhere. You're okay, now.'*

"Would anyone else like some water?" Micah asked grabbing three glasses despite the muted response. Glimmer took her gratefully, sipping slowly, as Angella dressed the now clean wound with a bandage half the size of Adora's forehead.

"Keep this on for the night, as least," she instructed, finally leaning back to examine her work. "I know you might not be able to wear it tomorrow, but it's important the antiseptic does it's work this evening."

Adora nodded obediently. "Yes ma'am. Thank you."

Angella's expression softened and she gently patted Adora's shoulder. "Would you care to spend the night?"

Once again, Adora nodded, her hand tightening on Glimmer's.

"Glimmer." Angella nodded to her daughter, who helped Adora stand and then led her to the staircase, hands still tightly intertwined.

"C'mon Adora, the bed is made and everything. It's perfect."

Glimmer knew her parents would stay in the kitchen for a while, cleaning up and discussing what happened. But Glimmer was determined to protect Adora from anything she could tonight. It was movie, snuggle, sleep and forget time.

She would make sure of that.

They collapsed into Glimmer's bed, amidst the piles of pillows and cozy blankets. Glimmer tucked Adora in tightly, making sure she was comfortable before switching off the lights and turning on a movie, setting the laptop on her knees between them.

Adora leaned against her shoulder, sinking into the mattress with a contented sigh that made Glimmer's heart ache. She definitely should have told her parents about Mrs. Weaver when Adora had shown them the bruise earlier in the week. It was abuse. Of course, it was going to get worse.

But Adora was here now, at least. Glimmer could keep her safe for the moment, so she tried to focus on that and the solid warmth of Adora's body pressed up against hers. With the lights off and the movie playing quietly, it didn't take long for Adora's body to go limp beside hers. Glimmer could see her eyelids fluttering as she tried to stay awake.

She must be exhausted.

Closing the laptop, Glimmer nudged her to get more comfortable.

"Let's get some sleep," she said, and Adora complied, rolling onto her side and curling into a tight fetal position.

Glimmer lay awake for quite some time, staring at the back of Adora's head as they lay together in bed, worrying her bottom lip

between her teeth. The girl's breathing had slowed significantly and while normally that would be relaxing, Glimmer couldn't get the image of all that blood pouring down her face out of her head.

"Adora?" She whispered after a moment of consideration.

Adora's reply was a sleepy mumble. "Hm?"

"Are you still feeling okay?"

"I'm fine, Glim," Adora chuckled slightly, her shoulders shaking in the dark.

"Okay."

Quiet fell over them again, but Glimmer could not get her eyes to close. She stared at the soft blonde strands falling stark against the white pillow they shared.

"Adora?"

A heavier sigh this time.

"Yeah?"

"Are you sure you should be laying on it like that? Maybe you should sleep on your other side tonight."

Adora stiffened slightly before peeking over her shoulder. "Would that make you feel better?"

Glimmer nodded, pursing her lips in a slight pout. Carefully, Adora shuffled around onto her other, uninjured side, so that she was facing Glimmer.

They were almost nose to nose now. Glimmer could see the flecks of gray in her eyes and the faint freckles on her cheekbones.

Slowly, Glimmer reached up, fingers tracing the outline of the large bandage Angella had placed over the injury on Adora's brow.

"Does it hurt?" Glimmer whispered, her chest tightening.

"Not anymore." Adora's voice was soft, it broke slightly as she spoke, and Glimmer noticed her blue eyes flickering over her face.

"Okay...If it does, wake me up. I'll tell mom and she can get more of that numbing stuff." Glimmer's fingers were softly brushing Adora's cheek and jaw now, running down to linger on the pulse point of Adora's neck. The blonde's eyes fluttered shut at her touch, and it looked like a battle was ensuing to keep them open.

"Sorry," Glimmer murmured, taking her hand away from Adora's face to clutch one of her calloused ones against her chest. "You can go to sleep now. I'll shut up."

But Adora shook her head slightly, eyes cracking open to peer at Glimmer through the darkness. "Will you sing to me?"

Glimmer felt her heart skip several beats as Adora's eyes bore into hers. "Okay."

She began to hum, more than sing, a song her mother had sung for her when she was a baby. Adora closed her eyes again, her body sagging into the mattress as Glimmer's voice filled the room.

Glimmer didn't want to think about how Adora would have to face her foster mother tomorrow. How she'd probably throw the bandage away so that she wouldn't know she'd gotten help.

How she'd work herself sick in training tomorrow at school even though she should be resting, healing...cuddling here with Glimmer. The one person who wanted to take care of her more than anything…

Without even really realizing what she was doing, just knowing she wanted Adora to realize how deeply she cared, Glimmer pressed her lips to the blonde’s forehead, lingering in a gentle kiss until she heard Adora snoring softly beside her.

'I'll be here for you, Adora,' she swore silently, finally letting her eyes slip shut. 'Always.'

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

This chapter is really short...but...the moment you've been waiting for perhaps??

Enjoy!

Somehow, Glimmer woke first that Saturday morning. She didn't get up right away, instead turning to study her still sleeping roommate; watching as the soft morning rays highlighted her golden hair, and softened the planes of her face.

Her eyes kept flickering back to the scar that cut through Adora's left brow. She wondered if Adora remembered that night. If she ever thought about how they'd fallen asleep tangled together, protecting one other.

Probably not.

It was a long time ago now and Adora has been exhausted and traumatized for most of it. Glimmer remembered though. Every detail in startling clarity. She doubted she'd ever forget it. Nor would she ever forgive Mrs. Weaver for what she did.

Not that is mattered anymore. Out of the two of them, Adora seemed to have her life entirely put together. She'd worked hard for it, no doubt. But Glimmer couldn't help but feel like a bit of a failure in comparison.

'Add her to the growing list of people I disappoint', she mused, slipping out of bed as quietly as she could and heading for the bathroom.

She had a lunch shift today at the bar; for once glad that she had work to distract her from thinking about Adora, their past, and all they'd fucking lost.

Adora had been surprised to see Glimmer gone by the time she woke up that morning. But considering how often their schedules contrasted nowadays, she supposed she shouldn't have been.

She wished she'd had a chance to speak with her roommate before work though. Lately, memories of high school, of… them, had been circling her mind. She wondered it Glimmer ever thought of their time back then. Especially now that they were living together.

The last few days had been… stressful, to say the least. It took her a while to be able to full sleep in the bed Glimmer had cum on… Moaning *her* name. But, besides that incident… Nothing seemed to have changed between them. Glimmer didn't *seem* interested, despite her shared fantasies. But maybe she was just as afraid as Adora was about broaching old feelings. If anything went wrong… Where would Glimmer go?

She didn't want to force her back to her mother's. Adora knew their relationship must still be rocky; she wouldn't be staying here otherwise.

Resigning herself to another day of reminiscing and… fantasizing, Adora got ready and made her way to work. For the most part, the day was nothing special. Her classes went well and she managed to bullshit with Lonnie for a couple of minutes here and there in between sessions.

A ding from her phone near the end of her shift made her heart race as she found herself hoping it was a message from Glimmer. What she saw when she opened it made her heart stop.

Catra, still on the road with her band, had sent her a picture with the caption 'wish you were here bby ;3".

Catra was reclined in someone's bed, fully nude torso exposed with some girl beside her, arm wrapped around the girl's waist. Adora didn't care to study the picture long enough to take in what

she looked like, turning her phone off immediately as rage rushed through her.

To be honest, Catra hadn't been at the forefront of her mind over the past two weeks. She'd almost managed to forget her and all the drama she caused. But seeing the picture, the blatant malicious teasing, brought every confused emotion she felt for the other woman roaring back. How fucking dare she? True… They weren't girlfriends right now… They hadn't been in a long time. But before Catra had gone on tour, she'd been spending so much time at Adora's apartment, it almost felt normal again. But fucking with her emotions like this? And what about her somewhat girlfriend Scorpia?

Catra toying with her was nothing new. But along with the confusing things she was feeling for Glimmer; the picture was utterly overwhelming.

Slipping into the gym bathroom. Adora allowed a few frustrated tears to escape, knuckles white against the sink that she was gripping so tightly she briefly worried it might shatter.

'Fuck her, fuck her, fuck her.'

By the time Adora's next class arrived, she was drained and exhausted, and the session was more than disappointing.

Adora didn't drink. She really didn't. She didn't like the taste, or how it made her feel. So why bother? Nevertheless, as she headed home from the gym that day, she found herself making a stop at the local liquor store. She picked up two bottles of cranberry flavored vodka, the dark cloud over her head only growing as she made her way home.

It was around 6pm when she arrived back at the apartment and Glimmer was already there, flipping through Netflix. She looked up when Adora came in, a bright smile lighting up her face. It almost made Adora feel better.

Almost.

“Hey,” her lavender eyes flickered to the bag Adora held. “What’d you get?”

“Vodka,” Adora replied shortly.

“You got alcohol?” Glimmer’s eyes practically bugged and she rose from the couch to join Adora in the kitchen. “You feeling okay?”

“Fine…” Adora leaned against the counter, heaving a long sigh. “I just… Felt like forgetting tonight, I guess.”

Glimmer didn’t comment on that, although she looked like she wanted to. Instead she examined one of the bottles, chuckling quietly to herself.

“What?”

“Nothing. Just—This was what I drowned my sorrows in after my ex dumped me.”

Adora picked up the other bottle, tapping the neck against Glimmer’s. “Cheers to shitty ex-girlfriends.”

“I’ll drink to that.”

The alcohol hit Adora quicker than she expected. She’d slowed about thirty minutes in, 1/3 of the bottle consumed. It was disgusting. Tasting only a little bit better than vaguely berry flavored battery acid, but even still she drank it. And soon the fuzzy lightness that filled her body made her forget her frustrations with Catra. She and Glimmer had chosen some show about tigers that she wasn’t even really watching, her focus more on the fact that Glimmer had sidled across the couch and was basically leaning against her shoulder.

She was warm and soft and the steady rise and fall of her breathing was relaxing. Adora glanced at her out the corner of her eye occasionally, gaze roaming over the smooth expanse of her exposed thighs, the dip of her cleavage inside her tank top. God,

she really was beautiful. The almost frumpy, nerdy girl she'd known in high school had confidently grown into her body, turning it into an artful canvas. Adora's hand twitched, almost moving to trace the pink cherry blossoms on her right thigh. She stopped herself just in time, hand clenching to a tight fist against her own thigh.

Glimmer seemed to notice, because she reached out, taking Adora's hand and lacing it with her own. Maybe it was the fact that their barriers were lowered due to the amount of alcohol consumed, or maybe Glimmer just felt more comfortable with her after two weeks. Either way, Adora's stomach did somersaults as Glimmer rubbed her thumb over her knuckles.

"I'm sorry your day sucked," she mumbled, although her gaze remained on the television.

"It's alright, just… stupid drama with someone."

"Do you wanna talk about it?"

"Not really."

Glimmer hummed and nodded and suddenly her head was resting against Adora's shoulder, soft hair tickling her chin. Adora could smell a hint of lavender coming from the fluffy locks. She closed her eyes, absorbing the moment. Catra may have been behaving like an asshole, but at least she had Glimmer's steady warmth and affection to support her.

She took another swig of her drink, beginning to drift away, her mind entirely leaving the present moment, once again returning to high school. To the nights she would fall asleep curled in Glimmer's arms. It didn't seem like they'd spent three years apart. This sort of closeness was familiar and comforting. She liked it.

She didn't realize Glimmer was asking her something until she repeated it a little more sharply, prodding the blonde's side.

"Adora, please?"

"Huh?"

"The remote? Please? This show is stupid."

Adora blinked at her dumbly, frozen, her mind spinning on the two words that had fallen from Glimmer's lips. She was transported back to the moment she'd seen her in the bedroom, arching, moaning.

'Adora… Please.'

"You okay?"

Snapping out of her reverie, Adora swallowed, smiled nervously and handed her the remote. Glimmer peered at her curiously but did not say anything as she scrolled through other options. Adora shifted uncomfortably beside her as she felt heat gathering between her thighs. The departure to her fantasies hadn't been intentional, but they were all bombarding her at once now. And Glimmer was *so* close, her fingers still laced with Adora's.

She studied Glimmer a bit more unabashedly now, eyes roaming the wonderfully supple curves of her body. Glimmer's eyes caught hers, the TV suddenly forgotten as something electric passed between them. Adora found she couldn't look away, her eyes locked on Glimmer's, body rigid as the tension in the air grew palpable. Lavender eyes flickered to her lips as Adora's tongue darted out to wet them. Slowly, they dragged back up her face, and Glimmer's hand left hers to slide against the outside of her thigh.

Maybe it was the alcohol. Maybe it was the obvious tension that had been dogging them for the better part of a week. Either way, Adora had been *waiting* for Glimmer's next request.

"Adora?"

"Yeah?"

"Kiss me."

Adora didn’t need to be told twice. She slipped one hand around the back of Glimmer’s neck, tangling her fingers into the downy hair at the base and pressing her lips firmly to Glimmer’s. It was like an explosion went off inside of her, heat rushing to every corner of her body as Glimmer’s soft lips slid against hers. None of the fantasies could compare to the actual sensation of Glimmer pressed against her, hands gripping the front of her shirt as she pulled Adora closer.

Her mouth opened against Adora’s suddenly and in the next instant she felt the brush of Glimmer’s tongue, a broken moan escaping her as she met it with her own. The kiss turned sloppy, heated, weeks of denied passion building as their hands wandered more frantically. In the back of her mind, Adora realized this was probably a bad, alcohol related decision. But it felt too good to care, the heat and wetness building between her thighs rapidly.

She suddenly felt Glimmer’s hand against the inside of her thigh, rising higher and higher until she brushed against the heat practically radiating through her leggings. To Adora’s extreme disappointment, Glimmer pulled away from the kiss with a harsh breath, her eyes locking with Adora’s wide and glassy.

In the next instant, her lips connected with the blonde’s again, wet and fierce and full of passion as she swung one leg over Adora, straddling her lap. The broken couch creaked beneath them as Adora leaned back, or rather, was pushed back by the force of her kiss. It was electric, alive...setting every inch of Adora's body on fire as Glimmer buried her hands in her hair, trying to pull her closer, groaning against her lips.

Adora matched her frantic passion, gripping Glimmer's hips and tugging slightly. The small gesture worked, because Glimmer began to pulse her hips against Adora's. Tiny, jerky motions due to the small space on the couch, but the rhythmic pressure was hitting Adora in just the right spot. With every pulse, a jolt when straight from Adora's core to her brain, making everything fuzzier, feeling more like her entire body was slowly bursting into flame.

"Oh fuck," Adora mumbled against her lips, just as Glimmer caught the bottom one between her teeth and tugged. Adora opened her eyes into Glimmer's, both of them unable to look away as Adora's lip slid slowly through Glimmer's teeth. Immediately, Adora chased her lips again, but Glimmer sat back, smirking slightly when she whimpered.

"Glim--,"

"It's hot," she complained, before suddenly tugging her shirt over her head. Before Adora could even blink, she'd reached behind herself and removed her bra, leaving her entirely bare.

Adora's mouth went dry as she saw what she'd fantasized about for days was revealed to her. Two small metal barbells pierced each of Glimmer's dark nipples. Both capped with tiny intricate roses.

"Oh…," was all Adora could say, hesitant to do anything but stare. She didn't want to cross any lines by barging ahead without permission... As if there were lines to worry about crossing at this point. But the piercings somehow made her breasts even more enticing.

"You can touch," Glimmer practically whined. "Or lick, or suck, or bite I don't fucking care."

"I can…?" Adora tried to ignore the way both her hands and voice were trembling. Glimmer simply nodded the second time, pushing slightly into Adora as it to tempt her.

Adora didn't need tempting. She leaned forward, a shaky breath escaping her as she laved a wet tongue around Glimmer's right nipple. The contrast of warm and cool, hard metal and unbearably soft skin was intoxicating. Adora let out a choked moan, hands gripping probably too tightly onto Glimmer's hips as she wrapped her lips fully around the nipple and began to suck.

Glimmer hissed, arms sliding around Adora's neck, one hand buried in her hair, tugging with each twist of Adora's tongue.

"Oh god…," she murmured as Adora lifted one hand, using it to palm and squeeze Glimmer's other breast, occasionally tweaking the nipple between her fingers. "These—ah—Were a good idea."

Adora almost pulled away as it suddenly hit her all at once what they were doing. She was literally sitting on her couch, sucking on the nipple of a woman who had once been her closest childhood friend. And sure, Adora had feelings for her back then… But it had been years. And sure, there were the fantasies. But she just missed Catra. Or something.

Glimmer groaned and tugged on Adora's hair again, pulling her somehow closer to her chest.

'Fuck, Catra.'

Leaning forward, Glimmer pressed her lips to Adora's temple, attempting to lay kisses against her hair as the blonde continued her assault on her chest. She wasn't very successful, her breathy moans brushing Adora's ear and stoking the fire raging between her thighs.

Pulling away once both nipples were red and swollen from her attention, Adora dared to meet Glimmer's hazy gaze.

"Should we—?" she swallowed and jerked her chin towards the bedroom door.

Yes," Glimmer breathed before diving in and attaching her lips to Adora's neck, sucking and biting dark marks into her skin.

Somehow, amidst the desperate assault Glimmer was laying against her neck, Adora made it to the bedroom. She hoisted Glimmer's weight off the couch easily, her wonderfully smooth thighs wrapping tightly around Adora's waist. She could feel Glimmer's hips pulsing ever so slightly, grinding against her abdomen, the button of her jean short rubbing irritably against Adora's skin.

Carefully, Adora turned, sitting on the edge of the bed. As soon as she settled, Glimmer detached from sucking on her neck, leaning back to meet her eyes before shoving her back against the pillows.

Adora pushed herself up onto her elbows, her lips just barely grazing the bare skin of Glimmer's chest again when the other woman put a hand on her shoulder, stopping her.

"Wait, wait, wait," she said breathlessly.

Immediately, Adora drew back, disappointment flooding through her as she realized this moment was probably about to end. Glimmer was coming to her senses. She knew they shouldn't be doing this…

"Before we do this…" Adora perked up. "We should lay down some ground rules…"

Rules… Okay, yes. Rules. Adora was slowly piecing together what Glimmer was saying through the lust clouding her brain. This would be a one-time thing… That was fine… She could sate her fantasies and forget Catra for a night. She could work with that.

"Rule number one," Glimmer let one hand crawl up from Adora's shoulder, around the back of her neck, through her undercut, blunt nails scraping her scalp. Adora's eyes practically rolled back into her head at the sensation. "No cuddling. No kissing while fucking."

"That's two—,"

Adora trailed off into a moan as Glimmer's hand crawled higher, undoing her ponytail and allowing long blonde hair to spill around her shoulders.

"Rule number two; no talking about this outside of the bedroom."

Adora nodded mindlessly, leaning forward in an attempt to taste Glimmer's skin again, but a firm hand held her back by the hair.

"And rule number three," Glimmer leaned in, ghosting her lips over Adora's before moving to whisper against the shell of her ear. "No falling in love with me."

She pulled back, teasing Adora with a wink, but Glimmer's words made her heart skip a beat.

What Glimmer was implying… All these rules together… Tonight wouldn't be the only night. Friends? But… Friends that saw each other naked sometimes? No attachments. No commitments. Just sex. Yeah, Adora could do that. She could definitely do that. It had been no different with Catra. And she was, at this point, desperate to sate the fantasies that had been plaguing her for two weeks now.

Ignoring the small voice inside her head that reminded her sleeping with Glimmer would bring deeply buried feelings back to the surface, Adora simply nodded her compliance.

"Do you want this, Adora?" Glimmer purred, grinding down into her lap once more.

"Yes."

Adora lunged forward, capturing her mouth in a fierce kiss, figuring they weren't actually fucking yet, so foreplay kissing was okay. She fumbled for the button on Glimmer's shorts, pulling them open and helping Glimmer tear them off her legs. She almost forgot the underwear, her fingers seeking out Glimmer's heat, only to find a barrier of wet fabric still in the way.

Adora whined, drawing an amused chuckle from Glimmer, even as she flipped them over, tugging the hem of Glimmer's underwear until they too were thrown over her shoulder and Glimmer was fully exposed to her.

She gently laid Glimmer against the pillows before pressing her down into the mattress, rolling her hips once, the slow grind making her heart stutter. She crawled down Glimmer's body slowly, mindful not to kiss exactly… But dragging her teeth and

tongue down the soft skin. She stopped to circle a pierced nipple once again, relishing in the sound of Glimmer's sharp hiss before continuing her tortuously slow path.

Scooting back on the bed a bit, Adora settling herself between Glimmer's thighs, biting the tiny stretch marks she found and licking at the apex between her thigh and core. Adora could smell the heady scent of her now, practically already taste it on her tongue and it was making her ravenous.

Luckily, Glimmer seemed to have had enough of foreplay, because she fisted a hand in Adora's hair and dragged her towards her sex.

Diving in, Adora licked a long path from her entrance to her clit, her eyes sliding shut as she savored the taste, the silky wetness and sensation of Glimmer's hips jumping as her tongue circled her sensitive nub.

Glimmer didn't speak much as Adora switched from long strokes to quick flicks, but her uninhibited moans and sighs filled the room, filled Adora's ears. It wasn't long before she was grinding along with the movement of Adora's tongue, desperately chasing her release, her thighs trembling and tightening fiercely around the blonde's head.

Adora gripped her thighs tightly to steady her shaking hands, eyes flickering up to Glimmer's face. Lavender eyes locked on hers and despite her current position, Adora felt like blushing. There was something incredibly intimate about looking into Glimmer's eyes as she groaned between her thighs.

All at once, Glimmer threw her head back against the pillow, a high-pitched whine in the back of her throat as she came, her taste heavy on Adora's tongue. After a few more gentle laps to guide her through her peak, Adora crawled up her body, only pausing when she remembered the fucking kissing rule. So instead she hovered above her, waiting for the other woman to open her eyes.

They were bright and glassy when she did, and immediately her hands went for the pants Adora still wore.

"Get your fucking pants off," Glimmer insisted, her face flushed and voice still a little airy.

"Oh, right," Adora kicked her pants and underwear off in a furious flurry of movement. She turned back to Glimmer quickly, surprised to see that the other woman had turned onto her stomach, and was peering teasingly as Adora over her shoulder. Adora crawled over her, pausing when she saw a tattoo she'd never been able to see before.

Two intertwining female symbols rested at the base of Glimmer's tailbone, swirling text that spelled out the word 'Princess' just beneath them. Adora reached up, mouth dry, tracing slowly over the letters. Glimmer shivered beneath her touch.

She couldn't help herself anymore. Leaning down, Adora pressed a soft kiss to the tattoo, yelping in shock when Glimmer slapped at her shoulder.

"What the fuck was rule number one, Adora?"

Frustrated, but unable to form an argument through the heat roaring in her brain, Adora crawled up, leaning over Glimmer again and dipping low enough to whisper in her hear. "Spread your legs."

Glimmer's entire body shook beneath her as she did what she was told, sighing, her hips pulsing ever so slightly against the mattress.

If she was being honest with herself, Adora didn't quite know what she was doing. She'd never been on top before… Literally or figuratively. But she was determined to take control. Glimmer seemed to be enjoying herself so far anyway.

She stroked Glimmer's thigh with one hand, smoothing her palm over the curve of her ass as she bit down lightly on one of the

intricate wing tattoo. It didn't count as a kiss, but Adora *really* needed something to do with her mouth at the moment and Glimmer wasn't complaining, letting out a low moan instead.

Adora knew she should work her up more, tease. But she was also desperate to finally *feel* Glimmer on her fingertips. Allowing her hand to trail back down, Adora teased into her folds, groaning against Glimmer's shoulder as the heat and slick wetness overwhelmed her.

"So wet for me…" She breathed, echoing the words from her own fantasies.

Glimmer moaned softly and Adora felt her press up, the curve of her ass settling against Adora's hips. A silent plea for her to continue.

Forcing herself to keep her own hips still, Adora teased gentle circles around Glimmer's still sensitive clit, savoring every twitch and sigh and moan. She felt Glimmer's thighs trembling around her again, toes curling against the blankets. A sure sign of another impending orgasm.

Adora's own breath was beginning to come in harsh pants. So after one more tortuously long circle, Adora pressed a finger against Glimmer's slit, pushing inside slowly.

The heat was overwhelming. Glimmer's walls fluttering and tightening around her single digit. Adora whimpered at the sensation at the same time Glimmer did. Her mind flitting back to how many times she'd imagined this years ago. But now it was real… Glimmer beneath her, Adora's finger sliding slowly in and out of her, the heat, the hammering of her pulse, the desire.

"Adora… Please."

The magic words. Glimmer didn't even need to clarify what she was asking for. She pushed her hips back at the same time Adora introduced a second finger, walls clamping tight around them.

“Fuck…,” she choked out, hands clenching in the pillow.

Adora braced herself on her free arm and began pumping her fingers with vigor. Glimmer was…enthusiastic, to say the least. Her melodic moans filled the bedroom, ringing in Adora’s ears until it was the only sound in the world. Until Glimmer was all that Adora could see, taste, feel…

She pressed her forehead against Glimmer’s shoulder, desperate to kiss, but eager to follow the rules as her fingers grew slicker with each movement.

Sloppily, hastily, Adora sat back, using her other hand to circle a thumb around Glimmer’s clit. It all happened too quickly, Glimmer cried out and then a gush of wetness hit Adora’s palm and her body was shaking hard, quivering as she came hard again. Adora didn’t stop pumping her fingers until she felt Glimmer’s walls stop fluttering around them.

Only then did she slip out, sitting back and staring in awe at the gorgeous woman lying before her. It hit her all at once, they’d just done that. She’d just been *inside* Glimmer. Fucking her. Glimmer moaning her name. It all felt surreal somehow. Glimmer lay loose and boneless against the pillows, her hips twitching slightly. The sight only made the fire in between Adora’s thighs burn hotter. She needed a release badly.

Glimmer peered at her over her shoulder, pupils blown wide. She jerked her chin, eyes flickering to the back of her thigh and Adora gulped as the invitation registered. Slowly, she crawled up, bracing her hands on either side of Glimmer’s hips before lowering her core onto Glimmer’s thigh.

Glimmer buried her face in the pillows, groaning as she felt Adora’s slick heat sliding against her skin.

“Oh god….”

Adora choked a breathless response as the pressure and the curve of Glimmer’s perfect thigh hit her clit. She bore down hard and

fast, grinding a harsh rhythm until she was panting against Glimmer's shoulder.

"Glim—," she breathed out, her hips stuttering as she felt the building explosion of her climax deep within her belly. "Fuck… I—I'm gonna…Glimm—!"

Glimmer pressed back against her, ass hitting Adora's hips and Adora's orgasm hit her like a nuclear wave, her voice lost in the intensity of her pleasure. She strained, her body rocking fiercely a few more times as wave after wave of her orgasm rocketed through her, before collapsing bonelessly beside Glimmer, staring up at the ceiling fan in awe.

They both lay their quietly, absorbing what had just happened between them.

'Holy shit.'

She must have said it out loud because Glimmer chuckled lightly beside her, her breath also coming in gasps.

"Yeah…"

They lay there quietly for a moment, Adora unsure of what to do next. No cuddling had been rule number one, but it felt wrong to just… End it here.

Glimmer didn't seem to agree because she rose from the bed and grabbed a robe from the closet, wrapping herself in it before heading for the door.

"That was fun," she laughed again. "I'm gonna go light up. Care to join?"

Not really coherent enough to remind Glimmer that this was a non-smoking unit, Adora simply shook her head in silence. Shrugging, Glimmer slipped out of the room, leaving Adora to reel with the events of the night.

‘*Holy shit.’*

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> Another update so soon? More smut? Yes and also yes. Here we go.
>
> In summation: Glimmer and Adora agree on a whole lotta rules. They go shopping for something a little out of Adora's comfort zone, wherein Glimmer runs into her arch-nemesis. Then they make a difficult economic decision to save water.

Adora wasn't really sure what to expect the next morning. Some tension? Some level of awkwardness? Maybe Glimmer would ignore her all together. To her surprise… None of the above were true.

Glimmer was waiting for her in the kitchen, scribbling on a piece of paper, tongue poking between her lips as she worked. As it turned out, last night's rules had not been all of them. There were many more, including, but not limited to:

-No pet names

-No jealousy or other possessive emotions, they were allowed to see other people.

-No dates or other couple-y activities.

-No 'sessions' more than once or twice a week.

By the end of the conversation, Adora had agreed to all of the rules Glimmer laid out, but her mood had soured entirely. Last night, as she'd suspected, had awakened things in her that she'd kept buried for a long time. Things she'd thought she was completely over. As it turned out, that was not the case, and Adora really didn't like the idea of the 'no kissing unless it's foreplay rule'. Glimmer was a really good kisser.

Adora dragged herself to work that day, grumpy and frustrated. It wasn't until she received a teasing text from Glimmer… Her lying fully naked on the bed in a position far too enticing for Adora not to speed on the way home, that her mood improved.

The once or twice a week rule didn't last more than a day… The picture triggered their second "session". Followed by a subsequent third time and then a fourth and before she knew it, tumbling into bed with Glimmer after a long day seemed to be routine. Not that she was complaining.

She was berated for breaking the rules more often than not, punished in the sense that Glimmer would often deny her any sort of contact the following day. But they were hard to follow! Particularly the no cuddling after sex rule. Even when she was back with Catra, they'd always curled up together after… doing stuff.

Catra.

Adora hadn't talked to her since she'd sent the selfie, and Catra hadn't pestered her further. And despite her new confusing relationship with Glimmer dominating her mind, she still wondered what she would say when Catra got back into town. She'd have to tell *both* of them about the other sometime. But… That was a problem for future Adora, she figured.

For now, it was plenty distracting to be trying new things with Glimmer. She'd never been allowed, with Catra, to dominate in the bedroom and it was… exciting to say the least. She liked pleasing Glimmer, liked being the source of her moans, the arching and quivering of her body when she came underneath Adora's touch. It was satisfying and more often than not, it helped her reach her own climax too. Glimmer seemed perfectly content to teach, as well. Adora wasn't exactly new to the whole thing, but there were certain intricacies she hadn't necessarily been aware of, especially as the one *doing* the things. But Glimmer was a surprisingly patient teacher 'mid-session' and Adora was a fast learner. And very eager to please.

It only took about a week for the two of them to fall into a comfortable rhythm, to understand the sweet spots each had. To know how to tease and draw the most intense orgasms out of one another. It was—really good. Adora wasn't going to deny that. And no matter how hard it was to lay on her cold side of the bed as Glimmer stacked pillows between them to avoid the mornings when Adora 'somehow' ended up curled around her… Adora liked this, whatever it was they had. For now, it worked.

It didn't take Glimmer long to figure out what Adora liked in bed, what worked for her. She seemed almost desperate to bring Glimmer the most pleasure whenever they were together. But more than that, she noticed how Adora really seemed to be a fan of the whole… thrusting thing.

An idea struck her late one night as she stared at the ceiling after a particularly intense session. And maybe it was the guilt that kept gnawing away at her the more they did this. But she wanted to do something for Adora.

Adora had done a lot for her already; and not just in regards to sex. She'd let her into her home, gotten her a job, given her a direction. The least she could do was maybe make the sex a little better for her?

So—she posed a risky idea to Adora; the blonde responded a bit nervously, but there was also a hint of excitement in her eyes.

"A… Strap on?" she queried when Glimmer brought it up.

"If you're comfortable with that," Glimmer replied, sipping her morning coffee as casually as she could. Adora hadn't touched hers. "If you want it. I'm not sure if you've ever used one before, I just noticed that you kinda seem to enjoy—,"

"I'd like to try it… I think," Adora cut her off quickly, a red blush coloring her face as she ducked behind her own mug.

A small smile tugged at Glimmer's lips. Why did she have to be so fucking cute?

The closer they got to the sex shop, the more Glimmer thought that maybe this was one of her weaker impulsive decisions. It had seemed like the perfect solution yesterday. But now, for some reason, she was uncharacteristically nervous.

Glimmer chanced a quick glance at Adora. She was driving with knuckles white against the wheel, her mouth little more than a grim line set in a pale face.

"You okay?" Glimmer asked, poking her (well-muscled) arm to grab her attention.

Adora jumped in her seat, whipping around to face Glimmer, her blue eyes distant and unfocused. "Yeah! Yes. Fine. Yeah. I've just… I've never been to one of these, er, shops before… I'm… I don't know—,"

"Just follow my lead," Glimmer assured her, rubbing her arm. "I know what I'm doing."

She didn't really. But certainly out of the two of them she had more experience.

"Oh," Adora mumbled, a bright blush recoloring her pale face.

"They're all professionals. Selling products to customers. That's all it is, don't get too in your head about it."

Adora nodded firmly as they pulled into the parking lot. She inhaled a deep breath, drawing herself up to her full height as she stepped out of the car (Glimmer quickly stuffed down how attractive that was) and walked around to open the passenger side door.

"What a gentleman," Glimmer teased as she slid out of the car, hoping the banter would calm Adora's nerves.

Sure enough, Adora's lips twitched into a crooked grin. She tipped her chin in a faux bow. "Princess."

Glimmer froze as Adora closed the car door and headed for the shop. Nicknames were hardly allowed *inside* the bedroom. For Adora to use it so brazenly outside, in public. Regaining use of her legs, Glimmer charged after Adora, fully intending to berate her, but by the time she caught up with the blonde's longer stride, they were too close to the front doors.

Later. They'd discuss it later.

For now, Glimmer pushed ahead of Adora and opened the door for her, plastering a smug grin on as Adora raised a suspicious brow. Glimmer's smile simply widened and Adora stepped meekly past her into the shop. The bell dinged as the door swung closed behind them and Glimmer took in the shop. She'd never been to this one in particular, but it looked like pretty standard fair. All sorts of toys, harnesses and various pleasureful and colorful items decorated the aisles.

Adora had gone pale again, shrinking in on herself as her eyes flickered nervously around the store.

"C'mon," Glimmer took her hand and led her to an entire wall of display dildos. Adora inched closer to Glimmer's side as they stopped in front of the colorful array.

"Take your pick." Glimmer nudged her with her shoulder and Adora snapped around to blink owlishly at her.

"What?"

"This is why we came here, remember?" Glimmer chuckled, squeezing her hand, her heart skipping a beat when Adora squeezed back. "You said you wanted to give one a try…So, choose."

"I… Get to choose it?" Adora's voice was breathy and somehow contained more awe than Glimmer had expected.

"You'll be the one using it," Glimmer reminded her, voice lowering to the register that she knew drove Adora wild.

As she expected, Adora's eyes darkened and she glanced back up at the wall, her posture straightening almost imperceptibly. Finally, as if Glimmer's words had emboldened her, Adora let go of her hand and began scrutinizing each model in studious detail. Leave it to Adora to analyze every aspect of a sex toy before committing to it.

"Am I allowed—," she looked back at Glimmer even as she reached out to touch a particularly large, neon green toy.

Glimmer nodded, snickering. "Go nuts."

Adora's nose wrinkled as she processed the innuendo, abandoning that particular model and perusing the wall once more. Glimmer followed a few steps behind, eyeing a few of her own choices. But this was about Adora. Ultimately, the decision was hers, for her own pleasure. Glimmer was sure she'd enjoy *whatever* decision the blonde made anyway.

"This one's really small," Adora murmured, picking up what Glimmer immediately knew was not something she wanted. "Is that normal?"

"That's… That doesn't go in vaginas, sweetie," Glimmer explained, gently taking the small diamond embellished toy away from Adora and replacing it on the shelf. Adora blushed furiously as she realized her mistake, allowing Glimmer to continue guiding her along the wall. Glimmer was thankful she'd been too flustered to focus on the nickname. It wasn't meant to be *affectionate*, per say, it had just sort of slipped out and—

"Look at this one." Adora was pointing to a decently sized model, patterned in a bright swirl of rainbows. "It's kinda…Weirdly cute, y'know?"

She giggled to herself and Glimmer couldn't help but smile. What was cute was Adora's reaction to the whole thing. Sure, the

nervousness was to be expected, but now she almost seemed excited to be exploring the possibilities of a toy. One that *she* got to choose. It occurred to Glimmer that she'd probably never had this before. A strap, obviously. But the choice? Control of her own sex life? It wasn't Glimmer's place to ask, that wasn't the point of their relationship anyway. It would be breaking so many rules.

Even still, Glimmer couldn't help but wonder. And watching Adora's quiet awe was almost…Charming.

"LADIES!"

Both Glimmer and Adora jumped as a booming voice broke the peaceful quiet of the shop.

"Is there absolutely *anything* I can help you find today?"

Glimmer turned to see a tall man with a ridiculous handlebar mustache approaching them. He wore a deep V-neck t-shirt and pants so tight they left nothing to her imagination. A bright red ascot and matching bandana topped off his look. It was one Glimmer had seen before too. He'd been at Mermista's apartment the day she moved out.

The same day he had moved in.

The entire world fell out from beneath Glimmer's feet as she stared into the honey brown eyes of the man who had cucked her. Adora was panicking behind her, stumbling for words, but Glimmer was reeling too hard to help her. The situation was made even worse by the fact that this fucking himbo didn't even seem to recognize her.

"We were just—l—looking around," Adora stammered. "Th—Um… You have a nice…Uh, these are nice… Selections."

"Only the finest!" Seahawk (Glimmer remembered how fucking stupid his name had sounded coming out of Mermista's mouth). "Was there anything in particular you were looking for? Any specific fantasies you wish to explore?"

“That’s really not any of your *fucking* business,” Glimmer found her words just in time to spit venom at the shop’s apparently *only* employee. God, what were the fucking chances that her ex’s boyfriend worked in the sex shop *she’d* come into with her girl….er, roommate.

“Untrue!” Seahawk crowed, ignorant or uncaring of her tone. “I am, in fact, the owner of this shop. And as such! It is my sacred duty to ensure that every customer who steps foot in this store leaves completely *satisfied.”*

He finished the sentence with a wink. Glimmer wanted to throw up. God, why were his fucking pants so tight? Adora was shifting nervously from foot to foot behind her, silently looking for somewhere to hide, probably. And Glimmer couldn’t blame her. Part of her wanted to crawl in a hole and die. But the other half… Well, maybe there was an opportunity here.

“You know what? You *can* help us,” Glimmer crossed her arms over her chest, a silent challenge. “I’m sure you know a lot about straps, seeing as Mermista pegs your ass every night.”

A wonderful display of emotions crossed Seahawk’s face, probably as he tried to figure out who the fuck Glimmer was. It struck him about ten seconds later because he gasped loudly. “My, my, my! It is you! Glitter! I wasn’t quite sure when you came in, but I’d recognize the questionable haircut and terrible attitude anywhere.”

Glimmer was two seconds from punching him in his stupid mustached face.

“How have you been? Mermista was just talking about you the other day,” he continued, seemingly unaffected by the pegging comment. “Is this your girl—,”

“Also not any of your business. Also, also, it's *Glimmer,*” Glimmer growled, stepping in front of Adora before Seahawk could reach out to shake her hand. “Um, but…What did Mermista say about me…?”

“Glimmer…,” Adora murmured, tugging on Glimmer’s shirt like a child who wanted to leave. Glimmer batted her hand away, this was important.

Seahawk’s smile never faltered, his stupid smug grin almost as taunting as his words. “Why I believe she was just lamenting the length of your fingers. It’s really no comparison, not through any fault of your own of course!”

Glimmer clenched her hands into fists to hide said fingers and to also perpare to deck Seahawk.

“Were you two looking for an appropriate model?” Seahawk breezed ahead, pushing past Glimmer and slinging an arm around Adora who looked like she wanted to pass out or be shot on sight. “We’ve got one here, excellent length and girth. Mermista and I are actually quite the fans of it.”

Seahawk pulled a long black one off the shelf, holding it up for Adora who almost cringed away from it, her terrified gaze flickering to Glimmer.

“Ah, but, perhaps,” Seahawk pursed his lips, giving Glimmer a once over. “A smaller size might be in order for you two…”

Enraged, Glimmer snatched the dildo from Seahawk, holding it like a football against her chest. “We’ll take it. Show me your best harness.”

“Right this way!” Seahawk shouted, prancing across the store.

Glimmer stormed after him, barely registering Adora’s muttered, “I’ll wait in the car.”

About ten minutes later, laden down with packages full of various toys and standing at the register, Glimmer finally realized that Adora was no longer with her. Seahawk was still brazenly discussing his sex life with her ex, with no regard for her sanity. Whether or not it was vindictive, or just stupidity, Glimmer still

couldn’t tell. But in the moments just before Sea Hawk ran her card, Glimmer stopped, guilt overwhelming her.

This trip was supposed to be about Adora. Her confidence, her choice. And now she was sitting alone in the fucking truck, probably burning with embarrassment and shame, having had *nothing* to do with the items Glimmer had collected for *her* pleasure. It was all wrong…And all because Glimmer had let herself get carried away by her bitterness, her anger.

“Wait,” Glimmer stopped Seahawk quietly, grabbing the many boxes off the counter. “Gimme a sec.”

Slowly, she went around the store, replacing what she’d gathered, until she had only two items left. Seahawk looked confused as she approached the counter again.

“This will be all, then?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer couldn’t meet his gaze, simply handed over her card with her head hung. “That’s all I need.”

Adora looked up as the car door opened and Glimmer slid into the passenger’s seat, silent. She had two boxes set on top of one another in her lap, and she stared hard at them, the silence in the cab growing almost suffocating.

“I’m sorry,” Glimmer murmured finally, looking up from the boxes to meet Adora’s gaze. “That was a disaster…”

“Kinda,” Adora agreed. Her heart was still racing, and her face still burned from how fucking embarrassing the whole thing had been.

Glimmer sighed through her nose, leaning back against the seat. “It wasn’t supposed to be so awful… I didn’t know he’d be there.”

“Who was he?” Adora asked as she picked quietly at the steering wheel.

“My ex’s current boytoy. The guy she cheated on me with…”

“Oh.” That wasn’t the answer Adora had expected. “I didn’t realize. I’m so—,”

“Don’t be,” Glimmer cut her off. “I shouldn’t have let it get to me. They’re both shallow idiots who deserve each other. It was just weird. And I went a little crazy…”

Reaching across the partition, Adora rested a comforting hand on her shoulder. Glimmer looked up, offering a weak smile before handing her the top box.

“Here.”

Adora took it, glancing at the picture on the cover, before a slightly embarrassed, slightly ecstatic smile spread her lips. “You got the rainbow one.”

Glimmer shrugged, pursing her lips, cheeks reddening slightly. “You liked it.”

“Don’t you?” Adora pushed the box in her face, making her burst into giggles.

“Stop! Get your fake dick out of my face.”

“It’s so cute though, Glim. Look!”

Glimmer shoved her away, using the other box as a sword until they were battling with Adora’s much smaller dildo box and the one Glimmer had that contained a sleek black harness with an accompanying set of size rings.

“Should we go?” Adora asked, blocking Glimmer’s last blow and denting both boxes in the process. “Before we literally ruin this stuff in the parking lot.”

“Oh shit, yeah,” Glimmer looked down at her dented box as if surprised to see it mildly destroyed. She paused, then blinked up

at Adora through her lashes. “Did you wanna go home and test them out?”

Adora swallowed, feeling the blood rush to her face. She nodded jerkily in response, turning the key in the engine before Glimmer could suggest anything else that might make her implode on the spot.

It wasn’t until they were halfway home that Glimmer realized she’d forgotten to purchase any lube. With an enormous groan, she had Adora turn the car around. This time, however, Adora was the one to face Seahawk, doing her best to ignore the devious smile on his face.

Glimmer lay splayed out on the bed, waiting impatiently for Adora as the blonde struggled with the straps of the harness. It was equal parts adorable and highly frustrating. Glimmer shifted her thighs together as the throbbing heat built between them.

Adora had already spent a fair amount of time between her legs, insisting she ‘prepare’ Glimmer for the use of the toy. Not like it was fucking necessary. But Glimmer would take any opportunity to have Adora’s talented tongue on her.

It really did seem like overkill now, because simply watching the muscles flex in Adora’s back as she tightened the straps was doing something to her.

“Okay.” Finally, Adora turned around, holding her arms out for Glimmer to observe the final product. “I think I got it.”

She definitely had it. The rainbow pattern decorating the dildo was a little ridiculous at first, but then Adora had one knee on the bed and was crawling towards her and suddenly nothing was funny at all. Just—Really intensely hot.

Glimmer leaned back against the pillows as Adora came to hover over her, strong arms braced on either side of her head.

“Can I—Kiss you?” She asked hesitantly, lowering her body against Glimmer’s anyway. “For, like, foreplay purposes?”

Glimmer responded by wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck and pressing their lips together in a heated kiss. Adora melted into her further, dropping onto her elbows as her tongue teased into Glimmer’s mouth. Glimmer felt like her entire body was on fire. They’d done this multiple times now, but somehow each session seemed to build upon the last as they learned more about each other.

As she expected, Adora began to grind her hips gently into Glimmer’s while they exchanged heated kisses. But with the strap between her legs, the dildo sliding against Glimmer’s folds—the sensation was very different now and almost overwhelming.

A broken whimper escaped her, and she gasped against Adora’s lips before the blonde let her mouth slide down to Glimmer’s nipple, rolling her tongue around the piercing in time with her slow thrusts. Glimmer threaded her hands into Adora’s hair, scraping her nails through her undercut like she knew Adora liked. The blonde’s eyes slipped shut and she dropped her forehead onto Glimmer’s chest, continuing to rock slowly, serving to make Glimmer wetter and wetter until she was about 92% sure she wouldn’t need any lube.

Despite that, Adora sat up suddenly, reaching for the bottle on the bedside table. She popped open the cap when Glimmer stopped her.

“Wait. Let me.”

The confusion cleared from Adora’s face and she swallowed, silently handing the bottle to Glimmer. She dropped a small amount into her hand and shuffled forward on her knees. Adora looked down between them, her eyes widening as Glimmer fisted the strap in one hand, slowly pumping it, enough to put a little pressure on Adora’s clit with each pass.

Adora's eyes met hers, wide and glassy and they leaned forward simultaneously, lips crashing together once again. Glimmer continued to work the strap tortuously slow, even as Adora tangled her hands in her hair and panted against her lips.

"Glimmer…" she murmured softly, the tenderness in her voice making Glimmer's heart jump.

She let go of the strap then, worried the moment might deepen further and broke away from Adora, flipping onto her stomach. This was their usual position by this point; that or on their sides. Glimmer refused to do anything else, or else she'd be forced to look into Adora's perfect eyes. They'd already accidentally done that the first time and the absolute intimacy of the moment had almost shattered her resolve entirely.

Adora hadn't complained thus far, but Glimmer had a sense she'd rather be able to look at her face. Unfortunately, Glimmer wasn't about to let that happen. It was too risky.

A gentle, feathery sensation on her lower back brought her back to the present with a jolt. Adora's long, calloused fingers were tracing the words underneath her tattoo. She sucked in a harsh breath as Adora's lips joined the almost ticklish sensation, crawling slowly up her spine. She couldn't even really be mad that Adora was already breaking the kissing rule, because it felt really fucking good.

Suddenly, Adora's chest pressed against her back, and her lips were ghosting Glimmer's ear, voice low and husky as she asked, "Are you ready for me, Princess?"

A whole-body shudder passed through Glimmer. Adora was adapting quickly to taking the lead and Glimmer couldn't say she hated it. It was really fucking hot if she was being honest. In response, she groaned slightly and nodded, burying her face in the pillows as she felt Adora sit back slightly to position herself.

Adora, ever the gentle soul however, lost a bit of her dominate edge as she murmured. “Let me know if I’m hurting you.”

Glimmer simply rocked back against Adora’s hips, feeling the tip of the strap pushing at her entrance. Adora pressed in slowly, pausing when she heard Glimmer’s gasp, pulling back a bit and then easing in again.

It was surprisingly gentle, and overwhelmingly considerate even though Glimmer was so turned on in the present moment, she was sure she could’ve probably taken the whole thing at once. Even so, the stretch of the dildo drew a low moan from her until Adora was fully hilted.

“You okay?” she panted, her body leaning over Glimmer’s again.

Glimmer nodded rapidly, choking on any possible words as Adora’s teeth caught the wing tattoo on her left shoulder.

It began slowly, Adora rocking cautiously, her thrusts deep. Glimmer could feel her breath ghosting against her shoulder, and it almost made her smile, despite their position; this was already getting Adora worked up.

She knew it had been a good idea.

Adora seemed perfectly content to maintain this almost sensual pace, but Glimmer was growing impatient. She could feel the beginnings of an orgasm building deep inside her belly, but it wasn’t enough.

Throwing an arm behind her, Glimmer gripped the back of Adora’s thigh, fingers digging into her skin as she pulled, encouraging a faster pace. Adora took the hint. She began to rock more quickly, more fiercely, until she was groaning against Glimmer’s shoulder and the sound of their bodies connecting was all that filled the room.

“Fuck, Adora.” The blonde’s name left her in a long moan. They should have gotten this fucking thing sooner.

Adora agreed with her own whimper, her thrusts switching deeper again but a bit quicker than before. Glimmer wasn't expecting her orgasm to creep up so fast, but as Adora hilted again, her teeth clamping down on Glimmer's shoulder, it hit her like an explosion.

Her cry was only slightly muffled by the pillows as she gripped them like a lifeline, her entire body jerking fiercely underneath Adora's.

Adora followed her over the edge, moaning against her skin as her hips stuttered and then she slumped, barely stopping herself from crushing Glimmer beneath her.

They lay there, panting, recovering, Adora still inside her. And for once, Glimmer didn't really mind the closeness—At least Adora wasn't trying to fucking kiss her again. They lay in relative silence, both trembling, bodies still twitching with the aftermath of their climaxes. It was intimate, but not in a way that made Glimmer uncomfortable. Part of her kind of wanted to stay like this forever until she realized Adora's weight on top of her was becoming a little uncomfortable.

"Adora… You're kind of crushing me."

"Oh! Sorry." Immediately, Adora's weight and warmth were gone; Glimmer struggled not to moan loudly as the toy slipped out of her at the same time.

The bed creaked when Adora flopped down beside her this time, the toy still sticking up proudly from between her legs. Okay… It looked a little ridiculous again now that the lust had gone.

"Um… That was—Wow," Adora chuckled a little nervously, her blue eyes flickering to Glimmer, who was still halfway buried in the pillows. It was always kind of endearing how bashful Adora became after their sessions. She could completely dominate the situation, but the second it was over, she seemed to insecure, so in need of reassurance that she'd satisfied Glimmer.

It was cute. And Glimmer kind of hated her for it.

"Yeah, 'wow' sums it up nicely." Glimmer flipped onto her back, gazing up at the ceiling fan, although she could still feel Adora's eyes on her. "We're definitely using it more often."

"Oh? Oh… Yeah, I'd—That would be good." Adora stumbled for her words and then reached for the straps, slowly undoing them and holding the toy over her head. "I'm—I should go clean this off I guess."

She hoisted herself out of bed, and Glimmer's eyes unabashedly fell to her naked rear, traveling down the toned legs as she walked. Why did she have to be so stupidly attractive? And cute? And a total dork?

"I don't actually know…," Glimmer's eyes snapped up to Adora's face as she suddenly turned around. "Can I use soap on this? Should we have bought something at the store? I'm not—"

"Here," Glimmer chuckled, hopping out of bed on shaky legs and pushing Adora to the bathroom. It felt a little strange, walking naked with her roommate through the apartment, but at the same time, it was almost equally exhilarating. There was a casualness to it that made Glimmer feel a little less guilty about the whole thing.

She closed the bathroom door behind them, as if someone might come in and see them, then directed Adora to the sink.

"Just throw some soap on there and rinse it off. It'll be fine."

"You sure?" Adora looked between the toy dangling in her hand and Glimmer like a very confused puppy.

Planting her hands on her hips, Glimmer gave Adora a look that said it all. 'Don't question me, I know what the fuck I'm talking about.'

Silently, Adora turned and threw the toy underneath the spray of water just as Glimmer turned on the shower head. Glancing over her shoulder, the blonde gave her a puzzled look.

“I’m sweaty and sticky and I smell,” Glimmer answered her unspoken question. “I’m hopping in real quick. You are free to use it after I’m done.”

“Or…,” Adora suddenly spoke in the same low tone she’d used in the bedroom and Glimmer paused, one hand tightening on the shower curtain. The blonde turned off the sink, abandoning the toy on the counter and sidling up behind Glimmer, slipping her arms around her middle. “We could save water and shower together.”

Glimmer shivered, the heat roaring back to life inside her and one of Adora’s hands rose to cup and squeeze her breast, while the other traveled lower, teasing of her mound.

“F—for the environment,” Glimmer justified as Adora’s chuckle ghosted the shell of her ear.

“For the environment,” she agreed, pulling away just enough to tug Glimmer into the shower.

In the next instant, she was pinned against the cool tile, back arching as Adora lifted one leg, wrapping it around her hip and smothering Glimmer’s lips with her own.

As she was swept away underneath Adora’s touch, Glimmer couldn’t find it in herself to complain about ending the night with a Round 2…. And maybe 3.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

Well.... Here we go :)

In summation: Glimmer tells Bow about her new relationship with Adora. He does not approve. Meanwhile, Adora remembers the night she realized she'd fallen in love with Glimmer. In the present, she realizes time has done little to dampen those feelings. But her realization comes a little too late as the EX rolls back into town. Things get messy. Who could have guessed?

Next few chapters will get the angst train really rolling ya'll. Enjoy!

-'Hey Bow'

-'GLIMMER!!!!!!!!!!!'

Glimmer didn't even have a second to exit her messenger app before Bow's text came crashing in. She winced as his typing bubble appeared and disappeared a few frantic times, knowing she should have reached out to her best friend soon. But the last couple of weeks had been very… distracting, to say the least. Not that Bow needed to know that. Nor was Glimmer planning on telling him *anything*.

-'Where have you been?? I haven't heard from you in like two weeks!'

-'Two and a half actually'

Bow ignored that, plowing on:

-' Ever since I sent you that stupid Kermit meme. I was worried you got mad…and then I thought you might be dead! Like maybe Adora had killed you. Or maybe you'd killed her. But then I

thought no that couldn't be the case, because we promised each other if we ever needed to hide a body that we'd tell the other person'

-'Bow'

-'But then I was like, okay well if she killed *Adora* who I happen to also consider a friend then maybe she wouldn't tell me. But who else would she tell?? And then I was worried you might be trying to hide the body alone'

-'Bow! Chill out. Everything's fine okay? I've just been settling in and stuff.'

-'oh.'

-'Adora got me a new job. I've just been getting used to doing important stuff with my time again. Y'know… not living off a couch.'

-'Except you literally are tho'

Glimmer flinched, quickly remembering that Bow wasn't aware of her current sleeping situation.

-'Haha yeah'

Bow's reply was delayed, and Glimmer realized she should at least *attempt* to be a little more convincing with her text lying.

-'That was weird. Are you okay? Are you *two* okay?

-'Me and Adora? Oh yeah. We're great.'

I totally haven seen her naked upwards of a dozen times in the past two weeks.

-'Call me.'

Glimmer heaved a frustrated sigh through her nose, head thunking back against the wall behind her. Either Bow knew her

too well, or she was really bad at this whole lying thing. Probably a bit of both. Clambering out of bed, Glimmer pulled on a robe (she was still bare after the 'before work morning session' Adora had insisted upon).

Bow picked up halfway through the first ring.

"What's going on?" His tone was already treading 'disappointed dad' territory and Glimmer hadn't even insinuated anything! … She hoped not, at least.

"Nothing!" The whine at the end of her tone seemed to tell Bow otherwise.

"Glimmer."

"Bow."

"Is something up with Adora?"

"No," Glimmer snorted, a nervous chuckle following as she began to sweat. Bow was persistent, especially when it came to her wellbeing. "We're fine. We're super tight again. It's—Great."

Bow remained silent on the other end of the line. Waiting to pounce.

Glimmer tried to wait him out, she really did. But she lasted a totally of maybe 7 seconds before giving in. She could practically picture the puppy dog eyes.

"We're—It's complicated."

"What's complicated?" Bow's tone had drifted from disappointment to concern. "Did you two fight or something?"

"No, no… We haven't fought. High school really hasn't come up that much, I promise. It's just—Other stuff."

"Glimmer can you please just tell me what's going on?"

Sighing, squeezing her eyes shut, Glimmer bit her lip in thought. She knew Bow wouldn't approve. There was no way. He'd call her out for making a stupid decision and she'd have to defend it despite knowing deep down he was right. It was barely 9 am and she really didn't want to get into this… And yet, there was no turning back now. She knew he wouldn't let her.

"I'm—," she could already see the shock in his expression. "I'm kinda, um, fucking… Adora."

There was silence for a split second as Bow processed her words and then he screeched so loudly he nearly blew out her phone speaker.

"*WHAT?!!"*

Glimmer made sure to pull the phone away from her ear before correcting herself. "I mean really, she's fucking me. I—It's mutual, I dunno. Anyway—,"

"Glimmer, what the *fuck?*"

Oops. Bow never swore. Unless he was *really* upset.

"Okay, Bow. I know how it sounds. But just let me explain, please?"

"Explain why you thought it was a good idea to start sleeping with your ex crush/best friend/nemesis? Yeah! Go ahead, Glimmer. Try to explain that decision to me." Bow's voice had gone dark again and the bitter anger was quickly rising in Glimmer's chest.

"I never said it was a *good* idea!"

"Clearly," Bow snorted.

"Look! I'm in control of the situation, okay? We've got rules and stuff. It's just—We're just blowing off steam. It's not a big thing. So… Stop acting like I did something super dumb!"

"But you *did* do something super dumb, Glimmer! Rebounding from your ex with your *OTHER* ex, who is your sole support for stability right now?" Bow's voice was rising frantically again. "Did you even consider what might happen if this goes south?"

No, she hadn't. But she wasn't going to tell Bow that. She already felt like a piece of garbage, hot tears beginning to sting her eyes as she gripped the phone in white knuckles. "It won't. We're fine, okay? It's—Everything will be fine."

"Glimmer…," Bow was softening as he registered the distress in Glimmer's voice. "Can we meet up for coffee or something soon? Or better yet, come over for dinner. Just you and me and the Dads. It'll be like old times and we can… Maybe talk about this more? I really think you should—stop. Cut it off before anyone gets hurt. Before… *You* get hurt again."

The stupid tears began dripping down Glimmer's cheeks. But she stubbornly refused to allow the hiccupping sobs out as they banged around inside her chest.

"I mean, is Adora even single? Last time I heard from her she was with—,"

"I'm sure I would have met any girlfriend she might have by this point, Bow. We're both—This is working, okay? I don't need you to freak out or 'Dad' me, right now. I can take care of myself."

"I know you can." Glimmer hated the affection in his voice at that moment. It felt like pity. "But I want you to be happy and I'm worried this whole thing might blow up in your face and send you spiraling again. You deserve love and a good relationship, Glimmer. And you'll find it! But—Don't keep throwing yourself at these people, these situations, that will only let you down. You owe yourself more than that."

"I have to go."

"Glimmer, please—?"

"I'll think about the dinner, okay?"

She didn't give Bow another chance to speak before ending the call and plopping down on the broken couch. The worst part of the conversation, besides being forced to face her guilt, was that she knew Bow was right. This was a bad idea. A terrible idea. Probably one of her worst. But—It also made her feel good. Really good. And not just in the physical sense.

Having Adora's attention again, her friendship—mutated as it might be—was something she hadn't realized she was stilling longing for until now. She didn't want to lose it again. This was the closest they'd been in years.

Whether she wanted to admit it or not, Glimmer had missed her, dearly. And when they weren't messing around in the bedroom, they were talking and laughing and watching TV together and playing games and cooking and—

Why did Bow have to make her doubt a good thing?

Glimmer spent most of the day letting herself spiral, ignoring Bow's texts as she cleaned the apartment in an attempt to lift her mood. She was not very successful. By the time the afternoon rolled around, she was seriously considering sitting Adora down and discussing their current 'situation'. It was probably the adult thing to do after all.

She'd only just plopped back down on the couch, her guitar in hand, when the front door opened and Adora came in. Her blue eyes flickered around the organized apartment, a brilliant smile that made Glimmer's heart flutter lighting up her face.

"Wow, Glim. The place looks great." She closed the door behind her with her heel, dropping her gym bag on the floor and flopping onto the couch. "Bored on your day off I take it?"

Glimmer focused on her guitar, plucking a random string. "Despite what Bow told you when I moved in, I do actually like to live in

relative cleanliness. Things were getting messy. I tided up. It's no big deal."

Adora hummed and Glimmer felt her shuffle closer. She expected herself to tense up, Bow's words still spinning in her mind, but as one of Adora's hands came to rest against her thigh, she couldn't help but relax back against the blonde's chest.

"Well, it's very appreciated," she murmured, her lips landing softly against the top of Glimmer's head. Why couldn't she follow the fucking kissing rule?

Before Glimmer could reproach her for it, Adora's hand slipped further up her thigh, fingers teasing and featherlight.

"I couldn't stop thinking about you at work today…"

A wave of heat rushed to Glimmer's face as Adora's voice lowered into that tone she was beginning to only use in the bedroom. Or when the bedroom was where she wanted to be.

"Oh?"

Adora must have noticed the quiver in her voice, because she chuckled and moved her lips lower to touch the trail of moon tattoos beneath Glimmer's ear.

"W—what were you thinking about?"

"You," the soft brush of Adora's tongue joined her lips and Glimmer's heart seized in her chest. "Waiting for me. Getting yourself ready for me."

A string twanged on Glimmer's guitar as her hand spasmed around the neck. Bow's warning was quickly beginning to fade from her mind. How the fuck could this be a bad thing when it felt so damn good?

Adora wanted her. Had been waiting for her. Thinking about her all day.

Fuck Bow *and* his advice, she decided as Adora's long fingers toyed with the hem of her pants. She had this and she was keeping it for as long as she could. The consequences were a problem for future Glimmer.

Setting her guitar down, Glimmer swiveled in Adora's grasp, almost surprised to see the softness that those blue eyes held for her. And then their lips connected, hands wandering and gripping, and there were no more words left to say.

Adora was feeling a little victorious.

Without so much as the hint of a suggestion from her, Glimmer had scratched off one of the rules they had posted on the fridge.

Their agreement to keep the 'sessions' to once or twice a week had failed miserably and quickly. But since neither of them seemed to be complaining—the rule was gone.

Since then, Adora had been distracted, trying to devise a plan to make Glimmer ditch the 'no kissing or cuddling' rule. Unfortunately, simultaneously trying to teach classes wasn't really working out in her favor.

Lonnie pulled her aside after one particularly haphazard class, grip firm and somewhat disciplinary.

"Adora, are you okay?" she asked as she closed the office door behind them. "You've been really out of it the past few days. And when you're not giving training one hundred and ten percent, I know something's gotta be up."

"What? No, nothing's wrong. I just," Adora sighed, lowering herself into the chair opposite Lonnie's. This woman was her boss, sure, but they'd also been friends since High School. And Adora had *no one* to talk to about her relationship with Glimmer. It might help her confused feelings if she could just say it out loud.

"I'm just—I'm kind of *with* someone now, I guess? I've been thinking about her a lot lately. It's—been hard to focus."

"Oh," Lonnie smirked, crossing her arms and moving around her desk to plop into her own chair. "Love's got you all googly-eyed. Got it."

Adora's face flushed red hot. "What? No! No, I'm not—It's not love, or anything. We're just… She's my new roommate. And we kinda made this 'agreement'—"

Lonnie's eyes flew wide open as she put the pieces together herself. "Adora are you fucking your roommate?!"

"Lonnie! Tell the whole gym why don't you!" Adora cast a nervous glance back at the door, as if the bass boosted music filling the gym wouldn't cover their conversation.

"Hold up. This isn't Catra again, is it?" Lonnie clarified, one brow quirking condescendingly. "Because you *know* how I felt about that garbage fire."

"No, it's not Catra… I mean she and I are still kinda—It's not Catra. It's," Adora paused, biting her lip as she gathered her thoughts. "You remember my friend Glimmer? From High School?"

Lonnie's mouth opened with an audible 'pop'. "Glimmer?"

"Yeah! So, her ex—,"

"Adora," Lonnie cut her off before she could explain the situation. "You left Catra to fuck the druggie from High School? What are *you* smoking?"

The flush in Adora's cheeks flared hot again, chest tightening in anger. "She's not—I mean, there were some weed brownies—and, like… she drinks sometimes. But—,"

Her defense didn't seem to be working because Lonnie sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose. "I don't know how or why you

seem to keep picking girls thar are just going to drag you down, Adora. Fucking your roommate is a bad idea on its own, but seriously, the girl who ditched you for the drop-out crew? Didn't you guys have some huge falling out or something anyway?"

"Kinda…"

"But you just forget about that when you hate fuck, I guess?"

Adora bristled. She knew it sounded bad, and Lonnie was only looking out for her. But even still—

"It's not like that—," Adora trailed off. She couldn't find the words to defend her decision. Hearing them come from Lonnie's mouth did kind of make this whole thing maybe seem like a stupid idea. "She's…"

She's what? Still your friend? Still Glimmer? Still the girl that you fell—

Lonnie held her hands up in a silent surrender. "Alright, look. What you do in your free time is up to you whether I approve or not. But if you keep bringing it into the gym, we're gonna have problems. Okay? Focus up and do your job."

Adora sat in her chair, staring at the floor long after Lonnie had gone, the faraway thrum of the bass echoing in her ears. Was this really such a bad thing? Glimmer wasn't a bad person. She was sweet and thoughtful, and she made Adora laugh. And the sleeping together thing was—It was good. Honestly, she'd expected Lonnie to be happy for her. To be happy that she was happy. But maybe that wasn't enough. Lonnie was right, things were complicated.

But when had things between her and Glimmer been anything but complicated?

The start of a new semester meant new classes. And it wasn't until Glimmer had a meeting with her advisor to decide on them,

that she'd been notified she needed a gym credit to graduate next spring. Which was fucking *stupid*, in her opinion. What did gym have to do with graduating High School?

Glimmer wasn't a jock. And not because she disliked sports or anything. She just disliked *participating* in them. Mostly because she sucked at most of them and it got her teased. So she'd managed to avoid taking *anything* even close to a 'physical education course' thus far. Leaving her few options for which one she could enroll in this late.

Her advisor had suggested the Fitness/Conditioning course and Glimmer accepted without much argument. She'd hate any class they picked; it wasn't worth fighting over which one might suck the least.

Bow, being the best friend she could have asked for, signed up as well even though he didn't need to. Emotional support, he'd said. Which, it turned out, Glimmer would sorely need as she discovered that the course was taught by the absolute *worst* teacher at Bright Moon High, Coach Huntara. On the other hand, Adora was the class' Teaching Assistant. So—Glimmer supposed it could've been worse.

Until the first day of class, that is. When she decided that, no, in fact, she had made the worst decision possible.

Coach Huntara taught most of the various girls' sports teams at the school. Lacrosse being her golden egg, and Adora her star student. Glimmer almost expected her to give the blonde special treatment. It surprised her to see Huntara barking harsh orders at her along with the rest of the class.

After grumping with Bow while they pulled on their sneakers and gym clothes in the locker rooms, Glimmer followed the rest of the class as they lined up on the outdoor track. Huntara's first order of business was to force every student into a militaristically straight row, ordering anyone who was out of place to drop and give her ten pushups. Most of the kids she targeted Glimmer thought

looked like the smallest, or nerdiest, or shyest out of the group. It didn't surprise her, but it did make her nervous. Huntara wasn't even halfway down the line and all the kids her size were on the ground already.

"Drop! Give me 15," Huntara ordered Bow, who did so without argument, although Glimmer caught the anxious glance he sent her way. "And hurry it up! I've got a Tinder date with a hot young blonde I should be on right now, but instead I'm stuck here with you nose-picking, pot-bellied, wastes of space. Drop! Give me 17."

The girl a few spots down from Glimmer did so with a quiet whimper.

"You call those pushups?" Huntara screeched at her. "On your toes!"

Glimmer barely stopped herself from rolling her eyes. The chip on this woman's shoulder was bigger than a fucking boulder. Glancing down the line, Glimmer saw Adora, helping up the students who had completed their pushups, patting their shoulders amiably or offering high fives. She noticed Glimmer staring and shot a careful smile; one Glimmer couldn't help but return.

"What are you grinning at, Tinkerbell?" Huntara sneered and Glimmer whipped around, not realizing the Coach had arrived in front of her. She leaned in close, Glimmer tried not to grimace at the smell of cigarettes and sweat wafting off her. "If you're smiling, you're not exercising right. Drop and give me 20."

Grumbling quietly to herself, Glimmer dropped onto her knees and attempted her first push up. It wasn't great. She couldn't go very low; her legs were already shaking, and Huntara was still hovering over her, shadow looming.

'Fuck gym. Why do I need it to fucking graduate!!?'

"Those aren't pushups," Huntara sneered. "You're not even trying. Blondie!"

Glimmer paused, daring to look up, as Adora jogged over, an almost fearful gaze trained on Huntara. The coach jerked her chin down at Glimmer.

“Show Tinkerbell how it’s done.”

Adora glanced between them nervously before kneeling beside Glimmer.

“Here,” she moved Glimmer’s palms apart with the calloused fingers she knew so well now. Then she patted her stomach slightly. “Tighten your core as much as you can, it’ll release the pressure on your back. And spread your feet apart just a little.”

Glimmer, for as embarrassing as this moment was, couldn’t help but share a conspiratorial smile with Adora when they locked eyes again. In her new position, Glimmer succeeded in eight sequential pushups before her arms began to burn. Uncaring of whatever Huntara might screech at her, she bent her knees to take a break, chancing a glance up.

The coach scoffed. “You’ve got 12 more, Powderpuff. Might be easier for you if you didn’t spend all day indoors eating food as puffy as you are.”

For a minute the words didn’t quite register. And then they did, and Glimmer gaped up at her with a mixture of rage and burning embarrassment. It wasn’t as if anyone was safe from the Coach’s abuse today, but Glimmer was seconds away from either bursting into tears or ripping out the Coach’s Achilles Tendon with her teeth when Adora stood up.

“Coach, it takes a while to build up proper form and endurance for pushups. She’s—They’re all doing their best. Maybe we should—”

“You trying to tell me how to teach my class, Blondie?” Huntara shouted so loudly that half the class flinched. “How about you show me what you know about endurance. 15 laps around the school. 10 minutes. Go.”

Adora stood frozen for a moment, staring dumbly when Huntara snapped. "Every second you waste is how much faster you're gonna have to run, kid. Get moving."

Adora took off, casting a quick glance at Glimmer over her shoulder as she disappeared.

Glimmer spent the rest of the class fuming. Doing as little as she could. Just *daring* Huntara to try to come for her again. She was going directly to Doctor Hope after this. The Coach couldn't get away with *abusing* teenagers like this.

She kept looking for Adora, seeing her pass the track from a distance sometimes. The campus was fucking monstrous. There was no way she'd complete fifteen laps in anything under twenty minutes, at least. No matter how fast she ran.

Huntara didn't seem to care, of she'd forgotten. Because she dismissed the class of tired, sweaty students without even looking for Adora. But Glimmer took her things and ran immediately for the far side of the school.

She found Adora there, leaning against the wall, her entire body shaking as she heaved, emptying the contents of her stomach onto the pavement.

Glimmer grimaced, tip toeing closer until she could place a gentle hand on her trembling friend's back.

"Adora?"

Adora stiffened, wiped a fist across her mouth and turned. Red-faced, sweaty, disheveled, worked sick and the first words out of her mouth were, "Are you okay?"

Glimmer almost burst into tears right then and there. She took Adora's hand, pulling her away from the mess and around the corner of the school, back towards the track.

"Of course I'm okay. Are you?"

“I’m good. That was basically training,” Adora chuckled weakly. “Nothing new.”

Glimmer hated those words with every fiber of her being. She squeezed the blonde’s hand more tightly, her burning eyes locked on their shuffling feet.

“You shouldn’t have done that.”

Adora looked down at her. “Done… What?”

“Talk back to her like that… Stand up for me, or whatever. It wasn’t worth it. Look at what she did to you and just because I couldn’t do stupid push—,”

“Glimmer.” Adora pulled her into a sudden and tight hug, and Glimmer didn’t care that they were both sweaty and smelled like shit. “I wanted to. No one should have the right to talk to you like that. Not even her.”

“She wouldn’t be the first,” Glimmer sniffed. “And she was right. I mean look at me—,”

“I am.”

Glimmer pulled away from the hug in shock, and Adora let her, but only far enough so that she could raise a thumb to brush the angry tears from Glimmer’s cheeks. Her heart shattered into a thousand pieces at Adora’s gentle words; at the tenderness in her blue eyes.

“You’re beautiful,” she continued with the bright smile Glimmer loved so much. “And the ability to do 20 pushups in a row doesn’t change that. I’d run around the school 15 more times in a heartbeat to prove it too, if you want?”

Glimmer chuckled wetly and shook her head, throwing her arms around Adora’s waist again. “No, please, god no. Just… Come over for dinner tonight or something. Okay?”

She felt Adora's cheek against the top of her head and maybe, just *maybe*, the brush of her lips?

"Deal."

Adora did come over to the Sato household for dinner that night. Unfortunately, only after a grueling practice session. Glimmer didn't even want to imagine what extra abuse Huntara must have put her through that afternoon after she'd talked back during P.E.

She let Adora use her shower before dinner, offering her a set of pjs that were too short on her, but still (really) cute, in Glimmer's opinion. Adora collapsed into her fluffy bed after she'd changed, burying her face in Glimmer's pillows and releasing a long heavy sigh.

"You okay?" Glimmer settled into the bed beside her, running a comforting hand down her back.

" 'm so tired…" Adora voice was a muffled mumble as she sunk deeper into the mattress.

"We don't have to eat," Glimmer assured her, rubbing her shoulder with a bit more force now; the knots there were hard as a rock. "I'll tell Mom we're just gonna hang out up here tonight."

Adora mumbled again and shifted so that Glimmer had better access to her shoulders and before she knew what was happening, Glimmer was treating her friend to a full back massage. Adora was quiet through most of it, grunting occasionally whenever Glimmer tackled a particularly tough knot. But otherwise, it was clear that the rhythmic motions were putting her to sleep. And good, Glimmer thought, she deserved it. Especially after today.

Glimmer drew away as soon as Adora's body went limp and loose. Adjusting the pillows so Adora wouldn't suffocate, she pulled a blanket over her shoulders before gently easing off the bed and creeping downstairs.

Her mother was still busy in the kitchen, but Glimmer made her way toward the den where she could see her father reading on the couch. He looked up when she sat down beside him, a warm smile growing on his face.

"There you are. Where's Adora? Dinner should be ready soon—," Micah paused as he caught the quiver of Glimmer's lower lip. "What's wrong, Angel?"

Sniffing, Glimmer rubbed the tears stinging her eyes and leaned against Micah's shoulder. He wrapped her up in one strong arm immediately, squeezing her maybe a little too tightly to him.

"I just wish I could help Adora more," she murmured, her voice already thick with the tears she was holding back.

Micah's own voice was soothing if not a bit confused. "What do you mean?"

"She just—," Glimmer didn't really want to get into what Huntara had done today, so she generalized instead, "—She does so much for me. She's such a good friend and it seems like everyone in her life just treats her like garbage. But her heart is still so big, and I just wish there was something more I could do for her. But I don't know what that is or if I'm even enough and I—,"

"Glimmer," Micah interrupted her rant just as the tears began dripping down her cheeks. "Honey, you are a wonderful friend to Adora. I'm sure that just being there for her when she needs someone to talk to or hang out with is more than enough for her."

Glimmer mumbled a weak agreement, letting her head fall against her father's shoulder.

"Adora knows she's safe here," Micah continued. "She knows that this is a second home if she ever needs it. And she knows that you care about her very much."

A blaze of heat rushed to Glimmer's cheeks. Her father hadn't used the word 'love', but it was clear in his tone and the

mischievous twinkle in his eyes. He knew how much she really liked Adora. And, maybe, how much Glimmer really hoped Adora liked her back.

"I promise you that the best thing you can do for her is just to keep being her friend. She needs you to be you, Angel," Micah squeezed her comfortingly once more. "And that's enough."

Glimmer nodded, wrapping her arms tightly around her dad's middle, grateful for his patient and soothing advice. It was at that moment that her mother joined them, undoing her apron as she glanced around for Adora.

"Dinner's ready. Will Adora be joining us tonight?"

"Probably not," Glimmer sniffed, rubbing her cheeks again to clear away the last vestiges of tears. "She had a really hard day at school. She's sleeping right now."

Angella's frown was mildly disappointed—or maybe concerned, Glimmer couldn't tell. Either way, she did not argue, and the Sato's went about dinner without Adora. Glimmer made sure to save her a plate for later, when she inevitably woke in a panic to hurry home. At least she had the beat-up old truck she'd saved up for now, rather than her bike. It let her stay a little later nowadays, knowing her commute would be quicker.

It was dark by the time Glimmer finished up with her parents and made her way back upstairs. She found Adora awake, sitting cross legged on the bed, staring wide eyed out the bedroom window.

"Hey, Sleeping Beauty," Glimmer teased as she close the door behind her and crawled onto the bed beside the blonde. "You hungry? I saved you some stuff if you wanna take it home with you. I know it's getting late…"

Adora glanced over at her, a soft smile quirking her lips. "So?"

Glimmer blinked. "Sooo…. You're usually gone by now. I don't want you to get in trouble or anything. You've dealt with enough

shit today."

A soft chuckle fell from Adora's lips and she shrugged, her blue eyes returning to the stars and moon hanging just outside in the velvety black sky.

"Who cares? Doesn't matter what I do nowadays. I'm always in trouble with Mrs. Weaver."

Glimmer leaned forward, nudging Adora's shoulder with her head. "It doesn't matter? Who are you and what have you done with Adora?"

Adora didn't answer that, her lips pursing in thought. Before Glimmer could even attempt to explain that she'd just been joking, however, Adora turned to her, eyes bright and round. "Hey, wanna go on an adventure with me?"

"An adventure?"

Adora nodded, a smile lighting up her face.

"Right now? It's…dark outside."

"Exactly."

Glimmer had no idea what Adora meant, nor where she was planning on taking them. But when she was staring into those clear blue eyes and being warmed by that brilliant smile, there was no way she could even fathom saying no.

"Yeah… Sure! Let's go on an adventure."

Adora's grin somehow widened and the next thing Glimmer knew they were sneaking out her bedroom window, climbing down the awnings so that her parents wouldn't know they'd left. Glimmer couldn't imagine they'd care too much if they knew she'd was out with Adora. But even so, the air of 'danger' added something a bit more exhilarating to the night as they scrambled for Adora's truck, giggling quietly.

The roar of the engine when Adora turned the key in the ignition probably blew their cover, but they were tearing out of the driveway too quickly for either of Glimmer's parents to check. And then they were gone, driving through Bright Moon towards the edge of the city.

Glimmer turned on the radio, the connection growing spotty as they drove past city limits, but the faint buzz of muffled music was almost as soothing as the quiet night itself.

"Where are we going?" Glimmer asked, readjusting the bundle of blankets she still carried in her arms. Adora had stripped them from her bed before they left, simply telling Glimmer that they would need them later.

"My favorite spot," Adora replied as she took them down a dirt road and into the low foothills that surrounded the city.

"You've been out here before?"

"A few times. Since I got the truck. I just wanted to explore a little bit and I found this great spot. You can see the entire city. It's really pretty."

Glimmer fell silent again, her heart swelling in her chest as they drove. Adora was sharing a secret hideaway with *her*. As they drove through the silent and dark world, it started to feel like they were the only two people who existed. Suddenly Huntara and Mrs. Weaver and her parents didn't matter. It was just her and Adora, drifting quietly through their own universe.

Adora drove them up into the foothills until they reached a small outcropping. There she drove the car near to the edge, until the truck bed faced the city below.

"C'mon." There was a bright and excited light in the blonde's eyes as she led Glimmer out of the truck and around to the back. There she hopped up and took the blankets from Glimmer's arms, laying them out so that they wouldn't be sitting on cold metal. Then she turned, taking Glimmer's hand and lifting her up.

When they'd both settled against the blankets, Glimmer looked out at the city. Adora was right, it felt much smaller out here. A tiny bright star, a burning light, against a sea of black.

"Wow. It looks really… Different from out here."

"Doesn't seem as important, right?" Adora prompted.

Glimmer nodded, shivering slightly as a chill swept through the air around them. Summer in Bright Moon had long gone, and the winter nights were here. Adora seemed to notice because she lay against the blankets, tugging Glimmer down by the back of her shirt until they lay side-by-side, one of the blankets pulled over them tightly.

It was then that Glimmer looked up, her mouth falling open at the ocean of sparkling stars that shone above them. It was even more beautiful than the city. Millions of tiny dots, twinkling, dancing, shifting in the black sky. The moon round and full and bright high above them.

It didn't look like this from inside Bright Moon, where the pollution of the city put a dim filter over everything. But out here, Glimmer almost felt like she could be swallowed up by the sky at any moment. Like she could fall into the sea of stars and lose herself among them. It was awe inspiring, and a little terrifying. But most of all, it made every frustration of the day slip away like sand through her fingers. Her little life in Bright Moon? It didn't matter. There was an enormous world out there. Bigger than she could even comprehend. Who cared about a little high school drama when all of *this* existed?

Her heart twisted in her chest as she realized she was sharing this oddly cosmic and somehow also intimate moment with Adora. It made her want to let down every wall she'd built to protect their friendship. She chanced a glance over at her friend, heart aching at the utter peace in Adora's expression. Everything, every worry was melting away. Reaching out, she took Adora's hand beneath

the blankets, squeezing gently. Adora looked over at her, maybe a bit surprised, but not disconcerted.

She squeezed back with a smile. “Pretty?”

“Beautiful.” Glimmer hummed and stroked her thumb over Adora’s calloused knuckles. “Thank you for bringing me here.”

Adora looked back up at the sky. “It makes everything seem really insignificant. I guess. If I ever get too stressed or freaked out—I just remember how small this all is. And that I won’t always be here. Y’know? There’s a bigger destiny for me out there. There has to be.”

Glimmer felt her heart twinge at Adora’s words. More than anything, she wanted the blonde to be happy. But picturing them parting ways? Their senior year would be starting in a few months. Adora was right. There was a lot out there. For *both* of them. But what if it took them different ways? What if it broke up the Best Friends Squad?

“What do you think you’ll do?” Glimmer asked, her voice muted and small in the huge emptiness that surrounded them.

“I’m not sure yet. Something with lacrosse, I guess. I think it could get me a full ride if I really apply myself this year. And then, I dunno. I could study anything! Or maybe stick with sports. Really… I just can’t wait to leave Bright Moon.”

“Oh?” Glimmer’s voice was a pained squeak, her hand tightening into a vice grip on Adora’s.

Adora flinched, glancing back down at her and then rolling onto her side to face Glimmer. “Yeah… Is---Is that bad?”

“No! No. It’s not bad at all. It’s just—,” Glimmer bit her lip and then rolled onto her side as well. “I’ve gotten so used to you—a-and Bow and stuff—just, like, always being there. It’s weird to imagine what might come next. When we graduate and do our own thing and—Yeah.”

Glimmer felt her throat closing up, eyes burning as she imagined saying goodbye to the two most important people in her life.

"Hey." A tear must have slipped down her cheek, because suddenly Adora was brushing it away with her thumb, blue eyes practically glowing in the dark. "We're always going to have each other, Glim. And the future isn't certain! What if we get into the same college? Or end up in the same town? What if our future careers line up somehow?"

Glimmer nodded. Adora was right, but it still felt overwhelming.

"I don't want things to change. That's all," she sniffed.

Adora paused for a moment, wiggling a bit closer, her hand still resting on Glimmer's cheek. "*We* won't change. I promise. You'll always have me, Glimmer."

Glimmer looked up at her, meeting Adora's blue gaze through her own watery one. There was so much tenderness in her eyes. So much love and acceptance and care, Glimmer felt like she might explode on the spot. Instead, she buried herself in Adora's chest, letting herself be wrapped in a strong embrace.

The words she'd been dying to say for months were on her tongue. But they stayed locked behind her lips, body simply trembling in Adora's arms. They stayed there for a long time, holding one another as the hours slipped by. Glimmer fell in and out of sleep, always waking up to see Adora's soft face inches from her own. Her lips so enticing. And yet…

She couldn't.

By the time dawn broke on the horizon, they were both stiff and sore from the night spent on a metal truck bed. Slowly, they gathered the blankets up and hopped into the truck, making their way back down into Bright Moon. Glimmer fell asleep more than a few times on the way back home, once waking up to find that Adora had fished her letterman jacket out and draped it on top of her as the dirtied blankets had been abandoned at Glimmer's feet.

She felt Adora's hand in her hair a few times as she drifted in and out of consciousness. Or at least, she thought she did. Everything was so dreamlike and surreal.

Glimmer blinked awake fully when they finally arrived back at her house. She turned to Adora before hopping out of the car.

"You gonna be okay? With Mrs. Weaver and everything?"

Adora nodded, smile soft. "I'll be fine. Think you'll be okay? With your mom?"

"I don't care," Glimmer admitted, grinning when Adora laughed out loud.

"Get in there then," she teased. "Show her who's boss."

Glimmer didn't move though. In fact, both of them just stared at one another for a moment, a million words passing between them in the silence.

Finally, Glimmer managed, "See you in English in a few hours then?"

Adora's smile turned a bit sad, but she nodded and nudged Glimmer's shoulder to prod her forward. "Of course."

With that, Glimmer slid out of the truck, only turning back when she'd reached her porch steps. Adora offered a small wave before driving off, leaving Glimmer to stare after her—hating herself for not doing what her mind had been *screaming* to all night.

It wasn't until she'd stepped inside and closed the door that she realized she was still wearing Adora's jacket.

Adora's drive home was not a pleasant one.

Her talk with Lonnie had left her in a sour mood. She figured it would be a good idea to talk to Glimmer. That was the adult thing

to do. They probably shouldn't be doing this whole… Friends with benefits things. It was going to get messy, inevitably. One of them was going to get hurt. Adora could practically feel the impending doom swirling in her gut.

By the time she got back to the apartment, she'd rehearsed the speech she was going to give a dozen times. She had the words down pat. But then she walked inside and was greeted by a smell so wonderful and rich and homey that it jerked her straight back to the Sato household all those years ago.

For as much as Glimmer seemed to want nothing to do with her mother. She had certainly picked up Mrs. Sato's famed cooking skills. She turned around when she heard Adora enter, effortlessly tossing the vegetables she was sautéing in a skillet and waving to the blonde with the spatula in her other hand.

"Hey, how was work?"

Adora blinked at her speechlessly, taking in the adorable sight of Glimmer dressed in her pjs and an old apron Adora recognized, decorated with moons. She wore a pair of fuzzy purple socks that climbed halfway up her calf, although one had slipped down to her ankle. And there was a lightness in her eyes that Adora hadn't seen in a long time. The kind that made her seem to sparkle.

The speech Adora had been practicing on the way home flew from her mind and she joined Glimmer by the stove, leaning as casually as she dared against the countertop.

"It was fine. Kinda, stressful, but fine." Adora handed Glimmer the saltshaker when she reached for it blindly. "Did you need any help?"

"Need it?" Glimmer snorted, shooting her a teasing smirk. "No. Want it? Sure. You can bask in my presence if you wish."

Adora shoved her shoulder lightly, although she obediently followed Glimmer's orders to wash her hands and then help her cut up the meat for the stir fry. Adora wasn't a good cook by any

means, although she still liked to try. With Glimmer's (mostly) patient guidance, she found it was more fun than doing it on her own.

Glimmer stood behind her as she grilled the meat, talking about her day, occasionally poking Adora in the ribs when she became too distracted with her words and let the meat burn.

"I know my bar stories are absolutely fascinating Adora," Glimmer teased, taking the tongs from her and quickly moving a few sticking pieces of meat around the pan. "But please don't set off the smoke alarm when this is going so well."

"Sorry," Adora chuckled, abashed as Glimmer handed the tongs back. Adora tried to ignore the electricity she felt when their fingers brushed. "But, um, how is the bar, by the way? We haven't really talked about it much."

"It's fine," Glimmer sighed, grabbing a few extra pieces of cut up carrot she hadn't tossed in the stir fry and popping them into her mouth. "Kyle's a nice guy. My coworkers are all cool. The clientele kinda sucks, but it's a fucking bar. What are you gonna do?"

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, brow pinching with concern.

"Eh," Glimmer shrugged and leaned over Adora's shoulder to throw another dash of seasoning on the meat. "They're grabby old dudes. It's whatever. Nothing I haven't dealt with before. It's just annoying."

Adora wasn't sure what to do with the hot flash of anger that turned into a tight, aching ball in the center of her chest as she imagined a bunch of creepy men groping Glimmer. It wasn't a good feeling… But at the same time, she knew she wasn't supposed to feel any sort of 'possessive' emotions. Those were strictly against the rules. They weren't even dating! Glimmer could be messing around with someone else *while* Adora was at work and she wouldn't even know. They'd agreed to that.

The tight ball in Adora's chest was burning hotter as her thoughts spun out of control. She jabbed angrily at the meat in the pan, ignorant to whatever else Glimmer might have been saying until she touched Adora's shoulder, gently drawing her back to the present.

"You okay? You look like that steak just killed your entire family."

Adora shook her head in a feeble attempt to clear it. "Oh—No, I'm just—I'm sorry you have to deal with that stuff… That sucks."

Glimmer chuckled, taking the pan away from her and mixing it with the vegetables herself, bumping Adora slightly with her hip to move her aside. "I can take care of myself, Adora. Don't let it bother you."

"I know." Adora didn't mean for her tone to come out as softly—or affectionate—as it did. But Glimmer must have noticed too, because she shot Adora a quick glance over her shoulder before returning her attention to the food.

"Why don't you grab us some plates," Glimmer suggested after a confusing silence. "This is almost ready?"

Grateful for the excuse to move, Adora did as she was told, setting the table just as Glimmer finished cooking. The meat was a little tough, but Adora knew that was her own fault. The rest was incredibly delicious and Adora made it a point to say as much, that tight ball in her chest loosening when Glimmer blushed at the compliment.

As soon as they'd finished, Glimmer popped a bag of popcorn and dragged Adora to the couch. They threw on the first show that popped up on Adora's Netflix feed and buried themselves in the large pink blanket Glimmer preferred for nights like these.

Most of the popcorn went to Glimmer. Adora took pieces much more slowly, careful to avoid the accidental brushing of fingers that she knew might make her snap. Lonnie's words from earlier hadn't really left her, but it was hard to care when they spent

nights like this. Cuddled up, warm, cracking jokes, making stupid commentary on whatever they'd chosen to watch. Adora didn't want to lose that. She didn't want to lose Glimmer.

Not again.

"How do we always pick the worst shows?" Glimmer asked as she leaned back against the armrest of the couch, sticking her feet underneath Adora's thigh. It tickled enough that she almost reflexively slapped Glimmer's legs away.

"Your toes are like actual ice cubes! How? You're wearing socks?"

Glimmer smirked at her, popping a single kernel into her mouth. "I'm not what you think I am, Adora."

"Then what are you?" Adora snorted. She already knew what Glimmer was trying to quote. They'd binged the series in hysterical tears not a few days ago.

"You know what I am. Say it." Glimmer wiggled her toes underneath Adora's thigh.

"Spider monkey."

A fistful of popcorn came flying her way, most of which Adora attempted—and failed—to catch in her mouth. It then quickly became a contest of who could catch the trickiest shot. Glimmer won when she stood halfway in the kitchen, catching the single kernel that Adora tossed at her from the couch.

"Holy shit!" she cheered, leaping over the back of the couch, settling back into a space much closer to Adora. They were basically breaking the no cuddling rule, but Adora wasn't going to point that out anytime soon. "Did you see that? I am a god."

"You have an exceptional set of talents, Glim," Adora chuckled. "Let me know when you make the Olympics trials for popcorn catching."

"I so would," Glimmer hummed, setting their empty bowl down and fully snuggling into Adora's side, head resting on her shoulder. Adora turned just enough to briefly brush her lips against Glimmer's soft hair. The black roots were growing out, silky and shiny. Adora wondered if she'd get it re-dyed any time soon.

"Bow invited me over for dinner the other day," Glimmer murmured suddenly, after a few moments of peaceful silence.

Adora couldn't help but notice that she sounded reluctant. "You gonna go?"

Heaving a sigh, Glimmer rubbed at her eyes like a tired toddler. "I guess I should. I haven't seen him in a while. I just know it's a trap. He's mad at me right now and I don't want to deal with the judgement. I get enough of it from my mother."

"Want me to go with you?" Adora offered, her hand squeezing Glimmer's thigh comfortingly over the blanket. "Emotional support or something?"

A small smile touched Glimmer's lips, but she shook her head, hair brushing Adora's jaw. "I can handle Bow. But I'm sure he'd love to hear from you sometime too. He's missed you a lot."

"I've missed him too."

Neither of them decided to elaborate on the three years they'd spent apart, but it weighed heavy on them like a wet blanket—heavy, uncomfortable and cold.

Glimmer fell asleep not long after, her body sinking deep into Adora's. She let herself savor the closeness for a while before turning off the TV and scooping Glimmer off the couch. Adora carried her into the bedroom, tucking her into bed before dealing with her nighttime routine.

By the time she'd returned, Glimmer had squirmed halfway onto her side of the bed, laying on top of the barrier of pillow she usually piled between them. Adora made no attempt to push her

over, simply laying down in her own spot—waiting for what she knew was inevitable. Glimmer would wiggle towards her, seeking out her heat. Adora was a human furnace. Catra had always told her that. It was why she didn't really like snuggling. They both ran warm. Glimmer seemed to be the opposite. She was a living ice cube, a heat leech, stealing what Adora was happy to share if it meant she could be close to her.

Sure enough, Glimmer mumbled and squirmed and soon enough she was pressed against Adora's side in a tight ball, her nose nudging the blonde's shoulder. Chuckling, Adora pulled the blankets more tightly around them, but kept herself rigidly in position. If Glimmer woke up and found that Adora was cuddling her back? There would be hell to pay.

For now, the closeness was enough.

Adora didn't sleep right away; instead staring up at the ceiling and pondering Lonnie's words. Sure, the situation she had with Glimmer right now wasn't exactly *ideal*… But they'd also spent the whole night on the couch eating, playing, teasing, snuggling one another. It reminded Adora of high school—when she'd unabashedly been falling for Glimmer.

She hadn't known what to do about it back then, and really now, nothing had changed in the regard. But it was nice to simply *feel* those things again. The warm, fuzzy happiness that filled her body at the sight of Glimmer. The way her giggles made Adora laugh too. Her icy feet that Adora would happily sacrifice her own warmth for. The tender way Glimmer looked at her sometimes—like she really *cared* about Adora. Really saw her.

Closing her eyes, Adora heaved a weary sigh. She should have known sleeping with Glimmer would bring these feelings back from the grave. Maybe she had known… Maybe she wanted them to.

Adora was fighting a losing battle. Breaking one of the first rules Glimmer had laid out for her.

‘Don’t fall in love with me.’

Turning her head, Adora took in the sight of her roommate silhouetted in the silver glow of the moon. She was beautiful. Sparkling in the dim light of the moon, long lashes fluttering against her cheeks as she dreamed. Adora’s heart swelled at the sight.

She was falling for her best friend—again. It didn’t help that they’d been so close all those years ago. That Adora had memories to fall back on, good and bad. But she knew Glimmer was adamant that this be a casual thing. No matter how often she ended up snuggling Adora at the end of the day. She’d made her stance clear…

Adora would hold her tongue, for now. She’d keep everything locked up tight inside. Just like she had back then. The last thing she wanted to do was lose Glimmer; scare her off.

She’d follow the rules. She’d do better. Anything to keep Glimmer from slipping away again.

Glimmer did end up going to Bow’s house that weekend. Luckily, Bow didn’t get much of a chance to pester her about the Adora situation given that George and Lance were too busy asking about her new job and new roommate. By the time they’d finally left Glimmer alone (and finished bragging about how well Bow was doing in school) it was late and Glimmer managed to escape without too much argument from Bow. Although he promised he’d been in touch again soon. They still had a lot to discuss.

And he was right. She knew that. But she also didn’t want to admit it.

Her situation with Adora was unorthodox, sure. But it was working for them. So, it really wasn’t any of Bow’s fucking business.

By the time she got home, Glimmer was surprised to see Adora still awake. And waiting for her apparently. It didn’t take long after

the door closed for the clothes to come off, tossed about the living room haphazardly as if carried by a tornado.

God, Glimmer really liked it when Adora got like this.

Aggressive and dominant, she pushed Glimmer back against the wall, beside the door to the apartment. In the back of her mind, Glimmer wondered how thin the walls were, if someone would hear them. The possibility kind of made her feel even hotter.

Adora's lips were on her neck, teeth and tongue leaving dark marks that Glimmer would have to hide for work the next morning. Or...maybe not. That was kinda hot too now that she thought about it.

She didn't think much more though...

All rational thoughts left Glimmer's head when Adora pressed her thigh to her naked and aching core, giving her a muscled surface to begin grinding against. Glimmer didn't waste any time searching for sweet relief. She tangled her fingers in Adora's hair, pulling her up to meet her in a searing kiss as she began grinding out a steady rhythm against Adora's thigh.

Adora groaned at what Glimmer could only assume was an embarrassing amount of slick heat coating her skin.

"You're so wet for me…," Adora murmured against her lips before diving back in for another kiss, her calloused hands moving to Glimmer's hips to encourage the rhythmic rocking.

Glimmer could only whimper as Adora's tongue slid against hers, her naked torso now pressing Glimmer so tightly against the wall that it was becoming difficult to breathe. But, god, she didn't care. She wanted more.

As if on cue, Adora's hand slipped from her hip to her thigh, pulling it higher around her waist, her own hips beginning to rock in time with Glimmer's.

"Holy shit…," Glimmer gasped, pulling away from the kiss just far enough to glance down at their bodies rolling together. She could hear the wall creaking behind them now. Either they were going to bust through it or alert the entire apartment complex and she didn't give a flying fuck.

Adora seemed to be at just as much a loss for words. She moaned softly, her breath hitching against Glimmer's lips as she searched for them again. But it was difficult to maintain a proper kiss at this point. They clung to each other instead. Panting, rocking, foreheads pressed together, and eyes shut tight in excruciating pleasure.

Glimmer was close now. Her clit throbbing with each pulse of Adora's powerful hips. She just needed a little more and--

A key turning in the lock startled them both. They froze, Glimmer trying to regain enough sense to wonder why a burglar would have a key to the apartment. Adora, she noticed, had never looked more terrified in her entire life. She didn't move from where she had Glimmer pinned against the wall, but it was clear from her expression that she knew exactly who was behind the door.

"Honey, I'm home-," a sing song-y voice cooed as the door swung open, stopping just short of slamming into them.

Glimmer met Adora's panicked gaze and the electricity that passed between them this time was deadly. If the key hadn't been enough of a hint, the pet name certainly was.

Adora had been hiding a girlfriend. Or a partner. Or something. And Glimmer had just unwittingly become 'the other woman'. This wasn't part of the deal. Glimmer wasn't a homewrecker. She'd *been* cheated on. She wasn't about to help someone *else* cheat. This whole agreement had been made on the premise that Adora was as single and lonely as she was. And the worst part—

Bow had been right.

Who the fuck---?

The door closed and Glimmer could make out a relatively tall, thin woman crossing the apartment. She hadn't noticed them when she'd closed the door behind her, and simply strolled casually into the apartment as if she owned the place.

"Adora?"

She paused by the couch, checking her phone before plopping down. Seemingly determined to make herself comfortable until Adora appeared.

Glimmer had never wanted to punch someone more in her life...And she'd wanted to punch a lot of people. Adora was silently begging her with blue eyes to remain silent. To sneak away. To hide.

To be the dirty little secret.

Glimmer tried just as hard to convey, '*Fuck. You.'*

Her message seemed to come across loud and clear because Adora frantically whispered, "Glimmer don't--,"

But Glimmer shoved her away with every bit of strength she could muster. Adora stumbled backward, tripping over an abandoned shoe and landing hard on her ass.

Somehow the sight did not make Glimmer feel better.

"Ador--what the *fuck?"* The dark-haired woman leapt up from the couch as she looked over to investigate the noise. Her bi colored eyes widened in shock. An amusing display of disbelief, anger, confusion and disgust flickered over her freckled face as Glimmer gathered herself proudly and strode past the both of them, as naked as the day she was born.

She caught the stranger's eye briefly, before turning up her nose and escaping into the dark bedroom, slamming the door and

locking it behind her. It wasn't until she was alone in the darkness that she sunk to the floor, breaking down into a heaving and shaking mess.

Adora stared after Glimmer, mouth agape. This could not be happening. How had she completely forgotten about Catra? Granted, the past few weeks had been distracting… And even the days since Catra sent the taunting selfie, she'd been erased from Adora's mind fairly quickly. But still! She'd promised herself she would at least tell Glimmer about her weird, also-kind-of-casual thing with Catra. She'd lost track of time. Or maybe—She just hadn't wanted to face it. The bubble she and Glimmer had created over the past few weeks felt like a safe haven. The real world didn't exist outside of it.

Unfortunately, reality has just come crashing back in.

Adora was still on the floor. Naked as the day she was born and for the first time ever—she was ashamed to be seen like this in front of Catra. The other woman had seen her bare too many times to count now. But this felt degrading. Like she'd been caught doing something wrong. Like she should be ashamed.

Which wasn't the case! She knew that!

Even still, as Catra glared down at her, mouth practically twisted into a snarl, Adora couldn't help but hang her head in shame as she stood.

"Wanna tell me who the fuck that was?" Catra spat, gesturing flippantly in the direction of the bedroom.

"My new roommate." Adora's reply was weak, almost a mumble. She stood hunched inward on herself. Her clothes were lost and the blanket that lay draped on the back of the couch was behind Catra. She was forced to stand there naked and guilty.

What was worse, she couldn't even imagine what Glimmer must be feeling. She must have thought Adora had been lying to her all

this time. She needed to explain.

Almost unconsciously, Adora made a step for the door, but Catra stopped her.

"Your new roommate?" Catra clarified, her tone dripping with sarcasm. "Were you planning on *telling* me you had a new roommate before I got back into town. Or was this just a fun surprise for you?"

Adora scowled at the carpet, cheeks burning red with anger now as well as embarrassment. What right did Catra have to be angry? They weren't together. She stated that implicitly every time they fell into bed together. She'd sent her a picture of herself with some other girl. What right did she have to Adora?

"Why does it matter?" Adora shot back, finally looking up to meet Catra's furious gaze. "Who cares? You've been gone for almost a month. Taunting me about all the random fangirls you're fucking. And you don't even live here, Catra! You have a girlfriend! We're not together. We broke up years ago, in case you forgot."

Catra's eyes narrowed; almost like she was taken aback by Adora's rebuttal. She glowered in silence for a moment, and when she did speak, she seemed determined to ignore every point Adora had just made.

"Who is she anyway?"

"What?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "The ten-dollar hooker you were just banging against the wall, Adora. Who is she?"

Grinding her teeth at the blatant insult, Adora simply answered, "She's—My friend."

Catra's lips quirked into an almost cruel smirk. "So is it just your *thing* to fuck any girl that calls you her friend now? Because I thought I was your friend too. Should I worry about Lonnie next?"

“What is your fucking problem?” Adora shouted, losing all shame even though she was still entirely naked. She stalked up to Catra, jabbing a finger into her chest. “I don’t owe you anything! You told me over and over again that the sex was just a casual thing. You left every morning. You have a god damn girlfriend. You kept me the dirty little secret. I wasn’t allowed to take you on dates or tell people we even spent any fucking time together. I was nothing to you. You only care about me now because you’re jealous that I’m not crawling after you on my fucking knees anymore. You’re upset that you can’t taunt me anymore. Stop acting like you own me when you’re the one who laid out the rules in the first place!”

Adora stopped short, breath catching in her throat as she registered her own words. Catra—wasn’t wrong. In a sense, she’d fallen into the same trap with Glimmer that she had with Catra. But—No, it was different, right? Glimmer watched TV with her. Glimmer (probably) wasn’t sleeping with anyone else. Glimmer cooked with her and told her about her day. Glimmer sometimes cuddled her (mostly on accident). She hadn’t made the same devastating mistake again.

She couldn’t have.

Before she knew what was happening, she was pushing past Catra, blinking back angry tears as she wrapped herself up in the blanket on the couch. It didn’t nothing to lessen the hot waves of shame coursing through her.

“You should have at least told me!” was Catra’s defense. “Walking in on you fucking some stranger against the god damn wall was a little shocking to say the least.”

“She’s not a stranger,” Adora sniffed, shuffling into the kitchen to grab some water. Her hand trembled fiercely around the cup.

“Well the who the fuck is she?” Catra had followed her, stopping close behind as she turned around.

"Glimmer."

Catra's eyes flickered over her face, trying to connect the dots and then they shot wide open in shock. "You're joking. *Glimmer*? Seriously, Adora? The loser from High School?"

Adora looked away, she wanted Catra to leave. She wanted to go talk to Glimmer, who was probably a fucking mess in the bedroom right now.

"The one who told you she never wanted to see your fucking face again? You're choosing *that*? Over us?"

"There is no us, Catra!" Adora shot back. "There hasn't been in a long time and we were lying to ourselves."

"Oh, but this," Catra snatched the sheet of rules off the fridge beside them. "*This* is somehow different? You like this better? 'No falling in love'. How cute. Please, you're *still* lying to yourself, Adora."

Adora couldn't hold the tears back anymore, they slipped down her cheeks in hot and angry tracks. "Just fucking go. I don't have anything else to say to you."

Adora headed for the couch, knowing there was no way Glimmer would let her inside the bedroom right now, no matter how badly she wanted to escape.

"Oh, so, you're done with me? That's it? Great." Catra crumpled the list, throwing it at Adora's head. It bounced off lightly, landing beside her blanket covered feet. Adora focused on staring at it as Catra continued to shout.

"I'd just like to remind you who was there to pick up the pieces when Sparkles tore your heart out of your chest all those years ago. Because guess what, Adora? It's not fucking happening again. I refuse to be the rebound you fall back on when this blows up in your fucking face. And I promise you it will."

Adora didn’t look up, listening instead as Catra’s boots scuffed the floor and then the door slammed shut loudly behind her. She waited a few horribly long seconds before breaking down into tears.

In that moment, as she crumpled into a shaking ball on the couch, Adora didn’t think she’d ever felt more alone.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> Here is 10k words of angst in case the drama last chapter wasn't enough.
> I would like to apologize in advance because stuff's gonna get a little heavy for a while ;-;... But on the other hand this chapter has a Mean Girls reference, so... we're gonna win in the end.
>
> To sum up: As High School comes to a close, Glimmer and Adora suffer a loss that breaks them apart.

Glimmer was floating.

It had been only a few weeks since Adora first took her to the stargazing spot. But ever since that night, they snuck out there more of than not. Bringing more blankets and pillows and even hot coco as the weather grew colder. Glimmer had to admit it was a little terrifying driving the icy roads into the foothills at night, but spending time with Adora, gazing up at an endless sky together—for Glimmer, it was all totally worth it.

And today, Adora had caught her just after her tutoring period.

'Can we head up to the spot tonight?' Adora asked, an almost uncertain waver in her tone. 'There's something I wanted to ask you.'

'You can ask me now!' Glimmer didn't like seeing Adora so nervous. 'I've got time. Dad's picking me up today and he's always late.'

'Uh…,' Was that a hint of a blush on Adora's cheeks? 'No, I mean —It can wait. I wanted us to be… alone?'

Glimmer glanced around at the hall full of students and then beamed up at Adora.

‘Sure, no problem. Just text me when you’re on your way, okay?’

Adora’s nervous lip biting smoothed into a gentle grin and she nodded enthusiastically. ‘Okay, cool! Great. I’ll see you tonight.’

She leaned towards Glimmer suddenly, then hesitated, her eyes going wide. Before Glimmer could even fathom what she might be doing, she spun on her heel and dashed down the hallway.

Glimmer hadn’t stopped thinking about that moment since. The flood of warmth filling her body easily combatting the cold of the snowy gray day. She sat on the freezing cold curb, shooting endlessly excited texts to Bow as she waited for her father.

-‘I’m pretty sure she was going to kiss me *BOW*’

Bow replied with his favorite image of a bent over Kermit doll, displaying its hole.

-‘you’re actually the worst, what do you think she wants to ask me about?’

-‘your hole probably?’

-‘blocked’

Just then a loud honk drew her attention. Her father had arrived in his tiny Prius. Ignoring a second buzz from her phone that told her Bow had responded, Glimmer stood up and made her way to the car. She nearly toppled over a patch of black ice as she slipped inside, but managed to maintain most of her dignity, stuffing her backpack at her feet.

“Hey, Angel. Sorry I’m late,” Micah said, putting the car in gear, but waiting until Glimmer had buckled in before pulling out of the school parking lot.

“It’s fine, Dad. Kinda worked out for me anyway.” Glimmer couldn’t keep the stupid grin off her face as she shot another text to Bow.

Micah gave her an odd look, one brow raised. “Oh?”

A furious blush grew on Glimmer’s cheeks, betraying herself even as she tried to maintain her cool. “Yeah… uh. Yeah. It’s—It’s yeah.”

“Were you planning on going on one of your ‘night drives’ with Adora again?”

“Dad!”

Micah chuckled though, making it clear that although he knew, Glimmer wasn’t in any trouble.

“How did you know?” she resigned to admitting the fact that, yes, her mood was attributed to Adora.

“You two aren’t as subtle as you’d like to be. And her car could certainly use some work. It’s not kind to two teenagers trying to sneak out of a quiet suburb past midnight.” Micah shook his head fondly. “You should tell her to bring it by sometime. We can fix it up like we did her bike.”

Glimmer ignored that offer for her own question. “Does mom know?”

“Not yet,” Micah shrugged, and Glimmer was overwhelmed with gratitude that her father kept her secret. “But if you keep escaping as loudly as you do, she might figure it out despite my best efforts.”

Grimacing, Glimmer turned her gaze out the window watching the snowflakes drift down from a gray sky.

“Well…. Thank you,” she murmured after a moment. “For—Y’know. Not busting me.”

Micah took one hand off the wheel, reaching over and patting Glimmer’s head. “I was young and in love too once, you know—,”

“DAD!” Glimmer’s screech was exacerbated in the small car. “I’m not—That’s not—We’re not—,”

“Okay, okay,” Micah surrendered but his eyes still twinkled with amusement. “Whatever you say.”

Glimmer huffed, her cheeks burning furiously. She pondered Micah’s words though. Her mind spinning around the possibilities. What *did* Adora want to ask her about tonight? She’d definitely been about to kiss her in the hallway. And they spent most of their nights falling asleep in each other’s arms nowadays. Maybe… Maybe Micah was right? And maybe that wasn’t as scary as Glimmer thought it might be to admit?

As they approached a stop light, Glimmer turned slightly to peer at her father.

“Dad?”

“Yeah, Angel?”

“Do you think that me and Adora—,”

A sudden fierce bump sent the car lurching forward. The driver behind them had slid slightly on the icy street, denting the back of the Prius and nudging them into the intersection. Before Glimmer had a chance to react, she saw the bright burning headlights of an enormous truck behind her father’s head. A loud honk filled the air drowning out her scream.

And then everything went black.

Glimmer was floating.

Everything around her was as white as the snow that had been drifting down from the sky. She blinked her eyes open, trying to figure out where she was. The last thing she’d heard was the ear-splitting screech of tires.

She couldn’t move. A deep ache radiated through every part of her body. The only thing that seemed unaffected by the paralysis was her vision. She glanced around, furiously searching for something to hold onto in the endless white abyss.

She found it not far away. The silhouette of her father stood nearby. But he stood with his back to her rigid as a statue. Somehow, although he wasn’t moving—he was drifting away, slowly being absorbed by the sea of white. And when Glimmer tried to call out for him, to ask him to help her, her voice was nowhere to be found.

She wanted to reach for him, to scream, to run. But she was frozen, trapped in her own body. Micah began to fade and Glimmer could do nothing but watch until he was completely swallowed up by the sea of white. And she was alone.

When Glimmer opened her eyes again, she was being carefully laid on a stretcher. The snow was still falling and although chaos reigned around her, the world was eerily silent. She couldn’t connect the pieces. Nothing made sense and she was so tired. Faces floated in and out of her vision. Strangers, her mother—sometimes Bow, although he looked distorted, like maybe she was imagining him. She couldn’t be sure. Somewhere inside of her a dull ache throbbed and her head was starting to pound as the sky disappeared and the ceiling of an ambulance replaced her view.

She drifted.

Sometimes floating in the white world again, looking for Micah, calling out without a voice. While other times she was jolted back into reality, her body arching under electrical currents as people shouted and rushed around her. She kept her eyes closed when she could, blocking it all out, trying to understand what had happened through the missing pieces in her brain.

She heard her father’s voice sometimes, she thought. Although what he was saying, she couldn’t make out. It wasn’t until the ethereal white world she wandered in turned into the off-white

sterile inside of a hospital building that Glimmer gave up the fight for consciousness and slipped into darkness again.

Leave it to Coach Huntara to make the team practice despite the snow. They ran around the track in the frigid air, moving to the indoor gym to practice drills afterward. Adora's mind wandered the entire time and her performance suffered. But she didn't care.

Prom was still a few months away. Realistically, it was probably pretty stupid that she was planning on asking Glimmer tonight. But, then again, she figured combining that invitation with the offer that she and Glimmer make things official made perfect sense. Adora's heart raced in her chest as she practiced her lines while the team played.

'Glimmer… No, just Glim. More personal. Glim, we've been friends for a long time now… Uh, wait no. Glim, you've been the best friend I could ever ask for. I really like you. Like, like you… No, don't—UGH! Glim, I'm… Afraid.'

A lacrosse ball connected with Adora's head, snapping her back reality as she stood still in the middle of the gym. Huntara shouted and ordered her onto the bench. For once, Adora went willingly, plopping down and considering the implications of her fantasy.

'I'm afraid. I grew up moving to home after home. So many people never really wanted me. And the home that kept me never really loved me. I didn't know what it felt like. Until I met you. I never knew that I could care so much for someone, the way I do for you. I think I'm—I'm in love with you.'

Huntara was shouting something again and the team was disbanding, grabbing their things and heading for the locker rooms to shower. Adora knew a shower was probably a good idea if she was going to profess her feelings, but at the same time, she couldn't wait any longer. Grabbing her bag, Adora bolted out of

the gym, pulling out her phone to send Glimmer a heads up. What she saw on her lock screen made her blood run cold.

Three missed calls from Mrs. Sato. Which as unsettling in and of itself seeing as Adora had never received *one* call from the woman let alone several. Below that notification, were at least 30 missed texts from Bow.

Something was very wrong.

Adora's hand shook as she unlocked her phone, the speech she'd been repeating vanishing like a cloud of smoke. She looked at Bow's texts first, stomach dropping sickeningly as she read the first one.

-'glimmer and micah were in a car accident.'

-'it's bad'

-'id call you but im with mrs. sato rn'

-'can u meet us at the hospital?'

-'I know ur busy but… I dunno.'

-'im freaking out pls come'

Closing the rest of the text, Adora opened the first voicemail from Mrs. Sato, praying she'd say something different. That she would tell Adora that everything was fine. This was all a stupid joke. Or a dream. Yeah, she was dreaming. She *had* to be.

Unfortunately, the voicemail told her much the same. Mrs. Sato's voice was uncharacteristically wobbly and Adora could hear the wail of a siren in the background:

"Adora, I don't mean to alarm you. But Glimmer has been in an accident. You are one of her dearest friends and we have been told there is cause for—," she paused, clearly searching for the least alarming word. "—concern… Should something happen, I

would like for you to be here for her. Bow has told me he sent you the hospital address. Adora I'm—"

Again, she trailed off and Adora waited with bated breath.

"—I'm so sorry."

The phone clicked. Adora didn't open the other voicemails. Instead, she ran for her car in a daze, shoving past Lonnie who cursed at her but Adora barely heard.

She slipped on the icy sidewalk more than a few times, stumbling her way to the car in a daze. Somehow, she was both bursting—fingers tingling like she'd just touched an outlet—and simultaneously numb. She was terrified and shaking, her stomach doing somersaults that made her want to throw up.

Glimmer was hurt. Micah had been with her. There was cause for concern. Both Bow and Mrs. Sato were panicking. Everything as disjointed and unreal and the life Adora had been living only a few short minutes ago, suddenly felt a million miles away.

This wasn't right. She should be driving to the Sato house to take Glimmer to watch the stars. They should be wrapped up in blankets, cuddled together as Adora told her how much she loved her. She was supposed to ask her to Prom and then maybe they might have shared their first kiss and fallen asleep under the stars and Adora wouldn't have been able to even *contain* her happiness.

This couldn't be fucking real.

Adora couldn't speed, the snow was getting worse and ice slicked the streets. So instead she crawled to the hospital, tears dripping down her burning cheeks as she begged whoever might be listening for her to get there in time. By the time she arrived at the hospital, whatever parade of ambulances might have brought Glimmer and Micah here had dispersed and the place looked eerily normal. It almost gave her hope that maybe she was dreaming this whole thing.

But then her phone rang, and Bow's panicked voice greeted her.

"Adora, did you get my texts?"

"Yeah, I'm sorry—I just got in my car and drove. I'm here. Are you—?"

"Main entrance, I'll come get you."

Bow hung up and Adora stumbled out of her car on wooden legs. This was devastatingly real, and each passing moment made the ache in her chest more painful. Bow met her at the doors. He looked sick, eyes sunken in and bloodshot, body hunched. When he saw her, he ran for her and she met him in a hug so tight she wasn't sure how it wasn't hurting either of them.

When they pulled apart, Adora managed to force the words she was afraid to voice. "Is she—?"

"She's stable," Bow answered, taking Adora's hand firmly and leading her inside. Adora took comfort in the firm grip, hoping he could ignore how clammy her hands were.

"What happened?"

Bow shrugged. "Somehow their car slid into an intersection. They got t-boned by a huge truck."

"Is anyone else—?"

"No. But—," Bow paused as he took Adora down another hallway. "Last I heard Mr. Sato isn't doing well."

Adora felt her heart stop, blood ice in her veins. "What does that mean?"

Bow just shook his head. "We don't know yet. Nobody knows anything it feels like. Mrs. Sato is meeting with the doctors right now, but they said we can have at least two at a time in Glimmer's room. C'mon."

Every part of Adora was consumed with guilt. Part of her told her it was stupid to imagine she could have done anything to help, the other half was screaming that she should have been there regardless. Instead she'd been daydreaming in her fucking gymnasium while Glimmer was fighting for her life. And Micah—

Adora didn't want to think about the possibilities so she shoved them to the back of her mind for now.

Bow led her inside a small room, closing the door quietly behind them. Glimmer lay at the center of a large hospital bed, countless IV's and wires hanging from her. She was so still and small. For a moment, Adora thought she might be dead, despite the quiet beep of the heart monitor. Her left arm was covered in a large white cast, as was most of her head. The rest of her visible skin was bruised and cut, all the way down to the tips of her fingers.

Tears sprung to Adora's eyes again, dripping down her cheeks before she could even try to stop them. Bow helped her forward when she froze, sitting her in the chair beside the bed and then stepping back. He seemed to fade away suddenly, the whole room did, as Adora took Glimmer in. She scooted closer, resting on hand as gently as she possibly could on Glimmer's cheek, brushing her thumb over the scrapes and cuts.

"Glim—?" Adora didn't know what she planned to say, but Glimmer didn't respond. The steady beep continued its droning, and Glimmer remained deathly still. Leaning forward, Adora rested her forehead on Glimmer's (mostly) uninjured shoulder. She felt sick, and scared and responsible for this all at once. More than anything she wanted to crawl into this bed and curl around Glimmer the same way she'd always done for Adora after her nightmares and her battle with Mrs. Weaver.

But she couldn't. The most she could do was run a gentle hand through Glimmer's tangled hair and swear silently not to leave her side.

The heart monitor jumped suddenly, startling both of them and Glimmer's eyes fluttered open, bleary and confused. She didn't even seem to recognize Bow and Adora as they stood over her. Adora knew the medication being pumped into her through the tubes must be affecting her mental state, but she wanted more than anything to see the recognition in Glimmer's eyes, the warmth that always calmed her. Instead she was met with pain and confusion.

Her lips parted and then clamped shut, face turning into a grimace. Adora could practically see her struggling to swallow and her heart wrenched in her chest.

"Glim?" Adora touched her cheek again, drawing Glimmer's hazy gaze towards her. "It's okay. It's me and Bow. Okay? It's me. You're safe."

Glimmer blinked at her, eyes clearing slightly. She tensed again and then opened her mouth. When she spoke, her voice was gravelly and raw.

"W-where's Dad?" she croaked.

Adora glanced up at Bow for help, but he shook his head, just as much at a loss as she was.

"I don't—,"

At that moment, the door opened and Angella stepped into the room. Adora had never seen her look so—fragile. Gone was the visage of a powerful, confident woman and beneath it was a broken soul who had almost lost her entire family in the blink of an eye. Angella ignored Bow and Adora, sweeping straight for Glimmer. She knelt opposite Adora on the other side of the bed and leaned over to plant a kiss on Glimmer's bandaged forehead. That was when Adora saw the tear tracks wetting her cheeks.

A cold weight settled in her gut; she could feel herself beginning to shake again until Bow's firm hand landed comfortingly on her shoulder.

“Mom?” Glimmer’s voice was barely more than a whimper, Adora could see her lavender eyes welling up with their own tears.

“It’s alright, Angel,” Angella murmured, kissing Glimmer’s forehead again as she stroked her hair. “I’m here.”

Adora leaned back in her chair, into Bow’s hand that was now an almost uncomfortable vice grip. But it kept her grounded and for that she was grateful. She was just about to dare ask about Micah’s wellbeing when Glimmer did it for her.

“Where’s Dad?” she whimpered.

Adora looked to Angella for an answer, her heart sinking when she saw the woman’s lower lip tremble and fresh tears dripped down her cheeks. She didn’t reply at first, stroking Glimmer’s cheek with a trembling hand.

It did nothing to soothe her, nor did it soothe Adora.

“Where is he?”

The longer Angella’s silence stretched the heavier Adora’s heart grew. She knew the answer and so did Glimmer. But neither of them were prepared to accept it. Bow’s fingers clenched in Adora’s hoodie and she raised a hand over his, squeezing back just as hard.

“Glimmer,” Angella said finally, her voice barely under control. “You need to rest, alright? We’ll talk when you’re feeling better. Everything will be alright, darling.”

Glimmer slapped her mother’s hand away with a sudden burst of energy, her eyes growing wide and wild. Before Angella could attempt to calm her again, she began to thrash, the beep of the heart monitor screeching in their ears.

She thrashed and screamed and tore at the needles in her arm as tears streamed down her bruised cheeks. Adora leapt forward at

the same time Angella did, doing her best to pin Glimmer down without hurting her further.

But she was strong. She always had been, and she fought them with every ounce of energy she had.

"Bow!" Angella called out to him; he stood frozen in the corner. Bow just nodded, needing no explanation to know that he was being asked to grab a nurse or doctor. He bolted, leaving the two women to struggle with the panicked and grief-stricken Glimmer.

"Glimmer, please calm down!" her mother tried, gently holding the arm braced in the big cast. "You're going to hurt yourself."

But Glimmer was inconsolable; babbling about needing to see Micah, how it was 'her fault', how she shouldn't have left him behind. Feeling her own tears falling, Adora reached for Glimmer's face, gently trying to turn her gaze, to get her to focus.

"Glimmer, *please*. Look at me, breathe." Adora tried. It was what Glimmer often said to her during her panic attacks. *Look at me, breathe. Tell me five things you hear. See. Feel.* For a few brief moments, Glimmer's eyes remained on hers as Adora stroked her cheeks with her thumbs. The eye contact almost broke Adora herself. She wanted to cry and scream with Glimmer, but she had to be strong for her.

"It's alright," she murmured and that seemed to be the opposite of what Glimmer wanted to hear because she suddenly tore away from Adora, wailing again.

This time Angella and Adora could do nothing but watch as a team of nurses burst through the door, pinning Glimmer down and injecting something into her that finally put a stop to her dangerous thrashing. Adora's knees shook. She wanted to collapse, but the hospital staff quickly ushered them out.

Once in the hallway, Angella, Bow and Adora all looked at each other—each somehow more broken than the last. As the reality

dawned on all three of them, Angella pulled them both to her in a tight embrace.

They held each other for a long time and cried.

Adora didn't see Glimmer again until the funeral.

She looked strange, all dressed in black. None of the neon colored clothes or decorative pins. Even hair seemed to have dulled, the black roots starting to grow out at the top. She stood next to her aunt—Adora only recognized her from pictures—as Mrs. Sato gave a eulogy that Adora only half paid attention to. Everything still felt so unreal, even now, as she stood amongst a dozen others mourning the loss of Micah.

Any second he'd reappear and laugh that they all looked so sad. He'd help Adora fix up her car. He'd make her feel like she had a real home.

But he didn't.

Adora watched Glimmer from her place beside Bow a few rows back. She didn't move, didn't turn to look at them. Simply picked at her cast and kept her eyes on the ground. As soon as the service came to a close and Micah's casket was lowered into the ground, Glimmer turned and ran. Adora almost moved to follow, but her Aunt and mother were already on their way. So instead, Adora turned to Bow who gave her a sad smile and pulled her into a hug.

As it turned out, she didn't see Bow much after the funeral either. The final semester of their senior year was kicking into high gear and Adora needed to ace her classes *and* perform better than she ever had during their final games if she wanted any chance at a full ride to Bright Moon University. She buried herself in practice and schoolwork, trying not to think about how much she missed Micah, or nights at the Sato house. She didn't see Bow or Glimmer for almost two weeks after the accident, the latter refused to

answer her calls or texts. And Adora couldn't really blame her for that, but she was starting to worry. Especially when Bow called her one night to voice the same concern.

When Adora did eventually spot her at school, Glimmer was surrounded by students the blonde didn't recognize. They didn't look—well, like the people Adora might have expected Glimmer to hang out with. She caught them behind the gym one day after classes, passing something around and inhaling from it before tossing it on to the next person.

They all turned when Adora rounded the corner, shuffling away in a pack, and taking Glimmer with them before she could even call out.

After that Adora made an attempt with Bow to corner Glimmer at her house, but Mrs. Sato turned them away, explaining Glimmer had been staying with her Aunt just outside of Bright Moon for a few days to 'clear her head'. Adora understood, she supposed… Living under the same roof that her father had been in not long ago must be indescribably painful. Defeated, Bow and Adora left. Unsure of her Aunt's address, there was no way they could find her outside of school, where she was continuing to avoid them.

Nevertheless, Adora tried to send texts or attempt to call when she could. It wasn't until she received a message telling her that 'this number's inbox is full' that she stopped trying. She threw herself even harder into her studies and lacrosse instead.

Sometimes, at night, when Mrs. Weaver was on one of her tirades and she could no longer escape to the Sato's, Adora drove up to the foothills on her own. She would spend the nights watching the stars, wishing Glimmer were beside her. And when she fell asleep, sometimes she'd find her in dreams. There they would talk again, and work through their shared grief. In her dreams they held each other again and promised to be there for one another through this. In the mornings, she woke alone. Cold, shivering and broken hearted.

She began hanging out with a few of her teammates to combat the loneliness. They weren’t the nicest and she didn’t have too much in common with any of them, but it was better than sitting in the cafeteria alone—or wandering the band hall hoping she might see Glimmer playing again.

She never had any luck.

One day, Adora sat with her teammates Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio in the packed lunchroom, picking listlessly at her turkey sandwich. No matter how hard she looked, she couldn't find the shock of pink hair that signaled Glimmer might be there. As far as Adora knew, she didn't come to lunch period anymore. Who knew where she did go with those...friends she hung out with nowadays. As a senior, she was allowed off campus anyway.

She could literally be anywhere in town.

Had it really been almost a month since they'd spoken?

"You gonna eat that?" Lonnie asked, jerking Adora back to the present as she slowly pulled her sandwich off the tray.

"Take it."

Lonnie did so without questioning Adora's lack of appetite. Kyle looked concerned, but also too meek to say anything. He simply gave her a pleasant smile when she met his gaze.

She was deciding whether to force a return smile when a sudden commotion drew her attention to the center of the lunchroom.

A girl she'd never seen before was shoving one of the larger boys on the football team. So hard, in fact, that she knocked his tray out of his beefy hands. It flew far enough to land on Adora's table, making Lonnie jump to her feet in shock.

"What the hell?"

Adora couldn't hear what was being said, but she *did* see the boy drawing a beefy fist back. Before she could think, Adora shot out of her seat, hurling herself between the two combatants before it could get any messier.

"Hey! Let's all relax, okay? What's going on here?" She glanced back at the girl over her shoulder, who glared at her with shockingly mismatched eyes.

"This bitch ran into me and then tossed my fucking lunch all over the room!" The bulky football player shouted, trying unsuccessfully to push past Adora.

"*He* ran into me!" The girl shot back. "He's just mad I'm not gonna take his bullshit like the rest of the losers at this school."

The football player snorted. "She doesn't even go here!"

"You don't own the fucking place, you dick."

"All right!" Adora shouted over both of them. "Just forget it and break it up before Doctor Hope shows up and reams everyone. Alright?"

The football player glared at both girls but finally stepped back. "Watch yourself, bitch."

"You first meathead," the girl shot back, then muttering quietly. "I'll bite your fucking tiny dick off."

"Hey," Adora hissed, guiding the girl back to her table with a firm hand on her shoulder. The girl tried to shake her off, but Adora ignored her complaints. "Wanna relax a little bit, before you get the entire football team after you?"

"Whatever. I'd ruin their day." The girl shrugged, plopping down at the table and glaring at Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio in turn.

"Uh—Who is this?" Lonnie growled.

"Catra. Who are you?" The girl shot back, already bristling for another fight.

"Catra," Adora cut in, sitting next to her quickly. "This is Lonnie, and Kyle and Rogelio. My friends. I'm Adora."

Catra blinked at her as if registering her for the first time, before scowling at the table again.

"Are you...new here? I don't think I've seen you around before."

"First day," Catra admitted, heaving a sigh. "I got kicked out of Horde Academy last week. They sent me here instead."

Can't imagine why, Adora mused. Out loud she grinned and chirped, "I've heard that school sucks anyway. Welcome to Bright Moon High."

Catra practically hissed.

"I'd be happy to show you around, if you'd like? Who to mess with...who to avoid. What do you say? Stick with us?" Adora looked to her friends, each one looked a little more disgusted than the last.

Catra shrugged again. "Whatever. Sure. I guess."

"Great! We'll teach you everything you need to—," Adora trailed off, looking over Catra's head to see a flash of purple/pink hair. "—Glimmer."

"Everything I need to *what*?"

Glimmer was pushing through the crowd, headed for the back doors of the cafeteria with her usual crowd of bums. Adora could practically smell the cloud of weed wafting off them as they passed. She straightened, catching Glimmer's eye for the briefest of moments. Before she could do anything though, maybe even just offer a smile, Glimmer looked away, heading more quickly for the door.

"Adora…?" Lonnie regained her attention.

"Sorry," Adora swallowed the hot lump in her throat. "Um...We'll show you around. Just...Stick with us. You'll be fine."

Catra blinked at her, bi-colored eyes narrowing. “You good, dude?”

No, she really wasn’t. She hadn’t been in a long time. But Catra, this girl she’d literally *just* met, didn’t need that baggage. So she forced another grin and returned to her lunch tray.

“All good.”

Adora kept her promise to Catra, showing her around the school, and although the school year was almost over the two ended up spending most of their time together.

Catra was an interesting person. She was quick to anger and lashed out at almost anyone who looked at her wrong; but when she and Adora were alone, she teased and made dumb jokes and taught Adora how to longboard and it was… nice. Nice to have someone to talk to again. To hang out with when she was feeling lonely. As it turned out, she had a lot more in common with Catra than she realized at first glance. Catra was also a foster kid, currently being kicked around houses. It was powerful to be able to connect with someone who related to Adora on that level.

A few times, Adora considered taking Catra up into the foothills, but she never could bring herself to follow through. That was her and Glimmer’s spot. Even if Glimmer didn’t talk to her anymore… Even if she never did… It would always be their place.

Instead, she and Catra found an old park that they chose to loiter around after dark. They sat on the swings and talked about—anything and everything. It reminded Adora of her late-night conversations with Glimmer. It was comfortable and familiar. And maybe that’s why she didn’t pull away the first time Catra kissed her, or when she asked her to Prom, and then when she followed it up with ‘let’s just date for real, what the fuck?’.

Somehow, it happened. As Glimmer and Bow disappeared from her life, Catra came in and loomed large, absorbing everything until she was the only thing keeping Adora tethered. She'd get her full ride, she and Catra would go to the same college, they'd be happy, and Adora would forget these last few months. She'd forget what it felt like to sit in Glimmer's living room, snuggled between her two best friends. She'd forget the nights under the stars. She'd forget what it felt like to be so deeply in love that is almost hurt to think about.

She had Catra now. That was enough.

Glimmer sat with her new 'friends' in the band hall. Friends was a generous term, she still didn't even know a lot of their names. But they got her high and drunk often and helped her forget the soul sucking ache that lingered inside her whenever she thought about her father.

She still couldn't believe he was gone. In the blink of an eye and it was all her—

Glimmer stopped herself, knowing that if she started spiraling now, she wouldn't be able to pull herself out of it. She'd save it for later when she was home, locked in her room, pounding the edibles this group of 'friends' had given her.

As the other kids chatted around her, Glimmer picked idly at her phone case. It had stopped buzzing constantly a few weeks ago. Adora didn't text her anymore, or call. She didn't see her passing in the halls. It was like she'd vanished too. Bow hadn't given up on her though, and Glimmer even responded to him sometimes. They didn't hang out like they used to. But he talked to her and asked her how she was doing more often than she'd like. In fact, he'd asked her to Prom last week, knowing she had no on to go with probably. And wanting to be there for her again. Bow wore his heart on his sleeve, his intentions were clear, and no matter how badly Glimmer wanted to fuck the whole thing, she'd said yes.

Because she missed him, deep down. She missed both of them.

Opening her phone, Glimmer clicked into her conversation thread with Adora, scrolling through the dozens of unanswered texts.

-'stars tonight?'

-'Hey, im just checking in… I know I've been awol, im sorry, practice sucks.'

-'I dunno if you got my call, but there's a sale on trades down at the Hall of Heroes today, if u wanna go?'

-'I miss you.'

-'let me know if you get this'

-'I'm here glim'

Biting back the tears that stung her eyes, Glimmer turned off her phone. She couldn't see Adora again, she didn't want to. Besides, the texts had stopped all together. Adora have given up, and Glimmer couldn't blame her. But she was also mad at her. They were best friends. Lacrosse shouldn't matter. Glimmer had lost her *father*. Adora should be trying harder. Glimmer just wasn't worth her time anymore. Maybe she never had been.

It hurt to think she might see her at Prom. If she was going with anyone. Glimmer had seen her a few weeks ago with a crew of kids she didn't recognize. They all looked like dumb jocks though. Except for one scrawny girl with an angry scowl to match Glimmers and a mess of wild curls. Whatever. It wasn't like it mattered anyway.

Bow made her go dress shopping for Prom. He took her out and they hugged and got iced coffees and shopped and talked and for a while Glimmer felt normal again. She felt like maybe she hadn't lost everything she'd ever loved. But then Bow dropped her off at home and she was forced to face her mother again and it all came crumbling down.

Angella was mad. She never said it out loud though and that made it worse. She knew Glimmer was smoking and drinking, she'd blatantly thrown the bags of edibles in the kitchen trash once. Glimmer had fished them back out quickly. They didn't talk anymore. They never had, really. But Glimmer wanted nothing to do with her mother anymore. She didn't understand her, she didn't care to understand her.

Sometimes, Glimmer heard her crying in her room late at night and it twisted a knife into her heart, made her question things… But then the mornings would come and she'd be scolded for *something*—leaving a plate out—and it was back to square one.

Glimmer held fast to the fact that this was her last year. She was almost out of this fucking school and this fucking house and then she could go wherever she wanted. It was the only reason she kept her grades up. If she didn't graduate, it was another year in this perpetual hell.

Too much time passed. But finally, Adora found herself back at the Sato house.

Adora parked just outside the long driveway. It felt strange being back here after all these months. The place she'd once called a second home and she now felt like she didn't belong anywhere near it.

Angella's call had been unexpected, but not unwelcome. It was comforting to hear the woman's voice after so many months without her or Micah. And when she'd asked if Adora could stop by for just a moment to talk, Adora couldn't find it in herself to say no.

As she stepped out of the car, Adora wondered if she might see Glimmer again. She doubted they'd be able to talk, even if she was home. Glimmer didn't seem to want anything to do with her these days.

Heart already aching in her chest, Adora climbed the steps, knocking on the front door and waiting for whoever might answer anxiously.

Angella opened the door, the weary lines on her face disappearing when she saw Adora. It was soothing, for the briefest of moments, to see Glimmer's mother again. Adora couldn't help but remember how many times she'd offered her refuge and solace. And even the advice of a mother that she'd always wished she had. The night she'd been there to care for her now scarred over wound…

"Mrs. Sato," Adora dipped her chin in a solemn greeting.

Angella's smile twisted a bit, as if she too suddenly remembered how much time and distance had grown between them.

"Adora, thank you for coming. Please come in."

Adora followed Angella inside, slipping her shoes off in a habit even though she didn't intend to stay long.

Angella took her into the living room, placing herself gracefully on the couch and gesturing for Adora to join her. She did, noticing a tea set resting on the coffee table in front of them.

"Tea?" Angella offered, but Adora shook her head. She felt sick to her stomach being in here again. Only a few feet away was the spot where she'd fallen asleep too many times to count in Glimmer's arms. Or danced with her in slow circles. Or where she'd fallen into hysterics after shoving popcorn into the waistband of her shorts.

"No thank you, Ma'am."

Angella's face fell slightly, but she gathered herself and plastered on a composure over the clearly fractured woman that existed beneath.

"Adora, I know it's been quite some time since we've last spoken. And I am truly sorry. I just… Things have been—difficult."

Adora didn't ask her to clarify. Micah's death had hit them all hard. Glimmer most of all. She couldn't imagine what Angella must be dealing with in regards to her daughter's grief.

"I need your help," Angella's voice tightened and she leaned towards Adora slightly in her intensity. "Glimmer is… Not well. She won't speak with me anymore. She won't accept help. The only friend she seems to keep around is Bow. And even then, I rarely see him anymore. But I thought that maybe… You—,"

Angella paused, her shoulders falling as she broke the intense gaze she shared with Adora, staring down into her lap instead.

"You two were very close. She trusted you. Cared very deeply for you." Adora didn't think Angella was actively trying to hurt her, but every word was like a knife in Adora's chest. She'd cared for Glimmer too. She *still* did.

"I wonder if you might be able to reach her…"

Angella looked back up at Adora, her violet eyes pleading. "Do you think you might be able to speak with her. To be there for her again?"

Adora didn't know what to say. How to explain to a grieving mother, that her daughter was actively choosing to avoid Adora. What *could* she say though? Angella had never looked this broken before. This lost.

"I know you're hurting too, Adora," Angella continued when Adora didn't reply. "I don't mean to dismiss that. But Glimmer she—,"

Again, she stopped, taking a shaky breath before resting a gentle hand on Adora's knee. "Please. The two of you… I need you to… Take care of each other, Adora."

Adora nodded, unable to find the words to argue otherwise. Maybe Angella was right. If she could just get Glimmer to talk to her. Things would be okay again.

They would be okay again.

"I will," Adora promised, not knowing whether or not she could keep it.

Angella gave her a tired smile. "Thank you. I know you can help her."

Adora got a text from Catra right after leaving Mrs. Sato's house. She waited until she was safe inside her truck before checking it.

-'party tonite at scorpia's. u down? >;3'

Adora really wasn't, but maybe loosening up a bit might do her some good. She could deal with considering how to talk to Glimmer tomorrow.

-'sure'

-'catch u there bby'

Adora frowned and turned her phone off, stuffing it into her pocket and driving away from the Sato house for what she did not realize then would be the last time.

Adora met Catra outside the party house. They were deep in the Fright Zone, one of the sketchiest neighborhoods in Bright Moon. Even growing up right on the outskirts, Adora had done her best to avoid it.

Catra was wearing a red tank top that exposed her flat stomach, the bright birthstone necklace that Adora had bought her and a pair of loose cargo pants. It was an odd look, but somehow one Catra was entirely able to pull off.

“You’re late,” Catra leaned against the hood of her car as Adora stepped out, moving around the front to meet her.

“I thought you always told me it was fashionable to be a little late,” Adora replied with a teasing smirk.

“Oh, so you do listen to me sometimes.” Catra quirked a brow and tugged Adora in by the wrist, meeting her lips in a kiss that was probably a little too intense for middle-of-the-street-right-outside-a-party, but Adora let it happen anyway. She tasted like the cheap cigarettes she smoked and beer; clearly she’d already been pre-gaming. Adora didn’t really care for the taste, but right now, the abject affection was something she needed.

When Catra pulled away, biting lightly on Adora’s lower lip before she did, Adora couldn’t help noticing the sinking feeling in her gut. It was happening less and less often now. But maybe because of her recent meeting with Angella. Kissing Catra felt like a strange betrayal. Like she shouldn’t be the one Adora was giving her affection to.

She shook off the strange feeling as Catra tugged her inside. The party was loud, dancing, drinking and obnoxious games of beer pong already taking place around her. Adora sighed internally. These things really weren’t her scene. With luck, Catra would get bored soon enough and they could leave. For now, she tailed Catra around as she mingled with a few partygoers Adora had never seen before. Scorpia greeted then, loudly and drunkenly, and Adora caught sight of Rogelio, Lonnie and Kyle at one of the beer pong tables.

She offered a wave, but they didn’t seem to notice her.

Resigned to a night of wall-flowering, Adora had just stopped by the drink table to pick a beer out of the ice cooler when she caught a glance of familiar pink out of the corner of her eye. She turned just in time to see Glimmer slipping through the crowd, following a group of punk looking teenagers Adora didn’t recognize.

Her heart skipped a beat in her chest, Angella's words rushing back to her. Now was her chance. Glimmer couldn't run from her here. She'd pull her aside, they'd talk. Everything would be okay if she could just tell Glimmer why she'd been so busy.

Abandoning her half-opened beer, Adora shoved through the crowd, uttering 'pardons' and 'excuse me's' until she was close enough to call Glimmer's name.

Somehow, the girl heard her over the din. She turned, confused, her eyes widening upon recognizing Adora.

"Glimmer," Adora stopped just short of her, body trembling with… nerves? Excitement? Suddenly, all the words she'd ever learned flew from her head and she just stared, her mouth opening and closing. "…Hi."

Glimmer's face hardened, but she turned to fully face Adora, one brow cocked curiously. "What are you doing here?"

"Me? Here?" Adora almost pointed to herself in genuine confusion. "Oh! The party… Yeah, I—I was invited. I… I dunno, I thought maybe… It might be—Fun?"

For some reason, Adora felt it best to leave out that she'd come with Catra. Even so, her answer didn't seem to assuage Glimmer. The girl's brow furrowed further.

"You hate parties."

"Yeah. No. Well! Most. Um, I dunno. Hey, can we talk?" Adora was sweating.

"We are talking."

"No," A frustrated huff escaped her, and Glimmer shrunk away further. "No, like, outside? Alone? Just for a sec."

Glimmer looked away, beginning to turn, but Adora reached out, fingers wrapping lightly around her wrist as she murmured,

“Glimmer, please?”

For a moment, Adora recognized a softness in Glimmer’s expression. She met Adora’s gaze with the tender lavender eyes that Adora remembered. But then she blinked, the moment was gone and Glimmer pulled her hand away, jerking her chin for Adora to lead the way outside.

Almost frozen with shock, it took Adora a second to move. When she did, she stumbled over a few party guests on her way outside. Glimmer was still following when they made it into the cool evening air, standing on the sidewalk beside Adora’s truck.

Adora faced Glimmer, her heart pounding, desperately wishing she’d thought of something to say. But she hadn’t imagined she’d really get this far.

“Were you going to say something or—?” Glimmer prodded, a bitterness Adora wasn’t accustomed to coloring her tone.

“Glimmer, look…,” Adora reached deep for the emotions she’d been working through for months with her counselor. Say what *you* would want to hear. “I’m really sorry about… The last few months. I know I haven’t been there for you when you needed me to be and I’m—It’s just lacrosse is—,”

“I haven’t *needed* you,” Glimmer’s voice was full of venom. “I’ve been just fine on my own.”

Adora blinked, surprised by how deeply Glimmer’s words cut. “I—Of course. Of course you have, I’m just…. I’m still sorry. I’ve been so busy. I’m trying to get a full ride into college and it’s a lot of work. But I know that I should be a better friend to you. You know. It’s been hard…. After—After Mic—,”

Glimmer’s face twisted with grief (?) anger (?) Adora wasn’t sure. “I get it, Adora. You’re busy. It’s not a fucking issue. I’ve got my own friends now and you’ve got… Whoever the fuck that tank top chick is and her squad. It’s whatever.”

Adora frowned, confused, until she realized Glimmer was talking about Catra. "Oh… No, I mean. Yeah, Catra. Lonnie and stuff. They're my friends too. But you and Bow—," Adora chuckled weakly, offering a pained smile. "We're still the Best Friends Squad."

Glimmer's eyes were chips of steel in the moonlight. "Bow's been doing his own thing lately too, Adora. Not that you would have noticed that either. I'm not sure how you notice anything anymore, honestly. Between throwing balls around and sticking your tongue down what's-her-face's throat all the time?"

Adora balked, a hint of anger burning in her chest. Glimmer wasn't being fair. She wasn't even listening to what Adora was saying. She'd been dodging her calls for months and now she was blaming *her* for neglecting their friendship?

"Glimmer, I've been reaching out to you since the funeral." She felt her heart twinge when Glimmer's face contorted again. "I've been trying as often as I can to see you. But you never even answer my calls! What was I supposed to do?"

"You ever consider I'm not interested in your friendship anymore, Adora?" Glimmer threw air quotes around the word friendship and Adora had to fight to stop herself from exploding. She tried to remember Angella's words. Glimmer was hurting. She was lashing out. She wasn't accepting help.

But Adora had to take care of her. She *wanted* to. She still cared about Glimmer. She missed her.

Steadying herself with a deep breath, Adora tried from another angle. "Glimmer… I know you've been hurting. But you can't just shut out everyone who cares about you. Your mother—,"

"What would you fucking know?" Glimmer was shouting now and Adora could see her eyes glistening with unshed tears. "You're never around anyway. How do you know how I feel?"

“I don’t!” Adora shouted back, losing her composure. “But only because you won’t let me! We used to be a team. And now, I don’t know what we are!”

“We’re not anything, Adora,” Glimmer shot back, beginning to push past her. “Go back to your slutty girlfriend and forget about me.”

“Glimmer!” Adora grabbed her wrist, pulling her back around harshly. “You’re not the only one who lost Micah that day. Okay?”

Glimmer’s face was a mask of fury, but she was paralyzed in Adora’s grip.

“Do you really think I’m not hurting too? Or Bow? Your mom? We all miss him.”

“What would you know?” Glimmer ripped her wrist away, the tears streaming down her face now. The sight tempered Adora’s rage. She didn’t want Glimmer to cry. She didn’t want to see her hurting so badly. “You don’t even have any fucking parents!”

Ignoring the painful sting of that comment, Adora countered. “Micah was like a father to me too, Glimmer! The only one I’ve ever had. You can’t tell me that I don’t know how it feels to—,”

“Fuck you, sports star! You still have everything!” Glimmer spat, her entire body wracked with painful sobs. “Fuck you and fuck your friends and fuck your stupid lacrosse games. Leave me alone!”

Adora stood frozen, she couldn’t find the words, or the strength to pull Glimmer back as the girl she’d loved so dearly tore away from her and ran off into the night. Adora wanted to fall to her knees. To cry or scream or punch something. But instead, she stood still as a statue, eyes and throat burning as Glimmer disappeared.

‘You ever love someone so much; you don’t want anything about them to change?’

“Glimmer…”

Adora had always thought the Disney movies they’d watched together in Glimmer’s living room were kind of cheesy. But as Glimmer disappeared, Adora felt her heart break into a dozen pieces, just like all those stupid cartoons.

This wasn’t right.

They were supposed to go to Prom together. She was going to tell Glimmer how she felt. How she’d fallen for her eyes, for her spirit, for her dumb puns, for the snorty-giggles she made when they were up late into the night, made loopy from exhaustion.

She was supposed to tell Glimmer how deeply she’d fallen in love with her.

But Glimmer was gone and Catra appeared, placing a warm hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Hey, what are you doing out here? Everyone in the fucking party heard you guys screaming… You okay? Or do I need to cut a bitch?”

Adora shook her head, rubbing the unshed tears from her eyes. “Sorry. It’s… Forget it. Let’s go inside.”

Catra looked unconvinced but nodded and led Adora back by the elbow.

Adora got drunk.

She didn't usually drink. Ever...Really. It messed with her sports performance.

But her stomach was twisted in knots as she replayed Glimmer's words over and over again, relived the look of disgust on her face as she pushed Adora away.

She wanted to forget tonight had ever happened. So she took shot after shot. Beer after beer until she found herself back at

Catra's place, exchanging sloppy, harsh kisses as they tumbled into her bed.

Adora didn't remember most of it honestly. Catra marked her skin, sucking dark bruises into her neck, breasts and thighs. Leaving long red scratch marks down her back.

It was fast and rushed and Adora really only remembered the painful moment when Catra's fingers slid inside of her. It was over quickly.

She thought maybe she came? But she wasn't sure. She was really drunk and Catra's face kept blurring with the ceiling.

She cried afterwards.

Told Catra it was because she couldn't handle her alcohol. Catra had laughed, wiped her tears away and curled around her before falling asleep.

Adora lay awake, listening to her heart pounding in her ears, trying to ignore the painful ache between her legs.

She tried not to think of Glimmer's last words.

But the fight followed her deep into her dreams when she finally drifted off to sleep.

Prom rolled around and Bow picked Glimmer up promptly, and to her mother’s great approval. He looked handsome, all smiles as he led her inside the venue. The wandered around the drink and food bar for a while, but Glimmer refused to partake in any of the other activities. Instead, she glued herself to the wall, insisting Bow go have a good time with his friends while she wall-flowered. Bow, being the loyal friend he was, sighed but did not leave her side.

"You sure you don't wanna just *try* and dance?" Bow asked, leaning against the wall beside Glimmer and taking a sip of his sparkling cider.

Glimmer was about to tell him off when her eyes fell on a very familiar couple twirling around the middle of the dancefloor. Her heart stopped in her chest, gut twisting, as she recognized the blonde.

Adora.

She was here and dancing with the same girl from the fucking party. Catra. She wore a maroon tux that matched the flowy red dress Adora had chosen. They even had matching corsages. Glimmer wanted nothing more than to punch a hole through the wall at that moment.

“Glimmer?” Bow must have seen the steam coming out of her ears.

Glimmer tried not to care. She really did. But every time she caught a flash of Adora's smile or the way Catra's hand slipped lower on her hip, she felt her gut twist nauseatingly.

That *could* have been due to the three cheap beers she'd already consumed before Bow picked her up, of course, and not a raging jealousy burning inside. But Glimmer wasn’t certain.

Bow, sensing a disaster, tried to distract her. "If you want to dance with Perfuma I can ask her for you! She's a great partner--,"

"I don't want to fucking dance, Bow," Glimmer growled sourly.

Bow sighed, following her glare to the couple now quite literally dancing center stage.

"Why do you care, Glimmer?" Bow asked after a while, his voice almost drowned out by the heavy beat of the music. "I thought you didn't *want* to talk to her anymore. You've been dodging her for months. And you told me you guys fought at that party---,"

"I don't care," Glimmer cut him off again. Not wanting to deal with the emotions Bow would inevitably bring out of her. "I just think they're being obnoxious. It's gross."

Bow heaved a sigh, but didn't argue further, resigning himself to slump beside his sullen friend.

Glimmer hadn't realized how tightly her jaw was clenched until the music changed to something much slower and suddenly Catra had pulled Adora so close to her, that Glimmer momentarily thought she'd stolen a kiss. The thought made her blood boil.

She squeezed her eyes shut as the nights and the stars and all the memories came rushing back to her. She remembered Adora’s eyes most of all. Glowing beneath the moonlight in the foothills. Soft as Glimmer sang her to sleep in her bedroom. Strong and sure as they met hers in the hospital; when they’d tried to convey without words: ‘I’m here. Don’t look away.’

But Glimmer had—and she’d ruined everything and now Adora was gone. As far away from her as her father.

Fuck them. Fuck them. Fuck them.

Glimmer chose the wrong moment to open her eyes. It all happened in slow motion. Catra slipped an arm around Adora's waist, dipped her low, and sealed the distance between them with a kiss. Glimmer watched in horror as Adora's hand rose to slip through Catra's hair, somehow pulling her closer.

In that moment, Glimmer felt an agony that rivaled the day she'd lost Micah. Her heart ached, a knife stabbing into her chest with every rapid beat. Her mouth ran dry, throat constricting until she couldn't breathe.

"Glimmer?" Bow's voice was distant and echoey. He must have seen too though, because he reached out, touching her shoulder gently.

It should have been me.

Hot tears burned her eyes, but she willed them not to fall, she would not break here.

"Glimmer," Bow prodded again. "Hey, take a breath."

"Let's go," she said, standing abruptly enough to startle Bow.

"Go where?"

"Away from here," she replied, already turning to go.

"Glimmer, it's *prom*," Bow insisted, dogging behind her a few paces. "Don't ruin it for yourself! Come on, let's hang out with some people. Let's have fun!"

"I'm leaving."

"Glimmer—," Bow grabbed her wrist but she tore away from him roughly, whirling on her friend and exploding in a bout of rage she'd bottled for months.

"Fucking *stay* if you want to, Bow! I'm done. This dance sucks and so does everyone here and I don't want anything to fucking do with it."

Bow's shoulders fell, his eyes full of pity. Glimmer hated him in that moment.

"I don't want to stay if you're not here," he murmured. "We're the best friend squad."

Fuck, she hated those words. They were lies.

"Then follow me and let's go find a real party where we can actually get wasted."

Without waiting to see if he would follow Glimmer pushed her way out of the venue, ignoring the way her heart continued to break with each beat. If the world wanted to fuck her over at every turn, then she had no choice but to harden herself. Or she'd drown beneath the crashing waves.

As she passed the row of seats where most students had stored their belongings, Glimmer got a terrible idea. She snatched up her own bag, no longer caring if Bow was following or now (he wasn't), and scanned the room for Doctor Hope. She stood near the buffet table, cheerily bobbing her head to the music as she sipped at a bowl of punch.

Quickly, Glimmer pulled out her phone, wallet and student I.D., stashing them beneath the benches until all that was left was a change of clothes and the small pouch of weed she'd brought for later in the night, Glimmer made her way across the dancefloor towards their principal.

"Um, Doctor Hope, excuse me?" she simpered as best she could, trying to play the role of 'small, impressionable student'. Doctor Hope looked down at her, questioningly.

"Yes?"

"Um, I'm sorry to bother you ma'am. But I was looking for my bag and smelled something, um, off? And, uh, I found this."

Glimmer handed her own bag over, allowing Doctor Hope to pull out the pouch for herself. Her face went dark immediately. "Do you know who's bag this is?"

Glimmer nodded furiously, pointing to Catra, who was just coming off the dance floor, Adora on her arm. Doctor Hope nodded, thanked her and gestured for the other various chaperones and security stationed nearby. Glimmer stepped back, watching this a sick sense of satisfaction as the adults dispersed and approached the couple.

Doctor Hope was first, holding the baggy of weed in front of Catra who's eyes widened with shock. Glimmer didn't wait to watch the rest unfold, she slipped into the shadows, grabbing her things and high tailing it for the door. Catra's wails of indignance followed her out into the cool night air.

Glimmer knew she should feel guilty. She'd ruined not only Catra's prom night, but also Adora's. But she didn't.

Fuck them both.

They deserved each other.

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> Last update before Season 5 everyone! I wanted to say that I really appreciate all the kind thoughts and comments and words of support you all leave every chapter. Each one means the world to me and I'm super glad you guys are enjoying this story as much as I'm enjoying writing it.
>
> I also wanted to say that whatever Season 5 brings us in the finale, I will be continuing this fic to completion as well as many other Glimmadora and She-Ra related fic ideas I have. I hope you all enjoy the last season of this awesome show and I'll see you guys on the other side!!
>
> Summary: Glimmer and Adora make up after Catra's surprise visit. Adora tries to impress Glimmer and fails... sort of. They have a good night anyway (smut content warning). Two ghosts from Glimmer's past make a surprise return.

Glimmer didn’t sleep well.

And when she did, she had nightmares so vivid, that they felt too much like reality to count as rest. She’d heard most of the argument that Adora and Catra exchanged through the door last night. But it didn’t do much to quell the twisting anger and hurt in her gut. It had to be some cruel twist of fate that the *same* woman who had taken Adora from her all those years ago, was *still* in the picture, *still* who Adora preferred. And what was worse, Adora had kept her a secret.

Glimmer knew she shouldn’t feel so betrayed. Dating other people was entirely within the rules. But this was Catra. Glimmer wasn’t sure she could ever let go of that personal wound. Maybe if it was someone else, anyone else… Glimmer wouldn’t have cared.

Or maybe she would have.

And maybe she was lying to herself and this was getting too fucking complicated and Bow was right and—

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer jolted upright in bed, holding her breath as she heard the doorknob jiggle. She'd kept it locked last night, refusing to let Adora inside out of spite. After another jiggle, she heard a heavy sigh and then a thunk against the door followed by more silence. Glimmer stayed frozen in bed, covers clutched around her like a shield. She knew she'd had to face Adora eventually, but this morning the wounds felt too fresh. Maybe when they'd both cooled off after a day at work. Adora would still have to get ready, but Glimmer would just shove her uniform under the door or something. She didn't want to talk to her right now.

There were no words left to say.

"I don't know if you're awake," Adora's voiced continued, breaking the silence very suddenly. "But—I'm really sorry, Glim. About last —About everything."

Glimmer held her breath, entire body taut like a string as she listened. She wasn't quite sure how to feel about the apology, it was almost hollow. Of course, Adora would be sorry for the awkward situation they'd been thrown into last night. But it didn't really do anything to assuage the strangling betrayal taking root in Glimmer's chest.

"I know I messed up," Adora continued to speak despite Glimmer's silence. "I guess I just---I've been thinking a lot about high school lately. About… You know, how we met and stuff. How I met Catra too."

Slowly, Glimmer climbed out of bed. Adora's voice was growing quieter, and Glimmer found herself genuinely intrigued to hear. She'd been thinking a lot about high school too lately. Remembering things. Confusing and painful memories—feelings she'd wished had stayed buried.

"After Micah died I—," Glimmer heart clenched in her chest as she crept towards the door, lowering herself quietly until she sat with her back pressed against it. "After we… Didn't talk anymore. I was really lost. And scared. I didn't have anyone to turn to and then Catra came into my life and she was like… She was like—,"

Adora trailed off again and Glimmer couldn't help but think she was struggling to describe what the other woman was. What she really meant to her.

"—The sun, I guess. So bright and overwhelming and when I didn't have anything or anyone else, she was what kept me going."

The description hurt more than Glimmer would have liked to admit. *'Like the sun'*; something bright and warm and comforting, it sounded like. Or maybe… from Adora's tone, something intense and dangerous and blinding.

"She's wasn't a bad person or anything. Not back then. In fact, I really needed her. She was devoted—maybe a little obsessive even. But that undivided attention, that dedication… I needed it, because I felt like no one else wanted me. And it was good, for a while. It was. We were in love, I think. I mean, she told me loved me. And I—,"

Glimmer turned, resting her ear against the door as Adora's voice grew small again.

"—I thought I knew what love was, so maybe I loved her back. Maybe I was just using her, I don't know anymore. But we were happy. For a while. We got into Bright Moon U together. She wanted to study music so she could start a band. A good one that would really take off someday. It was the most passionate I've ever seen her get about something. She really wanted to make something of herself. I was working just as hard though. Trying to improve my performance in lacrosse and keep up my studies and if high school had been hard, college was just intent on kicking

my ass. We both got so busy, maybe—I don't know if that's how it started to fall apart, but it did."

Glimmer felt her heart twinge, but not in anger. There was such a melancholy sadness in Adora's voice. Glimmer felt it resonate deep within her. A sense of regret. Of confusion and sadness.

Guilt.

"We started fighting. About… *everything*, it felt like. After a while, I started to wonder if I could never say anything right. If I was the fuck up. I didn't want to keep hurting her, but everything I did was wrong. Sometimes we'd fight and then we wouldn't talk for days and I remember feeling like I couldn't even get out of bed. I had to fight to get through those days because I was so consumed with the guilt. The idea that I would lose—That we'd break up because I was an idiot who didn't know how to use her words."

Adora fell silent for a while, the only sound Glimmer could make out through the door a few tiny sniffles.

"And then I got my injuries and they told me I'd never be able to play professionally, and it felt like—She gave up on me, I guess. Like, I wasn't sure what my future was anymore and because of that I wasn't worth her time. Or effort. It was really… kinda shitty in hindsight, when she dropped out entirely after that semester. The fights got worse and then—," Adora heaved a sigh. "We never really officially broke up, not out loud anyway. But I don't think the words needed to be said. It didn't feel the same anymore. *We* didn't feel the same."

Glimmer turned fully now, pressing her forehead against the door, heart hammering in her ribs. What Adora was revealing hurt. It made her stomach twist. She really wasn't too different from Catra, as much as she liked to pretend she wasn't. What they had… This 'agreement', these rules… They weren't any less confusing or upsetting for Adora. For Glimmer as well. This whole

thing had been a stupid idea. The last thing she wanted to do was hurt her friend. Or remind her of someone who *had.*

But she had. She had back then too.

"Eventually, I started catching her with other women. It just went unspoken after that that we were done. But I felt like I'd failed, like if I'd been a better girlfriend, somehow, maybe it wouldn't have fallen apart." Adora sniffed loudly and Glimmer felt her own tears rising. "I don't know. Either way, we stopped talking for a while. And then, she got drunk one night and came over and—Yeah. We started talking again a little bit. But it wasn't the same, you know? I mean how could it be?"

Glimmer glanced at the handle, chewing her lip as she considered opening it now.

"Before I met you at the gym that day, we'd kind of been on track to maybe—I dunno, fix things? Or at least talk about our issues but… Then she went off with her band and I was alone again. And then—I wasn't. *You* were there. And I hadn't let myself admit how much I'd just missed being around you until you were here every day and—,"

Glimmer placed her hand on the knob, waiting.

"I'm sorry," Adora sighed. "I should have at least told you about Catra. I messed up. But I haven't been *lying* to you, or anything. Not really. It's not like I'm with her. Or anyone else. I know that's not a rule. I just want you to know I haven't been playing you or anything… I would never do that."

Bracing herself for the look on Adora's face, Glimmer opened the door. It swung inwards and Adora yelped. Apparently, she'd been sitting with her back pressed against it from the other side, because once Glimmer pulled it open unexpectedly, she fell backwards, landing with a thud at Glimmer's knees.

Blue eyes blinked up at her, the pink blanket she was covering herself in slipping just slightly. For some reason, Glimmer blushed

and looked away, as if she hadn't seen this woman naked over a dozen times at this point.

"You're awake," she pointed out when neither of them spoke for a few awkward seconds.

"You're naked," Glimmer retaliated and Adora flushed, scrambling back into a sitting position.

"You wouldn't let me in."

Sighing, Glimmer scooted forward on her knees, inching closer until Adora looked up to meet her gaze.

"I heard everything last night."

Adora's eyes were owlish. "You did?"

Glimmer nodded, biting her lip. The petty part of her was still hurt that it had been *Catra* of all people to walk in on them last night. But the rest of her knew Adora has just shared some deeply personal feelings. And she deserved an apology for Glimmer's behavior.

"I'm sorry I freaked out," she said, placing on hand on Adora's blanketed thigh. "I was just—surprised. Confused. You didn't break any rules or anything, it really wasn't fair of me I—I just really fucking hate that girl."

Adora's eyes widened and then she snorted, continuing to laugh as she rubbed the tears from her eyes with the blanket. "I do too sometimes."

Glimmer picked at a stray thread near Adora's knee, keeping her eyes locked on that spot as she spoke. "I mean… You could date her. Or someone else. If—If you wanted to or whatever. It's… Like you said, it's not against the rules or anything."

Adora didn't respond at first, but Glimmer didn't dare look up to meet her gaze, afraid of what she might see in her eyes. Finally,

Adora's hand came to rest of Glimmer's, her rough thumb stroking over smooth knuckles.

"I don't want to date Catra."

Glimmer nodded, chancing a quick glance up to see Adora was watching her with knitted brows.

"Okay, good," she quickly broke the intense gaze and helped Adora to her feet. "Because I don't want you to either, she sucks."

Adora laughed again as Glimmer ushered her into the room so that she could finally exchange her blanket for some real clothes. Closing the door behind her for privacy, Glimmer was surprised when Adora immediately cracked it open again.

"Hey, we should do something tonight. After work."

Glimmer blinked at the blue eyes peering at her from the small crack. "Do something?"

"Yeah, like go out. Get a drink maybe. We spend too much time in here… Well, you know."

A fond smile tugged at Glimmer's lips. "Like a date?"

"Ye—," Adora's eyes widened. "No! No. Not like a date. Just hanging out somewhere that's not my living room."

Glimmer pursed her lips, pondering the offer and enjoying the way Adora's eyes somehow grew more round as she waited.

"Sure," she offered a nonchalant shrug. "Sounds good. But only if I get to choose the place."

A smile lit up Adora's face. "Deal."

Adora gazed at her reflection in the body length mirror, turning slightly to take in all of her outfit. She wore a red button-down

shirt, the sleeves cuffed back to her elbows and a dark pair of slacks that clung to the shape of her legs. A matching belt, dark tie and dress shoes topped off the look. For a while Adora had considered adding her pair of suspenders that she rarely got to wear. But then she considered the implications of taking them off again and had ultimately decided against them. Two partially drunk women would not be able to get them off quickly enough for the mood *not* to be killed.

Not that Adora wanted to *assume* where the night might lead. But… Just in case…

She tied her hair up in her usual ponytail, leaving it slightly looser than normal just as Glimmer knocked on the bedroom door. She'd been preparing in the bathroom, going the full ten yards with makeup as well as an outfit.

"You ready?

Smoothing her shirt one last time, Adora opened the door, trying —and failing—to stop her jaw from dropping as she took in Glimmer. She wore a black gossamer shirt that hung loose over a thin red tank top beneath. A matching red and black pleated skirt was layered over a (fashionably?) ripped pair of tights.

"You look—," Adora paused, searching for the most appropriate word that wouldn't be crossing to many lines. Glimmer watched her struggle for a moment with a smug grin, one penciled brow raised in amusement.

"Thank you," she interrupted when Adora couldn't seem to choose one. "'You look' too."

Adora chuckled nervously, a hot blush coloring her cheeks and then the two were out the door, heading downtown I search of a bar Glimmer had already decided on.

The place was relatively busy, by the time they arrived around 8:30 pm, but Glimmer was quick to assure Adora that the rowdy crowd would arrive soon enough. Adora stuck close to Glimmer's

side as they made their way towards the bar top. She'd been to plenty of these places with Catra, but it still made her nervous and uncomfortable. These environments really weren't her scene. Glimmer, on the other hand was practically glowing. Eyes bright and wide and excited as they took their seats. And Adora would do anything to see that look on her face more often. So she stuffed down her anxiety and took a sip of the first shots Glimmer ordered them.

Fireball whiskey.

It was a strong start and burned going down Adora's throat. She grimaced, shaking her head to clear the ringing in her ears.

Glimmer laughed. "You okay?"

"Yeah," Adora coughed unconvincingly. "—I just—Haven't had something this strong in a while."

"Mmm, we both know that's a lie," Glimmer murmured, eyes half-lidded as she leaned towards Adora, one palm pressed against her thigh. "It hasn't been *that* long since a bottle of vodka convinced you to suck on my tits in the middle of the living room."

Adora's eyes shot wide open, choking on her response this time, not the alcohol as a rush of blood shot immediately to her face and core. Her skin was suddenly very warm beneath Glimmer's hand.

"*Glimmer.*"

Glimmer's teasing smirk widened, but she backed away and waved to the bartender again, this time ordering them something new. Adora didn't really pay attention to what, her mind still spinning with the blatant flirtation. Was that against the rules? She sincerely couldn't remember.

This time she downed whatever shot Glimmer passed her way, choking a little less as the bartender chuckled at her.

“Doing alright over there, hot stuff?”

Adora’s face lit up in flames again, but not because of the nickname. This flirt felt more like a challenge and the woman giving it was truly intimidating. She was large with deep bronzed skin, amber eyes, and waves of sleek black hair. Oh, and did Adora mention she was large? Because she was huge. Taller than her, massive shoulders, and arms that almost popped through the black work uniform.

Adora gave her a feeble thumbs up.

“This your friend’s first time?” The woman teasingly asked Glimmer as she sipped more slowly at her third shot.

Glimmer glanced at Adora out of the corner of her eye and then smiled up at the bartender. “Unfortunately. My friend doesn’t get out much.”

Adora balked, thoughts already a little sluggish due to the alcohol, but yeah—she was pretty sure Glimmer had just called her a ‘friend’. And she was also pretty sure she was now leaning towards the bartender, exposing more than enough cleavage through her flimsy shirt. And yeah—*she was pretty sure*—Glimmer was definitely flirting with the bartender in front of her.

But that was fine! Adora quickly snapped at herself. They *were* friends. This was part of the rules. This was allowed…. Even though it felt a little weird after their whole heart-to-heart regarding Catra this morning.

“Name’s Rue,” the large woman said suddenly as she gave Glimmer a wink. “Are you interested in something a little fancier?” Adora noticed she was leaning just as close over her own side of the bar. “It’s on me.”

Glimmer let out a simpering giggle that made Adora want to punch a hole through the solid bar top. The bartender apparently took that as an invitation because she winked and began mixing a

drink, throwing the mixer over her head at one point, which Adora found entirely unnecessary.

She poured the drink out and pushed it politely towards Glimmer who took a sip, eyebrows bouncing with approval.

"A Sex on the Beach?"

The woman, Rue, answered her with another wink. Adora almost threw up.

"Anything for you, Hot Shot?" Rue asked Adora in a much gruffer tone.

In any other scenario, Adora would have said no. She didn't enjoy drinking in the slightest. But Rue was giving her a superior smirk, and Glimmer was still giving the bartender eyes, and Adora wasn't about to let the challenge hang in the air unanswered.

"Sure," she tried for a nonchalant shrug. "Something hard… And bitter."

Finally, Glimmer tore her eyes away from the bartender to stare in shock at Adora instead. Rue was grinning now; the game was on—and Adora knew she was well underprepared. But she wasn't going to back down now.

Rue went to work mixing a few liquors from different bottles and shaking it all together with another flip. She poured the drink out in front of Adora and leaned forward, propping her chin in her hand as she waited for her to sip.

"Hard enough for you?"

Adora licked her lips, the bitter scent already burning her nostrils as she raised the glass. Glimmer looked genuinely nervous, until Rue sent a coy smile her way and she grinned back and Adora furiously shot back the drink. It was disgusting and it burned and the coughing fit that ensues was enough proof of that.

Rue chuckled to herself, straightening and taking the glass away from Adora. “It’s alright, Blondie. Sometimes we all bite off a little more than we can chew to impress a beautiful woman.”

Adora glowered, pushing up her sleeves to—what? She wasn’t sure… Fight this much larger women, she guessed. But then Glimmer was leaning over again, fingers tracing the inseam of her pants.

“You’re really cute when you get all competitive,” she murmured, her lips briefly brushing Adora’s jaw.

After a minor stroke, Adora processed the compliment(?) and it called clicked. Glimmer was, for all intents and purposes, pregaming what Adora had suspected might happen by the end of the night. Working both of them up for what she knew would be an explosive encounter later.

Once she understood, the coy looks became a bit more appealing. Suddenly it didn’t matter so much that Glimmer giggled when Rue said something dumb, or batted her eyelashes, or flushed at every wink and smirk. She’d be going home with Adora tonight. They both knew that. It was a game Adora wasn’t really used to playing, but once she understood the basics, it was easier to go along with.

Still slightly confusing though….

But when Glimmer’s hand was busy trailing up her thigh underneath the bar top as she flirted shamelessly with Rue, it was hard to really care. Not when it was Adora’s name they both knew she’d be moaning tonight.

Adora hadn’t bothered to count her drinks, just struggling to keep up with Glimmer and silently battle Rue’s superior glances. But she was pretty sure she was drunk now. Glimmer definitely was. She wasn’t so focused on the bartender anymore, who had gone to assist other guests anyway now that the late-night crowds had started to trickle in. Instead, Glimmer was now fully zeroed in on

Adora, focusing every bit of flirtatious energy she had stored inside of her on the blonde.

They sat in barstools, but Glimmer was somehow already halfway in Adora's lap, leaning against her as she sipped slowly at her most recent drink. Adora found herself mesmerized by the way her lips curled around the straw.

"Wanna know a secret?" Glimmer asked suddenly, setting the drink down a little too hard, it banged loudly against the bar top.

Adora nodded, rolling her shoulder back slightly as Glimmer leaned into her, lips once again brushing the line of her jaw.

"This," she said, picking at the hem of her red skirt. "I'm not wearing anything underneath it…"

Glimmer's words hung in the air, a seductive echo as Adora tried to process what she meant. Suddenly, it clicked in her drunken state of mind.

"Did you forget your underwear?"

Glimmer's eyebrows pinched together, her lips pursing as if she were confused by the question. "No?"

Adora blinked back at her trying to puzzle together why she didn't have any underwear on if she hadn't forgotten it. Until finally, Glimmer rolled her eyes and gripped Adora's tie, tugging her close enough to kiss—but she didn't, which made Drunk Adora really sad.

"I'm not wearing anything because I want you to fuck me, Adora."

It clicked and Adora's brain shut down. She sat back slowly, her tie slipping through Glimmer's fingers. They'd brought Adora's truck to the bar tonight, but with this new revelation, there was *no way* Adora was waiting until they were sober enough to drive back on their own. She very much wanted to be home now.

Adora managed to pull her phone out of her back pocket, nearly dropping it only three times as she searched for her Uber app. Glimmer was watching her with a hazy look in those lavender eyes and it was making it *very* difficult for Adora to focus. Meaning she scrolled through her entire phone screen at least six times, unable to read the names of her apps, they had all turned to gibberish.

Sucking up any remaining pride she might have had, Adora waved Rue over, holding up her phone. "Can you call us an Uber?"

Rue cocked a brow and then smiled almost fondly, carefully taking Adora's phone. "You two taking off?"

"Yes," Adora nodded harshly. "We have to get home. It's very important."

Glimmer giggled in agreement, leaning into Adora again as Rue handed the phone back.

"Alright, Blondie. Your rides on the way. Let me get you two some waters for the road."

Rue stepped away and Adora turned to Glimmer, her mind starting to clear just enough for her to whisper against the shell of Glimmer's ear. "You want my strap tonight, baby?"

The nickname slipped out—another rule broken—but Glimmer didn't seem to notice or care because she suddenly stiffened, one hand tightening on Adora's thigh.

"Um…," for once, she seemed at a loss for words. "When was that Uber getting here?"

Smirking, victorious, forgetting all about the jealousy at the beginning of the night, Adora left some money for their bill on the bar and took Glimmer's hand, leading her out of the bar without waiting for their waters.

The ride home was agonizing. Glimmer's teases were tortuous. As the driver chatted away about her night carting a bunch of rowdy teens around, Glimmer teased her fingers up Adora's thigh, always ghosting—but never touching—right where she needed it. The fire was raging. Adora sat glaring out the uber window, jaw clenched and knuckles white in concentration. She couldn't count how many times her tenuous self-control almost snapped. Somehow she managed. But by the time they'd made it to the apartment and locked the door, Adora had Glimmer pinned to the wall.

She kissed her fiercely, ignoring the tiny squeak of surprise Glimmer gave and molding their bodies together. Her hands found the hem of Glimmer's skirt, hiking it up around her hips and immediately thrusting a thigh between her own. Glimmer didn't waste any time either, bucking gently against Adora's thigh, the heat searing even through two layers of fabric. Adora's hands slip up, wandering, almost ravenous, gripping Glimmer's hips and then her breasts. She kneaded harshly, attempting to twist the piercings through the fabric of her top.

Glimmer moaned and the kiss grew sloppy, until Adora tore away, moving to her neck instead. This spot had proven to be an effective one whenever she was actually given the chance to tease. Particularly, the soft juncture just below her ear. Adora nipped at the spot, teasing the skin with her tongue and Glimmer's entire body shuddered, sinking against her. Arms wrapped tightly around her shoulders, fingers digging into her skin and then Glimmer was grinding more intently against the thigh.

Adora removed it, earning a disappointed groan. Without a word, she dropped to her knees, pushing away the skirt and tugging at the hem of Glimmer's tights. There was a ripping sound, that neither of the seemed to care about, and then the tights were halfway down Glimmer's thighs and Adora's tongue found her heat. A soft thunk sounded as Glimmer arched, her head hitting the wall. Adora kept a firm grip on her shaking thighs as she lapped at the slick warm folds, avoiding touching her straining nub just yet.

Glimmer moaned her name and Adora smirked as her hands tangled in blonde hair tugging her closer. Adora obliged, shuffling forward on her knees and finally circling Glimmer's clit with her tongue. Glimmer buckled, her knees shaking and Adora had to act quickly to hold her up. She teased harder, sucking and swirling her tongue and Glimmer came in a sudden rush, her slick coating Adora's chin. She cried out and slid down the wall, coming to rest in front of Adora.

The blonde didn't waste any time, she pressed their lips together again, and Glimmer gripped her face—whimpering softly at the taste of herself on Adora's tongue. Adora pulled away after a moment, just far enough to whisper, "I'm not done with you yet."

She hoisted Glimmer into her arms easily, carrying her to the bedroom and placing her on the sheets. Glimmer watched her with a hazy smile as she stripped of her shoes and pants. She'd just reached for her tie when Glimmer sat up and grabbed it for her, tugging her back down into another smoldering kiss. Briefly, it occurred to Adora that they were really abusing the 'foreplay only' kissing rule, but then Glimmer's tongue slipped into her mouth and she didn't really fucking care anymore.

"I need to take this off," she mumbled against Glimmer's lips, gasping when her grip on the tie only tightened. There was something uniquely *hot* about the physical control Glimmer had on her right now.

"So take it off," Glimmer shot back even as she lay back down against the pillows, pulling Adora over her. "No one's stopping you."

Understanding the game now, Adora took her hands away from the tie, pinning them above her head with just a hint more pressure than either were used to. Glimmer squirmed beneath her, eyes glowing in the moonlight, lip caught between her teeth as tension crackled between them.

“Don’t move,” Adora ordered in a low growl, slowly letting go and surprised to see Glimmer obey. She stood up, stripping off the rest of her clothes and gathering the strap from the top drawer of her dresser. She made sure to prepare it before donning the harness and crawling back to join her partner on the bed. Glimmer had remained in the same position and Adora took advantage of her brief compliance to help her remove the rest of her clothes. She dipped down once Glimmer’s breasts were exposed, taking one soft dark nipple into her mouth and teasing the metal barbell until it grew hard under her tongue. Glimmer sighed and gasped and twitched as Adora teased her breasts, her fingers tightening in the blonde’s hair with each swipe of her tongue.

Finally, satisfied that her partner was more than ready for her now, Adora flipped Glimmer onto her stomach. It wasn’t the position she preferred, but out of all the rules Adora tried to break daily, she knew this was one Glimmer wouldn’t budge on. She didn’t seem to want to have to look Adora in the eyes. Pushing the thoughts away, Adora crawled over her, pressing the strap against the curve of her ass and rocking a few times to tease her.

Glimmer’s frustrated groan was reward enough. Neglecting to delay what they both wanted any longer, Adora lined the toy up at Glimmer’s entrance and slowly pushed in, pausing once she’d fully hilted. Her arms shook as she snapped her hips back and thrust forward again, hard. Glimmer’s moan was beautiful. It filled her ears and clouded her mind until the only thing that mattered was drawing more of those sounds from her. She kept up a powerful and fast pace for a few moments until something snapped inside of her.

Sitting back on her heels, Adora used all of the strength remaining in her shaking arms to hoist Glimmer back onto her lap and then began thrusting up in earnest again. Glimmer choked out a shocked gasp that quickly turned into another strangled moan. She arched back against Adora as the blonde’s hands came up to tease her stomach and chest, tweaking her nipples again.

“A-Ad-or—,” she couldn’t finish Adora’s name, simply trailing off into a low moan and Adora pumped her hips harder.

Face now buried against Glimmer’s neck, Adora took the opportunity to kiss. But she gentled them, merely brushing her lips across the tender skin. The touch must have been too starkly adoring for Glimmer because she turned her head away and tapped Adora’s thigh.

“Ad—ora. K—knock it off.”

“Make me, Princess,” Adora growled in response. Where the defiance came from, she wasn’t sure. But she continued to press (harsher) kisses and bites to Glimmer’s neck and shoulder. Glimmer gave up trying to stop her as her body became taught, her orgasm building like a wave about to crash against the shore. In one moment she opened her mouth, a squeak of what might have been words coming out, and then she practically exploded. She arched back against Adora hard, her body trembling so fiercely that she almost lifted off the strap. Gripping her hips, Adora pulled her back down harshly, prolonging her orgasm with a few gentler thrusts. The pressure on Adora’s clit and the sight of Glimmer arching in the moonlight had her following with her own orgasm moments later.

Finally, Glimmer went slack, her voice returning in a low moan and she slumped forward onto the bed, burying her face in the pillows. Adora collapsed beside her, blinking to clear her hazy mind and calm her racing heart. It only occurred to her how rough she’d unintentionally been when she saw the bite marks on Glimmer’s shoulder. Instantly, the pleasurable warmth that filled her body turned to an icy chill. She reached out, brushing her fingers over the red marks.

“Shit, Glim. Are you okay? I didn’t’ mean to—,” she asked, inching closer in an attempt to comfort if Glimmer needed it. Her roommate, however, didn’t seem bothered at all. She just nodded, face still hidden in the pillows as she worked to regulate her breathing.

Adora didn't push it, she didn't get closer either, although guilt was swallowing her whole. She *really* hated this no cuddling rule. She wanted to do *something*. She'd been unintentionally harsh with Glimmer thanks to the extreme buildup of the night. But now, in the afterglow, all she felt was soft warmth. She wanted to wrap herself around Glimmer and fall asleep tangled up in her warmth.

Biting her lip, knowing Glimmer would never allow it, Adora shuffled just a bit closer, carefully placing one hand on her shoulders and beginning to rub the tension away. Glimmer didn't bother to stop her, merely sinking further into the mattress under Adora's touch. She brushed her fingers tenderly over the bite marks, massaging Glimmer's muscles until the other woman was snoring softly beside her.

A small smile tugged at Adora's lips as she stroked that same tender hand down Glimmer's back. Daring to push her boundaries, she inched closer and closer until finally she was pressed against the curve of Glimmer's side, one arm looped around her waist.

She waited for Glimmer to wake, holding her breath—but it never happened. Finally, Adora closed her eyes, a smile still gracing her lips as Glimmer's warmth lulled her to sleep.

Adora was a light sleeper. She always had been. Back then, when she lived with Mrs. Weaver, for necessity. But even know, she struggled not to wake at the slightest provocation. So, when a thunderstorm picked up not long after she and Glimmer had settled in for the night, she was already awake when the panic started.

She'd been staring at the wall, squinting through the dark in a fruitless struggle to fall back asleep when the room lit up in a flash of lightning. A few delayed seconds later thunder boomed. It was so loud it shook the room. Adora was startled, but more than used to violent thunderstorms in Bright Moon. They happened

frequently enough for her to know that the slosh of rain and shake of thunder would pass eventually.

Another enormous boom filled the air and Adora heard an odd screech of metal outside, perhaps a rain gutter collapsing. In the next instant her previously sleeping roommate, scrambled out of her arms and out of bed screaming. Adora shot up, peering through the darkness for Glimmer just as another flash of lightning filled the room. She saw her roommate crouched in the corner of the room, curled into a tight trembling ball.

Throwing the covers off, Adora leapt out of bed, fear constricting her chest as she turned on the lights and processed the full sight of Glimmer. She was still naked from their earlier activities, arms wrapped so tightly around herself that her knuckles were turning white, fingers biting into her skin.

"Glimmer?" Carefully, Adora knelt in front of her, deciding not to put a hand on her when she noticed how badly she was trembling. Her entire body would go slack and then suddenly as taught as a wire, shaking so fiercely that her teeth chattered. There was a faraway and wild look in her hazy eyes. She was looking at Adora, but also seemed to see right through her.

"Glimmer?" Adora tried again to reach her verbally but was nearly drowned out by another thunder clap. "Are you okay? Can you hear me?"

Glimmer's eyes widened, her chest starting to heave and for a moment Adora thought she was choking, she gripped at her throat like she couldn't breathe. Terrified now, wondering if she should call for an ambulance, but reluctant to leave Glimmer's side, Adora pressed her hands firmly down onto Glimmer's shoulders trying to ground her.

"Glimmer, look at me, please. Try to look at me. It's okay, it's just a storm. It's just thunder."

It was clear to Adora now, that for some reason, Glimmer was in the midst of a full-blown panic attack. It only worsened with Adora's words however, and Glimmer began mumbling something like she felt like she was going to die. Or have a heart attack or both. The words didn't completely make sense, as if even she didn't know what she was saying. Her skin was clammy and hot beneath Adora's hands as she rubbed them fiercely up and down her arms.

Adora knew as terrifying as it was to see Glimmer like this, that she needed to remain calm and focused. The most important thing was to slow her breathing, or else she really might pass out. Carefully, she took Glimmer's face in her hands, meeting her unfocused gaze.

"Glim, I want you to try to breathe with me, okay? Just follow my lead. Okay? On three, we're gonna breathe in. Ready?" Adora wasn't sure anything was getting through, but Glimmer's eyes flickered once in response so she figured she might as well try. On the count of three she inhaled deeply and slowly, holding it for a second seconds before exhaling just as measuredly. Glimmer's rapid breaths did not stop. But Adora didn't give up. She kept her eyes on Glimmer's, hands holding her as tightly as she dared, and tried again. And then again. Prodding her verbally every now and then to focus and look at her and breathe. And finally, after the fifth breath taken alone, Glimmer joined it. Her first attempt was jittery and she couldn't hold it as long as Adora, but the next breath was better. And then the one after that improved as well. Soon enough her eyes had cleared, now fully focused on Adora's and her breathing had regulated.

She'd stopped shaking for the most part, but still held herself tightly. Lightning flashed again and Glimmer suddenly looked very exhausted, her body sagging against the wall. Quickly, Adora got up and snagged a sheet off the bed before re-approaching Glimmer.

"Can I hold you?" Adora asked, holding the blanket out as an offer. Glimmer just nodded silently and Adora sat down, pulling

forward, gently enveloping her body in a solid embrace, the blanket draped over both of them. Glimmer melted into her seconds later and then she jerked again as she tears came. She cried into Adora's shoulder; arms wrapped weakly around the blonde's waist.

"It's okay," Adora murmured into her hair, still not entirely sure what had triggered the attack. They both tensed as another boom shook the apartment. "You're okay. You're here with me. Everything's alright, Glim."

They sat there for a long time, Adora gently rocking them, or stroking Glimmer's still overheated skin until finally, the storm passed, and the room fell silent. Glimmer's tears dried, or maybe she'd run out of them, as dawn eventually broke. And still, neither of them moved. Adora's back was beginning to scream in protest when Glimmer suddenly sniffed and mumbled in a thick voice, "I had a dream about my dad."

Adora felt her heart constrict in her chest. She didn't push, waiting silently to see if Glimmer would continue. But she didn't need to. The panic made sense now. The storm had probably sounded like the inside of their car as it had broken apart around them during the terrible crash.

"And when I woke up," Glimmer paused, swallowing thickly. "I could still hear it all and see it. It was like I hadn't even woken up at all."

Adora didn't know what to say. How could she possibly say anything that would comfort Glimmer and pull her out of those awful memories? Still, she tried. "Everything's okay now. I promise. I'm here."

Glimmer nodded but didn't speak anymore, choosing to hide her face in Adora's shoulder once more as the bright morning sun spilled in through the window.

It occurred to Adora then just how deeply her friend's trauma ran. There was no way she'd ever spoken to anyone about it or gotten help for it either. It was festering inside of her, eating away at her. Even now, years later, leaving her a shaking shell in Adora's arms. The last thing Adora wanted to do was push Glimmer away, but tonight had made it clear that she needed help.

Help that Adora would do anything to give her.

Glimmer hadn't felt this truly happy in a long time. Or maybe happy wasn't the right word, maybe it was more akin to peace or contentment. There were issues and struggles and drama with Adora. Sure. But—She figured that not wanting to die every day that she woke up was a good start.

Of course, it had to come crumbling down when she received two messages from ghosts of her past the day after her panic attack.

The first was from Mermista.

It almost shocked Glimmer to realize she hadn't spoken to, let alone really thought of her ex, in almost two months. No doubt due to her relationship to Adora. Still, all it took was a single stupid text to bring it all flooding back.

-'hey Seahawk said he saw you at the shop ;-)'

Glimmer shouldn't have replied. She should have been smart and ignored her. Or blocked the number. Or anything other than engage. But she did anyway, because she was alone in the apartment and Adora was about 85% of her self-control at this point.

-'that was like 3 weeks ago'

-'yeah well he's stupid lol. Also hi'

Glimmer stared at her keyboard, biting her lip as the memories flooded back. It hadn't been all bad with Mermista, right? They'd

both had an equally shitty outlook on the world. They'd loved each other. Or whatever.

She cheated on you.

-'hi'

Mermista's typing bubble disappeared a few times and Glimmer hated that she held her phone with a white knuckled grip as she waited.

-'so we were wondering if u were interested in a ménage-a-trois? U can bring the tall blonde too if you want'

Glimmer's heart sunk. She should have known. No apology, no how are you, no nothing. An offer for sex, for a fling. She'd never meant anything to Mermista. She'd never meant anything to anyone. Before she could even *think* or a reply that would convey her disgust and hurt, she received a phone call. The caller I.D. displayed the one word she didn't want to have anything to do with right now.

'Mom'

Setting her phone down, Glimmer curled into a ball on the couch, waiting until her phone stopped buzzing and the room went silent. She hadn't spoken to her mother since she'd moved out of Mermista's place. And even then, they'd hardly spoken before that. She didn't think she'd ever even told Angella Mermista's name. And they'd been together for a year.

Of course, it was just her fucking luck that both ghosts would come back to haunt her the day after she felt like maybe things were looking up.

Her phone started buzzing again.

Chancing a glance, Glimmer saw her mother's I.D. again. She wouldn't stop. She'd keep calling or texting until Glimmer answered. But she was not in the mood for the inevitable reaming

today. Picking up her phone, Glimmer didn't even wait for the ringing to stop before she turned it off and shoved it in the coffee table drawer.

"Not today, Mom," she grumbled, flopping back on the couch.

It was at that moment that the door opened and Adora returned from work. She tossed her gym bag away, grinning as Glimmer peered up at her and reached an arm out, a silent gesture for 'c'mere, I need you'. She grabbed Glimmer's hand and plopped down next to her on the couch. Glimmer saw blue eyes flicker to her lips more than once, but to her credit, Adora did not dive in for a kiss, instead playing casually with Glimmer's fingers as they sat together. It was probably a much more intimate gesture in hindsight, Glimmer realized, but she didn't question it then.

"Hi," Adora beamed at her, the smile already taking away some of the sorrow that was threatening to swallow Glimmer.

"Hi," she chuckled, propping her legs up on Adora's thighs. "How was work?"

"It was good! Lonnie said that—," Adora's phone rang suddenly and she paused, rummaging around in her pocket for a few seconds before pulling it out and studying the screen.

Her eyes suddenly lit up and she beamed, raising the phone to her ear before Glimmer could even question who it was.

She should have known though.

"Hi, Mrs. Sato!" Adora shot Glimmer a grin and mouthed 'it's your mom'. As if that wasn't already clear.

Glimmer collapsed inward on herself, Adora's voice turning into a muffled echo in her ears. If Angella Sato was one thing, it was stubborn.

Unfortunately, Glimmer was much the same. And she knew now, it was only a matter of time before it all came to an ugly head.

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

So season 5 sure was a thing... Anyway, back to this AU

Summation: Glimmer takes Mermista up on her offer...sort of. Him Bow? HImbo. Angella comes over for the worst dinner in all of history and Adora realizes Glimmer needs more help than she can offer if they're going to make this whole 'friendship' thing work.

Warning: This chapter contains a TW for dubious/questionable consent.

Mermista's apartment didn't look that different from what Glimmer remembered of it. Maybe a few less beer bottles and pizza boxes lying around. But the couch still bore the same dolphin patterned fuzzy blanket and matching sea blue pillows. The tv stand still had a noticeable crack in it. The shelves of movies that Mermista collected were still arranged alphabetically and by genre.

It was strange to notice all these little, intimate things. The things that had become common place back when she and Mermista were together. Odd that these were the ones that stuck so fiercely in her memory.

A cold chill ran through Glimmer as she heard the door click shut behind them. She'd only agreed to meet Mermista here to 'talk things out'. But the somewhat disturbing lingering offer of a threesome still hung in the air. Glimmer was reminded of it when Mermista offered her a drink.

"Thirsty? Seahawk bought Ginger Ale of all things yesterday. Diet. Ugh, *why*?" She rummaged around in the fridge as Glimmer stood with her arms wrapped around herself in the living room. "Otherwise… We have, like… Water. I guess."

“I’m good,” Glimmer insisted, perching anxiously on the edge of the couch. Mermista shrugged and grabbed herself a glass of water before joining Glimmer, sitting far enough away that it wasn’t uncomfortable, but somehow still close enough to make Glimmer squirm.

“So…,” she drawled, and Glimmer noticed her toying with a thread on her jeans. “You wanted to talk?”

“I felt like we should,” Glimmer replied, easing back onto the couch, forcing herself to relax. “You texting me out of the blue and—offering… Whatever that was… Kind of nuts.”

Mermista shrugged one shoulder. “I guess.”

Narrowing her eyes, Glimmer tried to read the woman she thought she’d known so well at one point. But Mermista would not meet her eyes.

“Why did you text me in the first place?” she prodded when the silence stretched.

“Threesome.”

“Mermista.”

Rolling her eyes, Mermista finally looked up, throwing her arms out in surrender. “I don’t know! I missed—talking to you, I guess. Seahawk said he’d seen you and I wanted to—check in?”

Glimmer blinked, trying to process Mermista’s confession with the fact that this woman had: “You cheated on me!”

“Glimmer,” Mermista’s quiet sigh only made her angrier.

“You did!”

“It was a drunken accident,” Mermista shot back, anger suddenly rising. “But you wouldn’t even talk to me about it.”

“So it’s my fault?” Glimmer crossed her arms over her chest. “You being wasted doesn’t excuse anything!”

“It doesn’t,” Mermista agreed as she rubbed her hands over her face. “But you wouldn’t even let me *try* to explain myself or even apologize! I thought you were done with me anyway... Like, a long time ago.”

“What?” Glimmer’s heart sunk as Mermista’s expression turned somber. “What do you mean?”

Her ex looked away, biting her lip. “I mean we didn’t even talk to each other anymore, Glimmer. We lived in the same place and barely saw each other. And when we did hang out, it felt like all we did was fuck. There was nothing to ‘us’ anymore. And any time I tried to reach out to you, I got shut down. I couldn’t help you and it was driving me crazy. I didn’t know what to do. I thought you hated me.”

Shame and guilt flooded through Glimmer at the realization that her break up with Mermista had largely been due to her own behavior. It was true, the final few months before the ‘incident’ Glimmer had been struggling more often than not with a deep unshakeable sadness. The drinking had gotten a lot more frequent, the smoking too. But Mermista had always joined her in that. A spark of anger quickly rose to join the slew of other emotions. That still hadn’t given the Mermista the right to cheat on her.

“Well… If you wanted to break up with me, you should have just done it! Instead of totally betraying my trust,” Glimmer shot back, the fury overtaking any potential apology.

“I *didn’t* want to break up with you,” Mermista insisted and suddenly one of her hands was resting comfortingly on Glimmer’s thigh. “I was just upset and lost. And that doesn’t excuse what I did. But—I don’t know, Glimmer. I’m sorry.” She paused. “I’m sorry it fell apart the way it did. I really am.”

Glimmer looked down at the hand on her thigh, the warmth and weight too familiar. Lavender eyes flickered up into soft brown and before Glimmer could even try to fight the emotions running through her, she'd pressed her lips to Mermista's. The kiss was brief, Mermista's hand tightening on her thigh before she pulled away, her expression almost pitying. Glimmer hated it.

"We shouldn't," she murmured, hand slipping away.

Glimmer nodded, blinking back the angry stinging tears. She didn't know why she'd leaned in. Maybe the realization that Mermista had still loved her—that *she'd* been the one responsible for destroying a perfectly salvageable relationship. Maybe for the briefest of moments, she'd wanted it to work again.

"I'm sorry," she murmured finally as tears slipped down her cheeks.

"Don't be," Mermista's voice was uncharacteristically soft. "I shouldn't have texted you like that. I just—I didn't know how to reach out so that maybe we could at least be on speaking terms or something. I'm an idiot."

Glimmer shook her head, rubbing away the embarrassing tears with the heel of her palm. "You're not an idiot. A little blunt maybe. But if anyone here is the idiot, it's me."

There was silence for a while as both tried to figure out what to say next. Finally, Mermista offered a timid smile and asked, "So… That girl you were with? Are you—I mean did you find someone —,"

"She's just my roommate," Glimmer interrupted, voice dull.

"Oh." Mermista paused to toy with the hem of the dolphin blanket. "Cuz, the way Seahawk talked about her made it sound like she was pretty into you."

Glimmer let out a wry chuckle, sniffing away the last of her tears. "She's not."

Mermista chewed her bottom lip in thought for a moment before speaking again. "Glimmer? Maybe… This time… Don't push away the people who care about you, okay? If she's just your roommate, fine. But please, let *someone* in."

Unwilling to argue any further, Glimmer just nodded, giving in to the overwhelming grief of this entire stupid conversation.

She didn't stay much longer. Mermista offered to drive her home, but Glimmer didn't think she could stand to be around her ex much longer. She took an uber instead, arriving at an empty apartment and laying down on the couch to mourn. Her mind spun with memories, with newfound guilt and… regret.

She wrapped her arms around herself, curling into a ball and letting the tears fall. That was how Adora found her an hour later, upon returning from work. Glimmer didn't even have a chance to pretend she was okay before Adora had joined her on the couch and pulled her into her strong arms.

Adora held her silently, which Glimmer very much appreciated. She didn't ask the reason for Glimmer's tears or push her to speak. Instead, she just held Glimmer close, stroking her arms and pressing reassuring kisses to the top of her head. The warmth and sense of security was immediately calming. Glimmer allowed herself to let go, to sink into Adora's embrace and *feel*. She nuzzled her cheek against the blonde's shoulder, nosing into her neck to breathe her in. Even Adora's scent was calming. It was familiar and warm.

Glimmer didn't tell her why she was crying. There was no way she could explain she was breaking over her shattered relationship with her ex. She hadn't even told Adora she was going to go see her. Luckily, it seemed Adora didn't need to know to want to comfort her.

Finally, after what seemed like ages, Glimmer heaved a shaky sigh as her tears began to dissipate.

"You okay?" Adora's question was murmured into her hair as she continued rubbing comforting hands up and down Glimmer's back.

"I will be," Glimmer whimpered in reply; knowing, despite the pain, that it was true.

Despite her better judgement, Glimmer acquiesced to meeting up with Bow the following day. She needed to talk to *someone* about her meeting with Mermista, even if she knew exactly what Bow's reaction would be.

'Glimmer you told me you blocked her number! What were you thinking? Did you two do anything?'

God, sometimes the Bow in her head sounded so much like Angella it was gross. The Uber she'd ordered pulled up to the address Bow had given her. Apparently sometime in the last couple of weeks Bow had managed to move out of his Dads' place. It filled Glimmer with guilt to realize she'd been missing big milestones in her best friend's life thanks to her current disastrous situation with Adora, Catra and now Mermista.

It was a tiny apartment complex, very similar to Adora's in layout and Glimmer found her way to Bow's first floor apartment easily. The door swung open on the first knock and Bow immediately tugged Glimmer into his arms.

"Bow," she choked, patting his back lightly in return as he squeezed her further. "You're crushing me."

"Sorry," he loosened his grip only slightly, holding her by the shoulders at arms-length to study her. "I just had a feeling you could use a best friend hug."

Glimmer almost burst into tears on the spot.

"Come on." Bow's brow crinkled with concern as he pulled her inside. "Come in, let's talk. I can tell you need to. Your face is all scrunchy."

“So is yours,” Glimmer pointed out as Bow sat her on a small couch in the living room and draped a blanket over her.

“This is my ‘concern for my best friend who is in a very messy and emotional situation right now’ face,” Bow plopped down beside her, placing a comforting hand on her thigh. “Do you want some therapeutic brownies? Adam should be done with them any minute.”

Glimmer couldn’t help but grimace at the memory of the last time she’d made brownies and almost killed Adora in the process. “I think I’m good actually. Wait, who the fuck is Adam?”

The wrinkle in Bow’s brow creased and he glanced down at his lap. “Uh, my boyfriend?”

Glimmer’s mouth popped open and she gaped for exactly three seconds before screeching, “YOUR *WHAT*? Since when?”

Flinching, Bow sighed and flopped back against the couch. “Since like a few weeks, Glimmer!”

“What??? Why didn’t you tell me?!”

“I tried!” Bow looked defeated. “But every time I reached out you left me on read, or ignored my calls, or were too busy talking about your drama with Adora for me to interrupt.”

A hot wave of guilt washed over Glimmer. First Adora. Then Mermista. Now Bow. It seemed the only thing she was good for was being a selfish needy bitch that ruined her own relationships.

“I’m—I’m sorry, Bow,” she murmured, staring down at her lap, unable to meet her best friend’s gaze. “I’ve treated you really badly lately. It’s just… It’s been a lot. And I know I got myself into this whole thing. But it’s turning into more than I expected and I’m not sure—What to do anymore. I’m sorry I’ve been abandoning you, Bow. That was shitty of me. I need you. And you’ve stuck with me all these years. If I lose you too now—,”

“Hey, you won’t ever lose me.” Bow’s smile was sad as he wrapped an arm around Glimmer’s shoulders. “I’m sorry too. I haven’t exactly been patient with you about this whole thing. I know it’s confusing and you need your best friend’s support.”

“You can’t apologize to me,” Glimmer sniffed, leaning into him. “I’m apologizing to you.”

“Well, my sorry is right and yours is wrong.”

Glimmer snorted with laughter at the exact same moment that a tall, burly blonde man with long blonde hair that he’d tied up into a messy bun stepped into the room. He was carrying a plate of admittedly delicious smelling brownies, a bright grin lighting up his chiseled face.

“Hey!” he called out in an exuberant tone that didn’t match the teary mood of the room. “Who’s hungry?”

Glimmer peered shyly over the back of the couch at the *very* tall man, while Bow waved him over, taking the brownie plate and setting it on the coffee table.

“Glimmer, this is Adam. Adam, this is my best friend, Glimmer.”

Adam’s smile widened and he reached out a large hand to shake. Glimmer took it, almost terrified when her tinier fingers were dwarfed in his.

“Nice to finally meet you, Glimmer,” he said. “Bow talks about you a lot.”

“He does?” Glimmer glanced at Bow who gave her a soft smile.

Adam nodded, brushing a lock of blonde hair out of his face in a gesture that reminded Glimmer oddly of Adora. “Only good things, don’t worry. Or… Mostly good anyway.”

“Babe,” Bow quickly interrupted. “Glimmer’s here for an impromptu best friend therapy sesh. Do you mind giving us the

room for a bit?”

“Oh! Yeah, sure. Of course.” Adam’s blue eyes widened with understanding and he nodded quickly again, leaning over the couch to press a quick kiss to Bow’s cheek before once again grinning at Glimmer and scurrying out of the room. Stuffing down the strange sense of jealousy she felt over Bow and Adam’s casual intimacy, Glimmer reached for one of the brownies she’d denied before and snuggled further into her blanket.

“So,” Bow turned back to Glimmer once Adam had disappeared down the hall. “You want to talk about Adora?”

Glimmer took her time chewing the brownie. “Um… No… Mermista.”

A single brow shot up and Bow’s jaw clenched, but he did not burst like she’d expected him to. His reply was calm. “Oh?”

Suddenly no longer hungry, Glimmer set the half eaten brown down in her lap, picking at it as she spoke. “I, uh, went to see her the other day… She texted me about a threesome.”

“Glimmer,” Bow’s sigh was heavy and sad.

“I didn’t do it!!” she quickly elaborated. “We just talked… She—It made me feel like shit, Bow. It was all might fault. What happened between us.”

Hot tears pricked the corners of her eyes.

“Glimmer, she *cheated* on you,” Bow debated.

“Because she thought I didn’t love her anymore!”

“That’s not an excuse.”

Glimmer shrugged sadly, staring down at the mushy brownie. Bow simply watched her in silence, waiting for her to continue.

Finally, she said, "I guess… I feel like, maybe I'm making the same mistake again. I missed Adora. A lot. I didn't realize it. And this…friends with benefits whatever, is fun. But I'm worried it's hurting her."

"And hurting you," Bow added, one hand drifting from the back of the couch to rest against her shoulder. Glimmer shook her head 'no' but Bow pressed on.

"Glimmer, I don't understand. Why don't you just make things official? Wouldn't that make these feelings less complicated? At least give it a shot?"

"I can't do that, Bow. That's not—Adora doesn't feel that way about me."

"Glimmer," Bow rubbed his forehead. "She is literally sleeping with you. She has to feel something."

"I'm not the only one," Glimmer mumbled, the brownie now moosh in her hands.

"What?"

"Catra."

Bow's brow wrinkled as he struggled to remember the name. Glimmer knew he'd connected the dots when his eyes popped wide open. "Catra? So, she *is* still in the picture?"

"Sort of," Glimmer shrugged Bow's hand away, the touch felt too hot now. "Or she was. She walked in on us. It was super fucking weird."

Bow grimaced. "Ew. Did you talk about it?"

"Yeah… I mean, we did. Yes. We… Worked it out, I think."

"So…," Bow didn't push for more details. "Why are you worried then? Do you think she still has feelings for Catra even with your

guys' 'agreement', or whatever?"

"No. Or, I dunno. I just think—," Glimmer trailed off. *I'm not enough for her.* "Why did I go and talk to Mermista, Bow? It did nothing but fuck up my peace of mind. I thought it would help! Closure or whatever, but it just made everything worse. And now I can't stop thinking about our time together and what we lost and it *sucks!"*

Finally, the tears came, and she leaned into Bow's arms, bursting into shaky sobs. Bow held her quietly, rocking her with a heavy sigh. He let her cry in silence for a while, which Glimmer appreciated when suddenly a new weight on the couch nearly startled her out of Bow's arms.

"Are you okay?"

Glimmer peered over her shoulder to see Adam had returned. He was worrying his hands in his lap, blue eyes round and anxious.

"I'm sorry, I didn't want to interrupt, I just heard crying and I—," Adam flushed, rubbing the back of his neck. "I should go."

"No, it's okay," Glimmer sniffed, rubbing her teary eyes with the blanket. "Crying's not gonna do me any good anyway. You can stay. I don't want you to be a prisoner in your own apartment."

The three sat in silence for a bit before Adam reached out and gently patted her shoulder with a large hand. Glimmer couldn't help but smile as she patted it with her own and leaned further into Bow; truly happy that her friend had found such a wonderful himbo to rail him daily.

By the time Glimmer got home, she found Adora on the phone, pacing nervous circles around the apartment. Her stomach dropped sickeningly for a brief moment as she imagined *who* it might be. And then Adora spoke and her stomach dropped even further.

“I’m really sorry, Mrs. Sato. No, I’m not sure why Glimmer hasn’t been reaching out to you…. No, ma’am. I would have told you she was staying here if I didn’t know that she hadn’t!” Adora glanced up even when Glimmer tried to quietly shut the front door and sneak away before she was spotted.

The blonde’s eyes lit up. “But she’s here—,”

Rapidly, Glimmer shook her head, waving her arms wildly to dissuade Adora from letting her mother know she was nearby. Adora paused, mouth hanging open as she struggled to simultaneously lie, while deciphering Glimmer’s hysterical sign language.

“Errrr…She’s uh… She’s busy.”

Slapping a hand to her face, Glimmer tried to make a motion for Adora to hang up. Apparently, it did not come across.

“Sleeping. She’s busy sleeping,” Adora continued, still staring at Glimmer through confused blue slits. “But as soon as she wakes up, I’ll have her call you, Mrs. Sato!”

Adora’s laugh was nervous, and then she cupped one hand over her phone, yell whispering to Glimmer, ‘come talk to your mother.’

She didn’t wait for Glimmer’s response, returning to the phone as Angella’s voice came through again. “What was that, Mrs. Sato? … Dinner?”

Glimmer shook her head again, waving her arms to regain Adora’s attention.

“Dinner at your house? Uhhhh,” Adora glanced at Glimmer again for confirmation. Glimmer waved her arms around the apartment in a futile attempt to convey how desperately she did not want to see her mother. Adora misunderstood.

“No?—I mean, yes, dinner would be great. But you should, uh,” she peered at Glimmer, “Come over here! We’d love to have you.”

Groaning, Glimmer collapsed back onto the couch, throwing an arm over her face in utter defeat and waiting until Adora finally hung up with her mother after a series of "yes, yup, uh huh, yes ma'am's". Afterwards, the blonde crept her way over to the couch, leaning over the back and peering down at Glimmer.

"Sooo…. Your mom's coming over for dinner tomorrow."

Glimmer let out a long groan. "*How* did she even get your number?"

"She said Bow gave it to her. She called him a couple weeks ago when she couldn't get a hold of you." Adora's brow wrinkled with concern. "Glim, why aren't you talking to your mom?"

Removing her arm/shield from her face, Glimmer glared back up at her concerned roommate. "Because, all she ever does is judge me. Judge my job, judge my living situation, judge my choices, my girlf—My friends. I don't want to deal with her right now. Or… Ever."

A quiet sigh made Glimmer's body run hot with guilt, and then Adora had crawled over the back of the couch and sat down beside her, lifting Glimmer's legs into her lap. "She's your *mom*. She's just worried about you. She loves you."

"Debatable."

"Glimmer."

Fuming quietly, Glimmer played mindlessly with a stray thread on one of the couch cushions, sinking further into the dark cloud that hovered over her. Angella was literally the *last* thing she wanted added to the mountain of emotional shit she was gathering.

"Glimmer, are you pouting about seeing your mother?" Adora's voice barely contained her laughter, as she cocked a curious brow.

"I'm not pouting," Glimmer pouted, brows furrowing. "…Can we have sex?"

Snorting, Adora shook her head and pushed Glimmer's legs off her lap, standing up before tugging Glimmer to her feet as well. It was a bit of an awkward struggle as Glimmer went dead weight and slid halfway off the couch before Adora used her far superior strength to pull and hold her up.

"You really think that will help right now?" Adora teased, although Glimmer noticed she still hadn't removed her arms from around her.

"Help?" Glimmer repeated, lowering her voice a bit in an attempt to shift the mood. "No, probably not. But it sure would make me *feel* better." She let one hand slide up Adora's chest to cup her cheek, rising on her tip toes, aiming for those soft lips…

To her credit, although her blue eyes darkened with desire, Adora turned her head at the last minute and Glimmer's kiss landed against her cheek instead.

"I think we should focus on getting this place cleaned up a bit for your mom. Then… Maybe later."

Rocking back on her heels, Glimmer resumed her pout as Adora chuckled and moved out of the embrace.

'This is going to be a disaster.'

Glimmer was still busy in the kitchen the next evening when a quiet knock on the door signaled that her mother had arrived. The day had been tense; Adora spent most of it cleaning and Glimmer spent most of it moping, only cooking at Adora's request when the blonde had given her such an earnest look she'd almost melted on the spot. They'd only paused once when Glimmer's anxiety reached a breaking point. She'd gone to try and calm her nerves in a steaming shower only to have a seemingly equally nervous Adora join her with the toy in hand and—

Well, here they were now, moments away from facing Angella and the nerves were back in full force.

It occurred to Glimmer that she hadn't actually *seen* her mother in nearly 6 months. They'd argued once over a brief visit home while she was still with Mermista. Glimmer remembered not even mentioning Mermista to her mother at the time though. Just that she was staying with a friend.

She hadn't wanted Angella's quiet judgement then.

Nor did she want it now. Turning off the stove, Glimmer tossed her apron aside and joined Adora who was scrambling for the front door. She paused just before opening it, straightening her blue button down and holding out her arms for Glimmer to examine her.

"Do I look okay?"

Rolling her eyes affectionately, Glimmer stepped forward and straightened Adora's collar, then using her thumb to smooth the wrinkle between Adora's brows. "Adora, my mom loves you. There is literally nothing you could do to *not* impress her tonight.

"Oh okay," Adora didn't sound convinced, but she turned to open the door and Glimmer was, finally, face to face with her mother.

She looked as prim and composed as always, her light hair tied up in a loose bun around sharp cheekbones. She wore a light lavender sundress, simple, but somehow more put together than either Glimmer or Adora. And Adora had actually put *effort* in.

"Hi, Mrs. Sato!" Adora's voice was a little too high. "It's so good to see you again. Come in! Everything's almost ready."

Angella's always stern expression softened as she thanked Adora and moved inside. "It's wonderful to see you as well, Adora."

Her lavender eyes fell to Glimmer, hardening—Glimmer felt herself tense in response.

"Hi, mom," she mumbled, refusing to close the distance between them.

“Glimmer.”

She was angry, that much was obvious from the way she clipped the end of Glimmer’s name. But Glimmer couldn’t really blame her. She’d basically dropped off the face of the map for over half a year. But dealing with her mother was hard enough, and life had only been getting harder recently. Glimmer opened her mouth to speak again… Maybe apologize or something? Why not try at this point. But then Angella had swept past her into the living room and was speaking to Adora once more.

“Your apartment is lovely, Adora.”

“Oh!” Adora snapped ramrod straight, practically sweating as Angella walked around the tiny space. “Thank you! It’s not that impressive… We just—We cleaned up today.”

Angella nodded, a subtle smile playing on her lips. “And everything smells wonderful. Did you cook?”

“Glimmer did!” Adora grabbed her shoulders and pulled Glimmer in front of her like a shield. “I can’t really cook anything. I manage to burn boiling water.”

Adora snort laughed awkwardly and Glimmer cringed as her mother moved closer to both of them, her hypercritical scowl returning.

“You cooked?” Angella’s tone hinted she must have been thinking of how often Glimmer had resorted to take out, or no food at all, after Micah passed away.

“Dad’s favorite,” Glimmer shot back.

Angella’s eyes flickered away briefly before returning to run up and down Glimmer. “Your hair is getting longer.”

It didn’t sound like a compliment if it was supposed to be. “Yeah?”

One of Angella's hands rose to stroke through the mess of spikes. For a moment, Glimmer almost leaned into the touch before catching herself.

"Is this a new 'style' or—,"

Recoiling, Glimmer clenched her jaw hard. "Yeah, it's called 'bedhead that I didn't bother to deal with this morning'."

Adora's wide blue eyes flickered nervously back and forth between the two women as a tense silence fell over all of them. Suddenly the oven timer beeped and Adora clapped her hands loudly.

"Dinner's ready! Let's eat!"

Dinner was going… as well as Adora could have hoped for. There was a constant thick layer of tension and discomfort at all times… But other than that!!

All three of them took a seat at Adora's tiny kitchen table as soon as the food was laid out. Save for Angella, who excused herself quickly to wash. Adora and Glimmer sat waiting in silence as the bathroom door closed. Adora stared mostly at her food, mouth watering--she was really hungry. Glimmer was tapping the edge of her plate with a fork absently, when suddenly it clanked loudly enough to grab Adora's attention. That and the swift kick Glimmer gave her underneath the table shocked her back into reality.

"Adora," she hissed, face red and eyes furious.

"What??" Adora's reply was just as sharp, but mostly out of pure confusion.

"Did you--," Glimmer made a strange gesture and then pointed towards the bathroom. Adora just blinked, at a loss for what she was trying to say. "Did you clean up--? In there--?"

Again, Adora stared, the gears in her brain audibly whirring as she struggled to keep up. It suddenly clicked when Glimmer made an

obscene hand gesture for fucking and Adora's eyes shot wide open because no she had *not* cleaned up. She'd been unwittingly distracted *by Glimmer* as she was cleaning up the toy in the bathroom… and she'd never gone back for it.

The *one* thing she hadn't cleaned today!

Oh my god, fuck no, shit, fuck oh my god …

Jolting up from her chair, Adora hurled herself at the bathroom door. She offered three quick knocks before clearing her throat and calling, "Um… Mrs. Sato… Is--Er, is everything alright in there?"

She heard Glimmer groan at the same time she heard the running sink shut off and then there was silence. Adora waited, her entire body a block of ice. Slowly, the bathroom door opened. Mrs. Sato tall frame blocked out any view Adora had of the counter, but the look on her face was enough. An odd combination of placid neutrality and barely contained rage.

She stepped past Adora, finally allowing her to see the rainbow dildo, still contained within the harness, lying exactly where she'd left it on the counter. Adora wanted to crawl into a hole and die. She leaned forward, head thunking against the door frame as Angella returned to the kitchen in silence.

She stood almost rigidly in front of Glimmer, who looked like she might combust into flames at any moment, and finally asked in the most devastatingly cool voice Adora had ever heard, "Glimmer, may I speak with you privately for a moment?"

Adora turned around, meeting Glimmer's petrified gaze across the apartment. Despite what she expected, Glimmer didn't argue. She stood and followed her mother silently into the bedroom, where the door clicked behind them.

Adora was paralyzed, eyes burning a hole through the bedroom door. Slowly, on numb legs, she crept towards it, pressing her ear against the wood when she was close enough. It wasn't like she

needed to. The voices exploded from inside almost immediately, making Adora cringe back.

“What are you *thinking*, Glimmer? Actually, that’s a foolish question. I’m sorry. Clearly you aren’t thinking at all!”

“Mom! We don’t need to get into this. It’s not even any of your business!”

“You’re well-being isn’t my business?”

“My well-being is fine! That’s not what this is about anyway, so stop pretending like you’re not just mad that I’m--,”

“Sleeping with Adora.”

Glimmer paused, the anger sucked out of her voice when she replied.

“Yeah.”

“Glimmer, I want you to stop and think and explain to me why you think that this is anything but a terrible idea.”

“You wouldn’t be mad if it were Bow!”

"This has nothing to do with the fact that Adora is a woman. She is your friend. Or she was! Before you shut out everyone in your life—,"

"That's bullshit and you know it!” Glimmer seemed to ignore the last half of Angella’s statement. “You've never cared about me or *any* of my relationships. You think I deserve to get my heart broken over and over again because of my fucking 'lifestyle' or whatever."

"Do you really think that I don't care?! After all I've done for you?"

"What have you *ever* done for me?" Glimmer’s voice cracked with barely contained tears.

“Glimmer, the last time I heard from you, you were living with someone I never even had the courtesy of *meeting*! And before that you called me crying and drunk because some other--person--had broken up with you just outside a bar in the Fright Zone and I was the only one who could pick you up. And yet, when I did, you refused to speak to me, or even look at me, Glimmer! And now you subject Adora to all of this bitterness? She doesn’t deserve this kind of behavior.”

Glimmer scoffed loudly. “What kind of *behavior*?”

“The kind where you abuse her hospitality and kindness when you don’t have any idea what you’re doing or what you want!”

“You don’t fucking know that! You’re not a part of this, Mom. Stop acting like you have *any* right to tell me what to do with *my* life!”

"What are you doing with your life then? Working at a *bar*? Drinking, smoking. Relying on another person's generosity to get you through every day? For how long, Glimmer? You dropped out of university. You dropped out of my life, I don't--I don't know what to do anymore."

"Nothing! There's nothing I want you to do except butt out of my life and stop *judging* me because I'm not your perfect little clone! I’m not what you want me to be, I get it! But I never will be, so get over it!"

“Glimmer, all I ‘want you to be’ is happy!”

“Who says I’m not?”

Angella sighed. “Glimmer, please. Look at yourself. Look at this situation. Would you rather I do nothing to help? To simply wait until I get another call someday? Some other stranger calling me to tell me they’ve found you dead in some ditch?”

“What are you even talking about? I’m not going to die!”

“What do you suspect will happen then when you inevitably destroy your relationship with Adora too? Where will you go. Who else do you have to turn to at this point, Glimmer?”

“Not *you* I guess!” Glimmer shouted, and Adora could hear the strain in her voice.

“You won’t *let* me help you, Glimmer. Do not blame that on me. After your father died, I tried--,”

“Don’t fucking talk about Dad. Don’t.”

Angella quieted for a moment and Adora realized she was trembling as she listened.

“If you’re father could see what you're doing to yours--,”

“Seriously? What did I just fucking say? You have no idea what Dad would think of me now. But I fucking wish he was here instead of *you!”*

Once again, a deafening silence fell over all of them. Adora held her breath, waiting. When Angella spoke again, her voice was eerily calm.

“Well then… At least you’re finally sleeping with someone consistent.”

Adora heard footsteps and she scrambled back towards the bathroom just as the bedroom door opened. Angella swept out, casting Adora an apologetic glance as she grabbed her purse and headed for the door. Adora stared after her, unsure what to say or do.

“Mrs. Sato—,” she tried, reaching out as if to pull the woman back.

Angella turned, her expression so broken that it brought Adora right back to the same moment years ago when she’d asked them to ‘take care of each other’.

“I’m sorry, Adora,” Angella murmured. She smiled tightly and then left the apartment.

Adora waited a few moments, as if she might return, before closing the door and turning to face Glimmer. She stood in the middle of the apartment, her entire body a tightly coiled wire. Her face was red, shaking arms crossed over her chest.

Adora wasn’t sure whether she was about to scream or cry, but the promise she’d made to Angella all those years ago was ringing in her ears and she had to try to help.

“Glimmer, what happened?” Adora asked, taking a step towards her trembling roommate. “I’m sorry I left the thing out, but you guys can’t—,”

Glimmer recoiled. “My mother’s a fucking asshole, that’s what happened. *I* didn’t do anything. *She’s* the one who treats me like some fucking embarrassment.”

“Glimmer, that’s not what she was saying to you,” Adora pressed, moving closer again despite Glimmer’s clear desire to *not* be touched. “I could hear everything. She’s worried about you.”

“What the fuck is she worried about, I’m fine!” Glimmer spat. “I don’t need her help. I don’t need anyone’s help.”

Glimmer was spiraling into the same pit of self-hate and anger Adora had seen on the night their friendship shattered. She couldn’t let that happen again. She *could not* lose Glimmer again.

“Everyone needs help sometimes, Glim. You’re hurting, I can see that. I’m sorry she upset you. Okay?” Adora reached out one hand, fingers brushing Glimmer’s crossed arms. “What can I do? Please, let me help you now.”

Glimmer didn’t respond at first.

The tension in the air between them was palpable. But not the kind Adora was used to. This tension was brittle, hard, ready to

snap and unleash an anger Adora wasn't sure she was equipped to handle. To her surprise, Glimmer's voice was icy cool when she spoke.

"Fine. You want to help?" she took a step away from Adora and pointed to the bedroom door. "Make yourself useful and get in the bedroom."

Adora frowned. That wasn't what she'd been expecting to hear. They didn't need to have sex right now, they needed to talk about this anger Glimmer was harboring for her mother. For everyone.

For herself…

"What?" It was all Adora could think to ask, all that she could process as Glimmer's glare hardened further.

"Get inside the fucking bedroom, Adora."

For a moment, Adora considered resisting her demands. She knew what would happen the second they got inside… But, maybe, it was what Glimmer needed? Maybe words wouldn't help right now. Maybe Adora could help her feel better in the physical. If she could try to convey her feelings—how she was there for Glimmer no matter what… Maybe that could work.

Slowly, still trying to convince herself that this wasn't a terrible idea, Adora turned and made her way to the bedroom on unsteady legs. Glimmer followed, making a brief stop to gather the harness from the bathroom, before joining Adora and closing the door behind them as the blonde took a precarious seat on the edge of the bed.

Glimmer turned to face her, crossed the room in a few quick steps, and gripped Adora's face tightly, tugging her into a searing kiss.

Confused, upset, and more than a little concerned about where this night was headed, Adora's response was weak. She lifted her hands to Glimmer's waist but held them there gently. Perhaps

hoping to soften her furious partner with a gentle touch. It didn't work.

Glimmer climbed onto the bed, straddling her lap as she continued to press searing kiss after searing kiss to Adora's mouth, tugging and biting on her lower lip until she was sure it would bruise. Once again, Adora tried to soften her, raising one hand to Glimmer's hair, stroking through it gently. But Glimmer grabbed her hand and pushed her back onto the bed, pinning them above her head.

She moved her furious kisses to Adora's neck, biting harsh marks into her skin. Adora tried not to flinch away. If the harshness was what Glimmer needed, maybe she could just sit here and take it for a while. It wouldn't be the first time that had ever happened to her…

But Glimmer seemed to have other plans. Very suddenly, she climbed off of Adora, allowing the blonde to sit up as she stripped her clothes off and snatched up the harness from where it lay beside them on the bed.

"Glim—," Adora knew what she was looking for and the thought of using it now made her stomach clench.

"Put this on." Glimmer tossed the harness and toy at her.

Adora stared down at the items dumbly, as if she'd never seen them before. This had to be a good idea…right? Even though it felt wrong and made Adora kinda want to throw up…? Glimmer needed it, right? It would help her. So she'd do it.

She just wanted to help.

Shakily, Adora stood and pulled her clothes off, replacing them slowly with the harness and toy. She tried to ignore the impatient shifting from Glimmer, the way the crackling tension in the air was threatening to smother her.

Once she'd donned both items, she turned to kneel on the bed, her heart sinking when Glimmer positioned herself on her stomach, hiding her face from Adora in the pillows. Adora leaned over her pressing a few soft kisses to the wings on her back.

Glimmer tensed, raising a hand blindly to slap her away.

"Adora. Just fuck me."

Adora leaned back, the burning lump in her throat was becoming unbearable, the sick twist in her stomach screaming for her to stop. But she didn't. She raised her hands, running the soothingly over Glimmer's thighs, trying to prepare her. She wasn't even sure how her partner could be ready at the moment, there was nothing arousing about this situation.

Realizing she should definitely grab the lube if they were going to do this, Adora moved to leave the bed, but Glimmer grabbed her thigh.

"Adora," she'd turned slightly to peek at Adora from the corner of her eye. Adora saw no tears, or shame, just pain…It made her heart ache.

"We should use the lube—,"

"I don't need it. Can you just fucking do it already?"

Adora froze, concern outweighing the venom in Glimmer's tone. She tried to decide quickly, but in the end Glimmer practically decided for her. She pushed Adora back into position and slid back onto the toy herself, a sharp cry leaving her as she did. It didn't sound pleasurable at all and the sinking ache in Adora's stomach strengthened.

She leaned over Glimmer again, quickly, trying to ease in more slowly. This could still work… She could still make this good and kind and caring. All the things Glimmer needed, maybe even if she didn't realize it.

Adora picked up a slow pace, rocking gently to ensure Glimmer's comfort as she pressed yet another kiss to the base of Glimmer's neck. Glimmer tensed again but seemed too focused on fucking to actually berate Adora for rule breaking. The room was eerily quiet, and it made Adora even more unnerved. There was nothing save for the squeak of the bed and the harsh panting coming from Glimmer.

"Glimmer are you—," Adora didn't get a chance to finish her question as Glimmer began rocking back more quickly against her, seemingly determined to set her own pace if Adora wouldn't do it for her.

"Glim, please—," Adora stopped moving all together, unable to ignore the sickening twist in her gut anymore.

She heard Glimmer mumble something into the pillows, although she did not stop moving.

"What…?" Adora prodded gently, and Glimmer peeked out just enough to mumble:

"Spank me."

Adora balked. Normally, she supposed that was supposed to be something…sexy? She guessed. But she'd never personally seen how pain equaled pleasure and the last thing she wanted to do was hurt Glimmer. Especially not physically. Hit her, right now? After everything that had happened that night? How could she be serious?

It finally occurred to Adora, in that moment that this wasn't helping Glimmer in the slightest. There was no way it could, not in her current state of mind. Glimmer was using her to hurt more. Maybe she thought that abusing herself like this would erase the pain of arguing with her mother, and all the painful memories that brought up.

Adora was not about to help her do that. She'd already gone too far as it was in the hopes that she could help.

“No,” Adora stated as firmly as she could. Her voice shook with unshed tears anyway as she pulled out and undid the harness.

Glimmer made a noise somewhere between a whine and a scoff. “What are you—?”

“I’m not helping you do this,” Adora replied, throwing the harness across the room in her frustration. It smacked loudly against the closet door before landing with a soft thud. Adora turned back to a surprised Glimmer, her entire body shaking with self-loathing and sadness.

“Do what?!” Glimmer sat up, practically shouting at her now. “We’re just fucking. We do it all the time in case you’ve forgotten, Adora. This was the deal.”

“I never agreed to help you hurt yourself!” Adora shot back, getting up and grabbing her shirt and pants off the floor with trembling hands. She’d sleep on the couch tonight. “This isn’t just sex for you right now and you know that.”

“You’re being fucking dramatic,” Glimmer growled at her. “I don’t see what the problem is! You get to fuck me and I get to—,”

“Forget all your problems? Forget how much pain you’re in? Yeah, no. We’re not doing that, Glimmer. I’m not letting you run anymore,” Adora tugged her shirt over her head, walking as confidently as she could for the door.

“That’s not your fucking choice and—and—you don’t know what you’re talking about anyway!”

Ignoring her, Adora left the bedroom, heading for the couch. No pillow, no blanket. Not that she imagined she’d get much sleep tonight anyway.

“You know what?” Glimmer followed her to the doorway. “I should have fucking known you’d be like all the rest. Why did I expect anything different? Fuck you, Adora. And fuck your pity!”

The bedroom door slammed shut, a whoosh of air battering her back as she stood alone in the middle of the living room.

Slowly, Adora made her way to the couch, curling up on the cushions before bursting into tears and crying herself to sleep.

Adora's stomach was aching when she woke up the next morning. She'd sobbed until there were no more tears left inside her and even then, the dry heaves and trembles kept her awake. She'd finally fallen asleep in the wee hours of the morning, the tears now dried on her cheeks.

Slowly rising from the couch, stiff and sore, Adora hobbled to the bathroom. She splashed her face with soap and cool water, brushed her teeth and popped a few Advil for the headache she'd woken with. She wasn't sure how much better Glimmer had fared last night. There was no alcohol in Adora's room for her to drown her sorrows in. With any luck she'd simply fumed quietly to herself and then fallen asleep too. Adora couldn't know. The room had been silent all night.

Leaning against the sink, Adora let her forehead rest on the cool glass of the bathroom mirror. She had to find a way to help Glimmer this morning. If this… If last night broke them apart again… Adora wasn't sure what she'd do without Glimmer now and she didn't want to find out. Things were difficult between them. Glimmer's trauma ran deep and it made it hard to truly connect with her. But Adora knew what she felt for her best friend ran deeper. She didn't want to lose it again.

A good breakfast.

That would draw her out and boost her mood. Maybe they could talk then. Discuss why last night had taken such a turn after her mother had left.

Scurrying to the kitchen, Adora pulled out a few pots and pans, settling on chocolate chip pancakes and eggs and bacon. A

perfect and hearty breakfast.

Adora was well into pouring pancakes into the hot griddle, ignoring the flour that dusted the countertop when she heard the bedroom door open.

Suddenly, Adora was too scared to turn around. Afraid of what she might see. Afraid that Glimmer might snap again. So she kept her gaze trained on the pancakes, flipping one over as she heard a kitchen chair scrape against the floor.

Act calm. Act natural. Don't let things get heated. Just pretend everything's okay.

"Morning, Glim," she called cheerily over her shoulder. As she expected, there was no response. "Breakfast is almost ready, okay?"

Adora's plan was ruined when she heard a quiet sniff and an even smaller whimper. Daring to turn around, Adora took in a sight that broke her heart.

Glimmer sat hunched in one of the kitchen chairs, a blanket from Adora's bed draped over her shoulders. Her face was pale, eyes red rimmed and puffy, hair sticking up in a dozen different directions. She sniffed again, wiping her nose with her sleeve before daring to meet Adora's concerned gaze.

It seemed that the raw eye contact was the last straw. Glimmer broke down, hiccup-y sobs escaping her as she buried her face in her hands. Throwing down the spatula, Adora hurried to her side without a second thought.

"Glim," she murmured, wrapping her arms around Glimmer's shaking shoulders from behind. It was an awkward angle, and Adora had to bend low to reach her from behind the chair, but Glimmer didn't seem to care. She leaned back, her head falling against Adora's shoulder as she reached up, gripping Adora's forearm with white fingers.

“I’m—so—s—sorry,” she hiccupped and Adora sagged, her eyes falling shut in a mix of relief and agony. They should have been there for each other last night. Instead they’d spent the lonely hours in pain, isolated.

“It’s alright,” Adora murmured, turning her face into Glimmer’s soft, messy hair and pressing a gentle kiss to her temple.

It wasn’t alright, Adora knew that. They had a lot to discuss. That night had been messy and a mistake Adora didn’t want to make again. But for now, maybe they could just hold each other and find peace. For now, at least, Glimmer had apologized. Their relationship hadn’t shattered into a million pieces again.

“Adora…?”

“Yeah?” Adora squeezed her, a quiet reassurance that she was.

“I think…something’s burning.”

“Shit!”

Releasing her tearful roommate, Adora made a mad dash for the stove, where the pancakes she’d been making had transformed into blackened rocks.

“Great….”

Sighing, Adora dumped her attempt at breakfast and made her way back to the kitchen table. She plopped down in front of Glimmer, pulling their chairs so close that their knees brushed.

“Hey,” Adora reached out, cupping her tear streaked cheek and guiding Glimmer to meet her gaze. “Whaddya say we call out of work today, huh? Spend the day here. Relaxing, watching movies, eating junk food. Just… A good recovery day. Yeah?”

Glimmer blinked once, owlishly, then nodded. “Sure…”

“Okay,” Adora stroked her thumb once over her cheek, smiling when Glimmer’s eyes fluttered at the gentle touch. “Wanna help me set up a pillow fort for some movie binging?”

A small smile touched Glimmer’s lips as she followed Adora into the living room. Together they piled up a bunch of blankets and pillows from the bedroom, making a makeshift nest on the floor in front of the couch. Forgoing the breakfast idea, Adora grabbed all the snack food in her cabinets. Glimmer had supplied the earlier in the week of course. Adora rarely ate junk food. But today seemed like the proper morning for loads of sugar. Popcorn, some old M&M’s, poptarts, oreos and pretzels.

Gathering them all in a large salad bowl, Adora rejoined Glimmer, who was curled into a ball under some blankets, scrolling through her phone, eyes dull and listless.

“Hey, scoot,” Adora nudged her with her toes as she sat down, placing the snacks to the side and grabbing a few pillows to prop herself up with. Glimmer seemed to have decided her thigh was a much better pillow than she was ever going to find elsewhere, because she rested her head in Adora’s lap, drew the blanket up and did not move for the next hour and a half as the first movie— Jurassic Park— played. Adora wasn’t quite sure if Glimmer was actually watching at first. She lay very still and silent, not even bothering to berate Adora for rule breaking as she began running her fingers through Glimmer’s soft hair.

Over and over again, she ran her fingers through the strands, playing with the ends. The repetitive action seemed to soothe both of them. In fact, Adora wasn’t entirely sure Glimmer hadn’t fallen asleep until she stretched and yawned loudly halfway through the movie.

A single hand came to rest on Adora’s thigh, small fingers picking at her pajama pants.

“Are you mad?” Glimmer’s voice was tiny, slightly muffled and distorted with her cheek pressed against Adora’s thigh.

“Mad?”

“At me?”

Adora let her hand run through Glimmer’s hair one last time before coming to rest on her shoulder.

“No, I’m not mad at you, I’m—,” Scared for? Hurting for you? Desperate to help? “Sad… I guess.”

Glimmer’s shoulder sagged beneath her hand. “Me too.”

“Last night was…”

“Awful?”

“Yeah,” Adora couldn’t help but chuckle slightly and Glimmer did too. “That’s… Not how I ever want it to be.”

“No hate sex?” Glimmer clarified, turning her head to peek up at Adora, one eye twinkling mischievously.

“No… Should we make that a new rule?” Adora teased back, booping the tip of Glimmer’s nose.

Glimmer snapped at her finger, Adora manage to jerk it away just in time.

“We’re bad at following rules,” Glimmer made it a point to grin at her extra wide, showing all of her dangerous teeth.

“Apparently,” Adora snickered.

“I didn’t mean to yell at you,” Glimmer continued, the playful spark in her eyes dying again as she settled further into Adora’s lap. “My mom just—She gets me so angry. I don’t—I shouldn’t have taken it out on you. I won’t do it again, I’m sorry.”

Adora let her hand squeeze Glimmer’s shoulder gently. “I know it’s hard to deal with her. But she does love you, Glimmer. I think

she's trying hard to relate, she just doesn't know how. Maybe give it some time to cool down and then talk to her again."

The shoulder underneath Adora's hand lifted in a shrug, but Glimmer didn't outright deny her, and she figured that was a start. They were quiet for a bit again; the roar of people being eaten by dinosaurs filling the silence.

Finally, Glimmer rested a hand on Adora's thigh and squeezed. "Do you remember the night at that party? When you—When I—You know… When we didn't talk after that?"

Adora's heart twisted. She'd never forgotten it. The memory lay buried deep within her, but it had risen to the surface more often than not lately.

"Yeah."

"I'm sorry for that too," Glimmer mumbled. "I know that's hardly worth anything. I was so awful to you. You don't have to forgive me. But I *am* sorry for what I said that night. It… I'm kind of a fucking disaster, I guess."

Adora shook her head 'no' even though Glimmer wasn't looking at her. "You're not a disaster."

"No, I am. It's okay."

A soft chuckle came from both of them. Adora wanted to reassure her that she was wrong. That she just needed help working through her trauma. But the events of last night and this morning had drained her. Talking seemed thoroughly impossible at this point. So instead of reassuring with words; Adora slid down to lay beside Glimmer, shifting and allowing the smaller girl to curl against her side, head resting on her shoulder. They lay there quietly, Adora staring at the tv screen, but ultimately look through it as Glimmer breathed steadily in her arms, one small and warm hand pressed to her chest. Adora wondered if she could feel how quickly her heart was beating beneath it.

“Glimmer?” she prompted after a while as the credits began to roll. She wasn’t quite sure what she intended to ask… maybe the rules? Their relationship as a whole? If Glimmer might consider meeting with Adora’s old therapist?

It didn’t matter much, however, when Glimmer’s only response was a soft snore. Smiling to herself, Adora let her own eyes slip shut, turning her head to press her lips against Glimmer’s forehead.

“Sleep tight, Princess,” Adora murmured, arm tightening around her smaller form as she too drifted off to sleep.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

> Surprise! This entire fic has been a ploy to push my Adam x Bow agenda mwahaha
>
> Oh, uh, summary: The bubble bursts. When Glimmer finally hits rock bottom, there is nowhere left to go but up.
>
> Also, my very talented friend Rod made some artwork for this chapter, support it here:
>
> https://therodrigator6.tumblr.com/post/619285588843069440/therodrigator6-no-strings-attached-if-were

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer stood just outside the living room, her back pressed to the wall, inhaling deep calming breaths as she prepared to face her mother. She was reading just on the other side of the wall, completely ignorant to the bomb Glimmer was about to drop on her.

Micah had been easy. Micah had always been supportive. Always loving. In fact, Glimmer suspected after their talk that maybe he'd known all along.

Angella, on the other hand—Angella had a perfect vision of what she wanted Glimmer to be. If she strayed from the path—in any way, there was no telling what Angella might think of her after this. But Glimmer wasn't going to hide who she was anymore. She *couldn't* live like that.

Taking a deep breath, Glimmer rounded the corner to face her mother. Her bravado failed the second Angella's lavender eyes flickered up to her.

“Glimmer?” Her tone was light and airy, maybe a hint of concern, as if she were surprised to see her daughter. Or maybe she could read the anxiety written all over her face. “Are you alright?”

“Yes, uh, no. Well, yes! It’s just,” Glimmer swallowed the anxious lump rising in her throat. “Can I talk to you about something for a sec… It’s—It’s important.”

“Always, dear.” Angella dog-eared her book and set it down, patting the space next to her. Glimmer remained standing, frozen with fear. Angella’s brow wrinkled. “Glimmer, what’s the matter?”

“Mom…,” Glimmer’s entire body trembled. *Just say it, just say it, just rip the band-aid off just fucking do it…* “Mom, I—I’m, uh… I don’t….” Glimmer braced herself. “I don’t like Bow.”

Angella’s penciled eyebrow quirked. “Oh… Alright?”

“No, I mean—,” Growling at herself, Glimmer stood taller, lifted her chin and squared her shoulders. “I don’t like Bow… Or, or any boys, Mom. I’m—,” Angella’s face hardened and Glimmer felt her knees began to shake. “Mom, I— I’m gay.”

A terrible silence filled the room. It was worse than what Glimmer had been anticipating. Anger, judgement, conversion therapy right here in her living room? But none of that came. Instead, Angella just stared at her, face an unreadable mask. Glimmer’s trembling worsened; she clenched her jaw tight to stop her teeth from chattering. Tears were gathering in the corner of her eyes, but she refused to let them fall. She didn’t have any reason to cry…

When Angella still refused to speak, Glimmer plowed ahead. “I know that’s not… What you wanted from me. But—I’m not gonna pretend to be someone I’m not, just for you! I—I can’t do that. I don’t think… You’d want me to.”

Angella’s lips thinned into a frown and slowly the looked away from Glimmer, a long breath leaving her. Glimmer didn’t know what to say or do. So she waited—shaking, hands clenched into clammy fists.

Finally, without looking at her, gaze faraway, Angella simply asked, "Have you spoken to your father about this?"

The way she wouldn't even say the words, instead leaving it some ambiguous concept suddenly made Glimmer furious.

"Of course I have," She spat. "I told him first. I wasn't even going to tell you, but he thought that I should—,"

"Why wouldn't you think to tell me?" Angella asked, her own tone tinged with anger now. "Were you planning on hiding from me for the rest of your life?"

"No! I just—I knew you'd be angry. You'd hate me. You'd—,"

"I don't hate you, Glimmer," Angella rose from the couch, tall and menacing despite her words. Glimmer stepped back. "I'm… Disappointed. Scared, for you. I suppose."

Anger flared in Glimmer's chest again, drowning out the initial fear and concern for her mother's opinion. "Scared? What are you scared about? You think I'm *condemned* or something?"

Sighing, Angella closed her eyes briefly to center herself before reaching out to her daughter. "Glimmer, choosing a life like this isn't easy—,"

"It's not my *choice!*" Glimmer shot back, her voice rising an octave. "You really think I'd make a choice that would make you hate me? Or that other people would judge me for or talk about me behind my back? Or call me names? You think I *want* that?"

Angella seemed hung up on Glimmer's first few words. "Stop telling yourself that I hate you, Glimmer. That's not what I'm saying. I want you to lead a successful and happy life and this—It's not what—,"

"What *you* want," Glimmer finished for her. Angella looked fierce but did not deny it.

“I want you to be happy.”

“You want me to be you.”

“Glimmer—,”

Glimmer turned and ran. She made it all the way to Bow’s house that night before bursting into tears on his doorstep. When he convinced her to return home the following morning, Angella said nothing. So neither did Glimmer (although she was grounded for running away past curfew). Otherwise, the entire conversation was ignored and it would remain that way until Glimmer graduated high school. Until she dropped out of college.

Until a stupid rainbow dildo in the sink reopened old wounds and brought the tenuous veil of normalcy crashing down.

Glimmer had been struggling with the lid of a jam jar for the better part of five minutes when Adora joined her in the kitchen the next morning. The blonde gave her a quiet but curious glance, which Glimmer returned with a tight smile that said, ‘I’ve got this don’t help me’. Shrugging, a light smirk tugging at her lips, Adora turned on the Keurig, peeking at Glimmer from the corner of her eye as she prepared her coffee.

Glimmer returned her full attention to the jar. As if it hadn’t been hard enough to open if before, now Adora’s eyes on her was making it worse. Huffing she grabbed the spongy lid opening thing they kept in one of the drawers and tried again. No luck. Somehow even the tool meant *not* to slip on jar lids was slipping.

Growling quietly to herself, her toast now growing cold, Glimmer buckled down, tucking the jar in the curve of her arm, and twisting with all her might. Adora was still watching over the rim of her coffee mug, one brow quirked in amusement.

She took a long sip as Glimmer struggled, finally asking, “Did you want me to—,”

"No," Glimmer interrupted immediately. "I've got it. Drink your gross ass coffee."

Adora pursed her lips, failing to hide her amused smile, and let Glimmer struggle stubbornly for a few more moments before setting her mug down. She moved silently behind Glimmer, slipping her arms around her until she was also holding the jar as if she were about to teach Glimmer how to golf. She shuffled them towards the counter, hands still over Glimmer's and guided them to tap twice, hard, against the edge of the counter. Then she prompted Glimmer's 'lid' hand to twist and the jar opened with an easy 'pop'.

Adora released her, leaving Glimmer to stare at the open jar in awe and incredible rage.

"How the fuck—?" she whirled on Adora who was already taking her coffee into the living room, a proud prance in her step.

Eyes narrowing in a challenge glare, Glimmer furiously prepared her toast, proceeding to replace the lid as tightly as she could.

'Let's see Adora be smug about this next time…'

Her evil plan would turn out to backfire of course when Glimmer struggled yet again the next morning and Adora easily solved the problem with a quick run under some hot water.

Glimmer's recent meeting with Bow had rekindled their daily conversations. Glimmer was careful to avoid dumping too much of her own drama with Adora on him; spending most of their conversations asking about Bow's new job, or his boyfriend, George and Lance or even just sending dumb memes like they used to.

It was nice to have her best friend back, nice to not focus so much on her own issues, nice to feel like Bow cared about her enough to give her a second chance. Or… Maybe more like a fifteenth chance at this point… Bow seemed happier with her

attitude as well. In fact, he rewarded her a few days later with a surprise.

-'Ta da!!'

Bow sent her a picture of four tickets. Glimmer had to squint to make out the text on them via her phone screen, but when she did:

-'You got tickets to the Paraless concert?!?! How?!!"

Bow answered her question with a kiss emoji.

-'so r u coming?'

-'what????!?!?'

-'I have 4 tickets glim. You me adam adora les go'

A group outing to see one of Glimmer's long time, favorite bands? Hell yes. She didn't even much care to know how Bow had gotten the tickets at such short notice.

-'*BOW*'

-'I know I'm amazing you owe me'

-'literally my entire life'

-'I'll take your first born child'

-'what if I don't want kids?'

Bow paused.

-'ur first born dog'

-'deal. I'll ask adora if she's interested.'

-'nooo just make her come, plssssss, I don't wanna waste the tickets.'

-‘idk if she even likes Paraless tho’

-‘yeah well she likes *us* so make her deal with it and she and adam will get along great I can feel it in my bones.’

-‘in ur boner’

-‘perish thot’

Adora was still up, reading something on her phone on the couch by lamplight when Glimmer got back from her late shift at the bar. Part of her wanted to think that maybe Adora was up on purpose, to make sure she got home safely, as it was well past midnight by now. But that was probably a little too presumptuous of her.

Still, Adora looked up from her phone when Glimmer entered, grinning as she plopped down beside the blonde on the couch.

“Hey, how was work?” she asked as Glimmer laid down, propping her legs over Adora’s lap.

She knew she smelled like booze and greasy bar food and that she was also probably covered in sweat from running around during the hectic late night rush, but Adora didn’t complain as she placed warm hands over Glimmer’s thighs, rubbing the soreness out of them.

“Exhausting, but also money so—,” Glimmer pulled a wad of ones and twenties out of her back pocket. “I’m absolutely thriving.”

She suddenly remembered Bow’s offer from the day before and realized she *still* had yet to tell Adora about the plans she’d basically already made for them.

“Hey, so, Bow got us tickets to a concert,” she propped herself up on her elbows to meet Adora’s curious blue gaze. “Him and his boyfriend too. He wanted to know if we could all go together this weekend?”

“A concert?” Adora asked. “This weekend?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer felt her cheeks flushing hot for some reason. “I know you’re not—That’s not really your thing, or whatever. But it might be fun to get out of the apartment for a bit. And you haven’t seen Bow in a while and his boyfriend is—,”

“I’d love to go,” Adora beamed at her and Glimmer couldn’t help but grin back. She sat up, removing her legs from Adora’s lap, and heading for the shower.

“Great, I’ll let him know. Now if you’ll excuse me, I need to wash the fucking cigarette smoke out of my hair.”

She was halfway through the bathroom door before Adora rose from the couch, inching slowly towards her. “Did… You want help? Or…”

Glimmer cocked a brow. “Do I want help showering? What am I five?”

Adora shook her head jerkily, her face turning an adorable shade of pink. “Or company… I guess?”

“Adora,” Glimmer waited until the blonde looked up to meet shyly meet her gaze. “Do you want to have shower sex?”

Biting her lip, Adora nodded, taking a small step closer to the bathroom.

“It’s one in the morning.”

“So?”

“So, get your ass in here if you’re so horny,” Glimmer teased.

Adora lit up, springing for the bathroom. Glimmer wasn’t done with the game though. She made an attempt to close the door before Adora could make it. But she’d underestimated the blonde’s longer stride. She got a foot in the door easily and shoved her

way inside, lifting Glimmer into her arms as she burst into hysterical giggles. Adora's laughter mingled with hers as she carried Glimmer over to the shower, holding her much like a potato sack as Glimmer reached for the shower knob.

"Closer please, Jeeves," she teased and Adora lowered her further.

"Your arms are so short."

"All of me is short," Glimmer shot back as she managed to turn the water on, and hot steam filled the bathroom.

"All of me is long," Adora sounded almost disappointed by this fact.

Glimmer wiggled in her arms, tilting her head back onto Adora's shoulder and brushing her lips against her jaw. "Oh, I know."

Shivering slightly, Adora grinned and set her down, spinning her until she could cup her cheeks and pull Glimmer into a proper kiss.

"No kissing," Glimmer mumbled against her lips, doing nothing to stop her, however.

"This is foreplay kissing," Adora mumbled back as she bent low and hoisted Glimmer into her arms again, this time supporting her thighs as Glimmer wrapped her legs around the blonde's slim waist. "Doesn't count."

"Is that how it works?" Glimmer asked, looping her arms around Adora's neck.

The blonde murmured an indecipherable response before carrying Glimmer into the shower, despite that fact that they were both still fully clothed. Glimmer screeched as her shirt clung to her skin beneath the spray and Adora's laughter filled the bathroom and for the first time in a long time, Glimmer felt—

--happy.

Bow and Adam picked met them first at Adora's apartment, the night of the concert. Glimmer was the only one wearing something she wouldn't otherwise define as 'business casual', but she would *never* complain about the opportunity to see Adora in a button down with the sleeves rolled up. It was just entirely and hilariously ironic when Adam showed up wearing the same thing, but plaid.

Glimmer felt something strange awaken in her when the two blonde's shook hands. Adam was at least half a foot taller and that was saying something, since Adora was already pretty tall.

Bow was right, the two hit it off swimmingly.

"Wow, this place is so nice!" The tall blonde man said after introductions, turning a circle to take in the entire apartment. His eyes fell on Glimmer's guitar case and he practically gasped. "Which one of you plays?"

"Glimmer does," Adora answered for her, a twinge of pride in her voice that made Glimmer blush. "She's really good."

"It's true," Bow added, throwing an arm around Glimmer's shoulders and squeezing. "She used to write her own songs back in high school too!"

Adam's blue eyes were round with awe. "I've always wanted to learn how to play guitar. My favorite band is Aerosmith. They've got some *sick* guitar riffs."

Glimmer shrugged. "It's not hard, I could probably teach you."

Adam's usually deep voice, lifted into a grateful squeak. His eyes then moving to Adora's gym bag in the corner of the living room.

"Boxing gloves!"

"Oh yeah," Adora lit up too, she bounded over to the bag, pulling out her gloves. "I teach at the gym downtown!"

Adam's jaw was practically on the floor. "No way. Are you guys taking new members?"

"Always! I'm taking clients now too."

Adam threw a few fake punches, surprisingly nimble for his size. "I've always wanted to learn how to box too."

"Wait, wait," Adora stopped him, adjusting the placement of his arms and then centering herself into a lower stance as an example for him. Adam followed her lead with rapt attention. "There you go, that's way better. I'd be happy to take you on if you really want! I'm sure you'd make a great fighter."

Adam shot Bow an enthusiastic glance who grinned back at him with a thumbs up. As his boyfriend turned away, Bow leaned over to Glimmer, murmuring in her hear. "What did I tell you? Himbos in arms."

Glimmer shoved him playfully, her heart still swelling with warmth as she watched Adora exchange practice jabs with Adam.

"Alright, Children," Bow interrupted them with a clap of his hands. "We should take off if we wanna get to the venue on time."

Adam lowered his arms, but grinned at Adora, shoving her arm once more playfully before bolting out the door. Bow sighed, following his giant child of a boyfriend as Adora took her place at Glimmer's side—although Glimmer noticed she looked like she was itching to give chase.

"Ready?" she asked, fingers brushing Adora's hand.

The blonde looked down with a soft smile, linking their fingers. "Ready."

The car ride to Bright Moon's biggest venue, appropriately named, The Palace, was short. It felt even shorter as Bow preemptively played a Paraless CD to warm up for the main event, and Adora

and Adam conversed about their nearly identical high school sports careers the entire time.

"Lacrosse is great," Adam nodded approvingly as Adora finished telling him how she'd gotten a full ride to Bright Moon U for it. "I was a football guy, personally. But I got a pretty bad concussion and decided it wasn't for me."

"You gave up on it?" Adora asked, sounding almost sad.

"Not entirely. I'm a sports therapist now! It's still a part of me. But I don't have to suffer permanent brain damage to be around it," Adam tapped his head and laughed.

"And we're all very grateful for that," Bow added, casting a affectionate glance in his himbo boyfriend's direction. "No permanent damage to my man please."

Adam chuckled, leaning across the partition to press a wet and loud kiss to Bow's cheek.

Glimmer glanced over at Adora, who happened to be looking at her as well. They locked eyes for a brief, heart pounding moment, before immediately turning to peer out their respective windows.

The rest of the car ride was mostly filled by music.

The venue was packed with people by the time they arrived. Glimmer was forced to stick close to Adora's side as they pushed through the crowd, hands tightly interlocked so as not to lose each other. Not that she was complaining much.

Adam and Bow led the way to their seats and then Adam offered to grab some drinks as there was still quite a bit of time before the show officially started. Adora hopped up to go with him, turning to Glimmer and asking, "Beer?"

For a moment, Glimmer almost said yes, and then she pictured herself sloppy drunk by the end of this night and decided against

it. For whatever reason, she wanted to be more present tonight that she had the last few weeks for *both* her friends.

"Water would be nice actually," she replied.

Adora's brow crinkled in confusion, but then Adam was tugging her away and they disappeared into the crowd. Glimmer glanced over at Bow whose proud smile told her he already understood her thought process.

"You ready to see the band of our *childhood* blow our minds tonight?" Bow teased, leaning into her shoulder. Glimmer beamed and nodded excitedly. She was sure she'd be able to sing along to most of the songs by heart and being here with her best friends and he best friend's adorable boyfriend was filling her with glee.

Adora and Adam returned shortly, balancing drinks in what looked like some kind of contest. Adam plopped down next to Bow, pecking his cheek as he handed him his drink. "For you, good sir."

"Dork," Bow's blush betrayed how charming he actually found the comment.

Glimmer turned when she felt Adora poking her side. The blonde handed her a water bottle, her blue eyes flickering briefly to Adam and Bow before he murmured, "Princess."

Glimmer snorted. "What are you doing?"

Adora pursed her lips and flushed, hiding behind her own bottle and turning away. Heaving an affectionate sigh, Glimmer leaned into her side, nudging her shoulder to regain her attention.

"Thank you," she murmured, lifting the water bottle slightly, but hoping that was the was really grateful for was clearer. Adora gave her a crooked grin and nodded.

By the time Paraless finally arrived on stage later that night, Glimmer was buzzing with the energy of the room. The first song they played was one she remembered well, but as the notes filled

the air and the large audience screamed along, they hit differently than ever before.

'Down to you
You're pushing and pulling me down to you
But I don't know what I want
Now when I caught myself, I had to stop myself
I'm saying something that I should have never thought'

Glimmer stopped singing slowly, the guitar and drums and bass filling her ears as she glanced over at Adora. The blonde was bouncing along to the music she didn't know with ample enthusiasm. Watching her made Glimmer's heart twist, her body tingle. Everything inside of her was suddenly warm.

Everything was right.

And she didn't know why.

'You got it, you got it
Some kind of magic
Hypnotic, hypnotic
You're leaving me breathless'

By the end of the show, Glimmer's buzzing energy had settled into a contented high that the others seemed to share. They traipsed out of the Palace, smooshed amongst the rest of the excited crowd. Adam was still singing loudly to himself and Bow was laughing. Glimmer kept close to Adora's side, hands locked, bodies practically pressed together amidst the crowd.

After a quick discussion about how fucking hungry they were, particularly the monstrously sized Adam, the four decided to stop at the closest restaurant—Denny's.

Shitty food. But 24 hours service and Glimmer was too hungry to be picky. The restaurant was nearly empty considering they'd traipsed in around midnight. Once they were seated, all crowded into a booth that was clearly too small for Adam, the conversation began in earnest again.

“I can’t believe I haven’t listened to them in so long,” Adam huffed, glaring at his menu as if it were in a foreign language. “They’re so fucking good.”

“The encore was great,” Bow agreed. “What did you think Adora? Have fun?”

Adora laughed as Bow poked her shin with his boot underneath the table. “Yeah! It was a lot of fun. Kinda… Loud? And I’m glad we weren’t anywhere near that mosh pit too. But otherwise—,”

“Ready for the mosh pit, Shaka Brah?” Adam interrupted, throwing up a hand sign without looking up from his menu.

Bow shoved him. “Shut up, meme lord.”

“The Best Friend Squad is back in action,” Glimmer chimed in, grinning when both Bow and Adora sent her affectionate smiles.

They all quieted slightly, perusing their menus. Bow had turned in the booth, leaning fully back against Adam’s shoulder in a way that was so casually intimate it made Glimmer’s heart ache. Adam kept fiercely studying his options, occasionally turning to press very focused kisses to the top of Bow’s head. Glimmer glanced over at Adora, she seemed to be watching them too. Her blue eyes wide and curious.

Glimmer nudged her and Adora practically leapt out of her seat at the sudden touch.

“You decide on anything?” she jerked her chin at Adora’s menu.

“Oh! Uh… Yeah, just a… Burger I guess, maybe.” She cleared her throat and just then the waitress came to take their order.

Once their menu’s had been passed away, drinks set down and the waitress plodded away, Adam took the wrapper from his straw, beginning to mess with it as Bow proceeded to rant about ‘the worst hand job he’d ever received’ at top volume.

Adora's phone buzzed suddenly against the table; both she and Glimmer glanced at the caller I.D. Glimmer tried not to feel sick as she read the name 'Catra'. Adora scowled down at her phone, fingers clenching. Gently, Glimmer put a hand on her shoulder and leaned in to whisper, "You can take it, if you need to."

Silently, Adora shook her head, pressing the end call button and setting her phone face down on the table. She turned to Glimmer, lips brushing her ear with her whispered reply. "No, I'm here with you right now. If she really wants to talk to me, she can wait until I'm free."

A soft warmth bloomed in Glimmer's chest. She smiled and took Adora's hand beneath the table, squeezing gently. Across the table, Adam had fashioned a tiny human figure out of his straw wrapper.

"Check it out!" He brandished the little paper man for everyone to see. Glimmer and Bow exchanged exasperated glances, while Adora leaned forward with wide eyes, absolutely enthralled.

"How did you do that?!"

"Gimme your straw thing!" Adam shot back, holding out his hand as Adora fumbled for her wrapper. "I'll show you, watch."

Glimmer sat back, her heart fluttering like she was a stupid teenager again as she watched Adam excitedly walk Adora through the steps of straw wrapper folding. Adora focused diligently, tongue poking between her lips as she folded the little creature per the other blonde's instructions. Her face lit up when she'd finished and she turned to Glimmer, her laughter full of childlike glee.

"Look, Glim!"

Maybe it was the heat of the moment, maybe it was the fact that she'd seen Bow and Adam doing it all night, maybe it was due to how fucking cute Adora was as she proudly showed Glimmer her paper 'human'. Whatever it was, Glimmer cupped Adora's soft

cheek with one hand and pressed a proud kiss to her lips. It was quick, but still she lingered long enough for Adora to stiffen in shock beneath her touch. When she drew away, blue eyes were studying her, a mix of confusion and overwhelming joy making them glassy and bright.

Glimmer flushed, her cheeks burning as she felt three pairs of confused eyes on her all at once. Luckily, at that moment, their food arrived, and they all began stuffing their faces too quickly to continue any serious conversation. Adora and Adam quickly began a wordless competition over who could force the most french fries into their mouth at one time.

Throughout the meal, Glimmer spent most of her time trying to subtly inch closer to Adora in the booth. Something strange was happening inside of her tonight. She couldn't quite explain what she was feeling, or even define it with words. It was warm, it was comfortable, it was calm and exciting all at once. She felt like that young girl that had so naively pictured herself as a princess dancing with her knight around her living room all those years ago. All she wanted was to be closer to Adora; touching her in some sense. As if the blonde was a tether holding her down, a safe haven as she was floating through the endless unknown.

She managed to inch her way to Adora's side slowly as they all ate, the conversation muffled through the roar of blood in her ears. Soon enough, through very tiny scoots, Glimmer had pressed her thigh to Adora's, shoulders brushing. If Adora noticed, she didn't say anything, not until they ordered dessert anyway. Two shakes. One for each 'couple'. Glimmer had surrendered her desire for chocolate peanut butter, to share a plain vanilla with Adora. Seeing the way her eyes lit up when the dessert was set down, was more than enough of a reward anyway. Glimmer glanced over at the boys on the other side of the booth, they'd stuck two straws in the shake—half of it was already gone as Adam playfully tugged the mug away from Bow and then used both straws to absorb the drink. Bow was laughing, smiling brighter than Glimmer had ever seen him as he reached for the shake to no avail.

She watched her best friend, contentment spreading though her body like a warm wave. A gentle pressure on her hand drew her attention and she looked down, almost surprised to see Adora's hand over hers, calloused thumb brushing over her knuckles. Glimmer's heart jumped in her chest, her entire body beginning to pound as she glanced up to meet Adora's gaze. It was indescribably soft, her blue eyes eager as she used her other hand to shift their own shake towards Glimmer.

Two straws.

Glimmer couldn't hold back the giddy smile as she pictured herself in some cheesy teen romcom. She'd never gotten this back then, losing Micah had taken her innocence entirely; but she had a second chance now. One that Adora was giving to her.

Leaning forward, Glimmer ignored the altogether boring taste of vanilla ice cream to instead savor the fact that Adora's face was so close to her own, and their eyes were still locked. But the normal heat, or electricity, that might have exploded between them normally at this proximity, was gone. There was something else sparking between them. Something deeper and more terrifying than Glimmer had ever known. She felt open, raw and exposed, even after Adora sat back leaving Glimmer to enjoy the shake alone as Adam shot a straw wrapper at her. She shot back with a balled-up napkin she'd used to clean up a spill from her soda.

It landed with a wet thud against Adam's chest and then the war was really on as they started throwing soggy fries at each other. Not surprisingly, the group of adults, was asked to leave the restaurant soon after. But none of them cared. The night air was cool, and they were all giddy and laughing as they traipsed out into the parking lot.

Glimmer looked up at the moon, it was barely a sliver in the night sky, but somehow seemed to cast so much light. The stars were dim pin pricks in the sea of velvety black, nowhere near as bright as she remembered them from her nights stargazing out in the cliffs with Adora. Still the sight made her chest tighten with an old

ache of nostalgia. Bow and Adam's laughter seemed faded and far away.

It was like all of the sudden she was standing alone. Floating in a dark universe. The weight and grief of the past three years of her life settling heavy on her shoulders. A sick ache filled her gut, the sadness becoming overwhelming. Glimmer wanted to sink into herself and disappear. How had she come to this point? How had so many of her mistakes left her so alone? She'd been in so much pain, lashing out at everyone who tried to help, until her own bitterness left her more alone than she ever wanted to be.

How could she possibly even begin to fix what she'd broken? With Bow, Mermista, with her mother, with—

Adora's arms slipped around her middle, pulling her back into a firm and warm embrace. The fear, the grief, the anxiety, it all faded suddenly as Glimmer settled into Adora's arms under the moonlight. She let her head fall back against the blonde's broad shoulder, closing her eyes as the familiar scent surrounded her. Adora's lips brushed her temple and although neither of them spoke, to Glimmer, it seemed like a thousand confessions passed between them at once. A fact that was almost as terrifying as being alone. But—somehow exhilarating at the same time.

Slowly, Glimmer raised her hands, resting them on top of Adora's and stroking her calloused fingers. Adora's head fell forward, lips now pressed against the curve of Glimmer's neck. She expected the familiar heat at the intimate contact to start boiling in her belly. Instead, she felt nothing but the heavy thud of her heart against her ribcage and a deep, comforting sense of safety.

"Hey!" Bow's call broke through the quiet intimacy of the moment and both girls snapped around to look at him. "Are you two gonna walk home or…?"

Chuckling, Glimmer removed herself from Adora's arms, taking her hand instead and leading her towards Bow's bug. They played Bow's Paraless CD again on the way home to cap off the night,

while Adora and Glimmer kept their respective gazes trained out the window in the backseat. Considering the size of Bow's bug, they were already pressed fairly close together. Adora's hand lay resting open against the seat, near Glimmer's thigh although she refused to look anywhere but out the window. Glimmer studied it a while, as they drove, Adam singing quietly to the songs they'd heard in concert a few hours ago. She looked up in time to see Adam take Bow's hand off the stick shift, linking their fingers together and kissing his knuckles. Bow turned to him with a sappy grin and Glimmer looked back down at Adora's waiting hand.

Slowly, she let her own hand drop into the blonde's palm, a warm tingle spreading through her body as Adora's fingers immediately laced around her own. She looked up, half expecting those soft blue eyes to be on her, but Adora still sat turned away, her forehead pressed against the car window. Glimmer squeezed her hand softly and then turned away as well, watching the stars float by outside.

The ride home was too short. Soon enough, they were parked inside Adora's apartment complex, Adam hanging out the window, almost comically large.

"Hey, Adora," he called out and the blonde turned to face him. He gestured her back towards the car. Adora glanced once at Glimmer before dropping her hand and returning to the bug. Adam grabbed her jacket and tugged her down, cupping one large hand against her ear, his blue eyes flickering to Glimmer as he whispered something.

The confused crease between Adora's brow disappeared and her lips quirked into a smile as Adam released her. Whatever conspiratorial secret they'd shared, Glimmer could only imagine how full of 'dumb jock energy' it was. Adam pushed her back towards Glimmer, shouting, "I'll see you at the gym tomorrow! G'night ladies!"

Adora chuckled, watching the bug peel off before returning to Glimmer's side and taking her hand once again.

“What did he say?” Glimmer asked as she followed Adora up the stairs, their arm swinging between them.

Adora shook her head. “Something dumb. He’s dumb.”

“You like him though,” Glimmer nudged Adora with her shoulder.

“Sure,” she agreed, pushing open the apartment door after a brief one-handed struggle with her keys. “He’s like the brother I never had.”

Glimmer was already tucked into bed by the time Adora joined her. She tried not to stare but failed miserably; her eyes roaming Adora’s lean form as she paused to check her phone on the bedside table. The low lamp light accentuated the strong curve of her thighs, her broad shoulders that crept out from beneath the light sleep tank top she wore. Her golden hair fell in loose waves, partially hiding the undercut that Glimmer could practically feel beneath her fingertips.

Adora set her phone down suddenly, looking up and Glimmer quickly tore her eyes away, staring at the ceiling—praying it was hopelessly obvious that she’d just been ogling her roommate. If Adora noticed, she didn’t say it out loud; instead slipping underneath the covers and turning off the lights. The room fell into relative darkness, the soft silver glow of the moon through the thin curtains the only source of light.

Glimmer rolled onto her side, away from Adora, trying to ignore how the high of the evening was slowly fading into the same aching loneliness she felt every night. Even with Adora right beside her. Somehow, even so close, it still felt as if they were a million worlds away from one another. Glimmer didn’t even know how to begin bridging the gap. For as often as they pretended, they were okay, that *this* was okay… Glimmer knew they couldn’t keep it up forever. They existed in a tiny bubble. A fragile one that was about to burst. She could feel it every time they looked at each other.

Someday, one of them would grow tired of the game. Of the hurt. They would find someone else. Someone who could give them what they *needed*. And then what? Would they be friends? Would they explode in another devastating argument? Glimmer had been trying so hard to protect herself, she didn't think how devastating it would be to inevitably lose Adora again.

Exhaling a shaky breath, trying not to ruin a fantastic night by breaking down into tears, Glimmer forced her eyes shut in an attempt to sleep. They shot back open the moment she felt Adora's strong arm slip around her waist and pull her back against her chest.

Rule breaking: no cuddling.

But Glimmer's heart was aching too much to care and Adora's body felt so *good* pressed against hers. Every curve complimented her own. The contrast of strength and soft was intoxicating. Adora's lips found the back of her neck, a single tender kiss landing on her skin before Adora breathed out a deep sigh. She didn't say anything, not even a murmured 'good night'. But she didn't need to. Like in the parking lot, this moment between them felt packed with thousands of silent confessions. Glimmer couldn't even begin to unravel what she was feeling before Adora's warm feet tangled with hers and she was entirely locked in the embrace of the woman she—

--*Fuck.*

Silent tears slid down Glimmer's cheeks.

It took a long time before she was finally able to sleep, Adora's body sagged against hers, deep breaths indicating she'd had no such issue. When sleep finally did come, Glimmer's dreams were full of visions she knew she could never have.

That deep down she knew she wanted with all her heart.

Adora was going to ask her.

It was time.

If anything, although they'd had that big fight regarding Angella a little over a week prior. Things seemed different now. Better, more casual and intimate. Adora didn't want to assume Glimmer's feelings but—She had to at least *try*.

The worst that could happen is that Glimmer would turn her down…. And if that were the case, Adora would just play it off as a joke or something!

She'd ignore the heartache. Everything would be *fine*. Glimmer wouldn't turn her down! She *had* to feel the same way. She'd allowed so many rules to slip through the cracks recently. She was probably just scared too. She didn't want to frighten Adora off by asking her first.

That had to be it.

Adora just needed to find the right moment. But every time she tried; the words caught in her throat. Okay so… Maybe a confession wasn't a great idea. Maybe something smaller? A real date.

Just a date!

The start of a potential 'official' relationship.

That much she could totally handle.

She wasn't entirely sure how it happened the moment it did—She was laying back against the pillows, Glimmer hovering above her, practically glowing in the moonlight. Her eyes were so beautiful, her soft hips beneath Adora's hands, lip caught between her teeth as she prepared to lower herself onto the strap.

The moment was too charged. Full of desire and *need* and want.

The words bubbled up and out of Adora before she could even try to stop them. "Glim, do you wanna go on a real date with me?"

Glimmer froze, hovering almost impressively over Adora, her eyes blown wide. As the silence stretched Adora felt an icy chill spread through her body. She could feel Glimmer tense as a strung bow beneath her hands.

"What?" she asked finally, her voice small.

It was then that Adora realized the mistake she'd made. She must have misinterpreted Glimmer's feelings. It was just—Everything lately—They'd seemed to be just as close as they had been all those years ago. Back when Adora had been ready to confess how she felt underneath the stars.

"A… A date," Adora tried to force a chuckle, it came out more as a choke. "Or… Not. We could—We could just hang out as friends. I just—You know the concert seemed a little like…. A—and before that, with the bar. I thought—,"

Glimmer's weight was gone in an instant. Adora jolted upward, staring after her, regret cold and heavy in her stomach as Glimmer gathered her clothes.

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer didn't respond, simply tugging her clothes on and shaking her head, body trembling.

"I'm sorry, Glim," Adora tried, scooting to the edge of the bed, still wearing nothing but the ridiculous strap. "I was—I was just kidding. We—I didn't mean it like that—,"

"Yes, you did," Glimmer's voice was shaky and too high. "You meant it exactly how you said it. You—You promised me, Adora."

"I promised you?" Adora's head was spinning too quickly for her to understand.

"You fucking promised me, 'no feelings'," Glimmer shot back, practically storming for the door. "That was the deal. No falling in love. No strings attached."

“There aren’t any feelings!” Adora insisted, lying, desperate for Glimmer to stay. “It’s just a date! Please, I’m sorry—Glimmer! We don’t have to. Just talk to me. Wait—!”

The bedroom door opened and then slammed shut. A few pounding footsteps and Adora heard the front door do the same. She sat naked on the bed, staring into the darkness in shock. Wondering how she could have possibly been so wrong.

She’d been so sure.

But the bubble had finally burst.

Okay, fuck….Glimmer definitely should not have gotten this drunk. The entire street was blurry, and she was 87% sure she was being followed, hopefully not by some creep who intended to fuck with her.

But god, how could she not have gone out to get completely shit faced? After Adora crossed the *fucking* line. She was so far past the line it wasn't even funny anymore. Yeah, she broke rules sometimes and it was kinda cute, and endearing and… ignorable.

But asking her on a date? A real date? Exploring feelings? That they *weren't* supposed to have? They'd promised each other. That's why Glimmer had allowed this all to happen in the first fucking place. It was simple. Easy. No commitment or expectations or confusing emotions...No broken promises. Why did Adora have to go and ruin a good thing?

Again?

Fuck her.

Glimmer tripped on an uneven piece of sidewalk, nearly face planting on the concrete when she fell against *someone* instead.

"Jesus, watch where you're going," a harsh voice snarled as ridiculously strong arms shoved her back to her feet. "Who let you

wander around this drunk? You--oh come on...,"

Glimmer blinked up at the person currently verbally assaulting her. It took a moment for her swimming vision to clear before she could make out the vague shape of--

"Catra."

The woman's nose wrinkled, and she drew herself up taller than the already slumped over Glimmer.

"Of all the drunk idiots to run into…"

Glimmer flared at the insult, only slightly comforted by the fact that she knew Catra was only angry to see her, because the last time they'd been face-to-face she'd been shamelessly fucking Adora.

"Let me guess," Catra drawled, glancing over her shoulder. "You two went out to get wasted and horny? Where is she?"

"Who?" Glimmer asked innocently, enjoying the way Catra bristled.

"Adora. Or did you forget you two are supposed to be attached at the clit?"

"Adora can suck my dick," Glimmer slurred, wishing her brain was operating at more than 25% for the insult factor.

Catra cocked a single brow. "You mean she hasn't? Weird...She always did it for me."

Glimmer felt the angry ember burning in her chest suddenly ignite at the image of Adora on her knees for this absolute shit stain of a human being.

"Guess we know who's strap she prefers then," Catra simpered in a mock sing song voice. "I knew I she'd come crawling back eventually. You're just not her type, Sparkles."

"What's her—,"Glimmer hickuped. "Type then? Dumb jerks?"

Nailed it.

Catra just smirked and shook her head. "It's certainly not fat drunk sluts like you."

Glimmer balked, wanting both to cry at this very moment and punch Catra square in the jaw. She was fairly sure she'd miss if she even tried though.

"Do you seriously think anything is going to come of this thing with her?" Catra sneered, prowling closer as Glimmer to a step back. "You're a fucking barmaid, drunk off her ass, wandering the streets at midnight, looking for what? To get mugged? Adora deserves better than you. She actually has a chance to do something with her life."

The fury inside Glimmer was growing with every word, beating down the insecurities Catra brought up out of sheer hatred.

"We're not together, it doesn't matter," she spat, her words not nearly as vitriolic when she was slurring them.

"You're right, it doesn't. And I'll help her kick your sorry ass to the curb if it's the last thing I do."

Glimmer shouldn't have said what she said next, but she was so unbelievably angry.

"You're just mad I ruined your prom. Betcha were hoping to get laid and not blueball in juvie for the night, right?"

Catra's eyes narrowed and then widened with realization. "That was you? *You* planted the weed?"

Glimmer gave her a smile and sloppy wink. "All's fair in love and war, kitten."

Glimmer wasn't entirely sure what happened next. In one instant Catra was snarling and in the next, Glimmer's cheek stung, and her head spun and then she was on the cool concrete, a loud ringing filling her ears. She tried to push herself back up, but her limbs had turned to water, every muscle abandoning her.

"Fuck you, Sparkles. Rot in the gutter for all I care."

Catra's voice and the sound of her footsteps retreated until all Glimmer could hear was the sounds of cars passing her by. And even those began to fade.

As black consumed her vision, a final thought crossed her mind.

'If this ends here...maybe Dad will be waiting for me…'

Chapter End Notes

Paramore please don't sue me, I love you.

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

I've had this chapter written and stored away for over two months now ... I hope it lives up to expectations. Many thanks to my awesome co-author EtherianFrigatebird for all the help up to this point and beyond ;-;

Summary: The greatest teacher failure is.

(I also illustrated a bit of this chapter months ago:

https://freezingmyblitzballs.tumblr.com/post/613580007225294848/i-thoughtthe-last-thing-i-thought-before-i

)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora drove through the dark streets, eyes scanning every minute movement she caught passing under streetlamps. Glimmer's phone was off, dead, or silenced because the 50th call Adora tried went immediately to voicemail.

God, she shouldn't have said what she'd said. She shouldn't have broken the rules. But they'd been getting so much closer lately. She'd thought maybe…

Well, she hadn't known what she'd thought. But she hadn't expected Glimmer to *panic*, let alone run and disappear for hours without a word. She knew Bow was looking on the other side of town, but as it got later and later, Adora was beginning to wonder what state they'd find her in. If they found her at all.

'*Please be okay,'* she begged to no one. *'I need you to be okay. I need you.'*

It had to be irony, or cruel fate maybe, that she saw Catra strolling along the sidewalk, hands stuffed deep in her pockets and a scowl etched onto her face.

"Catra!" Adora leaned out the window of her truck, waving to grab her ex's attention. Catra certainly saw her, but she scoffed and turned on her heel, walking quickly in the other direction.

"*Catra!"* Pulling up to the curb and parking, Adora leapt out of the truck, jogging a few steps to catch up with Catra. "Hey! Stop. What's with you?"

"I've had enough of you and your fuck buddy tonight, thank you very much."

Adora brightened. "You've seen Glimmer? Where?"

Catra's scowl deepened. "Are you kidding me, Adora? What is with you and her anyway? She's a fucking deadbeat. Always has been. You didn't want anything to do with her in high school, what changed?"

Adora opened her mouth to try to defend Glimmer when she realized that wasn't more important than her safety right now. "Forget it, Catra. We can talk about it another time. Just tell me where she is, please. She needs me."

"Yeah, that much is fucking obvious, Adora. But you don't need her. She's just going to drag you down whatever pit she's dug for herself."

"Catra."

Catra glowered at her for a long moment before jerking her chin in the opposite direction. "She passed out that way a while ago."

"Damn it…," Adora spun on her heel, hurrying down the street as fast as she could.

"You're fucking welcome!" Catra called after her, but Adora ignored her, breath coming in sharp pants as she saw a crumpled figure lying halfway in the street.

The outfit became recognizable as Glimmer's as she drew closer. Adora's heart came to a jarring halt in her chest.

"Glimmer!" She cried out, dropping to her knees beside her crumpled body. Adora picked her halfway up, taking her out of the disgusting rain gutter and cradling her to get a better look at her face. Her bottom lip was split and bleeding, her cheek swelling and there was a large lump on her head where Adora had assumed she'd hit the ground. She reeked of booze and was out cold, but at least she was alive and breathing. Adora felt shaky with relief as she scooped Glimmer up and headed quickly back to the truck. She'd take her home and doctor her and they would talk, and everything would be okay.

It's fine. It's fine. Everything will be fine.

Everything was not fine. It took Glimmer awhile to wake up, but when she did, she was violently ill. Adora barely got her to the bathroom in time before she remained glued to the toilet bowl for the next hour and a half. Adora only left her side to make trips to the kitchen to refill the water glass she kept expelling.

As she returned for the 5th time, a blanket draped over her arm too (the fuzzy pink one Glimmer liked), she paused in the doorway, taking Glimmer in.

The cut on her lip had opened and was bleeding again. Her swollen cheek/eye was turning into a big dark bruise and the lump on her head had grown into a genuine goose egg. She was pale and shivering, curled around the toilet bowl that Adora would have to give a thorough cleaning later.

She looked absolutely awful, miserable and smaller than Adora had ever seen her. It made her heart ache, each beat a piercing

throb in her chest.

"Here," Adora said, setting the glass down on the floor and draping the blanket over her shoulders as she plopped down behind Glimmer, resting against the edge of the tub. Glimmer nudged the glass away, but Adora pulled it back and held it up.

"You need to drink, Glim," she urged.

"I can't keep it down." Glimmer's mumble was weak, Adora had to strain to hear it.

"Try smaller sips, really tiny. You need to try to stay hydrated."

Adora waited patiently with the glass until Glimmer finally took it in a shaky hand and took the tiniest of sips. She leaned back down against the toilet bowl afterwards, resting her cheek on her forearm and letting out a shaky sigh.

Adora rubbed a comforting hand down her back, through the blanket, gently, not too much pressure, just enough to let her know she was still there.

"Why are you helping me?" Glimmer asked suddenly, in a dull voice, so null of emotion that is scared Adora.

"What do you mean 'why am I helping you'?"

Glimmer didn't immediately respond, instead wiping the blood from her split lip away and then spitting into the toilet, grimacing at the taste in her mouth.

"Here," Adora rose and grabbed her toothbrush, plastering on a fair amount of toothpaste on before handing it back to Glimmer. She took it, slowly scrubbing her mouth down before using half of Adora's water glass to rinse it out. She flushed the toilet once again, watching the water swirl silently as Adora sat down behind her again, this time so she sat facing Glimmer's back.

"I want to help you," she answered. "I broke a promise a long time ago…"

Glimmer snorted; her next words spoken with vitriol. "Oh, and you want to fix that now?"

"No…," Adora reached out to feel Glimmer again, feel the rise of fall of each breath. Proof she was alive, that she hadn't been too late. "I can't fix the past now. But I can make sure I never make the same mistake again."

Glimmer was quiet for a moment, her breathing steady, if not a bit shallow underneath Adora's palm. It hitched very suddenly and then Glimmer sniffed loudly and pressed her face further into the crook of her arm.

"I'm sorry," she murmured, voice almost completely muffled.

Adora didn't ask to clarify what she was apologizing for. At this point between them, it could have been anything. But she didn't want to see Glimmer cry, she *hated* that. So she scooted forward, unfolding her legs to frame Glimmer between them and she pressed herself against the smaller girl's back, wrapping her arms around her waist and resting her cheek against Glimmer's shoulder. The position hurt a little bit, with both of them so hunched over. But it was as close as she could think to be. And Glimmer didn't push her away, she just began to tremble a bit more, her breaths still harsh and tearful.

"It's okay." It was all Adora could think to say as she sat there, holding her as tightly as she dared, pressing her face into the blanket and squeezing her eyes shut. "You're safe and that's what matters."

"I… Don't deserve it…," Glimmer replied, keeping her words slow to avoid the embarrassing stutter of sob-speak. "Catra was right about me 'n you have ...so much going for you. And I'm just--,"

"Wait, Catra?" Adora stopped her. "You talked to Catra?"

Glimmer just nodded, face still hidden.

Sighing, Adora let her cheek fall back against Glimmer's shoulder. "Catra is really good at saying awful things. At making you feel really small."

"Yeah," Glimmer agreed quietly.

"But that doesn't make what she says true." Reaching up with one hand, keeping the other locked on Glimmer's waist, Adora ran her fingers through the soft, downy hair at the base of Glimmer's neck, smiling slightly when the other woman almost immediately sagged beneath her.

"She used to make me feel like she was the only person I could depend on in the entire world," Adora continued as she let her fingers creep higher to run through the rest of Glimmer's hair. "If I didn't have her, I was nothing. If she didn't have me, she'd fall apart. It was messy and manipulative, and I couldn't even see it for the longest time because when she wasn't all of that, she was nice, and she made me forget…"

Adora trailed off, unsure of what she desperately wanted to say would scare Glimmer off again. So instead, she continued to play with Glimmer's hair gently, mussing the black strands at the top and dragging through to where the purple ends were fading to pink.

"Forget what...?" Glimmer prodded after a moment of silence, peeking out of her arm.

Adora met her watery gaze, hoping to convey all the love she'd ever felt for Glimmer in the next few words.

"That I'd lost you."

Glimmer hid her face again and Adora felt her shaking worsen, so she wrapped both arms around her tightly, squeezing to remind her that she was still there.

"After—Micah died...After we started to drift apart—and then the fight….I'd never felt so lost in my entire life. But I couldn't stop. Life wouldn't let me slow down and so I just got swept away in a current I couldn't control. And by the time I got back on my feet, you were gone, and I knew I'd broken every promise I'd made to always be there for you. To be your friend no matter what. And that hurt more than losing *him* did, Glimmer."

Glimmer's shoulders shook, jostling Adora so much she had to sit back a bit.

"I want to be here for you now because—I still care about you so much. You're still my best friend. And I'm in a better place to help you find the support you need now. You know?"

Glimmer nodded and Adora knew that her walls were finally lowered enough for Adora to gently offer suggestions.

"I want to find someone to help with the drinking, Glim. It's dangerous now. If I hadn't been able to find you tonight--,"

"I know." Glimmer sniffed, heaving a shaky sigh as some of the trembles left her body.

"And maybe someone to talk to about your Dad." Adora knew that was a riskier suggestion. "That really helped me...I know someone you might like, actually."

Glimmer didn't physically respond, but after a moment she leaned away from the toilet bowl and back against Adora, head resting on her shoulder.

"I thought--the last thing I thought, before I passed out….was that I might see him again…," Glimmer whimpered.

Immediately her voice broke and her face scrunched up and Adora used the new position to bury her face in Glimmer's neck as she rocked them both slowly. Her own hot tears began to spring forward as she imagined Glimmer accepting defeat tonight.

Losing her too.

Again.

"You miss him," she said, her lips brushing Glimmer's neck in a way that made her shiver. "You never really grieved for him."

"I've been 'grieving' him for three years," Glimmer objected with a dry laugh.

"But not how you need to.” A few hot tears slipped down Adora’s cheeks, wetting Glimmer's collar.

"Yeah…," Glimmer agreed, and then she stiffened when Adora sniffed. "Are you crying?"

"No," The blonde insisted even as she wiped her teary cheeks on Glimmer's shoulder.

"I don't like it when you cry…"

"Well, I don't like it when *you* cry."

Glimmer chuckled wetly, slumping slightly into Adora's arms, further surrendering herself to the embrace.

"Thank you for being here for me tonight. And... I’m sorry…," she said again. "I know I smell and look like shit."

"You don't smell good, no," Adora agreed, with a slight elbow from Glimmer. "But I think you always look nice."

Glimmer peeked at her from the corner of her eye, smiling lightly as Adora pressed a gentle kiss to the trail of moons beneath her ear.

"Rule breaker...," she teased, but there was no anger behind her words this time.

"Mm, that's me," Adora replied, kissing her again, more firmly this time. "A total rebel."

Glimmer hummed, allowing herself to be rocked gently for a few peaceful moments. It wasn't long, however, before she blurted:

"Did you really suck Catra's strap?"

Adora tucked her face into Glimmer's neck again as it began to burn red hot. She didn't even want to imagine how Glimmer had learned that.

"Can we not talk about that, please?"

Glimmer twisted slightly in her arms in an attempt to gape at her. "You *did?!"*

Huffing, Adora slumped them back against the wall, keeping herself hidden in Glimmer's neck to avoid her gaze.

"I'm sorry!" Glimmer said upon feeling the heat in Adora's face. "I just...It's really hard to picture that."

Adora chewed on her bottom lip, trying to decide how she should respond as Glimmer leaned back against her again and rested her smaller hands over Adora's.

"I didn't like it…," Adora began, finally, and Glimmer perked in her arms. "I hated it, actually. But I did it because I thought that's what a good girlfriend did...I didn't want to disappoint her. Or...you know…"

"...Or what?"

Adora heaved a weary sigh. "Or lose her too."

"Oh."

They fell silent again, Adora growing sleepy as Glimmer traced gentle fingers over her own calloused ones.

"I like, uh...things, better with you," Adora admitted, the exhaustion and emotional weight of the night destroying her

barriers. "It makes me feel *really* good to be able to do things for you…" she paused and cleared her throat self-consciously, "*To* you…"

To her surprise, Glimmer hummed contentedly in response. She slipped her fingers through Adora's lacing them together. "I like things with you better too. You're a good top."

Adora snorted nervously. "Uh, thanks…?"

"I mean it," Glimmer's smile was sad. "I've had a lot of not so nice partners. It can really suck with the wrong person."

Adora pursed her lips, fighting to quell the spark of jealousy that flared inside her imagining anyone but her getting to touch Glimmer.

"My first time was...pretty fucking awful," Glimmer chuckled darkly. Adora remained quiet, keeping her arms locked firmly around Glimmer's waist, which she seemed to take comfort in. "I didn't even know the girl. It was at some party, we were drunk. I kept thinking about you and Catra and I just wanted to...make it all go away. I guess I thought if someone fucked me, I'd forget you. Fall for someone else. I wouldn't hurt anymore. So I did. I didn't know what I was doing and I didn't tell her it was my first time and, even if I had...I don't think she would have cared."

'Wait… Fall for someone else?'

Before Adora could think about what that implied, a scene played out before her in her mind. A younger Glimmer, already shattered from losing her father, breaking further underneath some stranger's uncaring touch. She hated it. It made her stomach twist sickeningly.

"Needless to say, it hurt, and I cried afterwards. I called Bow and had him pick me up. Passed out at home and felt like dying the next morning."

"I'm sorry…"

"Don't be," Glimmer turned a bit in her arms to face her more properly. "You're here now. I'm safe with you."

One of Glimmer's hands rose, her fingers tracing the edge of Adora's jaw. Despite the emotional tax the conversation had taken, Adora felt her heart beginning to flutter at the look in Glimmer's eye. It wasn't the usual lust, or the playful twinkle. It was something deeper, and softer than Adora had ever seen before, and it captured her, keeping her very still as Glimmer drew steadily closer. Adora kept her eyes locked on Glimmer's only allowed them to slide shut when she felt Glimmer's hand slide around to gently cup the back of her neck.

Moments before Glimmer's lips touched hers, Adora's phone rang, buzzing so loudly against the tile floor that they jumped apart as if they'd been caught red handed.

"It's Bow," Adora reassured her as she caught a glimpse of the caller ID. "I'm sure he just wants to know you're still alive."

Glimmer nodded, looking at Adora owlishly as she reached for the phone. Adora knew her cheeks were burning. They'd almost kissed. Not that they hadn't done plenty of that in the past few month.

But this one felt different.

"Hey, Bow," Adora cradled the phone between her cheek and shoulder as Glimmer occupied her arms again.

"Adora, how's Glimmer? Has she woken up yet?"

"She has. It's been a rough couple of hours, but she's okay now," Adora replied, smiling slightly as Glimmer played with her fingers in her lap.

"Thank god...Okay, if you guys are alright, I'm gonna get some sleep. Swing by tomorrow, maybe? I'd like to talk to her."

"Yeah," Adora agreed. "Sounds good Bow."

They said their goodnights and Adora tossed the phone aside, nudging Glimmer to get her attention.

"Can I run you a nice bath? Perfect way to end a long night."

"Or start an early morning," Glimmer said, pointing to her phone screen, it read 2:32 a.m.

"That too. Come on, stinky," Adora said as she rose from the bathroom floor, helping Glimmer up with her.

"Hey, you said I was nice!"

"I said you looked nice. You *smell* like a garbage truck ran over you," Adora teased over her shoulder, turning on the hot water for the bath as she spoke.

A sharp smack on her rear made her straighten. She glanced around to see Glimmer pinning her with an affronted glare.

"Say one more thing, I dare you."

Adora mimed zipping her lips, packing away the feeling the sharp smack had set afire in her gut and adding a bottle full of bubbles to the water.

"All yours, Princess," Adora kept up the banter as she stepped away from the tub, pulling out a fluffy towel and setting it on the counter for Glimmer's convenience.

"Wait." Glimmer grabbed her wrist before she could leave, tugging her back a step. "Stay…"

Glimmer looked shyer than Adora had ever seen her before, and she couldn't seem to hold the blonde's gaze.

"Stay?" Adora clarified, her voice losing its teasing edge.

Glimmer nodded, pulling Adora into a sudden hug. "With me… Please? The tub's big enough. And you don't smell so great

either."

Slowly, Adora let her arms wrap around Glimmer, gathering her closer.

"Okay," she murmured.

They'd assumed the same position they had outside the tub, with Glimmer resting between Adora's thighs, her cheek pressed to the blonde's chest. But despite the very beautiful, very naked woman between her legs, Adora had spent the last ten minutes doing little more than running the loofa over her arms and legs. The gentle touch was putting Glimmer to sleep, Adora could feel long lashes fluttering against her skin.

Setting the loofah aside, Adora dumped a bit of shampoo in her palm, scrubbing it into Glimmer's hair as gently as she could. Glimmer hummed and leaned into her touch.

"Y'r good at that," she mumbled.

"Touching you? I know."

Glimmer grunted. "Don't make the hair washing thing gross, weirdo."

Adora laughed, dumping a cup of water straight over her head and making her gasp as her wet hair spilled over her eyes.

"Jerk," Glimmer grumbled, spitting soap spuds out as she pinched Adora's thigh. Adora flinched, but wrapped Glimmer up in her arms again, nudging her wet hair aside to kiss each of the small moons on her neck. Her favorite spot, she was realizing.

It was nearing 3:45 in the morning before the two of them fell into bed, both significantly refreshed and not covered in actual blood, sweat and tears.

Adora kicked back the comforter, making space for Glimmer to pull the pillows between them, like usual. But she surprised the blonde, squirming across the king size mattress to fully cuddle against Adora's side, one arm draping across her waist, warm and heavy.

Adora was too shocked, and too pleased to even *joke* about breaking the rules. Instead, she turned onto her side, taking Glimmer in both arms and tucking her chin against the soft pink/purple fluff of her hair. It was almost startling how easily they fit together, like missing puzzle pieces. Glimmer heaved a weary sigh, squeezing Adora and slipping a leg between her own, loosely tangling every limb. Now as close as they could possibly be, Adora allowed herself to admit that she wanted this every night. Closeness without restrictions. True intimacy. Both physical and emotional, as they'd been tonight.

She could tell Glimmer was still awake by the way she squirmed every now and then, her toes curling against Adora's calf. Gently, Adora ran a hand up and down her back, smooth and rhythmic, until she felt Glimmer's breathing began to slow.

"I wi...sh…," the words Glimmer was murmuring were barely loud enough to make out, but Adora strained her ears nevertheless.

"You wish…?" She prompted softly; curiosity piqued.

"I wish you had been my first…," Glimmer finished her sentence with a soft snore, leaving Adora to reel with a devastating confession.

She could have been.

She *should* have been.

Adora had been hours away from telling Glimmer how she felt all those years ago…She used to picture it, *being* with Glimmer. It used to scare her until Glimmer startled cuddling her when she had nightmares during their sleepovers. Until she sang away her anxieties and made her cry laughing every day at lunch with

dumb jokes and kissed her forehead when her evil foster mother tried to assault her. Then it became easier to imagine them crossing that line. More than friends. And all that came with that.

Yeah...She wished too.

But she had this moment, now. Glimmer's warmth surrounding her, gentle arms holding her, lips pressed softly to her neck. It was more than she'd ever dreamed of back then. A few quiet tears slipped down Adora's cheeks before she could even try to stop them, wetting strands of Glimmer's hair. Luckily, the shaky breaths did not wake her sleeping partner. The night had been so exhausting for her, Adora doubted anything *could*.

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Adora woke before Glimmer, rising quietly, so as not to wake her and heading for the kitchen. They'd both skipped dinner last night, and Adora wondered if a nice breakfast would be welcome. Glimmer would probably be dealing with the most massive hangover she'd ever had; food might not be the first thing on her mind.

Changing direction, Adora headed for the medicine cabinet grabbing a bottle of Advil and a glass of water. But the time she'd washed her face, brushed her teeth and combed her hair, Glimmer was waking. Adora slipped inside the bedroom, crossing to close the blinds to block out the morning rays as Glimmer groaned from the bed.

Smiling softly to herself, Adora sat down on the edge of the bed beside Glimmer, tipping two pills into her palm and tapping Glimmer's shoulder, or rather, tapping the blanket she was hiding under.

"Hangover?" she teased, and Glimmer moaned in response.

"Every second I breathe is one I suffer…"

Chuckling, Adora nudged her again until Glimmer peaked out from beneath the blankets. Adora handed her the pills and water, bracing herself against one arm as she watched Glimmer gulp the medicine.

Sighing heavily, Glimmer set the glass down on the bedside table and lay back against the pillows, her eyes dark and heavy lidded. Despite the exhaustion and pain clear in her expression, she smiled at Adora, reaching for her hand, and holding it against her chest. Adora could feel her heartbeat fluttering beneath it.

"Good morning," she murmured. Adora smiled, squeezing her hand in response. "Do you have work today?"

"I'll call out," Adora assured her, scooting a little closer so that she was sitting pressed against the curve of Glimmer's hips. "I think I might be needed a little more here today."

Glimmer lifted one hand, letting it trail up Adora's arm until it cupped her cheek. Adora felt her heart flutter, swelling with affection as Glimmer brushed a soft thumb across her cheek.

"Thank you," Glimmer murmured before slipping her hand around the back of Adora's neck and pulling her down.

Adora's heart pounded against her chest, butterflies filling her gut as if she were back in high school. As if she hadn't kissed this girl hundreds of times before this moment. Even still, as Glimmer's soft lips touched her own, Adora found herself melting into her embrace. Glimmer's hand moved up her neck to scratch at the fuzz of her undercut.

Adora shivered, humming softly against Glimmer's lips; they quirked into a smile beneath hers.

Any second, Adora was prepared for the kiss to turn heated. For Glimmer's tongue to brush her lips. But it remained soft, innocent...Sweet.

They pulled apart slowly, Adora making sure to brush her nose against Glimmer's as she beamed down at her roommate.

"I'll be right back," she assured Glimmer, pressing another quick kiss to her nose before heading to the living room to call Lonnie.

Her excuse wasn't foolproof, but Lonnie didn't seem to care and Adora snuck back into the bedroom, eager to be with Glimmer again.

She was asleep, or close to it, by the time Adora returned. Still in her pjs, Adora slipped underneath the sheets as carefully as she could so as not to wake Glimmer. It didn't seem to matter. As soon as Adora was settled against the pillows, Glimmer rolled over and snuggled against her side, draping both an arm and a leg over her.

"You're so warm…," Glimmer hummed, nuzzling into Adora's neck, the lightest of kisses landing against her skin.

"A human furnace," Adora agreed, stroking a hand down Glimmer's back as she pulled out her phone with the other hand, preparing to settle in for a long, relaxing day as Glimmer slept off her hangover.

Glimmer fell asleep quickly, her body going heavy and limp against Adora's as she scrolled through her Netflix feed. She picked an episode of the first recommended cartoon that showed up on her feed, turning occasionally to press gentle kisses against Glimmer's forehead. She mumbled quietly every time Adora did, her lips curling against the blonde's neck.

Adora watched, or pretended to watch, the magical princess show playing on her phone for awhile before admitting to herself that she wasn't even paying attention. With Glimmer fast asleep beside her, Adora chanced a quick text to Bow.

-'Hey, Glimmer won't be able to come by today she's absolutely beat.'

Bow's response was almost immediate, as if he'd been waiting (he probably had).

-'that's fine, as long as she's okay?'

-'she will be.'

-'are you?'

Adora was about to type out an instinctual yes when she paused to consider the events of the past 24 hours. In the months that she'd been falling for her best friend, the only person she'd really talked to about their relationship was Lonnie. And back then it had been nothing more than a joking 'I'm lowkey banging my roommate'. Bow knew though… He had to. Glimmer must have told him at some point. If she hadn't… Adora was about to. Because she realized she *needed* to talk to someone about her feelings. About what to do to help Glimmer. And who better to ask than *their* old friend (who also happened to be studying therapy)?

And she realized… no, she wasn't okay. She hadn't been in a long time. Catra had pointed it out first: 'you're lying to yourself, Adora.' But deep down, Adora had known the words to be true long beforehand.

-'no.'

-'Wanna talk about it?'

It was a lot to explain over text, but yes, she did.

-'can I call u?'

-'of course.'

Carefully, very carefully, Adora wiggled her way out of Glimmer's arms. Luckily, she remained dead to the world, curling around Adora's pillow as the blonde crept out of the bedroom. She waited until she was outside on the patio, gazing out at the slowly waking city of Bright Moon before dialing Bow.

“Hey,” he sounded as tired as Adora felt. “What’s going on? Everything okay?”

The first words she tried to speak were choked back by hot tears. She’d been stuffing it all down for Glimmer’s comfort. All her feelings, her pain, her own comfort… To be absolutely sure that she wouldn’t lose Glimmer again. But in the process, she’d severely neglected herself.

“I don’t know what to do anymore, Bow,” Adora finally whimpered through a throat that was tight with tears. Bow didn’t speak and Adora took that as permission to let it all out. “Last night was fucking terrifying. I found her in a *gutter*. And it was my fault! If I hadn’t asked her out, she wouldn’t have run—I knew the rules and I ignored them because I’m… I’m selfish. I’m selfish and I’m stupid and I’m—I’m in—,”

“Adora, hey—,”

“—I just care about her so much, Bow.” Silence rang on the line as they both processed that confession. Adora let out a watery, somewhat hysterical, chuckle. “So much. But I can’t. Or I’m not allowed to. It’s too much for her, it’s not what she wants. I’m trying so hard to make her happy… To *help* her and it’s like nothing I do matters…”

“Adora,” Bow heaved a weary sigh. “For as long as I’ve known you, you’ve been the kind of person who carries your friends’ burdens for them. You’re empathetic and kind and you’ve got a hero complex the size of Mt. Everest.”

“I don’t—,”

“And, trust me, I know what it feels like to want to help Glimmer when she spirals like this. I’ve been in your shoes for years.”

Adora tried not to let the guilt of their falling out after high school creep up.

"But look, at the end of the day, if Glimmer wants help… It has to be her decision. She's going to have to be the one to look inside herself, figure out what she wants, and make the change. And there's nothing you, me or anyone else can do about it no matter how much we love her."

"I—," Adora trailed off, deciding not to argue Bow's final words. "Then… What do I do now?"

"At the very least, talk to her," Bow replied. "I think it's fair she hears your real feelings, where you're coming from, how her actions are affecting you. It might help her see things differently. Who knows? She really cares about you too, Adora. Even if she's too much of a mess to show it sometimes."

"Talk to her," Adora repeated slowly, trying to imagine a scenario in which Glimmer would actually hear her out.

"Just try, Adora…I think, maybe this time, she's ready to listen."

Adora hoped he was right.

After saying her goodbyes, Adora rejoined Glimmer in the bedroom. She was still asleep but seemed to stir slightly when the bedroom door creaked and shut. She groaned and pushed herself up, blinking blearily down at Adora's empty spot. When the seemed to realize the blonde was no longer beside her, she sat up straighter, head whipping around and Adora registered genuine panic in her bleary eyes.

"'Dora?" unfocused, tired eyes locked on Adora as she moved quickly towards the bed. It melted Adora's heart to hear that same sleepy affectionate nickname from their younger days. Chuckling and running a gentle hand through Glimmer's wild bedhead, Adora guided her back down before slipping underneath the covers beside her again.

"It's okay, Glim. I'm here."

Glimmer mumbled another question that Adora couldn't make out, one arm snaking tightly around the blonde's waist, presumably to keep her from disappearing again. Her quiet snores indicated she'd fallen back asleep.

Resigning herself to a day of literally mostly staring at the ceiling and swirling in her own thoughts, Adora sunk back against the pillows with a heavy sigh. At least she could practice what she was going to say to Glimmer.

Hopefully, this time without scaring her off.

The soft rays of early morning light creeping in through the bedroom window woke Adora the next morning. Somehow, although Glimmer had spent all of yesterday curled against Adora's side nursing the world's worst hangover, she had somehow woken before the blonde.

Adora blinked against the light, rubbing the sleep from her eyes and stretching the stiffness from her muscles. Spending all day in bed with Glimmer had been—admittedly a little boring as her roommate mostly just slept—but the opportunity to hold her without argument or occasionally kiss her forehead. Adora would do anything for more days like that. More little moments where she was allowed to love her completely.

A cold chill erased the warmth blooming inside of her as she realized that they should *definitely* talk today. They had to. They couldn't keep playing this game anymore, or one (or both) of them was going to get seriously hurt. The last thing Adora wanted was to lose Glimmer again; but losing her over the truth would be better than living a lie with her.

The bedroom door creaked open suddenly and Glimmer slipped back inside. She was holding a plate and a mug of what Adora could smell was coffee. She wore one of Adora's plaid button downs, large and too long on her, it fell well past her thighs. The first few buttons were undone, exposing most of her chest in a

way that was overwhelmingly comfortable and casual. The sight itself made Adora's heart swell with joy. It looked so… normal. Like this was how things were always supposed to be.

Her short hair was still wild and messy from sleep, sticking up in every possible direction. And the golden morning rays caught her lavender eyes; they practically glowed as she crossed the room and sat down on the edge of Adora's side of the bed, offering her the plate.

"What's this?" Adora asked, sitting up against the pillows, a smile growing on her lips.

"I felt like making you breakfast in bed," Glimmer shrugged, setting the plate of toast and jam on Adora's lap and handing her the mug.

Adora took it gratefully, tasting a sip. Black coffee. Heavy, earthy and pungent. She knew Glimmer couldn't stand it, but the fact that she'd made it just the way Adora liked it for her….

"Thanks, Glim. This is really thoughtful." She took another sip and then a quick bite of toast before setting both on the bedside table.

"I figured I owed you that much after the other night…" Glimmer's mouth twisted into an almost embarrassed frown as Adora took her hands and pulled her forward.

"C'mere."

To her surprise, Glimmer did not resist, allowing herself to be pulled further onto the bed until she perched next to Adora, on folded legs. Adora kept her grip on Glimmer's hands soft, running her thumbs over smooth knuckles.

"Feeling better today?"

"Much." Glimmer's eyes were soft and light, her face free of the heaviness it always seemed to carry. The last two days had done something to both of them. "Thank you for staying with me

yesterday. And—The day before. You didn't have to help me like you did. I… Probably don't deserve it."

Glimmer's gaze finally flickered away from hers, to their interlaced fingers. "I know I've treated you like shit these past few weeks."

Adora frowned at the same time Glimmer's face scrunched up. Releasing one of her hands, Adora cupped her cheek, bringing her eyes back up gently.

"I wanted to help," she murmured, thumb stroking Glimmer's skin. More than anything, she wanted to tell Glimmer how she really felt, as she gazed into her soft lavender eyes. But the words wouldn't come. And they probably wouldn't have been a good idea anyway, considering the panic that had led to the last few nights events. So instead, she settled on a few words that might serve to get her affection across without explicitly being the ones she knew Glimmer was afraid of:

"I'd do anything for you, Glim."

Glimmer's lips twitched into a smile she immediately tried to hide as she leaned into Adora's hand. Uneasy to break the tender moment, but knowing she needed to be honest with, Adora braced herself before speaking again. "Do you think, we can talk? About the other night? About stuff?"

Glimmer bit her lip, eyes leaving Adora's. "I thought we kinda did already."

"I think there's more that needs to be said."

Glimmer's hands fidgeted in her lap, but she did not resist so Adora continued on cautiously.

"I'm—I'm not—," Adora hadn't planned on starting out like this, in fact her entire speech had slipped entirely from her head. Instead, she spoke from her heart. "I'm not okay, Glim."

Glimmer looked up, pain and confusion etched on her face as Adora's hand dropped back into her lap. Adora tried to hold back the tears, she'd been trying to be the strong one for so long—But the second lavender eyes locked onto hers she choked and the next thing she knew, hot tears were slipping down her cheeks.

"I'm sorry," she whimpered, flinching slightly when Glimmer's hand landed on top of hers. She laced their fingers quickly, hoping to let Glimmer know silently that she wanted the contact even if she couldn't find the words.

"I just—," pushing past the tears Adora continued. "I'm worried about you. And I've been trying to hard to help you, to follow all these rules to make you comfortable. But—I feel like I'm messing up. Like, I can't do anything right anymore. I feel like I'm pushing you away just by caring about you and I can't—I don't even know how to deal with that. I can't turn off my heart… I want you to be happy and safe and my *friend*, you've always been so important to me. But you won't let me… And it's hurting me."

Glimmer's fingers were tight around hers, soft thumb rubbing over her knuckles. Adora couldn't look her in the eye, staring down at their hands instead. She was still searching for the words to continue when Glimmer spoke:

"I'm sorry, Adora," her own voice was choked. Adora didn't need to see her face to know she was also crying. "I've been treating you horribly… You're not the only one either. I know that I've been fucking things up with everyone. Bow, my mom… I—I even saw Mermista recently…"

"Your ex?" Adora finally looked up in shock, her heart aching as she saw the tearful glisten on Glimmer's cheeks as well.

Glimmer chuckled bitterly and nodded. "It was bizarre. But she made me realize that even my relationship with her—the one where I felt so justified in being wronged… It was partially my fault it fell apart in the first place."

Adora squeezed her hand as Glimmer's face contorted and her shoulders shook with more tears. "I've pushed everyone away for so long. I've burned so many bridges but it's easier that way. I don't have to worry about letting people down, or about them hurting me… Not if I don't care about them. But—*I do* care about them and it just makes it worse because then I'm this giant fucking asshole to people who—,"

She stopped, breathing out a shaky sigh and Adora took her turn.

"You're hurting, Glimmer."

She shrugged in response.

"It's okay to be hurting. It's okay to be grieving. But—If it's affecting so much of your life, maybe it's time to talk to someone about it. Someone way more qualified than me or Bow."

Glimmer's face had turned red as if she were blushing at the mere thought of accepting help.

"There's nothing wrong with that, Glimmer. There's no shame in it. I think maybe, you might really like the therapist I saw after Micah passed away. She's—," Adora paused, still stroking Glimmer's knuckles as she considered how to best describe Razz. "Kinda… 'quirky', but she talks like she can really see who you are. Like she knows you better than you know yourself. I think she could help you understand some of your own pain and then maybe… It won't hurt as much anymore. Maybe we can work on rebuilding some of those bridges."

"'We'?" To her surprise, Glimmer did not turn down her offer to see Razz. Adora's heart fluttered a bit with hope.

"Yeah, we, Glim. I'll be here for you—supporting you—as long as you'll let me."

Glimmer sniffed, letting go of Adora's hand to rub the tears from her cheeks. "You're too good for me, you know that? Too good for anyone."

“That’s not true,” Adora scoffed. “I’ve got my own mess of issues. It’s not about ‘deserving’ anything, anyway.”

They sat silently for a moment, absorbing everything. Finally, Glimmer looked up at her, and her eyes held a light Adora hadn’t seen in them since their nights under the stars together.

“I’m sorry.”

“I know.”

Glimmer nodded, understanding that the words weren’t enough yet, but that Adora at least accepted them. This was a start, a step one. If Glimmer really was ready to move forward and heal, there would be further discussions.

“Hold me?”

Adora blinked at the sudden request but opened her arms nonetheless and Glimmer sunk into them, wiggling until she was comfortable against Adora’s chest, her fluffy head tucked directly beneath the blonde’s chin. Adora stroked gentle hands up and down her back, a sense of much welcomed peace washing over her.

In some ways this moment felt familiar—in another, it seemed like a new beginning. For both of them. They held each other for a long time until Adora’s coffee went cold and she thought Glimmer might be asleep again. But then Glimmer pulled away and gazed into Adora’s eyes. She appeared thoughtful, her own eyes darting to Adora’s lips briefly.

“Can I kiss you?” Her voice was so soft.

Adora didn’t even consider teasing her about the ‘rules’ or foreplay. As much as she was hurting over the events of the past few nights, she also knew she was desperately in love with her best friend. She would do anything to feel Glimmer’s earnest lips on her own in a true kiss. So she nodded and leaned forward to

meet Glimmer halfway, slipping one hand through her hair to toy with the downy strands at the base of her neck.

Glimmer's lips were soft as they touched her own, moving gently, her hands clasping in the front of Adora's shirt. It felt different this time. No passionate spark, no hungry desire. Instead there was a warmth blooming in Adora's chest like a bright flame. Something that made her feel tethered to Glimmer. Wanting to hold her closer than she possibly could. To lock her in her heart and never let go.

Glimmer pulled away slowly, her hands unclenching in Adora's shirt, only to slide up to cup her cheeks. Adora stared back at her, unsure what to do… afraid of pushing her too far. But Glimmer just gazed at her with a look Adora had never seen before. Suddenly, she was closing the distance between them again, her kiss a little more passionate this time and Adora felt the familiar spark.

In one quick movement, she swung one leg over Adora's, straddling her above the sheets. Adora sighed as Glimmer's body pressed forward against hers, hands still stroking the blonde's cheeks gently. The kisses they exchanged were something Adora hadn't experienced with Glimmer before. Soft and slow, almost sensual. Every moment felt like an eternity as she caressed every inch of Glimmer's lips with her own.

Almost on their own volition, Adora's hands lifted, clenching in the fabric of her shirt that bunched at Glimmer's waist.

"I like this on you," she murmured between kisses and Glimmer hummed in agreement.

"It's a good shirt… Really gay too," she chuckled, smile growing so wide that it temporarily broke the kiss. Adora's hands wandered slightly, traveling past the fabric to grip her—

"Glim?" Adora swallowed, her body stiffening.

“Mmm?” Glimmer hummed against her lips, still intent on exploring every inch of her as slowly as she could.

“Are you not—Where’s your… Um, underwear?” The sudden discovery had somehow rocked Adora to her very core as her hands roamed the smooth and perfect expanse of Glimmer’s bare rear.

“Oh,” Glimmer pulled away slightly, pressing her ass back into Adora’s hands as her lavender eyes bore into the blonde’s. “I just figured this might make things easier. Y’know… If we wanted to do something this morning. Or whatever.”

“Is that ever in question?” Adora breathed, taking a handful of rear in her hands, and squeezing with enough force that Glimmer jumped slightly.

“Well, you’re not the only one who can tease,” Glimmer shot back, her eyes growing cloudy with lust as she leaned forward again. And this time, their kiss was deep and heavy, tongues brushing and breath mingling.

“Off,” Adora ordered, parting briefly enough to pull (her) Glimmer’s shirt open and toss it to the ground. Glimmer did her the same courtesy, rising so that Adora could pull off her pants and underwear too before joining her above the covers this time. Only then did Glimmer settle back down, her arousal becoming more obvious when her core touched Adora’s thigh.

“God that’s, like, my favorite fucking feeling,” Adora smiled against Glimmer’s lips, allowing her hands to roam up and down her partner’s back, blindly tracing the tattoos she’d memorized by now.

“My slime on your legs?” Glimmer shot back, wrinkling her nose.

Adora coughed out a surprised laugh. “Your slime?? That’s disgusting.”

“Exactly! Why is it your favorite feeling?”

“Shut up,” Adora choked through her laughter, seeking out Glimmer’s lips again. She was met with half teeth as Glimmer grinned against her. “It’s not. Don’t be gross.”

“Sex is gross, Adora. We’re gross. I hate to break it to you.” But Glimmer ground down against her nevertheless, her slick coating more of Adora’s thigh, close to her own core. Adora groaned softly, letting her hands drift down to stroke Glimmer’s full thighs.

Suddenly, Glimmer was gone and Adora blinked her eyes open, utterly confused, to see her searching for something in the drawer.

“What are you—?”

Glimmer returned, strap and harness in hand, her lip poking out in a pout as she crawled back onto the bed and pressed the toy against Adora. “Please?”

Adora was confused by the sudden decision; but the soft affection of the morning had her in too jovial of a mood to say no. Instead, she teased again: “The strap? Are my fingers not good enough for you anymore?”

“Your fingers are perfect,” Glimmer assured her, kissing her softly, lingering there even when she pulled away. “But right now, I want your fake rainbow dick inside me, so let’s go.”

Rolling her eyes in mock exasperation, Adora heaved a sigh and lifted her hips, allowing Glimmer to help her attached the strap and position the dildo until they were both satisfied.

“Good?” Adora asked as she settled back into place against the pillows.

“Perfect,” was Glimmer’s reply.

She swung one left over Adora again, straddling her lap and hovering just above the toy that jutted up proudly between them.

“Ready for me, baby?” Glimmer teased, with a playful wink, but Adora was too taken aback by the nickname to appropriately respond. She simply gulped and adjusted her hips as Glimmer lined the toy up with her entrance before sinking down slowly. She closed her eyes, mouth opening slightly in bliss and Adora had to bite her own lip to stop a groan from escaping. She wasn’t very successful.

“Oh god…”

Glimmer snorted slightly; the toy now fully hilted inside her. “’Oh god’, huh? You can’t even feel this.”

“I know,” Adora flushed slightly, ears burning. “It’s just—Watching it kinda ‘disappear’ inside you is—It’s wow….”

Glimmer’s eyebrows shot up. “Oh? That does it for you?”

Biting her lip, Adora offered a timid nod, to which Glimmer grinned mischievously before grinding her hips down, rolling a slow circle around the toy. “And how about this?”

The pressure on Adora’s clit was unbelievable. She let her head fall back, groaning as it ‘thunked’ against the wall behind her. “That’s cruel and unusual punishment.”

“Punishment?” Glimmer lifted a single brow and stopped moving entirely. “I thought you might like it.”

“Okay, no,” Adora grabbed her hips, pulling slightly to encourage Glimmer to move again. “I lied. This is punishment. Please—,”

“Please what?” Glimmer’s lips ghosted hers again as one hand slipped into her undercut, blunt nails scraping through it. Adora’s eyes practically rolled into the back of her head, but she managed to speak.

“Please move. *Please.*”

“Hm… I kinda like it when you beg.”

“Anything for you, Princess.”

Adora’s hands tightened on Glimmer’s hips, squeezing the ample flesh there as she tugged her forward. Glimmer rocked once, a triumphant smirk on her face as Adora’s eyes closed in pleasure.

“Only if you look at me.”

The blonde’s eyes popped open. She was—kind of confused, honestly. This was an entirely new position in and of itself for them. But… Glimmer also wanted eye contact? Not that Adora had any problem with that! At all. It was just… New. Confusing. Maybe the past few days had more of an impact on Glimmer than she was letting on.

Maybe—Maybe she finally felt the same way Adora did.

No. Adora wouldn’t let herself hope like that. Not yet anyway.

As soon as Adora’s eyes were on hers, Glimmer began to rock her hips. Her movements were slow at first, purposeful. Every long drag of her hips ended with them sweeping back just as agonizingly slowly. Adora’s heart pounded frantically against her ribs, eyes trained on Glimmer’s, completely entranced as she watched them glaze over with pleasure. Glimmer’s lips parted slightly, her breathing growing heavier before she pressed them to Adora’s in another deep kiss.

She pulled back after a moment--the steady rocking of her hips stuttering. The morning light drifting through the window caught in her hair, highlighting the black strands that were growing out. They shone, some strands appearing like spun gold. Her eyes matched, pupils hazy and distant even as they remained locked on Adora’s. It was incredibly intimate, Adora almost wanted to look away from how exposed it made her feel. But that would mean missing out on Glimmer practically shining in the sunlight.

“You’re so beautiful.” She managed to murmur the words without stumbling on her thick tongue as one hand rose to card through the golden strands of Glimmer’s hair.

To her surprise, Glimmer's cheeks flushed pink, her eyes briefly flickering away from Adora's.

"I'm—,"

"Don't say you're not," Adora interrupted, fingers drifting down her soft cheek to trace her lips. "Please."

Glimmer paused, the movement of her hips halting even, as she studied Adora's face. Finally, she smiled almost shyly and kissed Adora once more.

"You're pretty beautiful too."

Adora's heart constricted in her chest and she pulled Glimmer forward, wrapping her arms around the other woman in a tight embrace as she began to rock her hips again. The languid strokes grew steadily faster and deeper until Glimmer had to sit back a bit, bracing her hands on Adora's shoulders again.

Adora's own hands went to her hips and she watched as Glimmer took her pleasure, her body rolling like an ocean wave. She broke the eye contact finally, squeezing her eyes shut as she rocked faster and more intently, her forehead falling against Adora's. Soft hands, now slightly clammy with exertion, moved from Adora's shoulders to her face, tangling in her hair and gripping like a lifeline as Glimmer approached her climax.

They were pressed together now, Adora could feel Glimmer's own heartbeat hammering with her own until they had synced, pushed skin to skin. Adora forced her eyes open even when Glimmer began to grind down against the strap, pleasuring Adora with each thrust of her own. She watched Glimmer's face, saving every twitch and sigh, every soft moan and whimper. She watched the rhythmic rolling of her body, gazed in awe at the spot where they joined. All the while, her hands ghosted every inch of Glimmer's body that they could reach. Her shoulders, her hips, her lower back, her rear.

She pulled with each of Glimmer's thrusts as her breathing grew even heavier, knowing by now how to tell when her partner was close.

"You okay?" Adora gasped, feeling almost lightheaded between the absolute intimacy of the moment and just how quickly her heart was hammering against her ribs.

"I—I—I'm," Glimmer choked on her words, forcing her eyes to open into Adora's. "Adora—Fuck… I'm—so close."

Adora nodded, capturing Glimmer in a kiss that betrayed the tension and heat burning between them. It was a soft kiss. Full of the love Adora wanted to shout from the rooftops right now. Instead, she gently ran her nails down Glimmer's back and tugged lightly on her lower lip, letting it slide between her teeth.

"Come for me." Adora pleaded, listening to Glimmer whimper with need before deciding to push her limits. "Baby, *please*. Come for me."

Glimmer's hands tightened on her cheeks and then her shoulders, gripping until her knuckles turned white as Adora's words sent her over the edge.

She came with a choked whine, her hips pulsing hard against Adora's, body jerking. And then she slumped forward, hips twitching with the aftershocks as she panted, resting her forehead on Adora's shoulder.

Adora breathed out a shaky sigh, running her hands lightly up and down Glimmer's back, soothing her through the ghosts of her climax. She could feel Glimmer panting against her overheated skin, could feel the tremors that passed through her. Her own heart was still pounding like a jackhammer, but she kissed Glimmer's temple softly and waited until she pulled back on her own.

Finally, Glimmer sat back, staring at Adora with pupils blown so wide they almost engulfed the beautiful lavender of her irises. Her

lips parted as if maybe she wanted to speak. Adora waited, teetering like she was on the edge of a precipice, eager to hear the words she wanted so badly to fall from Glimmer’s lips.

Instead, Glimmer stroked her cheek with one hand and leaned forward, pressing a silent and gentle kiss to Adora’s forehead.

The swell of disappointment was there in Adora’s chest. But so was happiness. A true, deep, comforting joy that she hadn’t felt in a long time.

They’d taken the first step towards healing and that was all that mattered now.

Chapter End Notes

> We are in the endgame now ... Is it a true slow burn if I'm almost 100k words in and they still haven't said 'I love you'?

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all for the lovely thoughts and comments and support on this story so far. As we approach the end, I hope everything I've dangled for 14 chapters now is tied up nicely ;-; It's been really fun to write this story and I'm so happy and grateful that so many of you are enjoying it/have stuck around since day 1.
>
> In summation: The girls get therapy!!!! :D Baby steps.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora didn't really want to see Catra. And ultimately, she realized she didn't *have* to if she didn't want to, she didn't owe her former partner anything. Not even an explanation really. And yet, something inside itched for her to at least find closure with Catra. For her sake, if not her exes. And so maybe that was how she'd ended up meeting with her old flame outside a quiet café. Catra had tried to get her to meet at her shared apartment with Scorpia. To which Adora adamantly refused. The environment would be too intimate, too familiar. And the last thing Adora wanted to do was encourage anything.

Catra was waiting for her, on time for once, outside the small café. She stood leaning against the wall, hands stuffed into the pockets of her old leather jacket, one boot scuffing rhythmically against the pavement. Adora paused as she stepped out of her truck. The sight of her ex in an outfit she remembered so vividly filled her with a strange, hollow sense of nostalgia. Memories passed before her eyes like faded photos, slipping away before she could pin any of them down. The twist of sadness in her gut was faint, certainly there, but more than anything the hope of the future that lay before her burned brighter. The least she could do, no matter how uncomfortable this conversation might be, was to find a way to help Catra let her go. And vice versa.

Mismatched eyes looked up, hardening, as Adora joined her outside the café.

"Hey."

"Hey." Adora had never been at more of a loss for words around Catra. It was strange to think they really didn't know each other anymore. "Wanna head inside?"

Catra huffed, pushing off the wall and pulling open the café door. To Adora's surprise, she held it open for her, pinning her with an almost challenging glare. Adora nodded her thanks and headed inside. She didn't really have the time to appreciate the quaint interior of the little café, but the delightful smells of coffee and pastry hit her nose immediately—calming her nerves a bit.

"Did you want anything?" she asked, glancing at Catra over her shoulder.

Catra's eyes narrowed. "What like a date?"

"Like a friendly offer," Adora shot back.

"No." She glanced away bitterly, stuffing her hands back in her pockets. Already tired of the pity party her ex seemed intent on throwing, Adora ordered herself a latte before joining Catra at a table in the far corner.

"So, you wanted to talk," Adora offered after a few moments of silence.

"*You* wanted to talk."

"*You* kept calling me after you…er, you walked… in on me."

"Don't remind me," Catra's face twisted like she might be sick. Adora was about to shoot back, but it seemed a reminder of that night was all Catra needed to open the floodgates. "I don't understand what the fuck you're thinking… Going back to her."

"You're jealous."

"No! Of *her*? Are you kidding," Catra scoffed, leaning one arm back over her chair. "That bitch is a fucking mess. She always has been. That's the confusing thing. I thought you were done with 'us' when *I* dropped out. You thought I wasn't going to do anything with my life. I don't see what makes her any different."

"That's not what I thought and also that's not what happened," Adora struggled to keep her anger from rising. "You gave up on *me* when they told me I'd never play professionally."

"I didn't give up on you," Catra's nose was wrinkling, the distaste in her gaze being replaced with confusion. "You wouldn't come out of your fucking room. You were depressed as shit and I didn't know how to help you. You wouldn't even let me in when I did try. What was I supposed to do? Break down your door and *force* you to acknowledge me?"

"That wouldn't have been out of character for you," Adora muttered. Catra had never been sensitive to boundaries before. Why she'd decided to respect them the moment Adora needed her not to was beyond understanding.

Surprisingly, Catra brushed past the jab. "Do you ever think that you were really just giving up on yourself and projecting that onto me?"

"I—," … Maybe? Adora blinked and then stared down at her latte cup.

"I mean…," Catra's shoulders slumped in defeat. "Damage done either way, I guess. It is what it is. I just really don't understand why you thought that throwing yourself back at her would be any better. Like, sure… We weren't exclusive or whatever. But walking in on you banging a blast from the past warranted a little bit of an explanation, I think."

"Oh? You think I owed you that, huh? After all the shitty selfies you sent me on your tour?" Adora's heart was pounding in her

chest. “Was I just a joke to you? Something to tease? Someone who would crawl to you on your knees no matter how much you played with my heart?”

“No,” Catra spat. “I didn’t think it was a big fucking deal! Those were the rules we laid out after the first time we fucked. We were allowed to sleep with other people.”

“And I did! So why are you pretending I wronged you somehow?”

“Why are you?!”

Realizing they were both getting too loud, Adora sat back in her chair, centering herself. She closed her eyes, inhaling deeply through her nose—But Catra continued in a hushed voice before she could.

“And then you go and act like you’ve got some kind of ‘love-of-the-century’ shit with this loser from high school. Nothing’s changed, Adora. You’ve got fucking rules about *fucking*. ‘No falling in love’. How is her game any different?”

“It wasn’t,” Adora realized, voice quiet. “It wasn’t different. Not exactly. But it is now…”

A bitter chuckle left Catra’s. “Sure… All the shitty things she said to you back then are totally outweighed by how tight her pussy is, right?”

“Can you fucking stop? Stop insulting her. Stop acting like you know anything about her.”

“And what do *you* know about her?” Catra shot back. “Did you know she was the one who planted the weed in my bag on Prom?”

Adora’s eyes widened. She remembered that night all too clearly. Embarrassing, frustrating… Confusing. But it lined up. The Glimmer who was crumbling under her grief in high school—She would absolutely lash out at Catra… At Adora. Coupled with the

confession Glimmer had given her that night in the bathroom, how she'd ached to be rid of her pain and jealousy… Adora knew she should be mad, and part of her was… But mostly—it was just pity.

"What?" Catra was watching her think. "Does the sex excuse that for you too?"

"It doesn't excuse anything," Adora replied with as even a voice as she could muster. "That's not alright, what she did. But—Glimmer also isn't that kid anymore."

"She seemed pretty much the same to me—stumbling around blind drunk the other night. Adora—," Catra paused, unable to meet Adora's gaze as she continued. "You deserve better than her. And I'm not saying that's me. We clearly missed our fucking shot. But—Respect yourself for fucks sake."

It had never occurred to Adora that she would need to put her feelings for Glimmer into words—to defend what she felt for one of her oldest and dearests friends. Gathering herself, she tried: "Glimmer messed up, Catra. She's made… Plenty of mistakes. I don't pretend she hasn't. But she doesn't either. She knows. She went through a lot when her father died, and she burned a lot of bridges in the process. And one of them was ours."

Adora paused, and to her surprise Catra listened.

"And we're working really hard, *together*, to build a new one. It's not easy. In fact, it's really different now. We're not those innocent kids anymore. It's not that fairytale love you imagine when you're young. Where everything is romantic and soft and nothing hurts. It's—," she chuckled, "It's messy and selfish and bold. It's not finding your perfect half. It's the trying and the reaching and failing—And the trying again. For me, Glimmer is—She's always been the person I could lean on when I needed *anything*. With her, I always felt *seen*, and it didn't matter what it was… I could have been telling her about my foster mom, or some dumb show I was fully invested in. It didn't matter to her. But *I* mattered to her.

And… That hasn't changed. Three years later and she's still the same person inside, beneath all the hurt. She cares about me; *Adora.* My feelings, my comfort, my happiness."

"Are you saying I didn't?" Catra's voice was tinged with hurt.

"No, that's not what I'm saying—," Adora heaved a sigh. "I'm just trying to explain… How much she means to me, how much she always has. Even through the shitty stuff."

Catra's bi-colored eyes finally met Adora's. "You guys... Aren't just messing around anymore?"

"If we are—I don't want to be," Adora realized she and Glimmer still had *so much* to work out. But the words were bubbling inside her chest and she couldn't contain them anymore… Even if *Catra* was the first person she admitted it to. "I love her."

Catra nodded, almost solemnly, glancing down at her lap. "You love her?"

Deciding it would be best if she didn't reiterate that she quite literally hadn't *stopped* loving Glimmer; rather burying her in the deepest recesses of her heart, Adora nodded. "Yeah… I'm sorry."

"Don't do that," Catra laughed. "Don't apologize for shit that doesn't warrant an apology. You always do that."

Falling silent, Adora ducked her head as Catra heaved a tired sigh.

"Well," she said finally and Adora heard the scrape of her chair. "That's it then. I'm—I hope it works out for you, Adora. It sounds like a fucking mess to me, but you seem happy so—"

A frown tugged at Adora's lips as Catra offered her a peace sign and a half grin. "Take care of yourself."

"Catra wait—," she caught the end of Catra's sleeve and to her surprise, her ex stopped, but did not turn around. Adora wasn't sure what to say. It seemed like there was too much and not

enough at the same time. Nothing she could say would bring the closure she wanted, not like this. Instead, she could only show that she harbored no truly ill feelings. That she wished Catra the best at the end of the day. They had been what the other needed at one point.

She would always remember that.

"You take care too, okay?"

Catra loosed a dry chuckle. "See you around, Adora."

And then she pulled free, disappearing out the café door… and she was gone.

Forever?

Adora didn't know, but it tugged viciously at her heart in a way she hadn't expected. Even so, she didn't move to chase her. She sat quietly, finished her coffee, made it to her truck and burst into tears.

By the time she got home, Glimmer was back from both her morning lunch shift *and* therapy with Razz. She was buzzing around the apartment, cleaning and singing to one of her favorite playlists that was blasting from Adora's little Bluetooth stereo. Adora, on the other hand, had driven home in tears. Confused, conflicted, frustrated. She hadn't gotten what she wanted out of the conversation with Catra and it was beyond devastating to know that may have been her last chance.

Glimmer paused in scrubbing down the stove top when she heard the door open. The music was still blaring over her as she buoyantly shouted, "You're back!"

And then she saw the tears still dripping down Adora's cheeks, because she scrambled to shut off the stereo and hurried to the blonde's side.

“Adora, hey,” Glimmer reached up, cupping Adora’s puffy and red cheeks gently. Her grip was loose at first, until didn’t resist, and then Glimmer pulled her down, hands clenching tight as she pressed their foreheads together. “What’s wrong? What happened?”

“Nothing,” Adora’s voice was a weak whimper. “I couldn’t—Fix anything. I tried. I don’t—She just left.”

“What do you mean?” Glimmer pulled away to look her in the eye—the tenderness there made Adora want to sob harder.

“I mean that’s it. I told her—,” Adora quickly censored herself, “—I tried to explain the place I’m in now… And she wished me the best and said goodbye. And that—I didn’t think it would end like that. Maybe… We’d be friends… Or, I don’t know. It was just so final. I don’t—,”

“Adora,” Glimmer stopped her gently and Adora was quickly made aware of how rapid her breathing was becoming. “Come sit with me.”

She allowed Glimmer to lead her over to the couch (still broken from Glimmer’s first night here) and they plopped down together. Adora let her head rest in Glimmer’s lap, closing her eyes as soft fingers trailed through her undercut.

“It’s okay to feel hurt,” Glimmer murmured. “You were trying to smooth things over and I guess that’s not what Catra wanted. That’s on her. Not you.”

“But it still affects me,” Adora muttered bitterly.

“Yeah…She made her choice though.”

Adora barely held back a choked sob and Glimmer bent low, awkwardly pressing a tiny kiss to her cheek.

“Adora, if she decided that not having someone as bright and loyal and brave and kind and wonderful as you in her life would make it

better, than she's the one who should be a fucking sobbing mess right now. And maybe she is. Maybe she'll come around. Okay? For now, you did what you could. You did what you needed to do."

Adora nodded and sniffed, politely wiping away the puddle of tears gathering on Glimmer's sakura blossom tattoo. "Razz is teaching you a lot, huh?"

Glimmer snorted. "She gives me the words. But this is shit I've had to learn along the way. All those hard lessons."

A heavy sigh left Glimmer and Adora turned her head to peer up at her, reaching one hand up to cup her cheek. The words she'd told Catra back at the café… Glimmer didn't have to be comforting her. She hated Catra. She could be scoffing, telling Adora she was better off. But of course she wasn't. Deep down, this woman was still the Glimmer she'd fallen in love with once… And then again with all her new layers and complexities.

Adora wanted to say it, the words burned in her throat, itching to escape. But that was too quick. They had things to work through first. Instead, Adora say up and curled into Glimmer's side, fully allowing the smaller woman to cocoon around her like a blanket.

"Thank you."

"Don't thank me, Adora… You literally do this for me on a daily basis."

"Yeah, and you always thank me."

"Because I dunno how you put up with my sorry ass. You're a perfect angel who deserves the world."

"Stop," Adora pinched Glimmer's thigh.

"No," Glimmer shot back, squeezing her tightly. "Never."

They sat in comfortable silence for a while, Glimmer's soft hands stroking through Adora's hair. The moment was so peaceful, so

gentle, Adora didn't want to break it. But she knew she should talk with Glimmer about what Catra had revealed to her at the café. Razz had urged them to communicate more openly, and what better way to put that into practice than now? When she had literally broken down in Glimmer's arms.

"Hey, Glim?"

"Hm?" Glimmer murmured against the top of her head.

Adora paused, running her fingers over the tattooed blossoms on Glimmer's thigh as she chose her words carefully. "Do you remember our senior prom?"

The answer was clear when Glimmer's body stiffened against hers. "…Yeah."

"Catra told me that you… Uh, you told *her* that you—There were some drugs involved and—,"

Glimmer's shaky sigh cut her off. "I was gonna talk to you about it, I swear. I just… Things were going really well lately, and I didn't want to fight with you again about something so... Petty, that I did almost four years ago now—,"

Pushing herself up, Adora sat back a way, one hand still on Glimmer's thigh as she looked her in the eye. "We don't have to fight about it. I just want to know why you did that. That night was… Really shitty. And it was my senior prom, y'know? I wanted to remember it. And… I *do*. But not the way I wanted to."

Glimmer bit her lip, looking down at her lap, at Adora's hand that still rested gently against her skin. "I know. It was really fucking awful. I won't even pretend I was just trying to hurt Catra because—Yeah, I knew it would hurt you too. I was just… So angry… Especially after our fight at that party. I know it's awful and selfish. But when you didn't come after me—? I felt like I'd been abandoned, I guess. I wanted to hurt you back…"

A frown tugged at Adora's lips as Glimmer's piercing honest stung her heart. "I hurt you that bad?"

"*You* didn't…," Glimmer scowled, twisting her hands together in frustration. "I mean, back then I thought you did. I thought everyone was hurting me. I blamed everyone but myself. When it was *me* who was cutting people down and burning bridges and being… A general piece of shit. But—"

She raised her hands, running them through her hair. Adora's eyes followed and she was suddenly aware of how much of the familiar purple had faded, leaving shiny black strands behind.

"I know it's worth pretty much nothing now but… I'm sorry, Adora," Glimmer forced herself to meet Adora's eyes, her own watering slightly. "I'm sorry for ruining your Prom and for trying to hurt you. I'm sorry I blamed you and treated you like shit. I'm—I'm just sorry."

"Glim, it's—,"

"It doesn't have to be okay," Glimmer interrupted quickly, beginning to rise from the couch. "I really don't deserve that endless store of forgiveness you apparently have inside you, Adora."

"Glimmer," Adora's voice was firm as she tugged her back down by the hem of her shorts. Glimmer yelped, landing with a thump in Adora's arms. She wiggled slightly to get more comfortable before surrendering to the embrace.

"Thank you for the apology," Adora murmured, propping her chin on Glimmer's shoulder, arms wrapped tightly around her waist. "It was… I mean, that was a pretty awful thing you did. But I know you're working really hard right now to deal with all that pain. What kind of a friend would I be if I ignored that and played the victim?"

"I—Well, it would be fair. You *are* the victim in this scenario," Glimmer retorted, but her voice was soft.

'I'm also stupidly in love with you and want you to be happy and I forgive you for being hurt and angry and lashing out four years ago.'

Instead of voicing her thoughts out loud, Adora shrugged and pressed a quick kiss to the moons on her neck. "Okay then. Fine. You win. You hurt my feelings. But I also accept your apology for a mistake you mad as an angry and stupid teenager and I'm prepared to move on with our lives. Fair?"

Glimmer giggled and glanced at the blonde over her shoulder, a tender smile gracing her lips. "Fair."

Glimmer had been crying—A lot.

Adora knew it was a good thing; the seemingly random tearful episodes began after she officially started meeting with Razz for regular sessions nearly a month ago. Adora recalled how her own conversations with Razz had brought out the deepest emotions and buried pain within her after Micah's death. It was hard and crying over dropping your cereal spoon on the floors was a little embarrassing, Adora knew, but she *also* knew that Glimmer really needed this. She'd been burying her feelings and her agony for years. Letting it all come out was part of the process.

And so Adora remained as patient and supportive as she could possibly be. She'd found Glimmer in the kitchen that morning, leaning against the counter as she wept over the fact that the Keurig wouldn't start. Chuckling softly, Adora moved behind her, slipping her arms around Glimmer's waist in a gentle squeeze.

"Evil coffee machine?" she murmured teasingly, her lips landing against the moon tattoos (her favorite spot).

Glimmer's shoulders shook, her voice quivering. "I d-don't kn-now why I'm f-fucking crying over a c-c-coffee machine. I c-can't g-get it to work!"

Hiding her smile against Glimmer's skin, Adora reached out with one hand, adjusting the setting for delayed drip and suddenly Glimmer's mug was filling with coffee. Her face lit up as if she'd been handed a gift from the gods. As soon as it was full and she'd dumped a (truly obnoxious) amount of cream and sugar in, she took a long sip—her tears finally stopping. Adora remained wrapped around her, offering steady physical comfort.

After a moment she felt Glimmer lean back into her, free hand coming to rest on top of Adora's.

"I'm sorry," she mumbled halfway into her mug.

"What are you sorry for?" Adora's reply was just as soft, her lips still brushing the tender skin of Glimmer's neck.

"Crying… Again. I can't fucking stop. I cried at work the other day when I dropped a soda in the beverage station. Had to hide in the freezer until my legs went numb."

"You don't have to be sorry for feeling your feelings," Adora replied, finally pulling away far enough for Glimmer to turn in her arms and face her. The blonde lifted a hand, brushing the stray tears from her cheeks, then cupping her face and stroking with her thumb. Glimmer leaned into the touch; her eyelids fluttering shut.

"That's what Razz says," Glimmer murmured. "I guess my feelings are just really big."

"I could have told you that," Adora teased, pressing a quick peck to Glimmer's nose before she could get angry at the subtle jab.

"Those are fighting words." A teasing sparkle returned to Glimmer's eyes as she set her coffee mug down and then looped her arms around Adora's neck. "You wanna fight?"

"Not particularly," Adora offered a casual shrug, leaning in to taste the sweetness on Glimmer's lips. Her heart lurched joyfully when

Glimmer did not pull away. “But I can absolutely think of something else physical we can do with our time.”

Glimmer pulled back, her nose wrinkling. “Did that sound smoother in your head or…?”

Scoffing, only somewhat truly offended, Adora shoved Glimmer away and strode out of the kitchen. “Okay, fine. I’ll just get ready for work instead. Your loss for not utterly appreciating this ass when I’m literally *handing* it to you.”

Adora was nearly knocked off her feet as Glimmer tackled her into another hug from behind, burying her face between Adora’s shoulder blades.

“Who could possibly appreciate this ass more than me?” she asked, one hand lowering to unabashedly grab a handful of said rear.

Adora yelped, spinning around and then they were falling backwards onto the couch a mess of limbs and laughter. The blonde ran her fingers up Glimmer’s ribs before she could dive in for a kiss. Glimmer burst into giggles, squirming but unable to escape Adora’s grasp. It was light and airy and utterly adorable and then suddenly…. Glimmer hiccupped and she was crying again.

“Oh, god…*Glim*,” Adora stopped her tickle attack to cup Glimmer’s wet cheeks. “Hey, easy… Honey, what’s wrong?”

Glimmer just shook her head and sobbed and then buried herself in Adora’s neck, arms wrapped tightly around her. Adora bit back her (bemused) chuckles, instead humming gently and running comforting hands down Glimmer’s back.

“It’s alright, Glim,” she soothed her crying partner as best she could, allowing her to get out what she needed. “I’m here.”

“I know,” Glimmer’s reply was muffled against Adora’s neck, but full of choked emotion. She pulled back, her face red and wet,

eyes puffy. Sniffing loudly, she placed one hand on Adora's cheek, thumb stroking her skin. "I'm here too."

"I think I'm gonna talk to mom…" Glimmer's voice was sleepy and mostly mumbled against Adora's neck as the blonde stroked lazy fingers through her hair.

They were tucked together in bed, tangled in the sheets, skin to skin. They weren't really supposed to be doing this anymore. The whole sleeping together thing. Or at least, according to Glimmer, Razz's had suggested decreasing the sessions until it wasn't so tempting to stop them entirely. She had not so indirectly suggested that their current physical relationship wasn't as healthy as it could be. And that, rather than the comfort Glimmer sought, the sessions were more likely twisting things up inside of her. So they'd tried to stop. But this time had definitely been Adora's fault…

It was just hard to restrain herself when Glimmer came out of the shower in nothing but a towel, wet droplets sliding over the skin that Adora yearned to taste. Glimmer hadn't complained though when Adora tugged her down onto the bed and what began as an innocent kiss—quickly evolved into something more.

"I don't really want to," Glimmer mumbled as Adora continued to play with her hair in silence. "Or—I guess I do, but I'm scared. Scared of what she'll say. What she'll think. If she'll even forgive me…"

"She's your mom. She loves you," Adora comforted her with a soft kiss against her damp forehead. "I think it's a good idea to at least try."

Glimmer seemed to shrink in on herself, curling more tightly around Adora as she considered the possibility of meeting with her mother.

"You're the bravest person I know, Glim. It's okay to be afraid, but I also know you can absolutely do this."

"But where do I even start?" Glimmer's voice was a weak squeak against her neck.

Adora thought about her answer. There was a lot of hurt between Glimmer and her mother. Most of it stemming from the fallout of Micah's death.

"Just be honest about when things started to fall apart, Glim. Maybe you can talk to Razz before you talk to your mom? You guys can practice a bit and you can really think about what you want to say first."

Glimmer snorted softly. "Are you telling me *not* to charge in headfirst without thinking? Who do you think I am?"

Grinning, Adora rolled them over until Glimmer lay beneath her, propping herself up on one elbow so she could gaze down into lavender eyes.

"I think you're a Glimmer who is growing, but still entirely susceptible to her more… explosive tendencies. Especially when she has to deal with her 'less than accepting' mother." Adora pecked Glimmer's nose as she giggled.

"You sound just like Razz."

"Think I have a career in therapy?" Adora teased, leaning down into Glimmer's neck and teasing the skin with gentle kisses.

"You could do anything you fucking wanted to."

Adora was surprised at the sudden softness in Glimmer's voice. When she pulled back, Glimmer was gazing at her with such tenderness that it made her heart ache. Instead of words, she sealed the distance between them with a kiss, hoping it could speak for her the words she longed to say:

‘I love you, I love you, I love you.’

Glimmer’s legs were heavy as lead as she climbed the porch steps of her childhood home. A bizarre sense of nostalgia overwhelmed her at how little had changed over the years. Her father’s old rocking chair still sat on the far end of the porch, his workshop nearby (although now empty, she knew) still stood even though the paint had chipped. The enormous doors loomed large before her. This place was familiar and somehow all together unrecognizable. She didn’t belong here anymore. She hadn’t in years.

Still, Glimmer braced herself—gathering all her courage and forcing herself to knock. She’d spoken and prepared with Razz. She’d received uplifting encouragement from Bow and Adora and even Adam… Now all she had to do, was have the conversation with her actual mother.

Glimmer waited in tense silence for what felt like an eternity, debating between knocking again or running away when the door finally opened. Her mother appeared, as tall and regal and composed as ever. Glimmer caught the slight widening of her eyes as she processed the vision of her daughter in the doorway, and then her face hardened, becoming cold and guarded. Glimmer couldn’t blame her. But it still hurt to see.

“Hey, Mom.”

“Glimmer.” Angella’s voice was a strong as Glimmer wished she could be. “What are you doing here?”

“I—,” Glimmer looked away from the lavender eyes that matched her own, inhaling a shaky breath. “I wanted to talk…”

Silence.

For a startling moment, Glimmer thought Angella might turn her away. She would have the right. Glimmer had given her no warning she was coming, nor did she owe Glimmer her

forgiveness in the first place. But then the door creaked open and Angella murmured a quiet:

"Come in then."

Glimmer followed, respectfully removing her boots by the door as had always been the rule. The pink fuzzy socks she'd forgotten to change out of this morning slid slightly on the wood paneled floor as she followed her mother to the living room. It reminded her of the days Micah would pull her across this same floor like an ice skater, back when she was 4 and insistent that was exactly what she wanted to do with her life. A brief and sad smile touched her lips, but she shook of the memory and took a careful seat beside her mother on the couch. It was still soft and still smelled of old sun-dried leather. Glimmer used to find it comforting. Now it made her stomach twist.

Angella sat stiff and tall, hands folded in her lap, lips forming a thin line. Glimmer knew she was waiting for her to speak first, but suddenly all the words she'd practiced with Razz seemed to disappear.

"Mom… I—," Glimmer swallowed thickly. "I came here today to tell you that I'm… Sorry."

Angella didn't move and Glimmer's eyes were locked onto the hands currently twisting in her own lap. "I'm sorry for the way I've treated you over the past few… Well, years. Since—When Dad died—," Maybe it was the fact that she was back under the same roof she'd lived in with *him* for years, or that her mother was so close—whatever it was, Glimmer felt the agony of losing her father all over again and collapsed inward on herself. The words poured out of her without censorship, and so did the tears.'

"I'm so sorry, Mom," she wept. "For everything. For how I treated you. For ignoring you. For blaming you. For not being there for you when you were hurting too. It was like—After Dad died it was like… I could *feel* everything so much more intensely. Everything was too much. Everything hurt. Like I was sick and wearing a

blanket that just rubbed constantly on my skin and made me want to scream. I couldn't deal with my own shit—And I didn't care about yours. Or anyone's. Nothing mattered but making everyone hurt as much as I was hurting. And then I started to resent you for even *trying* to make me feel better. That wasn't what I wanted. Or what I needed."

Glimmer's sobs had grown slightly hysterical as she clutched herself, arms wrapped tightly around her middle.

"And I know that I just kept letting you down. The drinking, and then the—the sleeping around, and the tattoos and piercings and —I could pretend I wasn't hurting anymore and piss you off at the same time. But it never helped the way I thought it would. And then I said those awful things to you at Adora's apartment. Wishing you had—you had died instead of him and…," She wasn't about to tell her mother the intimate details, but she continued with, "—And I tried to punish myself after that. I knew I deserved it for what I said to you. I didn't know how to fix it."

Glimmer buried her face in her hands only to suddenly feel the warmth of her mother's arms around her. Surprised, it took her a few moments to fully collapse into the arms that had held her in moments of absolute weakness like this for most of her life—The ones that had tried to hold her in the hospital the day her father died. She felt the drip of tears on her forehead and didn't need to look up to know her mother was also crying. Glimmer sunk into her, wrapping her own arms around Angella's waist and crying into her shoulder for what felt like an eternity. Angella didn't say much, she didn't even really make a noise besides the occasional shaky breath. Instead, she rocked Glimmer back and forth as if she were a child again, arms a steady warmth around her.

"I'm sorry, M-mom," she breathed out shakily after a long while, as the tears started to lessen.

"Oh, Glimmer," Angella's voice was thick with tears as well. "I'm sorry too… I only ever wanted to help you. But I realize I may not

always have said or done what you *needed*. I was trying—I didn't know how to help you…"

Angella paused, leaning back and taking Glimmer's chin in her fingers, wiping her tears away gently with the other hand. "I meant what I said back at Adora's apartment. All I've ever wanted was for you to be happy. Watching you go down a path that seemed to end with you in more pain than before was… difficult to see. But I should have done more to help you understand that I did not want to fight your choices. I didn't know *how* to support you."

"Will you support me now?" Glimmer asked.

"Of course," Angella murmured, pulling Glimmer back into a hug. "If you'll let me. Tell me how."

A watery chuckle escaped Glimmer as she tried to decide where to start. "We should probably start with the—Um, the stuff you saw at the apartment."

Angella stiffened slightly. "You and Adora?"

"Me and all women, really." Glimmer sat back again, wiping the last of her tears away. "We never really… Came to a 'conclusion' on that back in high school. But Adora too, yeah."

Angella pursed her lips in thought. "Are you two… Dating? And you felt you couldn't tell me?"

"No! No… We're—I mean, if we were, I wouldn't have told you, no. But, um, we're not… Dating."

"I see." Angella's shoulders fell, as if saddened by that fact. "Adora cares a great deal for you."

Glimmer's cheeks burned. "She does. Yeah, she does. I—Don't deserve it honestly, but… She—I care about her a lot too."

Angella's lavender eyes were on her, studying, trying to understand. Unaided by her mother's scrutiny, Glimmer found herself continuing:

"She's really been so incredibly helpful with—all the pain, I guess. She helped me find a therapist… Who's really weird and eccentric, but she helps. And—Adora never gave up on me." Glimmer swallowed. "Even when I gave up on myself."

"Do you think you'll continue to live with her at least?" Angella prodded. "I think it would be good for you. For both of you."

"Yeah, I think…," Glimmer hadn't really considered how long this roommate situation would last. But neither of them seemed particularly keen on it ending so. "I think we'll stick together."

"I trust she'll take care of you," Angella said with a quiet smile on her lips. "She's a good young woman."

Glimmer's heart picked up speed in her chest. "She—Yeah. I want to do the same for her. I mean, after everything… I owe her so much. I want to make her as happy as she makes me. And she doesn't even have to try. She just *is* everything I—God...Mom—," Glimmer paused, clamping down on the silly words that threatened to burst out. "I just care about her so much… I don't want to keep hurting her, but I hurt everyone. I'm a fucking—sorry—A monster."

Angella pursed her lips in thought, stroking one gentle hand through Glimmer's hair. "It seems to me, that the mark of a good person is someone who realizes their mistakes and works to atone for them."

Glimmer sniffled in acknowledgement.

"In your anger and pain, you lashed out and hurt those that love you. And now, you realize that and want to make a change in yourself. I don't see what about that makes you a monster. Or someone not worth fighting for."

Glimmer choked; a mixture of happiness and crushing fear strangling tight in her chest. “What if I mess up again?”

“Fearing failure is fearing all of life,” Angella scooted closer and pulled Glimmer to rest against her shoulder once again. “You will make mistakes again. You will for the rest of your life because you are human. What’s important is that you always strive to better yourself. You are a fighter, Glimmer. You always have been. Perhaps it’s time you put that stubbornness to good use.”

Glimmer’s watery chuckle mingled with her mother’s.

“Baby steps,” Angella refocused her with a squeeze of her hand. “You mentioned a therapist? Make this a journey about yourself first and foremost. The rest will follow.”

Glimmer sucked in a deep breath and then smiled up at her mother. “Are we gonna be okay?”

“As long as you want me in your life, Glimmer, I will be there.” Angella pulled Glimmer into another hug, this one she returned tightly. “I am your mother and have never stopped loving you for even a moment. No matter what you might have believed.”

Leaning into her mother’s shoulder, Glimmer sighed as a wave of calm washed over her. “I love you too, Mom.”

“Come in, come in, Dearie! It’s been too long! How are you?”

Adora didn’t really have time to answer the question before Razz was ushering her inside the tiny office and shoving her down on the familiar maroon sofa. It still smelled vaguely of flowers and old lady perfume, which was gross in and of itself, but kind of comforting in its familiarity. Adora had spent many hours in here as a teenager after Micah’s death. It was one of the only places she’d ever been comfortable expressing her deepest insecurities and feelings. And Razz, one of the only adults she’d ever truly trusted.

“I’m good, Razz.”

She glanced over at Glimmer who was sitting a bit more stiffly on the other end of the couch. It had been *her* idea for Adora to join her for a ‘couple’s therapy session’ in the first place. Her reasoning being that it would be the best way for them to really air out their dirty laundry without it dissolving into an argument or hurt feelings. Adora agreed wholeheartedly, but Glimmer’s expression seemed to imply she might be regretting it now.

“Um, thank you for letting me join you guys,” Adora returned her attention to Razz, who was adjusting her enormous spectacles as she took a seat in her own chair and pulled out her notepad. It seemed, years later, she still hadn’t updated her practice to include modern technology. A pen, some paper and an intensely unnerving stare was all Razz needed to crack her clients open.

“Glimmer’s idea, Glimmer’s idea,” Razz waved her off. “She mentioned there were some things she wanted to discuss with you and felt this would be the safest place to do it!”

Adora glanced nervously at Glimmer once more. She was staring down at her lap now, fingers twisting nervously.

“I’d like that,” Adora assured them both.

“Glimmer?” The soft prompt came from Razz. Glimmer quickly nodded in agreement and Razz sat back in her chair.

“Begin then!”

She grinned, pad at the ready and waited in silence.

“Uh…,” Adora blinked, unsure what exactly they were supposed to talk about. If she should let Glimmer speak first, or maybe prompt her since she was clearly so nervous. In the end, the brief awkward silence was interrupted by Razz who huffed a sigh and then tried again.

"Glimmer," she jabbed her pencil at the girl. "In a previous session, you mentioned that Adora makes you feel inferior sometimes. Why don't you explain that?"

Adora's stomach twisted. Inferior was a harsh word. And she didn't think she'd ever done anything to talk down to Glimmer. In fact, she'd only ever tried to boost and support her friend, as far as she knew.

Glimmer seemed to agree because she spluttered. "No, I didn't—I didn't mean it like… that. I meant—I was mostly talking about high school anyway, after that time we fought but I…" At Razz's not so subtle nod, Glimmer swallowed and turned to direct her answer at Adora. "I just mean that *I* feel inferior around you. It's not like you purposefully *do* anything to make me feel that way. You're not mean spirited or hurtful. You're the exact opposite of that. You're so supportive and kind. But I guess I just look at my life and at yours. I look at how good you are and how… I'm not and I feel like—Maybe it's not inferiority. Maybe it's feeling like I don't deserve… You…. In my life." She paused before quickly adding, "As a friend and stuff."

"You don't think you deserve me?" Adora was a little blindsided by the verbal spiral. It took her a second to comprehend the unspoken truth beneath Glimmer's words. "Why do you think so little of yourself?"

Glimmer's eyes widened, as if that hadn't been the answer she was expecting. "B—Because I'm—I'm just a loser who mooches off the kindness of other people. I mean, my own mother told me that. I took advantage of Bow when Mermista kicked me out of our apartment. I lived off money my mom sent me when I should have been looking for a stable job. I lied to *you* and made you…," she glanced awkwardly at Razz, "*comfort me* when I was hurting you just as badly."

She trailed off and Adora took her chance to speak. "You're Bow's best friend for a reason, Glimmer. He'd do anything to help you because you would do the same for him. You make him laugh and

you care about him and you've been there for the hard times in his life. And he's not gonna forget that because you were suffering and hurting. And your mother wouldn't have offered you help if she didn't want to either. You're her daughter and she understands that the little girl she raised to be kind and good and loving is still in you. And with me… I don't know how you think that I could ever forget how you gave me a safe haven from a "mother" and a house that abused me. You make me feel like a stronger person. You make me want to be a *better* person. You're the one I can come home to and cry about my ex because she broke my heart *again* and you don't judge me for it. You make me laugh and cry and feel like flying all at once just by being you. I don't need you to be perfect to be worth my time, or whatever, Glimmer. I just need to know that—You care about me too, I guess."

Adora didn't realize the tears were dripping down her cheeks until they plopped into the hands in her laps. She looked down, almost shocked to feel them there. Her chest was tight, heart pounding as the honesty poured out of her without reservation. Glimmer's eyes were watering too, and she bit her lip in an attempt to hold them back.

"Of course, I care about you. I… Want to be better for you. For *me* too… I mean, I know that's important… But it helps to want to find ways to make it up to you."

"I understand. But you don't have anything to prove to me, okay, Glim? I know who you are. I know who you are *to me*."

Carefully, Adora reached for her hand, Glimmer silently clutched her fingers and they shared a brief smile before Razz continued.

"Adora, is there anything you might want to say to Glimmer about your own feelings?"

She almost rejected the offer, until she remembered the morning when she'd told Glimmer she wasn't okay. "I guess… I just—We've talked about this. But I want to be able to care about you,

Glimmer. I want you to let me in. Because it hurts when I'm rejected for trying to be kind. It doesn't have to be, er, you know —more than friends. That's not what I'm saying. I am your friend first and always. But I need you to let me be that. Because I know it's big and it scares you. But it's the most painful thing ever to be punished for wanting to help you."

It was even more painful to reduce her feelings to 'friendly' and Adora supposed maybe she shouldn't have censored them, considering that this was a safe space… But this was also only the first session. They could work up to it. She could be patient. For now, rebuilding their foundation on friendship was what was important, Adora knew.

Glimmer nodded, guilt darkening her face as she squeezed Adora's hand. "I'm sorry."

"It's okay. I forgive you. Let's just make it a point to work on that, yeah?"

"Yeah." Glimmer's smile was bright and beautiful.

Razz clapped her hands, startling them both. "Excellent expression of your feelings, Dearies! Would either of you be willing to do this more often? I see true progress being made in your future."

Glimmer and Adora exchanged glances before nodding.

"Wonderful, we'll discuss fees later. For now," Razz picked up her pad again. "Let's talk about the sex."

Adora's face flushed red hot.

"Glimmer has informed me of the 'agreement' and 'rules' you two made quite a few months ago now," Razz adjusted her glasses matter-of-factly, although Adora still wanted to die. "Unfortunately, as I told Glimmer, I believe it will only serve to complicate rebuilding your relationship. My best advice would be to no longer indulge. At least for the time being, until Glimmer's emotional and

mental health is more stable. The same might apply to you, Adora! Your thoughts?”

“I…Er,” Adora was brought back to the moment she’d held Glimmer in her arms on the bathroom floor. Razz probably had a point that the sex was bad for their mental states in some capacity. But it also made Adora feel closer to Glimmer. It was the only time she could be raw with her. Her body and soul and heart bared for Glimmer in the most intimate of ways. The love went unspoken, but it was also the loudest in those moments.

But if it would be better for both of them to heal, then….

“Um, yes. That’s… A good idea. We can stop. We’ll stop.”

She felt Glimmer squeeze her fingers again and looked over to see a grim frown twisting her lips.

“Right, Glim?”

“Yes,” she responded a little too quickly, her eyes on the floor. “Yeah, you’re right. We’ll stop.”

Their promise lasted until they got home from Razz’s office and cleaned the apartment and watched a movie together. And then Glimmer’s legs found themselves swung over Adora’s lap and Adora’s hand wandered innocently at first and then not to innocently and then—

It was okay though, Adora decided as she lay tangled together with Glimmer, pressing soft kisses to her forehead as she slept.

Baby steps.

Chapter End Notes

I will see you all in the next and final chapter!! <3

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

Here we are... At the end of all things :-(
I have some notes at the end! But for now I'll just say that I hope you all enjoy the finale!

Final Summary: .... :-) They finally say it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was acting weird.

Not weird in a truly *concerning* sense. But weird in the fact that after nearly five more months of therapy (including the 'partner' sessions they sometimes did together), the end/and beginning of a new lease in an apartment complex closer to Bow's, the truly rekindled friendship… Adora was starting to behave as if she and Glimmer were strangers. As if she were *nervous* around her. As if they hadn't spent all this time growing comfortable around each other again.

After about a week of odd jumpiness, tension, and excuses to leave the room (on Adora's part), Glimmer began to really worry. Maybe she'd been right, all those months ago, about the bubble popping. They were friends again yes… But as Razz had insisted, they'd stopped sleeping together on the regular. They were close, sure… They snuggled a lot and fell asleep in each other's arms more often than not. But the sex? … Glimmer wondered if Adora had found someone else… Someone at work. A client or a new coworker. Maybe she was sleeping with *them* and afraid to tell Glimmer? Even though… They weren't exclusive. It didn't matter. It *shouldn't* matter.

Glimmer didn't want to admit to herself how much the image of Adora with someone else made her blood boil. Someone else tasting her lips, or being wrapped in the safety of her strong arms, blessed by the tender look in her beautiful blue eyes.

If that was the case, Glimmer knew they needed to discuss it. She didn't want to lose Adora in another explosive fight. Never again. Not when simply being able to wake up and see her smile every morning made Glimmer feel *alive* again. If she had to give Adora to someone else, simply to keep that support in her life… She would.

She *would*….

She would try.

Unfortunately, as often as she told herself this, the sadness began to twist in her gut. Taking root and dragging her down. She was depressed, her performance lacking at work, her guitar lay abandoned in the corner of the apartment most days. Until, finally, one night—Adora asked her to get dressed and meet her at the car for a 'quick adventure'. The words rang familiar, but Glimmer was too sullen to care. Her jumpy roommate simply offered her a nervous grin and dashed out the door before she could even ask anyway. Frustrated, grumpy, defeated—Glimmer threw on a pair of shorts and sweater before trudging out of their new apartment to join Adora in the truck.

Adora really needed a new one, she decided as she climbed inside only to be greeted by the familiar scent of grease and worn seats. Maybe—Glimmer would invest in helping her save up for a new car. She knew how attached Adora was to the old clunker, it held a lot of memories. But she deserved something nicer. Something that's doors actually functioned, anyway. Tonight though, as they drove; she found she was grateful for the old car's familiarity. It helped her return to the simple days.

On nights when she and Adora had wanted to escape it all, they'd drive up here, to the foothills just outside of Bright Moon. They'd bring blankets and thermoses of warm coco, and watch the stars from the truck bed, talking about everything they could think of. School, friends, family, the future...What it would be like when

they could both escape the smothering grip their parents had on them.

Glimmer hadn't known then how badly she'd miss that once it was gone and Adora hadn't realized just how difficult and lonely life on her own could really be. They were just kids back then. Foolish, stubborn, reckless.

Glimmer had to laugh, wondering if any of that had really changed. She glanced over at Adora who was navigating the foothills with a white knuckled grip on the steering wheel. When she caught Glimmer's concerned gaze, she flashed a reassuring grin, but it did not reach her eyes.

Adora always had been a bad actress. The quiet nostalgia of the night began to fade into anxiety as they drove up the hillside, accompanied only by the sound of the patchy radio signal. Eventually, Glimmer just leaned forward and turned it off, leaving them in total silence. She wasn't sure what Adora was going to reveal to her out here. If Glimmer's guess about a new 'partner' was correct… She didn't really want to be told out here. Not in their spot. It would twist the knife already embedded in her chest so much deeper. Unfortunately, she didn't seem to have a choice as Adora pulled the truck over into the familiar rocky alcove.

Stomach aching, Glimmer gathered the blankets from the backseat and kicked her way out of the side door, dropping onto the rocky ground below. The tension radiating from the blonde was palpable as she passed by Glimmer to hop into the truck bed. Glimmer tried not to feel even sicker at the pure anxiety written all over Adora's face.

She was about to be hurt… *again*. Whether Adora meant to intentionally or not.

Glimmer tried to remind herself that she'd known this was coming. She'd *known*. They couldn't exist undefined forever. Adora deserved better than that. She deserved better than what Glimmer could ever give her. So she tried to prepare herself. To seal off her heart again like she'd done so long ago when her entire world had been shattered with the death of her father. Tonight it looked like her world would be shattered all over again.

She was stronger now though, she told herself. She could do this. She could heal from another heartbreak. Because of Adora… And thanks to Adora.

"Got the blankets?" Adora asked from the truck bed, suddenly pulling her from her thoughts. Glimmer handed them up, silently, waiting until Adora had spread them out before attempting to climb the truck

Adora reached down immediately, offering a hand, but Glimmer pushed it away.

"I got it," she spat irritably. She knew she shouldn't snap. She shouldn't lash out. But even after her months of therapy, falling back into old habits to defend herself was too easy.

Unfortunately, it took her an embarrassing amount of tries to get up, and by the time she did, her fury had only grown. Her mind now running rampant with possibilities. Already playing out how tonight's inevitable conversation was going to go.

"Glimmer?"

Glimmer was ripped from her angry musings when Adora touched her hand. She was already laying down against the blankets, her fingers weakly wrapping around Glimmer's in an effort to pull her down too.

"Sorry," Glimmer huffed, plopping down beside Adora, stiff as a board against the many layers of plush blankets. It wasn't like she had the right to be angry at Adora. This was what they had agreed on since day one. Just friends. Just until Glimmer got back on her feet. No feelings. No attachments.

No promises.

But ever since that night in the bathroom. Glimmer's whole world had turned upside down. Her walls had been destroyed. She didn’t want to acknowledge it. She hadn’t wanted to ruin their friendship. She hadn’t wanted to chance gaining more than what they already had.

But no matter how hard she tried to pretend; Glimmer knew she was deeply, undeniably in love with her best friend.

And now she was about to pay the price for opening her heart.

"The Big Dipper’s out," Adora spoke in an airy tone, as if the tension wasn't palpable in the air. As if she wasn't about to break Glimmer's heart. Glimmer hated it. She wished she'd rip the bandaid off and get it over with. Why had she taken her all the way up here to do this? Was it an attempt to lessen the blow? An ‘I’ll always be your friend’ kind of thing?

"That's the easiest one to find, Adora," she grumbled, playing along for whatever reason. "You just look for the North Star."

"Yeah…," Adora murmured, drumming her fingers nervously against her chest. "Did you ever think it would be easier to follow?"

Glimmer blinked. "What?"

"You know…. When we would come up here before—as kids. And… We talked about how we'd know what we wanted when we were older. How we'd chart our own courses and be...so much more than what we were back then. Did you think it would be easier?"

Glimmer studied the night sky as she pondered her response. "Yeah… I guess I did. I guess I thought a lot of things back then

that weren't true."

Adora turned to look at her and Glimmer tried to ignore the way the moon made her eyes glow so beautifully.

"Like what?"

Glimmer scoffed, gesturing at the open sky above them. "Everything. My whole life is nothing like I imagined it would be. If I went back in time to give a message to younger me, she'd scream and run."

"She'd think you're a total badass," Adora objected.

"She'd be wrong."

Adora's brows drew down into a frown and she sat up, reaching tentatively for one of Glimmer's hands. Despite everything telling her not to, Glimmer let her take it. She let her lace their fingers together and squeeze.

"If I could go back, I'd tell younger me to do something very important. Because if she listened, I think it would have saved both of us a lot of heartache."

Glimmer looked away, Adora's gaze was too intense to handle. It was coming and Glimmer didn't want to hear it.

"I know why you brought me out here," Glimmer murmured, withdrawing her hand.

Adora blinked, blue eyes owlish. "You do…?"

"Yeah and... It's fine, Adora. Really. I mean, it's what I told you from day one. I know we don't have the 'rules' anymore. But you deserve *happiness*, Adora. You do. And I've done nothing but take and consume and leech off of you and if you've found someone else… Someone who can give you what I can't--," Glimmer was trying, she really was, but her calm facade snapped. She burst into tears, struggling to talk through them. "Then I want you to be happy. I do. I really do, I mean that. I'm sorry I'm crying I'm--"

"Glimmer…," Adora reached for her, but Glimmer held up a hand, a signal that she didn't want to be touched and Adora respected it, sitting back on her heels. Although she looked like she wanted to cry too.

"I want you to know that I am thankful," Glimmer gulped through her hiccups. "To you. For you…. These past few months…*Years*, really...You've always been my best friend, Adora. You always will be."

"Wait, what are you talking about?"

Glimmer looked up, surprised that Adora hadn't reacted to her last few words. In fact, the blonde looked more confuse than anything.

"What are *you* talking about?" Glimmer whimpered back. "You've been acting so weird lately, I thought that—,"

"Glimmer, no. I—," Adora's lip wobbled and she dropped her head, staring down at her lap. "I'm just gonna say it, okay? I don't want to hurt your or scare you but I—,"

Glimmer was now both very hurt and very scared, but she waited.

"I can't *do this* anymore, Glim!" Adora's shoulders hunched, her voice echoing off the rocks around them. "I can't lie to you or to myself anymore. I can't pretend like I'm happy and that everything's normal every day, when it's *killing* me. When you're so close. When I can wake up with you in my arms, and then look at myself in the mirror and pretend I don't want *more.*"

Glimmer's heart began pounding in her chest.

"I know that it's scary. I know it pushed you away before. I know Razz would probably want me to do this in one of our sessions, but I can't fucking stand it anymore." Adora's entire body was

trembling. Glimmer wanted to reach out to comfort her, but her own body was frozen. Paralyzed by Adora's words.

"Glimmer," Shimmering blue eyes finally looked up to meet her own. "I love you. And I can't pretend I'm not *so in love with you* that it drives me crazy not to be able to say it out loud every fucking day. I can't play this game anymore. I can't be your hookup, your roommate, your friend. I want more than that. I have since I met you, Glimmer. And I was too much of a coward to tell you back then and I lost my chance. But I have it back now. I have *you* back now. And—No matter how you feel about *me*, I can't pretend that I'm not in love with you anymore, Glimmer. I—I can't. I'm so sorry."

Adora's quiet sobs echoed around them, but Glimmer's ears were ringing almost too loudly to hear her. Glimmer repeated the phrase again and again in her head...Waiting for it to scare her, but, it didn't.

It wasn't another person… But her? Glimmer herself? Adora loved her? It was what Glimmer knew *she* felt with every inch of her heart, but the idea that Adora might feel the same way? Incomprehensible. Impossible.

Apparently, it wasn't, because Adora continued, "I know we agreed to keep this casual. But I never could have. I lied to you and to myself. I love you, Glimmer. I have for years." Adora's smile brightened, a small laugh escaping her as she said it again. "I love you. I'm *in love* with you."

Glimmer's heart was bursting at the seams, begging to be set free, her tongue itched to speak, her mouth yearned to say the words back. Instead, all that left her was a squeaked:

"Really?

"Yes. Yeah, Glim…," Adora chuckled wetly. “Really.”

She offered a quiet smile; it was almost sad… As if Glimmer’s lack of response confirmed the fear that Glimmer might not feel the same way. But she did!! She knew she did. The words caught in her throat though, so Glimmer simply launched herself at Adora, pinning her to the truck bed in a passionate kiss.

Adora’s squeak of astonishment was muffled by Glimmer’s lips, but she kissed back after a few moments, her arms wrapped tightly around Glimmer, keeping her close even when she pulled back to ask, “Why me?”

What do you mean, ‘why you’?” Adora’s chuckle was shaky. “Why *me?*”

“Because you’re you!” Glimmer insisted in shock. “You’ve got the biggest heart of anyone I’ve ever met. You’re so thoughtful and strong and you cared about me when I didn’t even care about myself. I wouldn’t *be* where I am without you—,”

“Glimmer,” Adora interrupted her again. “Me neither. Come on… I know you and Razz have been working on accepting the good

things about yourself that you so *stubbornly*—" she pinched Glimmer's side playfully "—refuse to see."

Glimmer squirmed, laughing as they rolled onto their sides to face each other.

"You've been my rock for as long as I've known you, Glim. You make me want to be a better person. Just by being you."

"Ditto," was all Glimmer could say past the burning lump in her throat.

Adora chuckled softly, leaning forward and touching their foreheads together. "Well, look at that… Guess we're meant for each other or something."

Laughing, her anxiety swept away by the joy bubbling like light in her chest, Glimmer slipped her arms around Adora's neck once more, pulling her close for another tender kiss.

Despite Adora's most valiant efforts, Glimmer was still shivering thoroughly by the time they got home. The star gazing, along with the memories and Adora's penultimate confession, had been romantic and perfect and Glimmer wouldn't trade it for the world and yet—

Winter was coming to Bright Moon and the only thing that had been keeping them from spending the night in the truck bed like

they had so many times when they were kids; was the fact that Glimmer had almost frozen to the metal in the cool winter air.

"Want me to start a bath or something?" Adora's tone betrayed her concern as she locked the door behind them and then took Glimmer in her arms, wrapping her much warmer body around her as best she could.

"N-n-no," Glimmer clenched her jaw shut to fight the chattering. She was not successful. "Let's j-j-just sn-n-n-nuggle or something."

Almost urgently, Adora led her into the bedroom wherein it suddenly got vastly colder before Adora helped her strip and change into her pjs. They were tucked underneath the covers within seconds, Adora wrapping around her like a starfish, long legs tangled with her own. True to form, Adora was a human furnace and Glimmer's shivers began to dissipate.

"I'm really sorry," Adora murmured, splaying one warm and calloused hand against Glimmer's stomach. "I shouldn't have taken you out there tonight. It was too cold. I just thought that maybe with the memories and stuff it was the perfect place to—,"

"It *was* perfect," Glimmer stopped her, placing her own hand over Adora's and turning to kiss her forehead. Adora blinked up at her, slate blue eyes shining in the moonlight. "Don't you dare be sorry."

A small smile grew on Adora's lips before she stretched upward, pressing them against Glimmer's in a gentle and slow kiss. Glimmer sighed, one hand carding through Adora's hair. It lay loose around her shoulders, soft against Glimmer's fingertips.

"You have no idea how happy it makes me to get to do this whenever I want now," Adora murmured against Glimmer's lips, her hand slipping around the other woman's hip to pull her close.

"And all you had to do was say the magic words," Glimmer teased back as both of their smiles broke the kiss.

Adora snorted softly, rolling her eyes. “If only I’d known.”

“If only…”

Glimmer’s teasing tone turned a little melancholy and Adora noticed, a worry line pinching her brow.

“It’s okay, Glim,” she murmured, kissing Glimmer’s nose and then her forehead and cheeks until she was smiling again. “We’re here now and that’s all that matters.”

For a moment, Adora’s words filled her with hope, before the fear came creeping back in. Adora cared about her, but what about after a few years? What about when Glimmer inevitably made another mistake? What if—

Adora caught her as she spun out of control, placing a gentle hand on her cheek, and waiting until lavender eyes met hers.

“I can see you freaking out,” she teased with a crooked grin.

Glimmer leaned forward until her forehead touched Adora’s; the gesture was simple, but intimate. It calmed her racing thoughts as Adora’s thumb brushed her cheek.

“Don’t overthink it, Glim. We have this moment, not the past, not the future. If you get too far ahead of yourself then everything gets overwhelming.”

“Yeah…”

“Hey.” Glimmer opened her eyes into Adora’s again just as the blonde kissed her gently and murmured the words that made Glimmer’s heart soar. “I love you.”

For a few moments, Glimmer fought to say them back. But they caught and lodged in her throat again, stealing her breath. She figured it was a step to be able to hear the words from Adora and not immediately want to run. But admitting she felt the same out loud? Admitting that Adora had her entire heart? Making herself

that vulnerable this quickly… It was too terrifying. She was still healing. Still learning to open up…

But words weren't the only way she could say it back. So, instead of responding, Glimmer tugged Adora on top of her, savoring the familiar and comforting weight as their lips came together in another kiss. It was somehow soft and simultaneously overwhelming. Adora was all around her. Her familiar scent. Her golden hair falling over her shoulders, a curtain that blocked out the glow of the moon. Her kiss was firm and grounding, lips sliding against Glimmer's in a way that was as familiar as it was exhilarating.

She slipped her arms around Adora's waist, allowing her hands to slide up past the blonde's shirt, caressing the warm skin at the small of her back. Adora whimpered against her lips, shifting on top of Glimmer until she'd managed to rest most of her weight on her elbows and slid a firm thigh between Glimmer's.

The invitation was clear, but Glimmer took her time. It seemed that all too often their foreplay erupted into a flurry of lust. But something felt different about tonight, no doubt in part due to Adora's confession. They didn't have to pretend they didn't care about each other anymore, that there hadn't always been an underlying current of genuine affection whenever they were together like this.

Adora's kiss intensified slightly, her tongue brushing Glimmer's lips, but otherwise she didn't move, allowing Glimmer to take the lead. For once, Glimmer was entirely content to spend the night simply exchanging these—frankly luxurious—kisses with her… girlfriend? Especially when Adora shifted, one of her hands stroking through Glimmer's hair, down to the fuzzy strands at the base of her neck.

Glimmer's heart jumped in her chest as Adora's nails briefly dug into her skin, and then her lips were gone, moving to caress Glimmer's neck just as a choked moan slipped out. Adora

breathed a chuckle against her skin as Glimmer lolled her head the side, allowing the blonde more access.

Adora was tortuously slow, picking up on the pace Glimmer had been keen to set. She pressed soft kisses to each of the moons tattooed behind Glimmer's ear, laving her tongue around them and then grazing her teeth over each, leaving tiny marks in her wake.

Glimmer's breath hitched, a slow burning ache building between her thighs. Adora knew all of her weak spots by now far *too* well. She often took advantage of this knowledge, particularly attacking Glimmer's neck during sex. But teasing her so languidly as an act of foreplay was almost torturous. Glimmer's hips rocked on their own when Adora nipped at the soft spot directly beneath her jaw. And with the blonde's muscled thigh still tucked comfortably between Glimmer's, the steady pressure against her clit as her hips dragged drew a long low moan from deep inside her.

Thanks to Razz's, advice, it had been nearly a month since they been truly intimate. The occasional kiss? Sure. Spooning to sleep? Of course. Sex…? Not in far too long. Glimmer found herself aching for Adora's touch. Missing the firm planes of her body, the power in her muscles when they moved together.

Glimmer's heart was pounding, slamming against her ribcage despite the otherwise slow and purposeful kisses and caresses. Glimmer let her eyes slide shut as Adora drew back a bit, tugging Glimmer's sleep shirt up until her entire torso was exposed to the cool air.

She shivered, but not from the cold, as Adora lowered herself again, mouth closing around one of Glimmer's nipples. She rolled her tongue in slow circles, teasing the metal barbell with her teeth until the friction made Glimmer groan. She slipped her hands into Adora's hair, fisting tightly to keep herself grounded as the blonde continued her steady ministrations.

"Is this okay?" Adora asked suddenly, voice breathless as she pulled away from Glimmer with a lewd 'pop'.

"Why wouldn't it be?" Glimmer gathered her thoughts enough to ask. As if they hadn't done this dozens of times before.

A faint blush colored Adora's cheeks in the darkness. "I dunno… We haven't done this in—a while. Not that it's a *rule* anymore. But tonight was—a lot…Emotionally. If you just wanted to snuggle or something, that's perfectly fine with—,"

"Adora. *Please*." Glimmer stopped her, squeezing her gently between her thighs and tugging on her hair to pull her back up for another kiss, this one laced with obvious desire. Adora hummed against her, pressing her thigh more firmly against Glimmer's core as the heat and passion grew exponentially between them.

"Please what, Princess?" she teased, biting gently at Glimmer's lower lip. Despite the taunt, her voice was soft, as were her blue eyes as they searched Glimmer's face.

Glimmer swallowed the nerves fluttering in her chest. She forced herself to meet Adora gaze and touched her cheek softly with the backs of her fingers. Adora leaned into the touch without hesitation.

"Please show me," Glimmer murmured, intending to finish the sentence with 'how much you love me', but the words died in her throat. It didn't matter. Adora seemed to understand, because she smiled and kissed Glimmer gently once more even as one of her hands slid down between them, tugging at the hem of Glimmer's shorts.

Glimmer squirmed beneath her, eager to help Adora in discarding the shorts as she was now excited to feel the blonde's fingers against her. After a brief, breathless struggle, with no shortage of embarrassed giggles from both of them, Glimmer was bare, while Adora wore only her sleep shirt still. The fabric dragged against Glimmer's piercings occasionally when Adora pressed their bodies

together again. The dodged Glimmer's attempt at another kiss this time, burying herself in her neck instead, lips caressing the heated skin as Adora's long finger slid slowly through Glimmer's wet folds.

Glimmer released a shaky sigh, sinking into the mattress and surrendering to Adora's touch. She hadn't been lying all those months ago, when she'd told Adora that she felt safe with her. She was. Trust was a difficult thing for Glimmer to come by these days, as were affection and honesty and all the other things she knew Adora deserved. But whether she could say it out loud or not yet, Adora had her whole heart in the palm of her hand. And when she was touching Glimmer so gently, kissing her like she was something worthy of worshipping, Glimmer found it hard to believe Adora would ever do anything to betray that trust.

Adora seemed determined to tease her thoroughly, her breath quickening against Glimmer's neck as she stroked her folds, circling slowly around her aching nub. Eager, but also having no issue with the pace they'd set for the night, Glimmer wrapped her legs around Adora's waist, opening herself further to the blonde's touch. It was a strange mixture of newness and melancholy. She knew the blonde's touch so well by now, and yet, after her confession, everything felt new. Like this was the first time.

Maybe in a sense, it was, Glimmer reasoned. The first time after they'd been truly honest with each other about their feelings. In some, strange, metaphorical way—Adora would be her *first* in the new life she was carving for herself.

Glimmer was pulled back to the moment when Adora nipped lightly at her neck before pushing herself up on one elbow to gaze down into her eyes again. Glimmer was confused at first, until Adora slowly slid one long finger inside of her, maintaining eye contact. The blonde's own face contorted with pleasure as Glimmer moaned, her eyes fluttering closed at the sensation of Adora now inside her.

A second finger quickly joined the first, but Adora kept her pace steady, easing her fingers in and out of Glimmer in an almost

leisurely rhythm. She stayed propped up on her free arm, her gaze a confusing mix of hazy affection and bright arousal. She would lean down and kiss Glimmer occasionally, who was doing her best to maintain the intimate eye contact but was reduced to squeezing her eyes shut and moaning whenever Adora curled her fingers just right.

"I love being able to feel you like this," Adora murmured against her lips after one particularly passionate kiss. "I love kissing you. I love tasting you. I love hearing you moan my name."

Glimmer whimpered at her words. Adora's steady pace wasn't really enough to bring her to orgasm, but it was certainly serving to make her wetter and wetter, the sound now almost filling her ears.

"You're so *perfect*, Glim," she whispered, kissing Glimmer's cheek and then the shell of her ear, before tugging lightly on her earlobe with her teeth. "I love you so much…"

Glimmer wasn't sure why Adora's praise was having such an effect, but the fire burning in between her thighs was raging. She needed more, she wanted Adora to push her over the edge. She wanted to let go of every fear and insecurity and be as vulnerable as she possibly could in this woman's arms.

"I—I n-need more, Adora. Please," she managed to gasp and Adora nodded, moving her kisses to the juncture of Glimmer's neck and shoulder as she began pumping her fingers faster—harder. Glimmer groaned, clinging to her, fingers twisting in the fabric of the shirt she still wore as she rolled her hips into each of Adora's thrusts.

"I want you to come for me, Beautiful," Adora's husky whisper was in her ear, surrounding her as her heart surged and her stomach flipped at the request. "I want to feel you come for me. *Please*…"

Glimmer couldn't have denied her if she'd tried. A few more rapid thrusts from Adora, a brief curl of her long fingers, and Glimmer

was unraveling beneath her. Her entire body spasmed, inner walls convulsing around Adora's fingers as a rush of wetness stained the sheets beneath them. But Glimmer couldn't bring herself to care. She felt back against the pillows, gasping for air as Adora continued to lay gentle kisses on her overheated skin.

She only removed her fingers from Glimmer's swollen sex once she'd stopped twitching with the aftershocks. Managing to open her eyes as her breathing settled, Glimmer was met with Adora's tender blue gaze. Expecting lust maybe, or something heated and full of desire, it pierced Glimmer's heart to instead *see* the love Adora had verbally expressed over and over again all night.

It broke her.

The final floodgates burst, and Glimmer began to sob. Suddenly, it didn't matter if one day Adora decided she didn't feel the same way anymore. It didn't matter if Glimmer knew she might screw up again and hurt her. It didn't matter that the future was big and unknown and scary. What did matter was that she loved Adora deeply and Adora *deserved* to hear it.

What mattered was that Glimmer had all these dreams and feelings and yearning she'd kept locked away in her heart for years. And they were pouring out of her in a flurry.

She loved Adora. She *wanted* Adora.

It all came out of her in a tumble or hysterical sobs.

"I love you," Glimmer gasped and then she was quaking in Adora's arms, tears streaming down her face. "God, Adora. I love you so much."

Adora drew back, both surprised and panicked as Glimmer's body began to tremble fiercely. She did her best to brush away the tears, but they were falling faster with every passing moment.

"I always have. I fell for you so fucking hard back then. And I've missed you… So much. But I never let myself admit it because I

thought you were gone. Forever. And I thought it was *my* fault. It *was* my fault." She clung to Adora so tightly, it was starting to hurt, but the blonde didn't move away. Her heart ached in her chest with each of Glimmer's words. "I knew I was being stupid and cruel and manipulative, but I was hurting so badly. Everything hurt. And all I could think to do to protect myself was to lash out at everyone that tried to get close. It's why I lost all my friends, my own mother—Bow is the only one who ever stuck around because he's so *good* and more than I deserve. I don't deserve this either—," she choked on a harsh sob, clamping her hands over her face. "—I don't deserve you. I—,"

"Glimmer," Adora stopped her finally, taking her hands away from her face, forcing her to meet watery blue eyes with her own. "Stop, please."

She buried her face in Glimmer's neck, wrapping her arms as tightly as she could around her smaller figure and squeezing. "Please, don't talk about yourself like that. *Please*. Love is messy and hard and it's awful sometimes. Sometimes it hurts more than it doesn't. But that doesn't mean it's not worth it. It's not about deserving love. Or deserving me. It's about how much we *both* want to work at what we have because it's important, because we want each other. Even the messy parts. I'm not perfect. You know that. I've made plenty of mistakes. I should have done more for you back then—,"

"You were just a kid," Glimmer interrupted, her voice choked as she ran a hand through Adora's hair. "Who was hurting as much as me. It wasn't your job to protect me."

"But it was my job to love you. And I failed," Adora murmured.

"Did you—," Glimmer paused, tugging on Adora until she pulled back to look her in the eye again. "—Did you ever stop? … Loving me?"

Adora's eyes softened somehow further. "No."

“Then you didn’t fail.”

Adora squeezed her eyes shut as the tears burned them again. She leaned forward, touching her forehead to Glimmer’s and taking a deep shaky breath to steady herself.

“Why did it take us this long? It’s not fair.”

Glimmer sobbed an agreement, one soft hand stroking Adora’s jaw. “It’s not. But—Maybe we both needed the time in between? I don’t know… I don’t know anything really. I just know that we’re here now, and I want you, and I’m *not* letting you go again.”

Adora let out a watery giggle. “Big talk.”

“I’ll prove it,” Glimmer chuckled a little defiantly. “Give me a ring pop, I’ll wife you right now.”

“I love you,” Adora’s reply was soft, spoken as she gazed into Glimmer’s eyes and touched her cheek with the pads of her fingers. Glimmer’s smile was gentle, it wobbled, and she closed her eyes, leaning into Adora’s touch.

“I love you too.”

Adora sunk into her, heart swelling at Glimmer’s confession. She buried her face in Glimmer’s neck, arms wrapped tightly around her and cried. Her body shook, tears dripping into the crook of Glimmer’s collarbone. Glimmer held her, stroking her back and hair and crying with her, sobs a little less intense than Adora’s. They stayed like that all night, tucked away together, safe and warm and loved for the first time in years.

When Adora woke up the next morning, Glimmer’s shock of soft hair was tickling the underside of her chin, one of her thighs tucked between Adora’s and arms wrapped tightly around her waist. Somehow, they’d stayed wrapped up in one another all night, and Adora was not at all willing to move. She closed her eyes again, breathing Glimmer in and snuggling a little closer.

Everything would be okay now. They'd confessed how they really felt about one another and expressed the desire for open communication and patience. *They* would be okay. Adora had to struggle not to start immediately making wedding plans, because deep down, she already knew. Glimmer was the one she wanted to spend the rest of her life with. Her best friend, her comfort, her support. This was always where she wanted to be, whether or not everything was always perfect between them. She would do her best to always be what Glimmer needed. And last night made it clear that Glimmer was finally ready to do the same.

Slowly, Glimmer shifted awake beside her, inhaling deeply and then sighing against Adora's collar. She murmured something, arms tightening around Adora, before the blonde felt the brush of Glimmer's lips against her chest.

"G'morning…"

"Good morning," she mumbled in reply, kissing Glimmer's forehead. "I love you."

Glimmer's giggle made her heart soar. "Oh? Even this early? How often are you gonna say that now?"

"Literally every fucking second of the day," Adora teased back, pressing her lips to Glimmer's forehead once more in a loud and exaggerated smack. "Deal with it, baby."

Glimmer looked up at her, mischievous twinkle in her eyes dimming into something softer and she smiled with a tenderness that made Adora's heart ache.

"I love you too."

---

1 year later…

Adora was nervous, her entire body trembling as she pulled up in front of the Sato household. She knew she shouldn't be so anxious. Since the…bathroom *debacle*, she'd been reconnecting

slowly with Angella, as had Glimmer. And besides that, Adora knew that it didn't *really* matter if Angella gave Adora her blessing or not. It was an archaic tradition. But considering all they'd been through, and all they *still* had to go through, Adora wanted to know that Glimmer's mother supported them.

Inhaling a steadying breath, Adora kicked her way out of the car and trudged up the long drive to the large double doors. Her mind briefly wandered to Micah, as she caught a glance of his old workshop out of the corner of her eye. She wondered what his answer to her question might be. Happiness? He'd always seemed to care for Adora like another daughter, and all he'd ever wanted was for Glimmer to be happy. A small smile tugged at Adora's lips as she tried to picture his voice and his blessing.

Now it was Angella's turn.

Knocking on the door, three quick raps, Adora only had to wait a few moments before Angella answered; as tall and regal as always.

"Adora?" her tone was surprised. "I wasn't expecting you, is everything alright?"

"Oh! Yeah, of course. I'm sorry, I should have called or something. I just—," Adora cleared her throat nervously. "I was just wondering if you had a few minutes to talk… About Glimmer."

The older woman's face twisted with minute concern and she ushered Adora inside, leading her to the familiar leather couch in the living room.

"Is something wrong?" Angella clarified as they each took a seat.

"No! No, not at all," Adora assured her quickly. "No, Glim's doing great. She's still seeing her therapist, she's playing her guitar a lot more, making new friends at work. She, um, I don't know if she told you yet… But she wants to go back to school. She put in her application for Bright Moon University last night."

Angella's eyes seemed to sparkle, but she maintained her excitement with a cool nod. "I wasn't aware of that, no. But I'm… I'm very glad to hear that. I'm proud of her for making that decision."

"Me too—," Adora clasped her hands tight in her lap to stop them from shaking again. "Um, which is kind of why I came by today… I —."

Angella was peering at her curiously, her pale lavender eyes wide, tinged with confusion.

"It's—Wow, I don't even know where to start. I'm sorry, Ma'am—," Swallowing thickly, Adora braced herself and met Angella's gaze with as much determination as she could muster. "Mrs. Sato, the day I met your daughter, she changed my life forever. I didn't know it back then, and I took it for granted. But I was lucky enough to get to know her again and… To fall in love with her again." A small jump in Angella's brow was the only reaction she got. "I know that—Glimmer's, uh, 'choice' in… 'partner's has been an issue for you two in the past. But—I want you to know how much I care about her. She's always been my friend, someone who supported me and loved me when I didn't have anyone else. I want to be that for her too. She deserves that. She's a good person. Whatever she needs, I want to *try* to be that for… For the rest of our lives."

Angella was still silent, waiting, but Adora couldn't read her expression, so she pressed on shakily.

"Mrs. Sato, I want to ask Glimmer to marry me and I wanted you to give me your blessing to do so."

Adora sat very still, body tense as a wire as she waited for Angella's response. Since she and Glimmer had been working on their relationship, for over a year now, Adora had been under the impression that the idea of Glimmer ending up with a woman was no longer an issue. Even still, Adora was nervous for that factor

alone, not accounting for the idea that Mrs. Sato just might not be crazy about her as a person.

Finally, Angella spoke, her words calm and quiet. "Adora. Do you remember what I asked of you? After Micah passed?"

Of course, she did, she'd never forget those words. And how she failed to follow through on her promise.

"Yes."

"For as long as I've known you, and known you *with* Glimmer, the love you two have for one another has been abundantly clear. It's why I asked you to look after her when she was lost. It's why I knew that if you could reach her, you'd both take care of each other. I still remember how bright she seemed to shine when you came into her life. And now, as she heals with you at her side, I see it again."

Adora felt her throat closing, eyes stinging at the tenderness in Angella's voice.

"If there is anyone in this world I trust now with my daughter's heart, it is *you*, Adora."

Feeling the tears about to burst, Adora dumbly blurted, "Even though I'm a girl?"

Chuckling, Angella leaned forward and patted Adora's shaking hands comfortingly. "The fact that you are a woman has very little to do with what I know to be true; that you will make Glimmer's life one full of love and happiness. I know she still doesn't seem to believe me, but that is all I've ever wanted for her. I know it's what Micah wanted too. You have my blessing, Adora. As I'm sure you have his."

Adora couldn't hold the tears back anymore. She choked as they slid down her face, shoulders shaking. And the next thing she knew, she was being hugged tightly by her future mother-in-law, who joined her in crying.

"I will take care of her," Adora mumbled into Angella's shoulder when she finally regained her voice. "I promise."

Angella's hum was full of pride. "I know you will."

As Adora drove away from the Sato household again once tears had dried, she knew in her heart it would not be the last time.

Proposing.

Now that was the hard part. She knew Glimmer would say yes. She *knew*. And yet Adora was still a bundle of nerves. Even after deciding on the perfect place, the perfect ring, the perfect time… Everything. Everything was ready. And yet Adora stood, shaking on the beach as the burning orange sun sunk slowly behind the waves.

At first, Adora had been against the idea of proposing somewhere that didn't immediately hold an inherent meaning for her or Glimmer as a couple. But after consulting with Bow and Adam and even Lonnie, they'd all agreed that simply doing it somewhere beautiful, in a memorable way, was what mattered. So she stood frozen in the sand, twirling the ring box over and over in her hands as Bow and Adam helped set up the last of the lights. They'd managed wrangle LENGTHS of chords, and thanks to the kindness of a few houses along the beachside, had ample electricity to make the sign they'd built glow like the stars above.

They also now had a beachfront audience, which Adora figured, was probably contributing to her nerves. Not that anyone would be able to hear her from so far away, but the eyes she knew were on her was more than terrifying.

The big glowing letters, embedded with enormous lightbulbs flashed behind her as Adam finally got them working.

'Marry Me?'

And behind that were a bunch of sparklers Bow had rigged to go off at Glimmer's response. The two men stood up from their work and trotted over to Adora, who stared at them with enormous blue eyes. The moment was coming.

"Lonnie texted," Bow said, checking his phone. "Says she's almost here with Glim. Are you ready?"

"No."

"You are," Bow said with a smile, rubbing Adora's shoulder.

"Yeah!" Adam agreed, forcefully patting her other one. "Come on, look at this! How could she say no?"

"She won't say no," Adora mumbled, staring at her fingers as they went numb around the ring box. "But I don't want to mess up. Or stutter. Or forget what I was going to say in the first place…"

"If you do, just speak from the heart, Adora," Bow assured her. "As cheesy as that sounds. Glimmer loves you, okay? You could literally just say, 'Marry me?' and she'd break down in tears and *immediately* say yes. I promise."

"I just want it to be perfect, Bow."

He smiled. "It already is."

Adora nodded, inhaling shakily as Bow's phone buzzed again. He checked it before nodding to Adam.

"She's coming, we're gonna hide. Let's go!"

"You got this, Adora!" Adam shot her a thumbs up and then scurried off with Bow to creep behind a few scattered bushes. Adora turned, back to the setting sun and waves, the letters glowing behind her as she faced the boardwalk that led to the beach.

Vaguely, she could make out the figure of Lonnie, guiding what looked to be a very reluctant Glimmer. Adora couldn't help but smile, imagining how confusing this must all be for her girlfriend. In the time since they'd made things official, Glimmer had made more of an effort to be social. Especially with Adora's coworkers. She and Lonnie shared some of the same snappy fire, so much so that Adora wasn't surprised they'd gotten along fairly quickly. Even so, they weren't incredibly close yet. And imagining the excuse Lonnie must have had to weave to keep the proposal a surprise while also convincing Glimmer to come with her to the beach at dusk was amusing.

Adora's hand clenched around the box as the two came closer. Both paused, and then Lonnie fell back as Glimmer continued to creep forward. The hesitance in her step told Adora she was trying to figure out what she was looking at from so far down the beach. And then suddenly, her girlfriend jumped and broke into a sprint.

Adora didn't move from her place, but opened her arms, laughing as Glimmer's crashed into them, nearly sending them both flying into the carefully placed letters.

"Adora—," it seemed the only word she could get out as she stepped back and cupped Adora's cheeks, her thumbs running over the flushed skin. Lavender eyes flickered only once to the letters over her shoulder before locking on blue ones, tears rising in the corners. "Are you…?"

Bracing herself, the speech she'd rehearsed slipping from her mind (of course), Adora kissed Glimmer's forehead and then dropped to one knee, holding out the box in front of her. She almost forgot to open it, remembering at the last second and revealing the diamond ring inlaid with two tiny amethysts. Glimmer's mouth opened, but her gasp was lost amid the crash of the waves on the shore.

"Glim," Adora began, losing her words once again and just staring up at the woman she loved. "I—You know how much I love you. I

tell you every day. I could tell you every day for the rest of our lives. And I *want* to. But it'll never be enough. *Words* will never be enough to express how much I love you. How happy you make me. It's been… Knowing you for the time that I have, all these years, every day is such an adventure. It's been a journey to get where we are. I've grown so much. You've grown so much. And I'm so proud to call you the woman I love. I just—," Adora's eyes watered and she paused to catch her breath and suddenly Glimmer was on her knees too. She cupped Adora's cheeks and beamed at her, the tears shining in her own eyes, urging her to continue. "—I want that joy, I want *you*, for the rest of our lives. If you'll let me, I will spend the rest of my life giving back to you, all the happiness you give to me. So…um, Glim?" Adora glanced down at the box, holding it up a little higher. "Will you marry me?"

Glimmer's reply was an immediate choked 'Yes' and then she was kissing Adora and their friends were running towards them, whooping and Adora could hear the cheers from the onlookers from the houses too. She wrapped her arms around Glimmer's middle, hoisting them back into a standing position and lifting her into the air slightly before parting. Glimmer closed in for a hug, tucking herself into Adora's neck and refusing to budge even as their friends bombarded them with hugs and Bow set off the sparklers.

When Adora finally managed to pry Glimmer off, just enough to slip the ring onto her finger she thought she'd never seen a smile so bright light Glimmer's face.

"I love you," Adora murmured, touching her forehead to Glimmer's as the voices of their friends dimmed around them and suddenly, they were the only two in the universe. The words Adora had made sure to say so many times since the night she'd confessed suddenly felt new again. They held so much and not enough. Infinite but bounded. Glimmer's hands clenched on her waist, joyful tears streaking her cheeks as she glanced up to meet Adora's eyes.

"I love you too."

After everything they’d been through, somehow an endless road full of possibilities still lay before them. Adora knew they’d already come so far.

But there was still a lifetime left to go.

Chapter End Notes

There we have it, guys. I wanted to thank everyone who left comments/kudos/bookmarks/everything. This story has been so much fun and amazingly cathartic to write and I've interacted with so many kind and awesome people through it and I will really miss these version of Adora and Glimmer.
As far as NSA goes, this is the end of the plot. HOWEVER! I would like to maybe touch on this universe again with some oneshots--fluff/smut/maybe a full epilogue for the wedding. If you guys would like to see any of that, please let me know! :D It would be fun to write these characters again.

As it stands. thank you all so much for the support, I sincerely hope you enjoyed the journey, and I'll see you guys in my next story!! <3

Works inspired by this one

Movie Night by TeamGlimmadora

No Strings Attached: Epilogue by Say_Anything

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!